Privacy-Preserving Machine Learning for Practitioners

Manuel V. Loureiro

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Preface

This is the practitioner edition of *Privacy-Preserving Machine Learning*. It is for engineers, data scientists and auditors who build or review machine-learning systems that handle personal data, and it tells them what each result says, when it applies, how to use it and what goes wrong, without proofs.

It keeps the parts and the chapter files of the full edition, so that every page here has a twin there that derives its results step by step, but it is organized around the work rather than the theory. Three kinds of page do that. A **workflow chapter** does one job end to end with real libraries on a real public dataset: assessing a model's privacy risk before release, releasing statistics with OpenDP and diffprivlib, calibrating and reporting a run of differentially private stochastic gradient descent, training and fine-tuning with Opacus, and governing a release. Each part reads in the order of the work, so a workflow comes early in its part and the pages it relies on follow. A **full chapter** covers a topic a practitioner computes with: the result and its formula, why it matters, a recipe with a worked example, what goes wrong, and a cheat sheet. A **reference page** covers a theory-heavy topic a practitioner meets but rarely computes with, in a few hundred words: what it is, when you meet it, how to use it and what goes wrong. Every page ends with a link to the full edition's chapter.

You need some Python and NumPy, basic probability, and enough machine learning to know what a loss and stochastic gradient descent are.

How this book is organized

1. **Prerequisites** covers hypothesis testing and divergences, the two pieces of mathematics a later chapter cites most. The rest of the mathematics stays in the full edition's Part 1.
2. **Threat models and attacks** shows how models and data leak, and assesses a model's risk before release.
3. **Differential privacy foundations** defines the guarantee, builds its mechanisms, and releases statistics with them.
4. **Privacy accounting** tracks the guarantee through private training, and calibrates and reports a run.
5. **Differential privacy in machine learning** trains, fine-tunes, audits and releases private models.

You do not need to read Part 1 first. With a background in statistics or machine learning, start at Part 2 or Part 3 and follow the links back when you need a fact.

Every piece of code on a page has been run: a snippet runs on its own, and an excerpt is a marked region of a workflow script in the repository's `code/` directory, which a test runs

and checks against the numbers the page quotes. To rerun a workflow, run `uv run python code/<part>/practitioner_<topic>.py`.

Part I.

Prerequisites

This part holds the two pieces of mathematics that the rest of the book uses most, with no privacy in them yet. You need not read it first, because later chapters link to each fact they use.

What each chapter is for

Both chapters rest on one idea, the **likelihood ratio**: how many times more likely an observation is under one explanation than under another. The rest of the book measures privacy with it, so these are the two pieces of mathematics a practitioner uses most.

Hypothesis testing is a full chapter. It shows how to read a detector's trade-off curve at a low false positive rate, and how to put an honest interval on a measured rate. Attacks, audits and the Gaussian view of accounting all rest on it. Divergences is a short reference page. It compares two distributions with one number, and the definitions of Part 3 and Part 4 are such numbers.

The rest of the mathematics is in the full edition's Part 1, which a page here links to where it uses a fact: probability distributions in the full edition, concentration inequalities in the full edition, information theory in the full edition, optimization in the full edition, algorithmic stability and generalization in the full edition and cryptography basics in the full edition.

Notation

Table 1.: Notation used throughout the book.

Symbol	Meaning
Pr, $\mathbb{E}$, Var	Probability, expectation, variance
$\mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$, Lap($b$)	Normal and Laplace distributions
ln, $\log_2$	Natural logarithm (nats) and base-2 logarithm (bits)
$\|x\|$	Euclidean length of a vector x
D, θ, $\ell(\theta; z)$	A dataset, the parameters of a model, and its loss on one record z

How to use the chapters

Each chapter states its results, works one example with real numbers, and links to its derivations in the full edition. Every number comes from a snippet on the page or from the full edition's seeded script for the chapter, so a new run gives the same numbers.

1. Divergences

1.1. What it is

A **divergence** puts a number on how different two distributions are. It is zero for equal distributions and grows as they become easier to tell apart. Take two distributions P and Q, and write $p(x)$ and $q(x)$ for the probabilities they give an outcome x. Every divergence sums up the **likelihood ratio** $p(x)/q(x)$.

The **Kullback–Leibler (KL) divergence** is the average log ratio when the data come from P:

$$D_{\mathrm{KL}}(P\|Q) = \sum_x p(x) \ln \frac{p(x)}{q(x)}. \tag{1.1}$$

It is not symmetric, and it adds up across independent observations.

The **Rényi divergence** is a dial set by an order α above 1:

$$D_\alpha(P\|Q) = \frac{1}{\alpha - 1} \ln \sum_x p(x)^\alpha q(x)^{1-\alpha}. \tag{1.2}$$

It equals the KL divergence as the order goes to 1. Higher orders give more weight to outcomes with large ratios, up to the **max-divergence** D_∞, the largest log ratio of all outcomes.

The **total variation (TV)** is the mass of P that does not overlap with Q:

$$\mathrm{TV}(P, Q) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_x |p(x) - q(x)|. \tag{1.3}$$

The **hockey-stick divergence** scales q up by a factor γ of at least 1 and measures the mass of p that still sticks out above it. Writing $(y)_+$ for the positive part of y, it is

$$E_\gamma(P\|Q) = \sum_x \big(p(x) - \gamma q(x)\big)_+. \tag{1.4}$$

At $\gamma = 1$ it is the total variation, and it reaches zero once γ exceeds the largest likelihood ratio.

1.2. When you meet it

You meet divergences when a feature drifts between training and production, or when a shift in test data can move a classifier's accuracy. Papers often state a result in a different divergence from the one you need.

1.3. How to use it

To measure drift, put the two samples in bins with the same edges and call `scipy.stats.entropy(p, q)`. It returns natural-log units (nats), or bits with `base=2`. Take a feature whose last bin was empty last month and holds a tenth of this month's data. With last month as P, the divergence is 0.1116 nats, but the reverse is infinite, because this month has mass where last month had none.

```
import math

from scipy import stats

before, after = [0.5, 0.3, 0.2, 0.0], [0.4, 0.3, 0.2, 0.1]
print(f"{stats.entropy(before, after):.4f} {stats.entropy(before, after, base=2):.4f}")  # 0
print(stats.entropy(after, before))  # inf
print(math.ceil(2 * 0.9**2 / 0.005), math.ceil((2 * stats.norm.ppf(0.95) / 0.1) ** 2))  # 32
```

For noise and a copy shifted by s, closed forms replace histograms. For normal noise, write σ for the standard deviation and $\mu = s/\sigma$ for the shift in standard deviations. The divergences are

$$D_{\mathrm{KL}} = \frac{\mu^2}{2}, \qquad D_\alpha = \frac{\alpha\mu^2}{2}, \qquad D_\infty = \infty, \tag{1.5}$$

the last because the ratio of normal densities is unbounded. The shift is squared, so a drift of 0.1 standard deviations gives a KL divergence of only $0.1^2/2 = 0.005$. For Laplace noise of scale b, the log ratio is bounded, and the max-divergence is the shift in scales, s/b.

The TV says how well a test can tell P from Q. If the two are equally likely in advance, the best test from one observation has an **advantage**, its true-positive rate minus its false-positive rate, equal to the TV. It is then right with probability $\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{TV}$. For two normal curves one standard deviation apart, the TV is 0.3829, so no classifier is right more than 0.6915 of the time. Also, when the test distribution moves, the accuracy of a fixed classifier moves by at most the TV.

For the same normal pair, the hockey-stick divergence is

$$E_\gamma = \Phi\Big(\frac{\mu}{2} - \frac{\ln\gamma}{\mu}\Big) - \gamma\,\Phi\Big(-\frac{\mu}{2} - \frac{\ln\gamma}{\mu}\Big), \tag{1.6}$$

where Φ is the standard normal distribution function. At $\mu = 1$ and $\gamma = 2$ it is 0.1906.

Pinsker's inequality converts a KL divergence into a bound on the TV:

$$\mathrm{TV}(P, Q) \le \sqrt{\tfrac{1}{2} D_{\mathrm{KL}}(P\|Q)}. \tag{1.7}$$

It is quick but loose. A test that detects the drift of 0.1 standard deviations 95% of the time needs a TV of 0.9. Because KL adds up, a sample of size n has a KL divergence of $0.005n$, so Pinsker asks for 324 samples. The exact answer is 1,083 (the snippet's last call).

1.4. What goes wrong

The KL divergence has a direction, so say which one you computed, and never mix nats with bits. An empty bin makes it infinite, so add half a count per bin or merge bins, and say which you did. Estimates change with the bins and the sample size, so compare like with like.

The **data processing inequality** says that bins, thresholds or other processing of an observation alone cannot make two distributions easier to tell apart, but it can make them harder. For normals one standard deviation apart, a threshold at the midpoint cuts the KL divergence from 0.5 to 0.3090. But it keeps all of the TV, because that threshold is already the best test.

A small KL divergence is an average, so it can hide rare outputs that are strong evidence. When every output matters, bound the worst case with the max-divergence, a high Rényi order or the hockey-stick divergence.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

2. Hypothesis testing

2.1. Why this matters

A fraud detector must call each transaction normal or fraudulent, so it decides which of two distributions an observation came from. Every detector and every binary classifier is such a hypothesis test. To evaluate one, measure its two kinds of error, false alarms and missed cases, at the low rate of false alarms that you need. Accuracy hides that rate.

2.2. Tests and their two errors

The default assumption, the **null hypothesis** H_0, is that the observation comes from a distribution P, such as the fraud model's scores for normal transactions. The **alternative hypothesis** H_1 is that it comes from a distribution Q, such as its scores for fraudulent ones. A **test** decides whether to reject the null, which here means to flag the transaction.

A test can make two kinds of mistake. A flag on a normal case is a false positive, and its probability is the **false positive rate (FPR)**, written α. A missed real case is a false negative, with probability β, the **false negative rate (FNR)**. The share of real cases that the test catches, $1-\beta$, is the **true positive rate (TPR)**. A lower threshold raises the TPR but also the FPR. So first fix a budget for the FPR, the **level**, and then look for the test with the highest TPR, or **power**, within it.

2.3. The Neyman–Pearson lemma

Write $p(x)$ and $q(x)$ for the probabilities, or densities, of an observation x under the two hypotheses. Their quotient is the **likelihood ratio**

$$\Lambda(x) = \frac{q(x)}{p(x)}. \tag{2.1}$$

A **likelihood ratio (LR) test** rejects wherever this ratio exceeds a threshold τ, which you set so that the FPR of the test equals the budget. The **Neyman–Pearson lemma** says that no other test at that level catches more real cases.

So the best test uses only the likelihood ratio of an observation. A threshold on a raw score is that test only when a higher score always means a higher ratio. To estimate the ratio from labelled scores, fit a logistic regression of the label on the score. Its log-odds, minus the log prior odds, estimate $\ln \Lambda$. If a known group shifts the scores, the ratio depends on the group, so the best test sets a threshold within each group.

2.4. Trade-off curves

The best FNR at every level says how hard P is to tell from Q. This curve is the **trade-off function** $T(P, Q)$, which you get when you move the LR threshold across its range. The **receiver operating characteristic (ROC)** curve holds the same information upside down, as TPR against FPR. Each real detector has its own ROC curve, on or below the best one.

2.5. The Gaussian trade-off curve

A common pair is a score that is normal under the two hypotheses with the same spread, scaled so that normal cases have mean 0 and standard deviation 1. Write μ for the distance between the two centres in standard deviations, and Φ for the standard normal cumulative distribution function. The best test has its threshold at $\Phi^{-1}(1-\alpha)$, and its FNR at level α is the Gaussian trade-off function

$$G_\mu(\alpha) = \Phi(\Phi^{-1}(1-\alpha) - \mu). \tag{2.2}$$

In SciPy this is `norm.cdf(norm.isf(alpha) - mu)`. Use `isf`, because `norm.ppf(1 - alpha)` loses the digits that matter at a very small α. The single number μ fixes the best TPR at every FPR. At $\mu = 2$, for example, the best TPR is 0.6388 at an FPR of 5%, and only 0.1378 at an FPR of 10^{-3}. In the other direction, a measured pair gives $\mu = \Phi^{-1}(1-\alpha) + \Phi^{-1}(\text{TPR})$, or `norm.isf(alpha) + norm.ppf(tpr)`. If that estimate changes with α, the scores do not have this shape.

2.6. The Laplace trade-off curve

Take a Laplace distribution and a copy shifted by κ times its scale. Their likelihood ratio stays between $e^{-\kappa}$ and e^{κ} (Divergences). So each outcome that a test rejects is at most e^{κ} times more likely under Q than under P, and every test has

$$\text{TPR} \le e^{\kappa}\,\text{FPR}. \tag{2.3}$$

At a low FPR the best test reaches this cap. At $\kappa = 1$ and an FPR of 0.05, its TPR is $e \times 0.05 = 0.1359$.

This cap makes the Laplace pair different from the normal one. A Laplace pair at $\kappa = 1$ and a normal pair at $\mu = 1.0301$ have the same best advantage, the largest TPR minus FPR of all tests (Section 2.7). But at a level of 10^{-6}, the normal pair allows 36 times the TPR. Its ratio has no cap, so a test can find rare observations that give strong evidence. So compare two pairs at the level you will use.

2.7. Best advantage and total variation

The **advantage** of a test is its TPR minus its FPR. The best advantage over all tests is the **total variation (TV)** distance of Divergences:

$$\max(\text{TPR} - \text{FPR}) = \text{TV}(P, Q) = \frac{1}{2}\sum_x |q(x) - p(x)|. \tag{2.4}$$

For the normal pair it is $2\Phi(\mu/2) - 1$, or 0.3829 at a shift of one standard deviation. Accuracy on a balanced set is one half plus half the advantage. So accuracy measures the same single point of the curve, and it says nothing about the low-FPR end.

2.8. ROC summaries: why AUC hides the low-FPR regime

People often compare detectors by the **area under the curve (AUC)** of their ROC curves, the chance that a random positive scores higher than a random negative. But the area gives the same weight to every FPR from 0 to 1. So the low FPRs where a strict detector works add almost nothing to it. For example, take two detectors with standard normal scores on negatives. The positives of detector A have mean 1 and standard deviation 1. Those of B have mean 1.5811 and standard deviation 2, so the two detectors have the same AUC of 0.7602.

But at an FPR of 10^{-3}, A catches 0.0183 of the positives and B about 12 times as many (Figure 2.1). A few positives of B score far above all negatives, and a strict threshold catches exactly those.

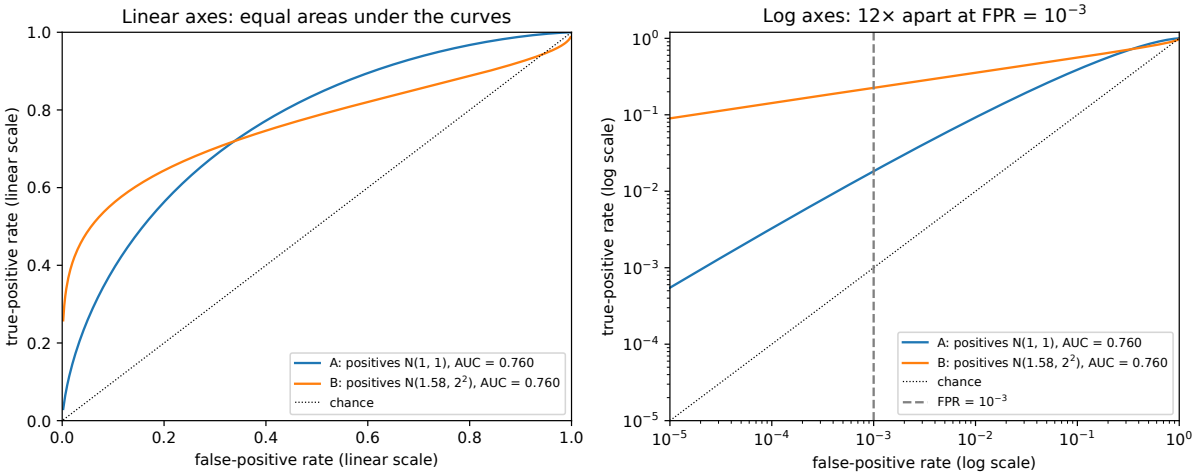


Figure 2.1.: Two detectors with the same AUC of 0.760, on linear axes (left) and log axes (right).

So plot the ROC curve on log–log axes, and report the TPR at fixed low FPRs. Drop the first point of `roc_curve`, because its FPR is 0. Give `roc_curve(y_true, y_score)` scores, not the labels from `predict`. At a target FPR, take the highest TPR among the points at or below it, because no single threshold reaches a value from `np.interp`. And do not read a TPR at an FPR below one over the number of negatives, because there the curve rests on one false positive or none.

2.9. The Bayesian view

Often you know a base rate π, for example that one transaction in a thousand is fraud. Bayes' rule says that the odds of H_1 after you see x are the odds before, multiplied by the likelihood ratio:

$$\frac{\Pr[H_1 \mid x]}{\Pr[H_0 \mid x]} = \frac{\pi}{1-\pi} \times \Lambda(x). \tag{2.5}$$

The decision with the fewest errors says H_1 when these odds exceed 1, so it is again an LR test.

The same rule applies to an alarm, whose likelihood ratio is the TPR divided by the FPR. Take the test with $\mu = 2$ in a population where 1% are positive. At an FPR of 0.05, a flagged case is positive with probability only 0.114, so most alarms are false. At an FPR of 10^{-3}, the ratio of the alarm is much larger, and that probability rises to 0.582. So when positives are rare, the FPR decides whether you can believe an alarm.

2.10. Measuring rates from finite trials

To measure the FPR of a detector, count the false positives among n test negatives. If the detector flags each negative independently with the same small probability, the count k is binomial and varies by about $\sqrt{k}$.

The **Clopper–Pearson interval** holds the true rates under which the observed count is not surprising. It is exact, because it uses the binomial itself, and conservative, because a 95% interval covers the true rate at least 95% of the time. In SciPy, it is `binomtest(k, n).proportion_ci(method="exact")`. A claim that an FPR is below a target needs only the upper end, which `alternative="less"` gives. With no events at all, the one-sided 95% bound is about $3/n$, the **rule of three**. The exact computation shows that an FPR below 10^{-3} needs 2,995 negatives with no false positive.

These intervals are wide. Even 10 false positives in 10,000 negatives give the interval $[0.00048, 0.00184]$, from about half to almost twice the observed rate. About 100 events fix a rate within about 20%, so an FPR of p needs about $100/p$ negatives. The **Wald interval** treats the count as normal and fails here, because it is too narrow and becomes $[0, 0]$ with no events.

2.11. Evaluating a detector at a low false positive rate

1. Fix the target FPRs, such as 10^{-2} and 10^{-3}.
2. Plan the trials with about $100/p$ negatives for a target FPR p.
3. Choose the threshold on the negatives of one split, and measure the rates on another. A threshold tuned on the evaluation set looks better there than it is. The calibration split needs as many negatives, because below one over their number, `np.quantile` only interpolates between the top scores.
4. Report the TPR and FPR measured at that threshold, with Clopper–Pearson intervals on the two, and the full ROC curve on log–log axes. A TPR read off the ROC curve of the test split is too high, because it picks its threshold on the test data.
5. Compare two detectors at the same FPR, never by AUC or accuracy alone. On a shared evaluation set, check the gap with McNemar's test, `binomtest(m1, m1 + m2, 0.5)`. Here m_1 and m_2 count the positives that only one of the two detectors catches.

The snippet runs steps 3 and 4 on scikit-learn's breast cancer dataset, with a logistic regression as the detector and malignant tumours as positives. It keeps 30% of the data for calibration and 30% for testing. For a target FPR of 1%, it puts the threshold at the 99th percentile of the benign scores in the calibration split.

```python
import numpy as np
from scipy.stats import binomtest
from sklearn.datasets import load_breast_cancer
from sklearn.linear_model import LogisticRegression
from sklearn.model_selection import train_test_split
from sklearn.pipeline import make_pipeline
from sklearn.preprocessing import StandardScaler

X, y = load_breast_cancer(return_X_y=True)
y = 1 - y  # make malignant (coded 0) the positive class
X_tr, X_ev, y_tr, y_ev = train_test_split(X, y, test_size=0.6, stratify=y, random_state=0)
X_cal, X_te, y_cal, y_te = train_test_split(X_ev, y_ev, test_size=0.5, stratify=y_ev, random
model = make_pipeline(StandardScaler(), LogisticRegression(max_iter=1000)).fit(X_tr, y_tr)
threshold = np.quantile(model.decision_function(X_cal[y_cal == 0]), 0.99)  # target FPR 1%,
s = model.decision_function(X_te)
pos, neg = s[y_te == 1] > threshold, s[y_te == 0] > threshold  # flagged positives, negative
tpr = binomtest(int(pos.sum()), pos.size).proportion_ci(method="exact")
fpr_upper = binomtest(int(neg.sum()), neg.size, alternative="less").proportion_ci(method="ex
print(pos.sum(), pos.size, f"{pos.mean():.3f} [{tpr.low:.3f}, {tpr.high:.3f}]")  # 56 63 0.8
print(neg.sum(), neg.size, f"{neg.mean():.4f} <= {fpr_upper:.4f}")  # 2 108 0.0185 <= 0.0571
```

The detector catches 56 of the 63 malignant test cases, a TPR of 0.889 with a 95% interval from 0.784 to 0.954. But the threshold for 1% flags 2 of the 108 benign test cases. From those counts, the one-sided 95% bound shows only that the FPR is below 0.0571. Step 2 asks for about 10,000 negatives at this target, so on a dataset this small, report the interval and do not claim the target.

2.12. Cheat sheet

Table 2.1.: The questions of this chapter and their answers.

Question	Answer
What is the best test?	Threshold the likelihood ratio, per group if groups score differently (Neyman–Pearson)
How good can any test be?	The trade-off curve; normal pair $G_\mu(\alpha) = \Phi(\Phi^{-1}(1-\alpha) - \mu)$
What does a capped ratio allow?	TPR $\leq e^\kappa$ FPR
What do accuracy and advantage measure?	Best advantage = TV, one point of the curve
Why is AUC not enough?	Equal AUC can hide a 12-fold gap in TPR at an FPR of 10^{-3}
What does a base rate do?	Posterior odds = prior odds × TPR/FPR
How sure is a measured rate?	Clopper–Pearson; zero events give about $3/n$ at 95%

Rules of thumb

- Plan for $100/p$ negatives, and use Clopper–Pearson, never Wald.
- Report TPR at fixed low FPRs on log–log axes, never AUC alone.

2.13. References

- Fawcett, "An introduction to ROC analysis" (Pattern Recognition Letters, 2006): ROC curves and their pitfalls.
- Brown, Cai & DasGupta, "Interval Estimation for a Binomial Proportion" (Statistical Science, 2001): why Wald fails and what to use.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

Part II.

Threat models and attacks

This part teaches you to attack your own models and releases before someone else does. You need the attacks even if you plan to use differential privacy, because they check that an implementation keeps its promise. Every attack here is a game, in which an adversary guesses a secret hidden in a model or a release. A guess counts only by how much it beats a baseline that never looks at the model.

Read Threat models and privacy games first and Membership inference second, then the chapter whose secret matches your question. For a trained model, Memorization and extraction looks for text the model memorized. In federated learning, Gradient inversion rebuilds a client's input from its updates. Two short reference pages cover rarer attacks: attribute inference looks for a person's sensitive field, and property inference for a fact about the whole training population.

For released data, read the last three chapters in order, because they tell one story. Records without names still fall to linkage. Records hidden in crowds still give away sensitive values. And accurate aggregates alone can give away the whole dataset (reconstruction attacks). So neither removing names nor releasing only aggregates is anonymization, and the next part starts from differential privacy instead.

Two lessons apply to every audit here. Report the true positive rate at a low false positive rate, such as one in a thousand, not accuracy or the area under the curve. And the worst-off records leak first, such as outliers, duplicates and people with a unique combination of attributes, so an average over all records misleads. A failed attack proves little, because it gives only a lower bound on the leak.

The part ends with a workflow, Pre-release privacy risk assessment. It fixes the blocking thresholds first, then reads the results of this part's audits against them and writes the decision down. At the end of the part, you can write a threat model and run a membership audit you can defend. You can also test a table for unique records, and decide if a model or a dataset is safe to release.

3. Threat models and privacy games

3.1. Why this matters

A hospital trains a model on patient records and offers it to doctors through a web service. The question "is the model private?" has no answer until you say against whom. One attacker reads only the labels the model returns. Another attacker holds the weights, knows the other patients or adds crafted records to the training data, so the answers differ. A **threat model** writes these assumptions down. With a threat model, an attack becomes a **game**: the adversary guesses a hidden **secret**, such as whether the model used one patient's record.

3.2. Writing down the threat model

Write the threat model before anyone runs an attack, because it decides which attacks to run and what result stops the release. In the worksheet, Table 3.1, the first six rows are the questions every threat model answers. The last two rows turn the answers into a test.

Table 3.1.: The threat-model worksheet.

Question	What to write down	Default when unsure
Goal: what is the secret?	Membership, an attribute of a known record, the records themselves, or a property of the whole dataset	Membership, the goal that differential privacy bounds directly
Access: what does the adversary see?	Labels only, scores, the weights, or the training transcript	The most anyone outside the training team can get
Behaviour: does it follow the rules?	Honest-but-curious, or malicious (poisoning, tampered models)	Malicious, if it runs any part of the system
Trust: who sees the raw data?	Central curator, local (data protected on each device before collection), or distributed	Central, only if the data holder is not an adversary
Side information: what does it know?	The population, public datasets, other records, the target's other fields	Every record except the target's
Unit: what is one record?	A row, a user, a household	The person, whenever one person has several rows

Question	What to write down	Default when unsure
Attack and metric	Membership: the strongest attack's true positive rate (TPR) at a low false positive rate (FPR). A table: unique share and smallest class. A language model: canary exposure and extraction	The row of the goal and artefact in the risk assessment's thresholds
Acceptable result	The number that blocks the release	Fixed before any attack is run

The access row has four levels: labels, scores, weights and the **transcript**. The transcript is everything that training exposed, such as the gradients of each step. Each level is enough to compute the one before it, so in this ordering, the **access chain**, more access never weakens the best attack. The chain compares the *best* attacks, not the ones someone tried, so "the attack we tried failed" proves little (Membership inference).

To fill the access row, read the serving code and the release plan. A service that returns probability vectors gives black-box access, and a checkpoint shared with a partner gives white-box access. A model in several deployments carries the risk of the most exposed one. For the behaviour row, an **honest-but-curious** adversary follows the protocol and analyses only what it sees. A **malicious** adversary may add crafted records to the training data, called **poisoning**, or send tampered models. If the party that collects the data may be an adversary, protect the data before they leave the user (Local, shuffle and distributed trust models).

You cannot see what else the adversary holds, so assume that it knows every record except the target's. The unit row decides what one guarantee covers: a guarantee per row covers each of a user's 200 rows, but not all 200 together.

For the hospital's classifier, the API returns class probabilities, so the goal is membership and the access is black-box scores. A doctor is honest-but-curious but may query adaptively, the side information is a public sample of the same population, and the unit is the patient. The release stops if the lower end of the TPR's interval at an FPR of 10^{-3} exceeds ten times that FPR. Fix that threshold before the attack runs, because a threshold chosen after the results can always pass them.

3.3. Scoring an attack against its baseline

In the membership game, a challenger flips a coin to decide whether to train the model with or without the target's record. The adversary then guesses whether the target is a **member**, that is, whether the model used its record.

The **true positive rate** is the fraction of members that the attack flags. The **false positive rate** is the fraction of non-members that it flags by mistake. Write π_1 for the chance that the

coin makes the target a member, the prior, and $\pi_0 = 1 - \pi_1$ for the opposite. The attack wins with probability

$$\Pr[\text{win}] = \pi_1 \,\text{TPR} + \pi_0 \,(1 - \text{FPR}). \tag{3.1}$$

The two rates do not depend on the prior, but this win rate, the accuracy, does. If only one target in ten is a member, the guess "not a member" wins $\pi_0 = 90\%$ of the games without looking at the model. So score every attack against a **baseline**, the best score of a guess that never looks at the model.

With a fair prior, $\pi_1 = \pi_0 = 1/2$, the baseline is one half. The attack's **advantage** is how far its TPR exceeds its FPR. With the fair prior in the win rate,

$$\Pr[\text{win}] = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2}\,(\text{TPR} - \text{FPR}). \tag{3.2}$$

So an attack with 55% accuracy at a fair prior has an advantage of 0.1. Unlike the accuracy, the advantage does not change with the prior. Differential privacy caps every attack's advantage, through the total variation distance of Divergences.

3.4. Reporting: TPR at a low FPR

An attack scores each target and flags those above a threshold. Its **receiver operating characteristic (ROC)** curve plots its TPR against its FPR as that threshold moves, and the advantage is the curve's largest height above the diagonal. The advantage and the area under the curve both hide the region where false positives are rare, which is where privacy breaks. For example, an attack that flags 1% of members with no false alarms has a tiny advantage, yet it identifies those members with certainty. So report membership attacks by their TPR at a low FPR such as 10^{-3}, as Carlini et al. (2022) do.

A flagged person cares about the chance that the verdict is right, the **precision**,

$$\Pr[\text{member} \mid \text{flagged}] = \frac{\pi_1 \,\text{TPR}}{\pi_1 \,\text{TPR} + \pi_0 \,\text{FPR}}. \tag{3.3}$$

When members are rare, π_0 is large, so even a small FPR on the many non-members swamps the true positives. For example, take a count of people with a condition, released with Gaussian noise of standard deviation 1. A member adds 1 to the count, so an adversary who knows every other record flags the target when the count is high. At an FPR of 10^{-3}, it catches members with probability 0.0183. At a fair prior the two halves of the prior cancel, so its precision is $0.0183/(0.0183 + 0.001) = 0.948$. If only one target in a hundred is a member, the precision drops to 0.156, so never quote a precision without its prior.

Each rate comes from a finite set of targets, so it needs an interval. The recipe of Hypothesis testing plans about $100/\alpha$ non-members for an FPR of α, so that about 100 false positives fix the rate. It sets the threshold on one split, measures on another, and puts a Clopper–Pearson interval on each rate.

The snippet below applies a short form of the recipe to the black-box membership attack of the Adversarial Robustness Toolbox (ART). The target is a random forest trained on half of scikit-learn's 569 breast cancer records. The attacker trains its attack on every other record, whose membership it knows, and reads the TPR on the rest at an FPR of at most 0.01. It sets the threshold on those same scores.

```
import numpy as np
from art.attacks.inference.membership_inference import MembershipInferenceBlackBox
from art.estimators.classification import SklearnClassifier
from scipy.stats import binomtest
from sklearn.datasets import load_breast_cancer
from sklearn.ensemble import RandomForestClassifier
from sklearn.metrics import auc, roc_curve

np.random.seed(0)  # ART's attack model draws from NumPy's global generator
x, y = load_breast_cancer(return_X_y=True)
member = np.random.default_rng(0).random(len(y)) < 0.5  # the target's training records
target = SklearnClassifier(RandomForestClassifier(random_state=0).fit(x[member], y[member]))
known = np.arange(len(y)) % 2 == 0  # records whose membership the attacker knows, to train
attack = MembershipInferenceBlackBox(target, attack_model_type="rf")
attack.fit(x[known & member], y[known & member], x[known & ~member], y[known & ~member])
fpr, tpr, _ = roc_curve(member[~known], attack.infer(x[~known], y[~known], probabilities=Tru
i = np.flatnonzero(fpr <= 0.01)[-1]  # the best TPR whose FPR is at most 0.01
n_in, n_out = int(member[~known].sum()), int((~member[~known]).sum())
tp, fp = round(tpr[i] * n_in), round(fpr[i] * n_out)
print(f"AUC={auc(fpr, tpr):.3f}  TP={tp} of {n_in}  FP={fp} of {n_out}")  # AUC=0.552  TP=3
t, f = (binomtest(k, n).proportion_ci(method="exact") for k, n in ((tp, n_in), (fp, n_out)))
print(f"TPR 95% CI [{t.low:.4f}, {t.high:.4f}]  FPR 95% CI [{f.low:.4f}, {f.high:.4f}]")  #
```

With only 151 non-members, the smallest FPR above zero is one in 151, far above one in a thousand. So the FPR's interval runs from 0.0002 to 0.0363, and it overlaps the TPR's interval, from 0.0047 to 0.0645. So this test cannot show that the attack beats chance at a low FPR, and its area under the ROC curve, 0.552, adds little. At 10^{-3} the recipe asks for about 100,000 non-members, which is why audits retrain many models on many records (Membership inference).

So report the TPR at a stated low FPR, with its counts, an interval on each rate and the ROC curve on log axes. Also give the worksheet's threat model, the baseline, the prior behind any precision, and whether the targets were random or chosen worst cases.

3.5. Average case and worst case

An evaluation that draws the data and the target from the population measures the **average case**. If the adversary knows or picks the other records and the target, the evaluation measures the **worst case**. Audits of real models measure the first, a guarantee must control the second, and the gap can be large. In the noisy count, the adversary who knows the other records has an advantage of 0.3829. If 100 of those records are fair coins unknown to the adversary, their sum blurs the count like extra noise, and the advantage falls to 0.0779. But an adversary who planted the other records knows them, so a defence that relies on the crowd fails against the adversary it most needs to stop.

An average over targets also hides the worst-treated person, because a few exposed outliers barely move it. So treat an average-case number as a lower bound on the risk. Audits close the gap with

canaries, records built to be as exposed as possible (Memorization and training-data extraction). Differential privacy bounds the worst case directly.

3.6. Cheat sheet

Table 3.2.: The results of this chapter.

Quantity	Formula	Use it for
Advantage	$\mathrm{TPR} - \mathrm{FPR}$	Comparing attacks at any prior; 0 means no attack
Precision	$\pi_1\mathrm{TPR}/(\pi_1\mathrm{TPR} + \pi_0\mathrm{FPR})$	What a flagged person faces; state the prior

Rules of thumb

- Fill in the worksheet, including the blocking threshold, before running or reading any attack.
- Assume the adversary knows the other records, and audit with worst-case canaries.

3.7. References

- Salem et al., "SoK: Let the Privacy Games Begin! A Unified Treatment of Data Inference Privacy in Machine Learning" (IEEE S&P 2023): every inference attack written as a game.
- Carlini, Chien, Nasr, Song, Terzis & Tramèr, "Membership Inference Attacks From First Principles" (IEEE S&P 2022): the case for reporting TPR at a low FPR on log-scaled ROC curves.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

4. Membership inference

4.1. Why this matters

A hospital publishes a model that predicts a disease, and you hold a patient's record. **Was that record in the training set?** If it was, the patient had that disease and was treated there. This question is **membership inference**, the standard measure of leakage, because a model that cannot hide its use of a record hides little else. Membership is a test about one record, so the attack for an audit compares each record with itself.

4.2. Membership as a test about one record

In the game of Threat models and privacy games, the attacker gets a training member or a fresh record and says "member" or "not". Its score is its **true positive rate (TPR)**, the share of members it flags, and its **false positive rate (FPR)**, the share of non-members it flags.

Fix a target record, written z, and look at the model's output on it, such as its loss. Retrain on fresh random draws of the data. The output then has an **IN** distribution over the runs that include z and an **OUT** distribution over the runs without it. The best test of membership compares their likelihoods at the observed output (the Neyman–Pearson lemma), so it does well only where the two lie far apart.

A typical record's two distributions almost overlap, because the rest of the data already predict it. An outlier's lie far apart, because the model gets it right only after training on it. So the records an attack finds at a low FPR are mostly outliers.

The numbers in this chapter come from practitioner_lira.py. It trains 64 logistic-regression classifiers, each on a random half of scikit-learn's 1,797 images of handwritten digits. Each model in turn is the target, and the other 63 are the attacker's **shadow models**, copies trained the same way on images the attacker knows.

4.3. The quick check: the generalization gap

Before any attack, compare the training and test errors. A model gets members right more often than fresh records, so Yeom et al. (2018) used the attack "member if the label is right". When members and non-members come from the same population, its advantage, the TPR minus the FPR, equals the gap between the two errors:

$$\text{Adv} = \text{test error} - \text{training error}. \tag{4.1}$$

On the digits, averaged over the 64 models, the gap is 0.0422.

So a large gap shows a leak at no cost. But **a small gap does not mean a private model**, because the gap averages over records and hides who is exposed. For example, the loss attack flags every record with a loss below one threshold. At an FPR of 10^{-3} it reaches a TPR of 0.0009 on the digits, no better than a coin that says "member" one time in a thousand.

The classic attack of Shokri et al. (2017) also applies one rule to all records, which it learns from shadow models. The script runs it from the Adversarial Robustness Toolbox (ART), a Python library of attacks, with four shadow models.

```
# ART copies the target's recipe and trains each shadow on a random half of the images.
shadows = ShadowModels(models.first, num_shadow_models=N_ART_SHADOWS, random_state=seed)
(x_in, y_in, pred_in), (x_out, y_out, pred_out) = shadows.generate_shadow_dataset(x, onehot)
# One attack model learns "member" from a shadow's probabilities and the true label.
attack = MembershipInferenceBlackBox(models.first, attack_model_type="rf")
attack.fit(x_in, y_in, x_out, y_out, pred=pred_in, test_pred=pred_out)
# The same attack model scores every target's probabilities on every image.
scores = [attack.infer(x, onehot, pred=p, probabilities=True)[:, 0] for p in models.probs]
```

Its one rule also fails at a low FPR: it finds only 0.0014 of the members at an FPR of 10^{-3}.

4.4. LiRA: a likelihood-ratio test per record

The likelihood ratio attack (LiRA) of Carlini et al. (2022) uses the shadow models to estimate each record's own IN and OUT distributions instead. Its statistic is the logit of the model's confidence p_y in the true label y,

$$\phi = \ln \frac{p_y}{1 - p_y}. \tag{4.2}$$

It uses the logit because the logit is close to normal over retrainings, while the confidence itself piles up against 1. For each record, the attacker fits a normal distribution to the record's logit in the shadow models that trained on it. Its mean is written μ_{in} and its standard deviation σ_{in}. A second fit, in the other shadow models, has mean μ_{out} and standard deviation σ_{out}.

Online LiRA scores the target model's logit ϕ_z on the record by how much more likely it is under the IN fit than under the OUT fit. With $\mathcal{N}(\phi; \mu, \sigma^2)$ for the normal density, the score is

$$\ln \Lambda_z = \ln \mathcal{N}(\phi_z;\, \mu_{\text{in}}, \sigma_{\text{in}}^2) - \ln \mathcal{N}(\phi_z;\, \mu_{\text{out}}, \sigma_{\text{out}}^2). \tag{4.3}$$

Offline LiRA uses only OUT models. They do not contain the record under test, so you can train them once and use them again for every new record. Its score is the number of OUT standard deviations by which the logit lies above its usual value,

$$\frac{\phi_z - \mu_{\text{out}}}{\sigma_{\text{out}}}. \tag{4.4}$$

Each score already compares a record with its own fits, so one threshold works for all records. In the script, ART's `SklearnClassifier` wraps the scikit-learn recipe, trains every model and returns its probabilities.

```
# Each image is in each model's training set with probability 1/2.
member = rng.random((n_models, n)) < 0.5
for k in range(n_models):
    model = recipe()  # a fresh, untrained copy of the target's recipe
    model.fit(x[member[k]], onehot[member[k]])
    probs[k] = model.predict(x)  # the probabilities the attacker sees, for every image
    p = np.clip(probs[k, np.arange(n), y], 1e-15, 1 - 1e-15)  # confidence on the true label
    phi[k] = np.log(p) - np.log(1 - p)  # its logit, close to Gaussian over retrainings
    confidence[k] = p
```

No library installed with this book computes the LiRA scores, so `lira_scores` in practitioner_privacy_tests.py fits the two normals per image and returns Equation 4.3 and Equation 4.4. The command `uv run python code/part02-attacks/practitioner_lira.py` runs in seconds. It compares the attacks by their TPR at two low FPRs and by their area under the curve (AUC) of the TPR against the FPR.

```
  loss attack: AUC=0.518  TPR@0.001=0.0009  TPR@0.01=0.0105
  ART shadow-model attack: AUC=0.570  TPR@0.001=0.0014  TPR@0.01=0.0146
  LiRA offline: AUC=0.577  TPR@0.001=0.0087  TPR@0.01=0.0345
  LiRA online: AUC=0.623  TPR@0.001=0.0318  TPR@0.01=0.0790
  LiRA online, global variance: AUC=0.614  TPR@0.001=0.0250  TPR@0.01=0.0737
```

By AUC the attacks look close, and ART's attack nearly matches offline LiRA. At an FPR of 10^{-3} they are far apart: online LiRA finds 0.0318 of the members and the loss attack only 0.0009. All the attacks see the same model outputs, so the whole gain comes from the comparison of each record's output with its own fits.

Noisy fits are the main practical failure, because each record's variance comes from only about half the shadow models. A variance that is too small makes an ordinary output look like a far-tail event. So with few shadow models, Carlini et al. recommend one **global variance** for all records. It makes 16 shadows usable, while variances per record need about 64.

4.5. Running LiRA on your model

The recipe is the same for any model. Train the target and its shadows each on a random half of the data pool, all with exactly the target's recipe. A shadow trained differently, even with another augmentation, estimates the wrong distributions. With the shadows trained, fit the IN and OUT normals to each record's logits. Then let each model in turn be the target, and score every pair of target model and record. Pre-release privacy risk assessment reads the result of this run against its release rule.

For a confident model, the confidence p_y in the true label nears 1, so $1 - p_y$ rounds to 0 and the logit becomes infinite. Compute the logit from the class scores f before the softmax, as $f_y - \ln \sum_{y' \neq y} e^{f_{y'}}$, or from `log_softmax`.

Do not clip the probabilities instead. On a nearly separable model most confidences hit the clip, so their fits have no spread. Those pairs then drop out, with the most exposed records among

them. Treat such dropped pairs as a failed audit. The script clips only because no digits model comes near the clip.

Draw members and non-members from one pool, split at random. If non-members come from a later period, another site or another preprocessing pipeline, the attack measures that shift rather than the model.

Returning only labels does not stop the attack, because a label-only attack measures how much an input must change before its label flips (Choquette-Choo et al. 2021). Among libraries, ML Privacy Meter implements LiRA, while TensorFlow Privacy's `run_attacks` and ART's `MembershipInferenceBlackBox` treat all records alike.

A change to training can make a model leak, so run a cheaper LiRA again on every release candidate. Train 16 models with the candidate's own recipe and score online LiRA with a global variance. On the digits, `practitioner_lira.py --models 16` runs in seconds and blocks the model under the release rule of the next section, as the 64-model run does. Compare candidates by their intervals, because their point values differ by seed noise alone.

4.6. Reading the result

Report the TPR at an FPR of 10^{-3} or lower, with the receiver operating characteristic (ROC) curve on log axes. Put a Clopper–Pearson interval on each rate, as in Part 1's recipe for evaluating a detector at a low FPR. That recipe also sets the thresholds on a separate split, which the script, like the literature, does not do.

```
LiRA offline: TP=502/57704  TPR=0.0087 [0.0080, 0.0095]  FP=56/57304  FPR=0.00098 [0.00074
LiRA online: TP=1833/57704  TPR=0.0318 [0.0303, 0.0332]  FP=57/57304  FPR=0.00099 [0.00075
```

The last word on each line applies the risk assessment's blocking rule. The rule blocks a release when, at an FPR of 10^{-3}, the lower end of the TPR's 95% interval is above ten times that FPR. Online LiRA's lower end, 0.0303, is above 0.01, so it blocks this model, which offline LiRA alone would pass. For online LiRA, $\ln(\text{TPR}/\text{FPR}) = 3.46$ estimates how large the privacy level ε of differential privacy (Part 3) must be to allow this attack. It is not a certified lower bound, because the pairs share models and so are not independent trials, unlike the canaries of Auditing.

4.7. Who is exposed, and what helps

The records an attack scores highest are usually outliers, rare subgroups or mislabelled points, which the rest of the data do not predict. On the digits, the most exposed image is a 9. The models give it confidence 0.812 when they trained on it and 0.003 when they did not. So online LiRA flags this 9 at an FPR of 10^{-3} in all 33 target models that trained on it.

Removing the exposed records does not help, because the next layer then becomes exposed, the onion effect of Carlini et al. (2022b). A smaller generalization gap is not enough either, because the worst records, not the average, set the low-FPR end. Differential privacy does help. Private training limits how far any one record can move the model, and so how far apart every record's

IN and OUT distributions can lie. Expect a trade-off, because when many subgroups are rare, the model can need to memorize them to be accurate (Feldman 2020).

4.8. Cheat sheet

Table 4.1.: Which attack or check to use.

Situation	Use	Notes
A first look, no attack budget	Test error − training error	A lower bound on the leak; a small gap proves nothing
A release decision	Online LiRA, Equation 4.3, 64 shadows	Report TPR at FPR 10^{-3} with intervals
Few shadow models	Online LiRA with a global variance	16 shadows are usable this way

Rules of thumb

- Audit with LiRA. A failed weak attack, such as a global loss threshold, is not evidence of safety.

4.9. References

- Carlini, Chien, Nasr, Song, Terzis & Tramèr, "Membership Inference Attacks From First Principles" (IEEE S&P 2022): LiRA, the global variance, and the audit protocol.
- Yeom, Giacomelli, Fredrikson & Jha, "Privacy Risk in Machine Learning: Analyzing the Connection to Overfitting" (IEEE CSF 2018): the loss attack and its link to the generalization gap.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

5. Attribute inference and model inversion

5.1. What it is

An **attribute inference** attack uses a trained model to recover a sensitive field of a person's record, such as smoking status, from the fields the attacker knows. For example, an insurer who knows your age and diagnosis could query a hospital's model of the disease from age and smoking, and guess if you smoke. But a published study on smoking allows the same guess, so success alone is not a privacy failure. What matters is whether the model reveals more about you because it trained on your record.

Yeom et al. (2018) turned this question into a game (Threat models and privacy games). A fair coin decides whether the target is a training record, a **member**, or a fresh draw from the same population. The attacker knows the target's public features and label, queries the model and guesses the sensitive value. Its score is the **attribute advantage**,

$$\mathrm{Adv}^{\mathrm{attr}} = \Pr[\text{guess right} \mid \text{member}] - \Pr[\text{guess right} \mid \text{non-member}]. \tag{5.1}$$

A guess from the whole population alone, called **population inference**, helps members and non-members equally, because both come from that population. So it cancels in the difference, and what is left is the leak about individuals.

5.2. When you meet it

You meet it when someone claims that "the model reveals" a sensitive field, or asks if a model is safe without a column. Only the extra success on members is then a privacy leak. Success up to what the population allows exists without the person's record, so it is a question for policy and fairness.

5.3. How to use it

Start with the **imputation baseline**, the success of the best guess of the sensitive value from the public features and label, without the model. Many published attacks do no better (Jayaraman & Evans 2022), so it is the number to beat. To estimate it, fit a classifier for the sensitive field on population records the model never saw.

Then run the attack. **Model inversion** (Fredrikson et al. 2014) scores each candidate value s of the sensitive field by two numbers. The first is the probability $p(s \mid x)$ that a person with the target's public features x has that value, estimated from population data. The second is $f_y(x, s)$,

the model's confidence in the known label y on input x with the candidate. The attack guesses the value that maximizes their product,

$$\hat{s} = \arg\max_{s} \; p(s \mid x)\, f_y(x, s). \tag{5.2}$$

Give the attacker every column it could hold, because a near-copy of the sensitive field, such as relationship next to marital status, moves the baseline most. Run the attack on training members and on as many held-out non-members. Report the baseline and the two success rates with confidence intervals. Also put an interval on the advantage, because Pre-release privacy risk assessment blocks a release when that interval lies above zero.

The script practitioner_attribute.py, run with `uv run python code/part02-attacks/practitioner_attribut` applies the Adversarial Robustness Toolbox (ART) to Adult, the census records of 45,222 people. A random forest predicts from every column if income exceeds $50K, and sex is the sensitive field. The attacker holds 4,000 records of its own, and everyone's other columns and income.

```
def label(rows: IntArray) -> Array:  # the label the model returns for each record, as a col
    return np.argmax(target.predict(x[rows]), axis=1).reshape(-1, 1).astype(np.float64)

np.random.seed(seed)  # ART builds its random forests unseeded, from NumPy's global generato
attack = AttributeInferenceBlackBox(target, attack_model_type="rf", attack_feature=SENSITIVE
attack.fit(x[attacker])  # the attacker's own records, sensitive field included
baseline = AttributeInferenceBaselineTrueLabel(attack_model_type="rf", attack_feature=SENSIT
baseline.fit(x[attacker], y[attacker])  # the same records and the true label, without the m
hits: dict[str, list[int]] = {}
for name, rows in (("members", members), ("non-members", others)):
    known = np.delete(x[rows], SENSITIVE, axis=1)  # everything but the sensitive field
    guess = attack.infer(known, pred=label(rows), values=[0.0, 1.0])
    imputed = baseline.infer(known, y=y[rows], values=[0.0, 1.0])
    hits[name] = [int(np.count_nonzero(np.equal(g.ravel(), female[rows]))) for g in (guess,
```

```
ART black-box attack: right on members 0.8300 [0.8180, 0.8415]  on non-members 0.8423 [0.830
ART black-box attack: advantage -0.0123 [-0.0285, +0.0040]
imputation baseline: right on members 0.8307 [0.8188, 0.8423]  on non-members 0.8417 [0.8301
```

The attack is right on 0.8300 of the members, and the baseline, which never queries the model, on 0.8307. So the success comes from the population, and the advantage's interval contains zero, which passes the rule. On a synthetic population the full edition does find a small leak. There, inversion is right on 0.7832 of members and 0.7262 of non-members, an advantage of 0.0569.

5.4. What goes wrong

The most common error is one success rate, such as that 0.7832 on members, without the baseline and the rate on non-members. That report overstates the leak. A rate on fresh records only understates it, because a model is surer of the true label on its own members (Membership inference).

A model without the sensitive column still allows population inference, because the column's correlates remain. **Confidence masking**, which rounds the confidences or returns only the top label, puts no bound on the gap between members and non-members. The gap can even grow. In the full edition's experiment, labels only raised the advantage from 0.0569 to 0.0650, because success fell more on non-members than on members. Less overfitting shrinks the gap, and differential privacy bounds it for every attacker and every output format.

5.5. References

- Fredrikson, Jha & Ristenpart, "Model Inversion Attacks that Exploit Confidence Information and Basic Countermeasures" (CCS 2015): inversion from confidences, and rounding as a countermeasure.
- Jayaraman & Evans, "Are Attribute Inference Attacks Just Imputation?" (CCS 2022): the imputation baseline, and what it takes to beat it.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

6. Property inference

6.1. What it is

A **property** is a fact about a training set as a whole, such as the share of a hospital's patients who are over 65. **Property inference** recovers it from a trained model. In the property game (Threat models and privacy games), a fair coin picks one of two shares for a subgroup, and the owner trains on data with that share. The attacker knows the two shares and the training method, and guesses the share. So a random guess is right half the time.

A property can leak when no single record does. Write n for the number of training records and g for the gap between the two shares. A switch of shares changes about ng records at once, so it moves the model far more than one record can. So the leak grows with n, while the risk to one record shrinks.

Even a release of only the exact count of subgroup records shows this gap. With 10,000 records, the best guess of whether one patient is in the data is right with probability 0.502. The best guess of whether the share was 0.45 or 0.55 is right with probability 1.0000.

6.2. When you meet it

You meet it when you share or publish a model trained on your organization's data. First decide if the property is a secret, that is, if it describes the *data owner* rather than the world. One hospital's patient mix is a secret, but the fact that smokers get more lung cancer is the point of a medical study. If the property is not a secret, write that in the threat model of Pre-release privacy risk assessment and move on.

If the property is a secret, differential privacy (DP) does not protect it. DP protects one record at a time, and its guarantee for a group is the privacy level ε times the group's size (Post-processing, group privacy and composition). For a hospital of 1,000 patients and shares a tenth apart, the group is the $ng = 100$ patients that differ between the two datasets. So the property gets only 100ε, which promises nothing at any useful ε.

6.3. How to use it

To measure the risk, run the shadow-model attack of Ateniese et al. (2015), which treats whole models as data points. Draw many datasets of your training set's size at each share, from data of the same population. Train a **shadow model** on each with your architecture and training code, and record its outputs on a fixed set of probe inputs.

With the outputs recorded, fit a linear **meta-classifier**, such as scikit-learn's `LogisticRegression`, to tell the two shares apart from those outputs. Its accuracy on held-out shadow models is the attack's accuracy. If the property is a secret, block the release when the interval on that accuracy lies above one half (Pre-release privacy risk assessment).

Use probe outputs rather than raw weights. A new order of the hidden units, or a sign flip of tanh units, changes the weights but not the network's function. So on the full edition's small tanh networks, every raw weight averages to zero under the two shares. A linear meta-classifier scores 0.497 on raw weights, which is chance, and 1.000 on the probe outputs. Probes need only query access, so a model behind an application programming interface is exposed too.

6.4. What goes wrong

The most common error is to assume that DP, or a passed membership audit, covers the property. A weak measured attack is not evidence of safety either, because a meta-classifier fitted to noisy shadow models finds a small shift badly.

No defence is cheap. A model without the group column still sees its correlates, and noise that hides ng records destroys the model's use. So if the property is a secret, do not release a model trained on that mix. If you must release it, report the attack's accuracy and say in the release notes that DP protects individuals only.

6.5. References

- Ganju, Wang, Yang, Gunter & Borisov, "Property Inference Attacks on Fully Connected Neural Networks using Permutation Invariant Representations" (CCS 2018): the practical attack on neural networks, and why raw weights fail.
- Zhang, Tople & Ohrimenko, "Leakage of Dataset Properties in Multi-Party Machine Learning" (USENIX Security 2021): property inference through queries alone.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

7. Memorization and training-data extraction

7.1. Why this matters

A language model trained on scraped text or support tickets sees phone numbers, addresses, keys and private messages. Asked to continue "Anna Smith's phone number is", it may finish with the real number. This is **training-data extraction**. Membership inference needs the record in hand to ask whether it was used, while extraction hands the attacker the record itself.

7.2. Which memorization to measure

The notions of memorization in Table 7.1 give rates that differ by orders of magnitude, so a report must say which one it measures. All use greedy decoding, which writes out the most likely next token at each step.

Table 7.1.: The notions of memorization and when to use each. The first three are verbatim, needing an exact match, and each implies approximate. Discoverable implies extractable.

Definition	The string counts as memorized if	Use it for
Discoverable (Carlini et al. 2023)	The text before it in the training data makes greedy decoding produce it	Measuring memorization on a model you own
Extractable (Carlini et al. 2021)	Some prompt, any at all, makes greedy decoding produce it	The real risk, which attacks find but no test measures
k-eidetic	It is extractable and appears in at most k documents	Flagging the dangerous case, $k = 1$
Approximate (Ippolito et al. 2023)	Greedy decoding comes within a set edit distance of it	Near copies, such as a number with one digit changed

Discoverable memorization is the one you can measure, because you hold the training text it uses as the prompt. Treat any verbatim rate as a lower bound on the leak, because near copies leak too. A filter that blocks only verbatim training text is easy to bypass (Ippolito et al. 2023).

Deployed systems sample rather than decode greedily, so whether a string comes out depends on how many samples the attacker draws. A sample at temperature 1 writes out a string with

probability p, the model's probability of that string after the prompt. Write β for the chance of failure the attacker accepts. Then a number m of independent samples suffices when

$$m \geq \frac{\ln(1/\beta)}{p}. \tag{7.1}$$

For a string of probability 10^{-3} and $\beta = 0.01$, that is about 4,600 samples. So report a sampling budget alongside the greedy rate, and measure with the decoding settings you deploy.

7.3. What gets memorized, and the first defences

Memorization grows with the copies of a string. On open models, the largest reproduced at least 1% of its training data in the discoverable sense (Carlini et al. 2023). A sequence repeated ten times is generated about a thousand times more often than one seen once (Kandpal, Wallace & Raffel 2022).

So the cheapest defence is **deduplication**, which lowers the copies of every repeated string. Models trained on deduplicated data emit memorized text about ten times less often, at the same quality (Lee et al. 2022). Deduplicate before you plant the canaries of the next section, so that only they carry known copy counts.

The second defence removes personal data before training. A detector of personally identifiable information (PII), such as Microsoft's Presidio, finds names, phone numbers and similar fields so that you can mask them. But it misses whatever its patterns do not cover. Neither defence helps a secret seen once in a large model, where one copy is enough. Only fine-tuning with differential privacy, which limits how much any one training sequence can change the model, gives a guarantee for such singletons.

7.4. Auditing with canaries and exposure

Discoverable memorization is all or nothing, while an auditor wants a graded answer. Carlini et al. (2019) plant **canaries**, random secrets of a fixed format such as "my pin is" followed by five random digits. After training, you order all the values the secret could have taken from the most to the least likely under the model. The planted value's **rank** in that order is the number of guesses an attacker needs if it tries them in turn.

Write $\hat{r}$ for the planted value and $|\mathcal{R}|$ for the number of values in the set $\mathcal{R}$ it could have taken. The **exposure** is the number of bits of search the model saves an attacker,

$$\text{exposure}(\hat{r}) = \log_2 |\mathcal{R}| - \log_2 \text{rank}(\hat{r}). \tag{7.2}$$

Each bit halves the guesses the attacker needs. At rank 1 the exposure reaches its maximum, $\log_2 |\mathcal{R}|$, and the secret can be extracted. For five digits, 10^5 values, the maximum is 16.61 bits.

Exposure works as an audit because we know how it behaves when the model memorized nothing. The canary's value is uniformly random, so a model that never saw it gives it a uniformly random rank. So for any threshold of t bits,

$$\Pr\left[\text{exposure}(\hat{r}) \geq t\right] \leq 2^{-t}. \tag{7.3}$$

So $2^{-\text{exposure}}$ bounds the p-value, the chance that an uninserted canary would look at least this memorized. The same uniform rank gives an uninserted canary an average exposure of $\log_2 e$, about 1.44 bits, which the controls should match.

To run the audit, draw canaries in the format of the secrets your data could contain. A format unlike your data measures only how the model treats unfamiliar text. Insert each canary a chosen number of times, from once to many, keep some never inserted as controls, and fine-tune as usual. Then score each canary's value, and many random values of the same format, by the model's log-probability after the prefix. The share of random values that score at least as high estimates the **rank fraction**, the rank divided by $|\mathcal{R}|$. Minus its base-2 logarithm is the exposure.

Most audits go wrong at the scoring step. A candidate's log-probability is the sum over its tokens, but the mean loss that Hugging Face models return divides that sum by the number of tokens. Values of different token lengths then get scores on different scales, and the ranking is wrong. So score every candidate by its summed log-probability, in a format where every candidate has the same number of tokens. For example, write a pin as "the pin of Alice is 8 6 5 2 3", so that each digit is one token.

Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA runs this audit on Pythia-14m, a small language model, and shows the code and its output. It inserts three canaries at each copy count from 1 to 64 into 1,024 sequences of Tiny Shakespeare. It keeps three more as controls and ranks each value among 2,000 random candidates. Exposure rises with the copies, and the controls sit at 1.4 bits, as the 1.44 expected for them predicts. Greedy decoding extracts only the three canaries seen 64 times. Yet two of the canaries seen 4 times reach 6.9 and 8.2 bits, which no extraction test notices. So an audit measures exposure and not only extraction.

The 2,000 candidates set a cap on the measured exposure. A canary that beats all of them shows only that its rank fraction is below about 1 in 2,000. So its exposure stops at $\log_2 2000 = 10.97$ bits. Past the cap, fit a skew-normal distribution to the candidates' scores and read the canary's rank off its tail, as Carlini et al. (2019) do. Ties also hide memorization, because when every candidate gets the same score, every exposure is 0.

A canary repeated 16 or more times is the positive control. If it does not reach a high exposure without privacy, the run is too short to tell you anything. In that run the canaries fill a quarter of the training set, which lets so small a model memorize them. Pre-release privacy risk assessment sets the exposure that blocks a release.

7.5. Extraction without the prefix: generate, rank, verify

A real attacker has only the model. Carlini et al. (2021) extracted data from GPT-2 in three steps. They generated many samples, ranked them by how likely each was to be memorized, and checked the top ones. The ranking is the hard step, because a model finds a string likely either because it is ordinary text or because it memorized it. A **reference model**, trained on similar data but not on the target's training set, stands in for ordinary text. Write $p_\theta(x)$ for the target model's probability of a string x, and $p_{\text{ref}}(x)$ for the reference's. Rank by the log-likelihood ratio

$$\Lambda(x) = \ln p_\theta(x) - \ln p_{\text{ref}}(x). \tag{7.4}$$

The ratio cancels the strings that any model finds likely, such as software licences and boilerplate. Raw likelihood would put these first, and they reveal nothing. A crude reference, such as a smaller model of the same family, works. To audit your own fine-tuned model, use the base model as the reference.

Without the prefix, an attacker extracts less than the discoverable rate suggests, but aligned production models are not safe. Nasr et al. (2023) asked ChatGPT to repeat one word forever, until it left its aligned behaviour and wrote memorized text. For about 200 US dollars of queries, they extracted over 10,000 records.

7.6. Cheat sheet

Table 7.2.: The results of this chapter.

Question	Answer
Exposure of a canary	$\log_2\lvert\mathcal{R}\rvert - \log_2$ rank, at most 16.61 bits for five digits; p-value at most $2^{-\text{exposure}}$; controls average 1.44 bits
How to score a candidate	Summed log-probability, in a format where all candidates have the same token count
Ranking generations	$\ln p_\theta(x) - \ln p_{\text{ref}}(x)$, never raw likelihood
Defences, in order	Deduplicate (`deduplicate-text-datasets`, `datasketch`), scrub PII, then differential privacy for singletons

Rules of thumb

- A verbatim rate is a lower bound on the leak, not a measure of it.

7.7. References

- Carlini, Liu, Erlingsson, Kos & Song, "The Secret Sharer: Evaluating and Testing Unintended Memorization in Neural Networks" (USENIX Security 2019): canaries, exposure and how to estimate it.
- Carlini, Ippolito, Jagielski, Lee, Tramèr & Zhang, "Quantifying Memorization Across Neural Language Models" (ICLR 2023): how memorization scales with duplication, model size and prompt length.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

8. Gradient inversion

8.1. Why this matters

In **federated learning (FL)**, a server sends the current model to each phone or other client. The client computes the gradient of the loss on its own few records and sends back only that gradient. The server averages the gradients and takes a training step. People often call this private because "the data stay on the device".

Yet one client's gradient can give back all of that client's data, because many of its derivatives are simple functions of the input. An average over a batch protects much less than people expect (Section 8.6). So treat each client's update as being as sensitive as the data it came from.

8.2. The attacker and what it sees

The attacker is the server, which knows every parameter because it sent the model out, and which also sees each client's own update. So its access is the **transcript** of Threat models and privacy games, everything that training exposes. Assume first that the server is **honest-but-curious**, so that it only analyses what it receives. Each client holds a batch of B records and sends the average of their gradients. Write ℓ_i for the loss on record i, which depends on all the parameters θ. The client then sends

$$g = \frac{1}{B} \sum_{i=1}^{B} \nabla_\theta \ell_i. \tag{8.1}$$

8.3. Exact recovery from a fully connected layer

The most common first layer, a fully connected layer with a bias, gives its input back by one division. Write W_1 and b_1 for its weights and bias. Each unit j multiplies the input x by its row of weights and adds its bias. Its backward signal u_j is how fast the loss responds to the unit's output. The chain rule turns this signal into the weight and bias gradients

$$\nabla_{W_1} \ell = u\, x^\top, \qquad \nabla_{b_1} \ell = u. \tag{8.2}$$

So row j of the weight gradient is the input scaled by u_j, and the bias gradient of unit j is that same scale. For a single record, divide one by the other. This gives the input exactly, for every unit whose bias gradient is not zero:

$$x = \frac{(\nabla_{W_1} \ell)_{j,:}}{(\nabla_{b_1} \ell)_j}. \tag{8.3}$$

Everything above the layer, including the network's depth, the loss and the label, sits inside u_j and cancels. So the attack needs no optimization and no knowledge of the data. The snippet below plays one client with one image of scikit-learn's digits in PyTorch. Its last line reads the label, as Section 8.4 explains.

```
import torch
import torch.nn.functional as F
from sklearn.datasets import load_digits

torch.manual_seed(0)
images, labels = load_digits(return_X_y=True)
x = torch.tensor(images[[7]] / 16, dtype=torch.float32)  # one client's image, pixels in [0,
y = torch.tensor(labels[[7]])
first, last = torch.nn.Linear(64, 32), torch.nn.Linear(32, 10)
F.cross_entropy(last(torch.relu(first(x))), y).backward()  # the gradient the client sends
# Row j of the weight gradient is the input times the bias gradient of unit j: divide them.
j = int(first.bias.grad.abs().argmax())
recovered = first.weight.grad[j] / first.bias.grad[j]
print(f"image recovered: {torch.allclose(recovered, x[0], atol=1e-6)}")  # image recovered:
# Only the true label's logit has a negative gradient (softmax minus one-hot).
print(f"recovered label {int(last.bias.grad.argmin())}, true label {int(y)}")  # recovered l
```

The snippet divides at the unit whose bias gradient is largest, because a ReLU unit that is off has a zero gradient. One active unit is enough. But a convolutional first layer stops the division. It uses the same filter at every position of the image, so its gradient is a sum of one product per image patch. No division can separate them. The attacker then has to search (Section 8.5).

8.4. Label recovery from the last layer

The label is often the most sensitive part of an example, such as a diagnosis. The attacker can read it off the last layer without search (Zhao, Mopuri & Bilen 2020). The condition is that the layer has a bias and feeds the softmax and cross-entropy loss. Write p for the predicted probabilities and e_y for the vector with a 1 at the position of the label y. The gradient of the last layer's bias b_2 is then $p - e_y$. Every entry of p lies between 0 and 1, so only the entry at the true label is negative, and for a single record

$$y = \arg\min_k (\nabla_{b_2} \ell)_k, \tag{8.4}$$

which is the snippet's `argmin`. It fails only for a very confident model. If the true label's probability p_y rounds to 1, that entry becomes zero, and no entry is negative.

A batch hides which record has which label, but not how many records each class has. Each entry of the bias gradient is then the class's average predicted probability minus its share of the batch. So a server that estimates the average prediction can read off each class's count. In the full edition's experiment, this gave every count exactly in all batches of 4, and in 52.5% of batches of 64.

8.5. Deep Leakage from Gradients

When the division does not apply, the attacker searches. **Deep Leakage from Gradients (DLG)**, from Zhu, Liu & Han (2019), guesses inputs and computes the gradient they would produce. It then moves the guesses until that gradient matches the observed gradient g. Write x'_i for the guessed inputs, y_i for their labels, read first from the last layer, and $\ell(\theta; x', y)$ for the loss of one guess. The attack minimizes the **matching loss** R, the squared distance between the guesses' average gradient and g:

$$\hat{x}_1, \dots, \hat{x}_B = \arg\min_{x'_1,\dots,x'_B} R(x'), \qquad R(x') = \Big\| \frac{1}{B} \sum_{i=1}^{B} \nabla_\theta \ell(\theta; x'_i, y_i) - g \Big\|^2. \tag{8.5}$$

In PyTorch, `create_graph=True` in `torch.autograd.grad` makes the guess's gradient differentiable, so an optimizer such as Adam can follow the slope of R back to the input.

Two things decide whether the search works. First, the activation's slope must vary, because the search differentiates a gradient. The ReLU's slope is constant on each side of zero, so Zhu et al. used the sigmoid. Second, R is not convex, so the search can get stuck. Run it until R stops falling, and compare the final value with the squared size $\|g\|^2$ of the observed gradient. In double precision, a successful run in the full edition ends near 10^{-27} and a stuck one near 10^{-5}. Another input can also give a small R, so restart from several random guesses, and trust an image only when the restarts agree on it.

8.6. Batches and averaging

Clients usually send the average over a batch, or the change in their parameters after several training steps on the device (**local steps**). The average breaks the division and slows the search, but much of the structure survives. Each record adds one outer product to the gradient of the first layer, so every row of that gradient is a combination of the B inputs. So the server learns their **span**, the set of all such combinations, which contains every record.

The division still recovers a record exactly when some ReLU unit is on for that record only. The other records then add nothing to that unit's row. Such a unit **isolates** the record. Isolation is far more common than a count of random units suggests. On images that resemble one another, a unit fires on many records or on few. In the full edition's network with 1,024 hidden units, a naive count predicts that 1.6% of a batch of 16 is exposed. But 69.1% was, as Table 8.1 shows. The share falls with a larger batch and rises with a wider first layer. So measure at your own width and batch size, and treat any isolated record as a breach.

Table 8.1.: Isolation attack on synthetic images, from the full edition.

Hidden units	Batch size	Share of the batch recovered exactly
64	4	0.838
64	8	0.550
64	16	0.144
1,024	16	0.691

Batches hurt DLG more: on the full edition's sigmoid network, the median run on a batch of 4 gets stuck. The search is harder, but the information is still there, because the isolation attack recovered all four images of such a batch. Local steps do not protect a single record either. The gradient of the first layer at each step is an outer product with the same input, so the division still works on the total change. A **malicious** server that chooses the weights can do more. It plants units that fire only on rare inputs, so that each unit isolates one record. It then recovers most records of a batch of any size (Boenisch et al. 2023, Fowl et al. 2022).

8.7. What to do as a deployer

The risk of an FL deployment depends on who can see one client's update, as Table 8.2 shows.

Table 8.2.: Gradient leakage by FL setting, and the response.

Setting	What leaks to the server	What to do
One record per update, fully connected first layer with bias	The input exactly, and the label	Never deploy without protection
Batches of any size, or several local steps	Label counts, the span of the batch, isolated records, and the rest by search in small batches	Treat each update as raw data
Server not trusted to choose weights	Most records of any batch	Batch size is no defence; treat each update as raw data
Updates protected by differential privacy (DP)	Bounded per client by the DP guarantee	The only protection with a guarantee

Secure aggregation is a cryptographic protocol that lets the server see only the sum over many clients. It removes the view of single clients that every attack here uses. But a sum over very few clients is close to a single update. So set a minimum cohort size, and make sure that clients who drop out in a round cannot shrink a sum below it.

Secure aggregation alone is not enough. The sum is still a batch average that the attacks above can read, and a malicious server can still choose its weights. For a guarantee, add DP with the client as the unit of privacy. Clip each client's update to a fixed maximum norm and add noise to the sum. That bounds what any one client's data can change (User-level privacy). Flower and TensorFlow Federated offer both protections. Gradient pruning and similar defences make the search harder but give no guarantee.

To assess your deployment, first find out whether the server sees single updates or only sums, and with what minimum cohort. Then run the attacks on your own architecture, batch size and number of local steps. Geiping's open-source `breaching` framework for PyTorch runs them. If the server can see one client's update on its own, block the deployment until secure aggregation or client-level DP is in place. Record the verdict in the Pre-release privacy risk assessment.

8.8. Cheat sheet

Table 8.3.: The results of this chapter.

Attack	Formula	Needs	Fails when
Exact recovery, one record	$x = (\nabla_{W_1}\ell)_{j,:}/(\nabla_{b_1}\ell)_j$	Fully connected first layer with bias	Convolutional first layer; batches, in part
Label, one record	$y = \arg\min_k(\nabla_{b_2}\ell)_k$	Softmax and cross-entropy	p_y rounds to 1
Deep Leakage from Gradients	Minimize the matching loss R	An activation whose slope varies; the labels	Search stuck (final $R \gg 0$); larger batches
Isolation, batch	Isolated records recovered exactly	Fully connected first layer, ReLU units	Rarely on real data

Rules of thumb

- Secure aggregation needs a minimum cohort, and only client-level DP bounds what any update reveals.

8.9. References

- Zhu, Liu & Han, "Deep Leakage from Gradients" (NeurIPS 2019): the gradient-matching attack.
- Geiping, Bauermeister, Dröge & Moeller, "Inverting Gradients — How easy is it to break privacy in federated learning?" (NeurIPS 2020): cosine matching with an image prior, on trained networks, local steps and batches.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

9. Linkage and re-identification

9.1. Why this matters

A hospital deletes the names from its discharge records and shares them with researchers. It keeps the postcode, the date of birth, the sex and the diagnosis. A voter roll lists names next to the same three columns. Anyone who has one can join the two tables and put a name back on most rows. This is a **linkage attack**, and putting a name back on a "de-identified" record is **re-identification**.

To judge whether a table can be linked, count its identifying information in bits. Each bit halves the candidates. So it takes $\log_2 n$ bits to single out one person in a population of n people. For the United States of 1990, that is 27.9 bits. Almost everyone is unique once the attributes an adversary knows carry a few bits more than that, and a unique record can be linked.

9.2. Quasi-identifiers and the linkage attack

Direct identifiers, like a name or an email address, name a person on their own. **Sensitive attributes**, such as a diagnosis, are what the release is about. **Quasi-identifiers** sit in between. None of them names anyone alone, but together they often single out one person, and they appear next to names in other datasets.

To score a release you hold, group its n records into **equivalence classes**. A class is a set of records with identical quasi-identifiers. Write J for the number of classes. Suppose an adversary knows the target's quasi-identifiers and knows that the target is in the release. If the target's class holds k records, the adversary names the right one with probability $1/k$. The class holds k possible targets, so every class adds one win whatever its size. Over all n targets, the chance of naming the right record is therefore

$$\Pr[\text{win}] = \frac{J}{n}, \tag{9.1}$$

and no adversary that sees only the quasi-identifiers can do better. This is the **prosecutor model**, the worst case, because it assumes the adversary knows the target is in the data.

The script practitioner_table_risk.py shows how fast uniqueness grows on a real table. The table is Adult, the 48,842 people of the 1994 US Current Population Survey in the UCI repository. Adult has no ZIP code or birth date, so the script starts from age, sex and race and adds one quasi-identifier at a time. For each set it prints the share of unique records, the share in classes smaller than 5, the smallest class size and J/n.

```
n = df.height
for qis in QI_SETS:
    # One row per equivalence class (records that agree on every quasi-identifier), with its
    sizes = df.group_by(qis).len()
    unique = sizes.filter(pl.col("len") == 1).height / n  # share of records alone in their
    small = sizes.filter(pl.col("len") < 5)["len"].sum() / n  # share in classes smaller tha
    min_k = sizes["len"].min()  # the table is k-anonymous for this k
    print(
        f"{' + '.join(qis)}: unique={unique:.2%}  in classes <5={small:.2%}  "
        f"min k={min_k}  J/n={sizes.height / n:.3f}"
    )
```

Run it with `uv run python code/part02-attacks/practitioner_table_risk.py`, which prints:

```
age + sex + race: unique=0.12%  in classes <5=0.75%  min k=1  J/n=0.012
age + sex + race + native-country: unique=3.07%  in classes <5=7.83%  min k=1  J/n=0.060
age + sex + race + native-country + marital-status: unique=5.88%  in classes <5=11.99%  min
age + sex + race + native-country + marital-status + education: unique=14.64%  in classes <5
age + sex + race + native-country + marital-status + education + hours-per-week: unique=36.5
```

Three columns that look harmless leave 0.12% of the records unique, and six leave 14.64%. The hours worked per week, which nobody would list as an identifier, then make 36.55% unique. So add every column an adversary could know to the test, one at a time. The column that breaks the table may be one that nobody suspected. A minimum class size of 5 is a common rule, yet every set here has classes of a single record.

9.3. Pseudonyms and hashed identifiers

Many releases replace each identifier by a **pseudonym**, a code that stays the same across a person's records. Such codes fail in two ways. First, an adversary can reverse a hash without a secret key, such as plain MD5, whenever the possible identifiers can be listed. It hashes every candidate and looks each pseudonym up. New York City hashed its taxi drivers' licences this way in its 2013 trip release. There were only about 2 million possible licences, so in 2014 Vijay Pandurangan hashed them all in minutes and named each driver.

The second failure survives any key. The pseudonym ties a person's records together, so a link to any one of them reveals all the others. In the taxi data, a passenger who knows the pickup minute and place can find one trip and its driver. The driver's pseudonym, even a random one, then reveals every trip that driver made. For this reason the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) still counts pseudonymized data as personal data.

If you must keep a join key, make it with a keyed hash, a hash-based message authentication code (HMAC). Keep the key away from the data.

```
import hashlib
import hmac
import secrets

licence = "482913"  # a six-digit licence number, the identifier being pseudonymized
pseudonym = hashlib.md5(licence.encode()).hexdigest()  # what an unkeyed release prints

# Dictionary attack: hash all 10**6 possible licences once, then look the pseudonym up.
lookup = {hashlib.md5(f"{i:06d}".encode()).hexdigest(): f"{i:06d}" for i in range(10**6)}
print(lookup[pseudonym])  # 482913

# A keyed hash still gives one code per person, but without the key nobody can build the tab
key = secrets.token_bytes(32)  # store it apart from the data; draw a new one for each relea
keyed = hmac.new(key, licence.encode(), hashlib.sha256).hexdigest()
print(keyed in lookup)  # False
```

The key stops the dictionary attack but not the second failure, because each person's records still form an identifying history. The same key in two releases would join that history across them, so draw a new key for each release.

9.4. How many people are unique?

When you design a release, there is no table to count yet, so estimate uniqueness by adding bits. An attribute with v equally likely values carries $\log_2 v$ bits, and the bits of independent attributes add. Attributes that carry b bits in total split people into 2^b cells. Suppose each person lands in a random cell, every cell equally likely. Then the expected share of the n people who are alone in their cell is about

$$\frac{\text{unique people}}{n} \approx \exp\left(-2^{\log_2 n - b}\right). \tag{9.2}$$

The share depends only on the bits beyond $\log_2 n$, and it rises steeply with them. Half the people are unique at only 0.53 bits beyond $\log_2 n$.

For example, ZIP code, birth date and sex carry 31.1 bits, a few more than the 27.9 bits that single out one American. The formula then predicts that 0.899 of Americans are unique, close to the 87% that Latanya Sweeney estimated from the 1990 census. Real attributes are skewed and correlated, which usually lowers uniqueness, so the estimate is cautious.

9.5. Sparse data: the Netflix attack

Ratings, purchases and locations have no quasi-identifier columns, yet they identify people even better. In 2006 Netflix released about 100 million movie ratings, with random numbers in place of the subscribers' names. Narayanan and Shmatikov (2008) matched its records to public reviews. Their score adds up the items on which a record agrees with what the adversary knows. It weights each item by its rarity, because an obscure film says more than a hit. Eight ratings with dates known to within 14 days identified 99% of the records, even when two of them were wrong.

The best score always points at some record, even when the target is not in the release. So the **eccentricity test** declares a match only if the best score beats the second best by a margin. It counts the margin in standard deviations of all the scores. Set that margin on people who are not in the data. On the full edition's simulated ratings, the original attack's margin also matched 26.3% of such outsiders. So report the attack's success at a stated false positive rate (Hypothesis testing).

9.6. Does releasing a sample protect?

Agencies often release a sample, as Adult is, because a record unique in the sample may share its attributes with someone left out. This protects less than it seems. Suppose the release holds a share q of the population, the **sampling rate**, and the adversary finds exactly one record that matches a person. Write λ for the expected number of other people in the population who share the target's cell. The record can be a look-alike's only if the target was left out, which happens with probability $1 - q$. So for a rare cell, the probability κ that the match is right is about

$$\kappa \approx \frac{1}{1 + \lambda(1 - q)}. \tag{9.3}$$

For example, take a cell expected to hold $\lambda = 0.1$ other people. Even in a 1% sample, a match is right with probability 0.910. The sample size enters only through $1 - q$, which can never exceed 1. So the chance of a right match never falls below $1/(1 + \lambda)$, and a smaller sample barely helps. A sample protects only people whose cells are crowded anyway.

So the Adult figures above are **sample uniqueness**, exact when the adversary knows the target is in the release. The **population uniqueness** behind them is lower, but not by much for rare cells. Estimate it with a model, and do not assume the risk away. ARX and sdcMicro offer such estimates, and Rocher, Hendrickx and de Montjoye (2019) model correlated attributes for it.

9.7. A pre-release risk check

First list every column an adversary could find next to a name elsewhere, such as a date, a location or a rare event. No tool knows what other data exist, so no tool can make this list. To lower the risk, coarsen geography and dates first, because they carry the most bits. Then suppress the records that remain unique (Syntactic anonymity and how it breaks). If the analysis needs fine-grained or sparse data, release a differentially private output instead (Release statistics with a library). Pre-release privacy risk assessment runs this check with thresholds fixed before the counts are seen.

9.8. Cheat sheet

Table 9.1.: The results of this chapter.

Question	Result	Use it for
Bits to name one person	$\log_2 n$	27.9 for the US of 1990
Risk of a release you hold	Success J/n; at most $1/k$ if every class has at least k records	Prosecutor model
Share unique, uniform cells	$\exp(-2^{\log_2 n - b})$	50% at $\log_2 n + 0.53$ bits, 99% at $\log_2 n + 6.64$
Releasing a sample	$\kappa \approx 1/(1 + \lambda(1 - q))$	0.910 at $\lambda = 0.1$ in a 1% sample

Rules of thumb

- Add quasi-identifiers one at a time, because one innocent column can more than double the unique share.
- Estimate uniqueness for the population, not just the sample.
- Hashing an identifier is not anonymization. Key the hash, and use a new key for each release.

9.9. References

- Sweeney, "Simple Demographics Often Identify People Uniquely" (2000): the 87% estimate and its variants with coarser geography.
- Narayanan & Shmatikov, "Robust De-anonymization of Large Sparse Datasets" (2008): the Netflix attack.
- Rocher, Hendrickx & de Montjoye (2019), in *Nature Communications*: population uniqueness from a sample.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

10. Syntactic anonymity and how it breaks

10.1. Why this matters

Linkage and re-identification showed that a table without names is not anonymous. Quasi-identifiers such as age, postcode and sex single out many people. The classic answer is to coarsen the table until every person hides in a crowd. The definitions of this answer are **syntactic**, because you check each one by reading the published table. You will meet them in audits, because statistics offices and tools such as ARX and sdcMicro still use them. But each one holds for one table and for an adversary whose knowledge is fixed in advance. One unexpected fact, or a second release of the same people, breaks it.

10.2. What the adversary believes about a class

To anonymize a table, the custodian, the organization that holds the data, applies a **generalization**. It turns an age into a range or a postcode into a prefix. Records with the same generalized quasi-identifiers form an **equivalence class**. An adversary who knows the target's quasi-identifiers finds the target's class E but cannot tell its records apart. So its belief about the target's sensitive value, its **posterior**, is the share of the class with that value. Write $|E|$ for the size of the class and $n_E(v)$ for the number of its records with a sensitive value v. Then the posterior that the target's sensitive value, written S_{target}, equals v is

$$\Pr[S_{\text{target}} = v \mid \text{release}] = \frac{n_E(v)}{|E|}. \tag{10.1}$$

The adversary's background knowledge about the target works by elimination. A fact that rules out a value crosses out its records, and the adversary computes the posterior again over the records that remain. Every attack in this chapter is this calculation.

10.3. k-anonymity and what it costs

k-anonymity (Sweeney and Samarati, 1998) asks that every class hold at least k records, for a crowd size k that the custodian chooses. Generalization gets there, together with **suppression**, which deletes the records that still stand out. In the previous chapter, an adversary who knows the target is in the release links it with probability J/n, the number of classes J over the number of records n. So with at least k records per class, there are at most n/k classes, and

$$\Pr[\text{win}] = \frac{J}{n} \leq \frac{1}{k}. \tag{10.2}$$

The guarantee covers names only, and only against an adversary who knows nothing beyond the quasi-identifiers. The choice of k is a policy, and 5 is a common minimum.

Anonymizers such as **Mondrian** search for a generalization that loses little, but you can also generalize by hand and check again. The script practitioner_table_risk.py takes the previous chapter's Adult census extract and its six quasi-identifiers. It puts age into 10-year bands, native country into US or other, and education into four levels. Then it counts the records alone in their class, and the different occupations in each class, with occupation as the sensitive attribute. Both are Polars counts, because no maintained Python package computes k-anonymity or distinct ℓ.

```
general = df.with_columns(
    (pl.col("age") // 10 * 10).alias("age"),  # 10-year bands: 30 stands for 30-39
    pl.when(pl.col("native-country") == "United-States")
    .then(pl.lit("US"))
    .otherwise(pl.lit("other"))
    .alias("native-country"),
    # education-num runs from 1 (preschool) to 16 (doctorate); 9 is high-school graduate.
    pl.col("education-num")
    .cut([8, 9, 12], labels=["no diploma", "HS-grad", "some college", "bachelor+"])
    .alias("education"),
)
# Recheck, and count the occupations in each class (distinct l).
classes = general.group_by(QIS).agg(pl.len(), pl.col("occupation").n_unique().alias("l"))
unique = classes.filter(pl.col("len") == 1).height / general.height
one_job = classes.filter(pl.col("l") == 1)["len"].sum() / general.height
print(f"after generalizing: unique={unique:.2%}  in a class with one occupation={one_job:.2%
```

Run it with `uv run python code/part02-attacks/practitioner_table_risk.py`. Its first two output lines use the six generalized quasi-identifiers, and the third adds the raw hours worked per week.

```
after generalizing: unique=0.94%  in a class with one occupation=1.20%
age + sex + race + native-country + marital-status + education: unique=0.94%  in classes <5=
age + sex + race + native-country + marital-status + education + hours-per-week: unique=10.0
  records in classes of size >=5 with l=1: 0.03%
```

Generalization cut the unique share to 0.94%, from 14.64% before. Yet the smallest class still holds one record. So suppress the 3.31% of records in classes smaller than 5, or make the bands coarser. The result is fragile, because an adversary who also knows the hours worked finds 10.09% of the records unique again.

10.4. Homogeneity, background knowledge and l-diversity

k-anonymity hides who a record belongs to, but not what it says (Machanavajjhala and colleagues, 2006). In the **homogeneity attack**, all three records of Alice's class say heart disease. Her posterior is then 1, and nobody has to find her record. In the **background knowledge attack**,

Bob's class says cancer, cancer and flu. A neighbour who knows that Bob did not have flu crosses out that record and learns that Bob has cancer.

l-diversity asks each class to hold enough different sensitive values. The distinct version asks for at least ℓ different values. It does not cap the most common value's share, so a class can be 3-diverse with one value in most of its records. The recursive version adds that cap, with a constant c that the custodian picks. An adversary who rules out $\ell - 2$ values then keeps a posterior below $c/(1 + c)$. That cap is already one half at $c = 1$, so even this version protects against certainty, not likelihood.

Suppression of the small classes also removes most homogeneous ones. On Adult, 1.20% of the generalized records sit in a class where everyone has the same occupation. Only 0.03% sit in such a class of 5 or more. On a synthetic hospital table of the full edition, distinct 3-diversity removed the certain disclosures at little cost. The recursive version forced some classes to grow to 641 patients.

10.5. Measuring what a release teaches

Compare every posterior with the **imputation baseline** of Attribute inference and model inversion, the best guess of a sensitive value from the population alone. Only the success beyond it is about the individual. On the hospital table, a guess of each patient's diagnosis from age alone is right for 53.6% of patients, and a 5-anonymous release raises that to 59.3%. Most of that gain is the link between age and diagnosis, which any useful study reports. Only the excess of 5.7 percentage points is a leak.

10.6. Skewness, similarity and t-closeness

l-diversity misses two attacks (Li, Li and Venkatasubramanian, 2007). In the **skewness attack**, a class that is half HIV is 2-diverse, yet in a table where 1% have HIV it raises its members' posterior fifty-fold. In the **similarity attack**, a class of three different stomach diseases is 3-diverse but still reveals a stomach disease.

t-closeness answers both. It asks that the distribution of values in every class E be within a distance t of the whole table's. Write $P_E(A)$ and $P(A)$ for the chance that a value drawn from the class, or from the table, lands in a set A of values. With the **total variation (TV)** distance, no such chance, and so no belief, moves by more than t,

$$|P_E(A) - P(A)| \leq t. \tag{10.3}$$

The bound is a difference, not a ratio, so it protects rare values badly. At $t = 0.15$, a value held by 1% of the table may rise to 16%. Against the similarity attack, Li and colleagues used the earth mover's distance instead, which counts similar values as close.

t-closeness costs a lot. At $t = 0.15$, a guess of diagnoses from the hospital release was right for only 22.2% of patients, below the 53.6% from age alone. So the release told less about the population than no release.

10.7. The composition attack

Ganta, Kasiviswanathan and Smith (2008) asked what happens when two hospitals each publish a k-anonymous or l-diverse table. A patient treated at both sits in a class E_A of one release and a class E_B of the other. The adversary keeps only the diagnoses that appear in both classes,

$$\{v : n_{E_A}(v) > 0\} \cap \{v : n_{E_B}(v) > 0\}. \tag{10.4}$$

When one candidate is left, the diagnosis is **pinned down**.

In the full edition's simulation, two hospitals share 6,649 patients. Together, their two 5-anonymous releases pin down the diagnosis of 9.9% of them, over three times what either pins alone. With distinct 3-diversity, neither release pins anyone, yet together they pin 18.

No definition for a single table can stop this, because the intersection of two tables is a table that neither custodian checked. A definition that survives must compose across releases and hold whatever the adversary knows. It must also bound the ratio of beliefs, so that it protects rare values. The definition of differential privacy meets these needs, and statistics offices such as the US Census Bureau have moved towards it (Reconstruction attacks).

10.8. Choosing and running an anonymization

Start from the quasi-identifiers of Linkage and re-identification, because a list that is too short is the most common failure. Use k-anonymity against linkage. Add distinct l-diversity when a class with one sensitive value is a disclosure. Use t-closeness, the costliest, only when the sensitive attribute is skewed or has similar values.

Then audit the anonymizer's output yourself, in Polars as the excerpt does, or with pycanon, which reports k, ℓ and t for a pandas table. Pre-release privacy risk assessment turns these checks into a release decision. Move to differential privacy if other releases of the same people exist, if the sensitive attribute is rare, or if the data are sparse. For tables of counts and sums, Release statistics with a library does the job end to end.

10.9. Cheat sheet

Table 10.1.: The syntactic definitions and the attacks on them.

Definition or attack	Condition	What it gives, and where it ends
k-anonymity	Every class has at least k records	Linkage at most $1/k$; says nothing about attributes
Distinct, entropy l-diversity	At least ℓ values, or $\log_2 \ell$ bits of entropy	No cap on the top value's share
Recursive (c, ℓ)-diversity	Top value below c times the values ranked ℓ-th and lower	Posterior below $c/(1+c)$ after ruling out $\ell - 2$ values

Definition or attack	Condition	What it gives, and where it ends
t-closeness (TV)	Each class within t of the table	A 1% value may reach $1\% + t$
Composition	Intersect the target's classes in two releases	No single-table definition prevents it

Rules of thumb

- k-anonymity protects names, not attributes, so check what each class's sensitive values reveal.
- Assume another release exists, because a guarantee about one table is not a guarantee about a person.

10.10. References

- Machanavajjhala and colleagues, "l-Diversity" (2006), and Li, Li & Venkatasubramanian, "t-Closeness" (2007): the attacks and the definitions that answer them.
- Ganta, Kasiviswanathan & Smith, "Composition Attacks and Auxiliary Information in Data Privacy" (2008): the intersection attack.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

11. Reconstruction attacks

11.1. What it is

A **reconstruction attack** rebuilds the records behind published aggregates, because every count is a linear equation in the secret values of the people counted. For example, each of n people has one secret bit, listed in d. A **subset-sum query** asks how many people in a set have bit 1. So the attacker's m queries form a matrix A of zeros and ones, one query per row. The **curator** who answers them publishes the true answers plus an error vector e,

$$a = Ad + e. \tag{11.1}$$

Least squares finds the real numbers with answers closest to the published ones, then rounds each to 0 or 1. Let each query include each person with probability one half. Let the noise be normal with standard deviation σ. Then least squares recovers about a fraction

$$\Phi\left(\frac{\sqrt{m-n}}{4\sigma}\right) \tag{11.2}$$

of the bits, where Φ is the standard normal distribution function. The baseline is the **majority guess**, which gives everyone the more common value, so it is right on one half of balanced bits. So with a few times more queries than people, noise well below $\sqrt{n}$ reveals the data. If the curator answers all 2^n subset sums, only error of order n stops reconstruction (Dinur and Nissim 2003).

These results are the **Fundamental Law of Information Recovery**: too many answers that are too accurate destroy privacy. But a release that stops reconstruction is not private for that reason. A curator that answers from a secret random half of the people stops it, yet gives that half away exactly. And a test of membership needs far fewer statistics (Lower bounds).

11.2. When you meet it

Every published count, cross-tabulation, dashboard cell or query answer is such an equation. The Census Bureau attacked its own 2010 publications and rebuilt a record for every person. About 46% of them matched a real person exactly on block, sex, age, race and ethnicity. With commercial data, they confirmed the identity of about 17% of the population, so the 2020 Census moved to differential privacy. Query systems fall too: the noise of Diffix did not grow with the number of queries, so Cohen and Nissim (2020) averaged it away.

11.3. How to use it

To audit an aggregate release, first count the equations. If the cells or allowed queries outnumber the people, only the noise protects the people. Put your noise level and number of queries into Equation 11.2. If the prediction is far above the majority guess, run the attack. The snippet draws the noise from OpenDP's Gaussian mechanism and runs least squares. OpenDP's noise cannot be seeded, so the snippet compares the share recovered with the prediction instead of printing it.

```
from statistics import NormalDist

import numpy as np
import opendp.prelude as dp

dp.enable_features("contrib")
rng = np.random.default_rng(0)
n, m = 500, 2000  # people with a secret bit each, and random subset-sum queries
sigma = 0.25 * np.sqrt(n)  # noise sd added to each answer
secret = rng.integers(0, 2, n)
queries = rng.integers(0, 2, (m, n))
space = dp.vector_domain(dp.atom_domain(T=float, nan=False)), dp.l2_distance(T=float)
gaussian = dp.m.make_gaussian(*space, scale=sigma)  # OpenDP's Gaussian mechanism on all m a
answers = np.array(gaussian((queries @ secret).astype(float).tolist()))
estimate = np.linalg.lstsq(queries, answers, rcond=None)[0]  # the textbook attack: least sq
recovered = np.mean(np.clip(estimate, 0, 1).round() == secret)
predicted = NormalDist().cdf(np.sqrt(m - n) / (4 * sigma))
print(f"predicted {predicted:.4f}")  # predicted 0.9584
print(f"recovered within 0.04 of it: {abs(recovered - predicted) < 0.04}")  # recovered with
```

The number of queries matters as much as the noise. In the full edition's simulation, with noise of twice $\sqrt{n}$, four queries per person recovered only 0.5875 of the bits. But Equation 11.2 shows that at that noise, 106.1 queries per person recover 90%. So fixed noise falls to enough queries, and the noise must grow with the number of answers, as differential privacy makes it.

For queries that are not random, use the linear-programming decoder of Dinur and Nissim, which fits unknowns between 0 and 1 with `scipy.optimize.linprog`. For published tables, write each cell as a constraint on whole-number unknowns. Solve the constraints with `scipy.optimize.milp`. Then count the solutions, because a single solution rebuilds the records. The release fails if either decoder beats the majority guess.

11.4. What goes wrong

Rounding, household swapping and small-cell suppression are not noise. Rounding hides nothing, because the attacker can round the answers of each candidate dataset too. Swapping leaves most constraints exact, and a suppressed cell even adds a constraint: the count is below the threshold.

And sticky noise, the same answer to a repeated query, stops only repeats, which the attack never needs.

Test the union of all releases, not one table at a time. Do not trust least squares alone, because errors chosen against it hurt it more than random noise. Before you publish, reconstruct your own release with the two decoders. Record the result in Pre-release privacy risk assessment.

11.5. References

- Cohen & Nissim, "Linear Program Reconstruction in Practice" (Journal of Privacy and Confidentiality, 2020): the attack on Diffix.
- Garfinkel, Abowd & Martindale, "Understanding Database Reconstruction Attacks on Public Data" (2019): a census block rebuilt with a solver.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

12. Pre-release privacy risk assessment

12.1. Why this matters

Before a model or a table leaves your hands, someone has to decide whether it leaks too much about the people in it. This chapter makes that decision for three releases. They are a classifier behind a scoring API, a language model whose weights go to a partner, and a census extract. The attacks themselves run in earlier chapters, and this one reads their results against fixed thresholds and writes the verdict down.

The order matters as much as the attacks. Write down which results block the release before any attack runs, because a threshold that you choose after you see the numbers can bend to fit them. A failed attack shows only that this attack failed, so the assessment also reports how strong its attacks were.

The three scripts below produce every result on this page. The first two run in seconds on public data. The third comes from Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA and takes a few minutes on an idle CPU.

```
uv run python code/part02-attacks/practitioner_lira.py
uv run python code/part02-attacks/practitioner_table_risk.py
uv run python code/part05-dp-ml/practitioner_lora.py
```

12.2. Fix the threat model and the thresholds first

Fill in the worksheet of Threat models and privacy games once per artefact, because each release can expose the same data differently. By default the privacy unit is the person, and the adversary sees scores, the confidences a model returns, because many services return them.

Then write the blocking rules of Table 12.1 into the plan. The membership rule uses two rates. The true positive rate (TPR) is the share of members an attack flags, and the false positive rate (FPR) is the share of non-members it wrongly flags. At an FPR of 10^{-3}, it blocks when the lower end of the TPR's 95% confidence interval exceeds ten times the FPR. The rule reads the lower end, so a lucky run cannot trigger it. The factor of ten is a policy choice: an attack may beat chance, but not tenfold.

Several remedies use differential privacy (DP), Part 3's guarantee that caps what any attack learns about one person by a privacy level ε. One is stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with each record's gradient clipped and noise added, called DP-SGD.

Table 12.1.: The blocking thresholds, written before any attack runs.

Artefact	The adversary sees	Attack	Blocks the release when	Then
Classifier behind a scoring API	Confidences for any input	Online LiRA, 64 models	Lower end of the TPR's 95% interval at FPR 10^{-3} is above 0.01	Regularize, or train with DP-SGD
Fine-tuned language model shared with a partner	The weights	Canaries, exposure, greedy extraction	Any secret extracted, or a one-copy canary's extrapolated exposure within 3 bits of the maximum	Deduplicate, or fine-tune with DP
Record-level table	The table and a register with the quasi-identifiers	Uniqueness on the agreed quasi-identifiers	Any record unique, or in a class smaller than 5 (11 for counts from US Medicare and Medicaid data)	Generalize and suppress, else release DP statistics
Model, sensitive field	The target's other fields and label	Model inversion	Attribute advantage's 95% interval above 0	Regularize, or train with DP
Model whose training mix is secret	Probe outputs	Shadow models, meta-classifier	Accuracy's 95% interval above one half	Do not release that mix
Published counts or queries	Every answer	Least squares, linear programming	Either beats the majority guess at the planned noise and query count	DP noise scaled to all answers
Federated training	Each client's update	Division and search	Any single update visible	Secure aggregation, client-level DP
Any model claimed to be DP	Depends on the claim	Audit with canaries	Certified lower bound on ε above the claimed ε	Block: the code or the accounting has a bug

A canary within 3 bits of the maximum exposure ranks among the 8 likeliest of all possible secrets. The rule reads one-copy canaries because a deduplicated corpus holds each secret once. If your corpus is not deduplicated, apply the rule at your data's largest repeat count.

The four middle rows block on any leak beyond the attack's own baseline. The chapters on attribute, property and reconstruction attacks and gradient inversion give each baseline. In the last row, an audit with independent trials certifies a lower bound on a DP model's ε. A bound above the claim proves a bug (Auditing private training).

12.3. Classifier: the free check

Start with the check that costs nothing: compare the model's accuracy on its training data and on held-out data. The classifier is a logistic regression on scikit-learn's 1,797 images of handwritten digits, from Membership inference. There, the mean gap over 64 models is 0.0422. So even the rule "member if correctly classified" beats chance by 0.0422, which is a lower bound on the leak.

Do not clear a model on this check, because the gap is an average over records and does not say who is exposed. For example, the loss attack flags every record with a low loss. At an FPR of 10^{-3} its TPR is only 0.0009, so it flags no more members than non-members. A weak attack's failure proves little. A large gap says regularize first, and a small one says only that you need the next step.

12.4. Classifier: LiRA with shadow models

The release decision rests on the likelihood ratio attack (LiRA) of Membership inference. It compares the target's output on each record with the outputs of **shadow models**, copies trained like the target with and without that record. Fix its strength before the run, because a weaker attack can pass a model that a stronger one blocks. The defaults come from Running LiRA on your model. Use online LiRA, the strongest version, with 64 shadows when training is cheap. If you can afford only 16 or fewer, fit one variance for all records. Put each record in each model by a fair coin, and let each model take one turn as the target.

With these defaults, the digits give 57,704 member and 57,304 non-member pairs of a model and an image. Reading the result counts the attack's hits on them. Online LiRA reaches a TPR of 0.0318 at an FPR of 0.00099. The lower end of its 95% interval is 0.0303, which is above 0.01, so the classifier fails Table 12.1. Offline LiRA would have passed it, and so would the shadow-model attack of the Adversarial Robustness Toolbox. So base the decision on the strongest attack you can afford.

Report the interval on the FPR as well. At 10^{-3}, the non-member pairs allow only about 57 false positives, so the FPR's interval runs from 0.00075 to 0.00129. The script also sets thresholds and measures on the same pairs, which flatters the attack slightly. Inspect the ten records the script prints as most exposed, because such records are usually rare or mislabelled.

12.5. Fine-tuned language model: canaries and extraction

A language model can repeat a secret word for word, and a membership test does not measure that. So the assessment plants **canaries**, random secrets of a fixed format, and checks how well the trained model knows them. Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA runs this audit,

with the scoring of Memorization and training-data extraction. It adapts Pythia-14m to 1,024 sequences of Tiny Shakespeare, once without privacy and once with DP at $\varepsilon = 8$ per sequence. Canaries with 1 to 64 copies and uninserted controls get two scores each. Exposure, in bits, ranks the secret by the sum of its tokens' log-probabilities, not their mean. Extraction checks whether greedy decoding, with the partner's settings, writes the secret out.

Read the exposure rule on the extrapolated column, not the measured one. The rank among 2,000 random candidates caps the measured exposure at 10.97 bits, while the whole space of secrets allows 16.61. So the measured column can never come within 3 bits of the maximum. First check the controls: a random rank is worth $\log_2 e = 1.44$ bits on average, and the controls' 1.4 bits match it, so the measurement is sound.

The non-private model fails Table 12.1. Its one-copy canaries stay far below the line, at 2.0 bits. But greedy decoding writes out all three 64-copy secrets, so the model must not be shared. The DP run extracts nothing. But its most repeated canaries still average about 4 bits, against 2.2 for its controls. The reason is that ε protects one sequence, and a repeated secret is many sequences. So deduplicate before training, whatever else you do.

12.6. Table: re-identification on quasi-identifiers

Quasi-identifiers are the columns an adversary can find elsewhere, such as age, sex and country in a register. Records that agree on all of them form an **equivalence class**, and a record alone in its class can be linked to a name. The table is Adult, a census extract of 48,842 records, and the agreed quasi-identifiers are six columns, from age to education.

Linkage and re-identification runs the uniqueness check. On the agreed six columns, 14.64% of the records are unique, so the table fails. Hours per week, a column that looks harmless, raises that to 36.55%. So list every column an adversary might hold, and when in doubt, test with the column added.

Syntactic anonymity and how it breaks then generalizes age, country and education and checks again. Generalization cuts the unique share to 0.94%, but the smallest class still has one record, so the table still fails. Suppression of the classes smaller than 5 removes 3.31% of the records. That fix works only for these columns, because raw hours per week makes 10.09% unique again. Also, 1.20% of the records sit in a class with a single occupation, a distinct ℓ of 1 (Syntactic anonymity). Such a class reveals the occupation without a unique match.

These shares count uniqueness in the sample, which fits the prosecutor model, where the adversary knows the target is in the table. Otherwise, estimate population uniqueness (Linkage and re-identification). Also, a table that passes after suppression can still be intersected with a second release of the same people (Syntactic anonymity). So when a table cannot pass and stay useful, release statistics with DP, as Release statistics with a library does. Plain aggregates are no fallback, because many accurate counts let an attacker rebuild records (Reconstruction attacks).

12.7. Write the decision

The last step compares each result with its threshold and writes a release memo, Table 12.2. A reviewer who did not run the attacks must be able to check it, so it gives each estimated rate with its interval.

Table 12.2.: A release memo for the three artefacts.

Memo entry	This assessment
Threat model	Scores from an API; weights shared with a partner; a table linked with a register. Unit: the person
Attacks and their strength	Loss attack, offline and online LiRA with 64 models; 12 canaries and 3 controls with exposure and greedy extraction; uniqueness on six quasi-identifiers plus one
Results	Online LiRA TPR 0.0318 [0.0303, 0.0332] at FPR 0.00099; all three 64-copy secrets extracted; 14.64% unique, 0.94% after generalizing
Verdict	All three blocked
Mitigation	Classifier: regularize or train with DP-SGD, then rerun. Language model: deduplicate and fine-tune with DP. Table: release DP statistics
Residual risk	Not assessed: attribute inference, property inference and reconstruction from aggregates. Not applicable, with no federated training: gradient leakage

The residual-risk entry names the attacks that were not run, and it is the entry most often left out. Write it even when every attack fails, because a model can pass this assessment and still leak to an attack nobody tried. Only a DP guarantee bounds every attack at once. For a DP model the memo carries that guarantee and its evidence, which Release and governance puts into the release package.

12.8. Checklist

Table 12.3.: The steps of a pre-release risk assessment, their defaults and their checks.

Step	Default	Check
Threat model and thresholds	Person as unit; adversary sees scores; rules of Table 12.1	Written and dated before any attack runs
Free check	Train and test accuracy; loss attack	Gap and loss TPR at FPR 10^{-3} reported; a pass clears nothing
LiRA	Online, 64 models, fair-coin inclusion, target role rotated	TPR's interval at FPR 10^{-3} against 0.01; enough non-members; top records inspected
Canaries	Secret format, 1 to many copies, uninserted controls	Controls near 1.44 bits; summed log-probability; deployed decoding
Table	Every column an adversary may hold; classes of at least 5	Unique share and smallest class after generalizing; distinct ℓ on the sensitive column
Decision	Memo with intervals, verdict, mitigation and residual risk	Every attack not run is named

12.9. References

- Carlini et al., "Membership Inference Attacks From First Principles" (IEEE S&P 2022): LiRA, and why attacks are reported by their TPR at a low FPR.
- Carlini et al., "The Secret Sharer: Evaluating and Testing Unintended Memorization in Neural Networks" (USENIX Security 2019): canaries, exposure and the skew-normal extrapolation.
- Rocher, Hendrickx & de Montjoye, "Estimating the success of re-identifications in incomplete datasets using generative models" (Nature Communications 2019): population uniqueness from a sample.

Derivations. This workflow has no counterpart in the full edition. It draws on the full edition's chapters on threat models in the full edition, membership inference in the full edition, memorization and extraction in the full edition, linkage and re-identification in the full edition and syntactic anonymity in the full edition.

Part III.

Differential privacy foundations

Part 2 showed that anonymization and access control do not stop a release from leaking. This part introduces **differential privacy (DP)**, a property of the release process, not of a dataset. If the data of one person changes, the probability of each output changes by at most a factor e^{ε}, plus a small slack δ. Here ε is the privacy level. This one condition limits every attack of Part 2. So a DP claim must state ε, δ and the unit of privacy, such as a record or a user.

Table 12.4.: Notation used throughout Part 3.

Symbol	Meaning
ε, δ	Privacy level and slack
$\Delta_1 f$, $\Delta_2 f$	Sensitivity, the most one record moves the answer
$\mathrm{Lap}(b)$, $\mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$	Laplace noise of scale b, normal noise of standard deviation σ

The part teaches one workflow in three steps. First, fix the unit of privacy and the neighbouring relation (the definition of differential privacy). Then bound each person's contribution and calibrate a mechanism to it (The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms). Last, account for every release, because only post-processing is free (Post-processing, group privacy and composition). Release statistics with a library does all three steps with OpenDP on the invoices of a real shop.

The full chapters between them cover common tasks. Selection picks the best of many options or a private median, and Query release publishes many counts at once. Use Trust models when nobody can hold the raw data, and Private mean estimation to find how many records a private mean needs. Of the four reference pages, Advanced composition and Beyond global sensitivity help when the simple rules are too loose. Read Discrete mechanisms before you sample noise yourself, and Lower bounds before you promise an accuracy.

Part 4 then replaces hand composition with accountants, and Part 5 uses all of it to train models. At the end of the part, you can release a count, a sum, a median or a table with error bars and a guarantee.

13. The definition of differential privacy

13.1. Why this matters

Every attack in Threat models and attacks runs an algorithm on one of two datasets that differ in one person, and guesses from the output which dataset it saw. **Differential privacy (DP)** makes the two outputs look alike against every test, including tests that nobody has invented yet. It is a property of the algorithm, not of the data, so you can check it before anyone touches the data.

13.2. Neighbouring datasets

The first question about a claim is what "differ in one record" means, and the **neighbouring relation** answers it. Under **add/remove**, two datasets are neighbours when one has a record that the other lacks, so the guarantee hides whether a person is in the data at all. Under **replace**, they have the same size and differ in the value of one record, so the guarantee hides only what the record says. A replacement is a removal and then an addition, and each step costs the privacy level ε of Section 13.3, so

$$\varepsilon\text{-DP under add/remove} \implies 2\varepsilon\text{-DP under replace.} \tag{13.1}$$

The reverse fails, because replace never compares datasets of different sizes.

You also choose the **unit of privacy**, what one record is. At the **example level**, it is one training record or one event, and at the **user level**, all the data of one person. A user who wrote 200 messages is then a group of 200 records under example-level DP, with protection only at 200ε (Post-processing, group privacy and composition). So check that the claim protects the person. The guarantee must also hide every record that the data format allows, even a person aged 900, who could move an average a long way. So private algorithms clip each input to a fixed range before they add noise.

13.3. The definition

A **mechanism** M is a randomized algorithm that takes a dataset and returns an output. Write D for a dataset and D' for one of its neighbours. The definition asks that no set of outputs becomes more than a factor e^{ε} more likely when one record changes, up to a small additive slack δ. Here ε is not negative. A mechanism is (ε, δ)**-differentially private** if every pair of neighbours and every set S of outputs satisfy

$$\Pr[M(D) \in S] \leq e^{\varepsilon} \Pr[M(D') \in S] + \delta. \tag{13.2}$$

The probabilities come only from the randomness of the mechanism, and the data stay fixed.

When $\delta = 0$, the guarantee is **pure DP**, and otherwise it is **approximate DP**. In both cases, a private mechanism must be random. A deterministic one that answers differently on two neighbours gives that answer probability 1 on one and 0 on the other, which no factor e^{ε} covers. So rounding, aggregation or the removal of small cells gives no guarantee by itself.

13.4. The privacy loss and δ

For an output y, write $p_{M(D)}(y)$ for its probability, or its density, when the mechanism runs on D. The **privacy loss** of y is the logarithm of how much more likely the output is on D than on D',

$$L(y) = \ln \frac{p_{M(D)}(y)}{p_{M(D')}(y)}. \tag{13.3}$$

Independent outputs multiply their likelihood ratios, so their losses add, and that is why the accountants of Part 4 work with the loss. Pure ε-DP holds exactly when every output has a loss between $-\varepsilon$ and ε. Laplace noise meets that condition, but the loss of Gaussian noise has no limit in the far tail (The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms).

Under approximate DP, δ pays for the outputs whose loss is more than ε. It counts only the part of each one's probability on D above e^{ε} times its probability on D'. So δ is not the chance that the loss is more than ε, and the total is the **hockey-stick divergence** (Divergences). Each ε has its own smallest δ, and the function $\delta(\varepsilon)$ is the **privacy curve** of the mechanism. The noise parameters fix the whole curve, so report them with the pair, and others can recompute it (Numerical accounting).

13.5. Randomized response

In **randomized response**, a survey design, each person tells the truth with some probability t and lies otherwise, so a single answer proves nothing. A person who tosses a coin, answers truthfully on heads and answers by a second toss on tails tells the truth with probability $\frac{3}{4}$. So the true answer is three times as likely as the false one, which gives pure DP at $\varepsilon = \ln 3$. In general, randomized response at level ε tells the truth with probability

$$t = \frac{e^{\varepsilon}}{1 + e^{\varepsilon}}. \tag{13.4}$$

With independent coins, the guarantee is ε per person for any number of people. But it holds only under replace, because under add/remove the number of reports shows who answered. Write $\bar{y}$ for the share of "yes" reports among the n people. A correction with t for the lies gives the estimate of the true fraction π and its standard deviation,

$$\hat{\pi} = \frac{\bar{y} - (1 - t)}{2t - 1}, \qquad \mathrm{sd}(\hat{\pi}) = \frac{e^{\varepsilon/2}}{(e^{\varepsilon} - 1)\sqrt{n}}. \tag{13.5}$$

For 1,000 people, the two-coin scheme has a standard deviation of 0.0274. When the true fraction is 0.3, that is about twice the sampling error of 0.0145 that the survey already has. This doubling

is the price of the **local** model, in which nobody sees a true answer (Local, shuffle and distributed trust models).

OpenDP builds the mechanism from its truth probability, 0.75 for the two coins, and `map` turns one changed answer into its ε, $\ln 3$. The `contrib` feature turns on mechanisms that are not yet formally vetted.

```
import opendp.prelude as dp

dp.enable_features("contrib")
rr = dp.m.make_randomized_response_bool(prob=0.75)
print(f"{rr.map(1):.4f}")  # 1.0986
```

13.6. What ε means for an attacker

A membership attacker looks at the output and decides whether to accuse the target of being in the data (Hypothesis testing). Its **false positive rate (FPR)** is how often it accuses a target who is out. Its **true positive rate (TPR)** is how often it accuses one who is in. The outputs on which it accuses form a set, which the definition bounds, so under add/remove every attack satisfies

$$\mathrm{TPR} \le e^{\varepsilon}\,\mathrm{FPR} + \delta. \tag{13.6}$$

Use this form, because Part 2 judged attacks by their TPR at a low FPR. Take $\varepsilon = 1$ and the $\delta = 10^{-5}$ that Section 13.7 gives for 10,000 people. At an FPR of 10^{-3}, no attack gets a TPR above $e \cdot 10^{-3} + 10^{-5} = 0.002728$. As the FPR goes to 0, so does the first term, and the guarantee then depends almost entirely on δ.

Read backwards, the cap turns a measured attack into a lower bound on ε,

$$\varepsilon \ge \ln \frac{\mathrm{TPR} - \delta}{\mathrm{FPR}}. \tag{13.7}$$

Suppose that a model is claimed to be $(2, 10^{-5})$-DP, and an attack gets a TPR of 0.05 at an FPR of 0.001. If those rates were exact, ε would be at least about $\ln 50 = 3.91$, so the claim would be false. A real audit puts confidence bounds on the rates and plants a **canary**, a record that is as easy to detect as possible (Auditing).

Two summaries are easier to explain to a lawyer. The first, the **membership advantage**, is the TPR minus the FPR, how much better than a coin flip an attacker does. Under (ε, δ)-DP, it is at most

$$\mathrm{TPR} - \mathrm{FPR} \le \frac{e^{\varepsilon} - 1 + 2\delta}{e^{\varepsilon} + 1}. \tag{13.8}$$

The second, the posterior bound, is about beliefs. Under pure DP, one output can multiply the odds of an adversary between two neighbours by at most e^{ε}. So a prior belief p that the data are D can rise at most to

$$\Pr[D \mid y] \le \frac{e^{\varepsilon} p}{e^{\varepsilon} p + 1 - p}. \tag{13.9}$$

Table 13.1 turns a claimed ε into both numbers.

Table 13.1.: What a pure ε-DP guarantee promises against the strongest attacker.

ε	Advantage bound	Posterior from a prior of 0.01	Posterior from a prior of 0.5
0.1	0.0500	0.0110	0.5250
1	0.4621	0.0267	0.7311
3	0.9051	0.1687	0.9526
8	0.9993	0.9679	0.9997

So an ε of at most 1 is strong for any mechanism, because a 1% prior rises to less than 3%. Between 1 and 10, a claim needs the privacy curve of the mechanism as its justification. Above 10, where the bounds promise almost nothing, it needs an audit as well (Choosing ε). For statistics, start from the error that you can accept and solve for ε (The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms). The table is for pure DP, so for an (ε, δ) claim, quote the advantage bound and the cap on the TPR, which both include δ.

13.7. How small δ must be

A small δ almost does not change the advantage bound. But the advantage is an average, so it can hide total harm to a few people. Take a mechanism that publishes each record in full, independently with probability δ. It is $(0, \delta)$-DP under add/remove, because a record changes the output only when its own coin publishes it. But over n records, it publishes at least one with probability

$$1 - (1 - \delta)^n \approx 1 - e^{-n\delta}. \tag{13.10}$$

With 10,000 records and $\delta = 1/n$, that is $1 - e^{-1} = 0.6321$.

So treat δ as a budget per person for catastrophe, such as these total failures. The default of this book follows Ponomareva et al. (2023) and keeps $n\delta$, the expected number of people exposed this way, well below 1. Let n count people, not records, and choose

$$\delta \leq \frac{1}{n^{1.1}}, \tag{13.11}$$

rounded down to a power of ten. For 10,000 people, the rule gives 10^{-5}. The publishing mechanism then has $n\delta = 0.1$, and it exposes someone with probability only 0.0952.

13.8. What differential privacy does not protect

DP compares a world with your record and a world without it, so the guarantee does not cover what someone can learn in both worlds. A study that never used Alice's record may show that smokers get cancer at a high rate. That changes what anyone believes about Alice, a smoker, yet the study is 0-DP with respect to her. So a harm is a DP violation only if the inference would be materially different without her record. Correlated records are a second gap, because a household of five that always answers alike is a group of five, unless the household is the unit of privacy. The third gap is the implementation (Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms).

13.9. Writing the guarantee down

A reviewer can check only what a claim writes down. So a guarantee names the unit of privacy with its neighbouring relation, and ε and δ for the whole release, not per query. It also names the mechanism, the library version, the trust model and the data treated as public, which the guarantee does not protect. This example uses the **central model**, in which a trusted curator holds the raw data and adds the noise:

> This release satisfies $(1, 10^{-5})$-DP for adding or removing one customer and all their invoice lines, at most 100 per customer, under the central model, with Gaussian noise from OpenDP 0.16.0. The market list was fixed in advance.

Release statistics with a library and Release and governance print such statements from the code that made the release.

13.10. Code

This snippet checks two numbers quoted above.

```
from math import exp, log

print(f"{(exp(3) - 1) / (exp(3) + 1):.4f}")  # 0.9051
print(f"{log((0.05 - 1e-5) / 1e-3):.2f}")  # 3.91
```

13.11. Cheat sheet

Table 13.2.: The results of this chapter.

Result	Formula	Notes
(ε, δ)-DP	$\Pr[M(D) \in S] \leq e^{\varepsilon} \Pr[M(D') \in S] + \delta$	All neighbours, all sets S
Attack cap	$\mathrm{TPR} \leq e^{\varepsilon}\,\mathrm{FPR} + \delta$	Audit: $\varepsilon \geq \ln((\mathrm{TPR} - \delta)/\mathrm{FPR})$
Choosing δ	$\delta \leq 1/n^{1.1}$, rounded down to a power of ten	n counts people, not records

Rules of thumb

- When people contribute many rows, the unit of privacy is the person.
- An ε is never a probability of re-identification. Under pure DP it bounds how far any output can shift an attacker's odds.

13.12. References

- Dwork & Roth, *The Algorithmic Foundations of Differential Privacy* (2014), ch. 2: the definition and what DP promises.
- Kairouz, Oh & Viswanath, "The Composition Theorem for Differential Privacy" (ICML 2015): the hypothesis-testing reading behind the attack cap.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

14. Post-processing, group privacy and composition

14.1. Why this matters

A private mechanism is never the whole system. Its output is rounded or goes into a model, a person often owns many records, and an analyst seldom asks only one question. Three properties of differential privacy (DP) cover these cases, which are post-processing, group privacy and composition. With them you prove each building block once and keep a ledger of what you spend.

14.2. Post-processing

Take a mechanism M that is DP with privacy level ε and slack δ. Apply to its output a function f that never reads the data, although it can use random numbers of its own. Then the processed release is just as private,

$$f(M(D)) \text{ is } (\varepsilon, \delta)\text{-DP.} \tag{14.1}$$

So it costs nothing to round a noisy count, to clamp it at zero, or to make noisy subtotals agree with their noisy total. So a private system adds noise at one narrow point, such as counts or gradients, and treats everything after it as public. The rule also covers attackers, because a membership-inference attack is a function of the output. So the definition's limit on the success of an attack holds even for attacks invented after the release.

The condition is that f never reads the data. "Take the noisy top category, then report its exact count" breaks it, because the second step is a new and non-private mechanism.

14.3. Group privacy

The definition protects one record, but a customer of an online shop has dozens of invoice lines. For a person with k records, the guarantee must cover datasets that differ in k records. You can go from one such dataset to the other in k steps that each change one record and each cost ε. So under pure DP, where $\delta = 0$, ε-DP per record becomes $k\varepsilon$-DP for the group. But the slack grows much faster than k. For a group of k records, an (ε, δ)-DP mechanism is

$$\Big(k\varepsilon,\ \delta_k\Big)\text{-DP}, \qquad \delta_k = \delta\,\frac{e^{k\varepsilon}-1}{e^{\varepsilon}-1} \le k\,e^{(k-1)\varepsilon}\delta. \tag{14.2}$$

The form on the right is simpler but looser. With $\varepsilon = 0.5$ and $\delta = 10^{-5}$ per record, a person with 10 records gets a slack of 2.272×10^{-3}. That slack is too large, because the book chooses δ far below one over the number of people (How small δ must be).

OpenDP calculates group guarantees from the mechanism itself. A measurement's `map(d_in=k)` gives its guarantee when neighbouring datasets differ in k records, here for a Laplace count and a Gaussian count.

```
count = dp.t.make_count(dp.vector_domain(dp.atom_domain(T=int)), dp.symmetric_distance())
laplace = count >> dp.m.then_laplace(scale=2.0)  # epsilon = 0.5 per record
print(f"Laplace count: epsilon {laplace.map(d_in=1):.1f} per record, {laplace.map(d_in=10):.

def gaussian(scale: float) -> dp.Measurement:  # a Gaussian count, as a privacy curve
    return dp.c.make_zCDP_to_approxDP(count >> dp.m.then_gaussian(scale=scale))

def at_1e5(scale: float) -> dp.Measurement:
    return dp.c.make_fix_delta(gaussian(scale), delta=1e-5)

scale = dp.binary_search_param(at_1e5, d_in=1, d_out=(0.5, 1e-5))  # (0.5, 1e-5) per record
curve = gaussian(scale).map(d_in=10)  # the privacy curve for a group of 10 records
print(f"Gaussian count, group of 10: epsilon {curve.epsilon(1e-5):.2f} at delta 1e-5")
# delta_k is the slack that the group-privacy formula gives the group
print(f"Gaussian count, group of 10: epsilon {curve.epsilon(delta_k):.2f} at delta {delta_k:
```

```
Laplace count: epsilon 0.5 per record, 5.0 for 10
Gaussian count, group of 10: epsilon 6.43 at delta 1e-5
Gaussian count, group of 10: epsilon 4.57 at delta 2.272e-03
```

For the Laplace count, `map(d_in=10)` gives $k\varepsilon = 5.0$, the same as the formula. The Gaussian count, set to $(0.5, 10^{-5})$ per record, does better, because OpenDP gets the group's guarantee from the whole privacy curve of the mechanism. At the formula's slack of 2.272×10^{-3}, the group gets $\varepsilon = 4.57$, less than the formula's 5.0. So take a group guarantee from the library's map, and use the formula only for a mechanism that the library cannot map.

Better still, make the person the unit of privacy. Then neighbouring datasets differ in all of one person's records. Bound the number of records that each person can contribute before you add noise, as Release statistics with a library does on real data. Use group privacy when you cannot do this, and for records of different people that reveal each other, such as a household with one address and one income.

14.4. Sequential composition

An analyst asks several queries of the same data, each with fresh noise, and an adversary sees all the answers together. For k mechanisms, write $(\varepsilon_i, \delta_i)$ for the budget of the i-th. Then the release of all their outputs is

$$\Big(\sum_{i=1}^{k} \varepsilon_i,\ \sum_{i=1}^{k} \delta_i\Big)\text{-DP}. \tag{14.3}$$

This is **basic composition**. It needs every mechanism to draw fresh noise and to use the same neighbouring relation, add/remove or replace.

The rule also covers **adaptive** composition, where the analyst chooses each query from the earlier answers, but only if each budget is fixed in advance. A budget chosen from the answers, as in "continue until the estimate looks good", needs a privacy filter. That is a rule that decides when to stop (Adaptive composition).

For many releases, basic composition gives too much. Ten Gaussian counts at $(0.5, 10^{-5})$ each cost $(5, 10^{-4})$ by basic composition, but at that slack their exact ε is only 1.504. So for more than a few releases, use an accountant. It calculates the total from the mechanisms themselves (Advanced and optimal composition, Part 4).

14.5. Parallel composition

Statistics per region use disjoint subsets of the data. When each person has one record, that record is in one region only. So each region can spend the full budget. To use this, fix in advance a public rule that puts every possible record in exactly one part. Then run a mechanism M_i with independent noise on the i-th part. If each M_i is $(\varepsilon_i, \delta_i)$-DP under add/remove, the whole release is

$$(\max_i \varepsilon_i,\ \max_i \delta_i)\text{-DP under add/remove.} \tag{14.4}$$

So a histogram with Laplace noise of scale $1/\varepsilon$ on every bin is ε-DP for any number of bins. Under replace, a record can move from one bin to another, so two bins change and the cost doubles to 2ε. A person with records in several bins also breaks the rule. Then charge each bin as a separate query, or first bound the number of bins that a person can touch.

The condition that is easiest to break is the rule fixed in advance. A split into "the top 10% of earners and the rest" moves its boundary when one high earner is added, so both parts change. A split on the keys that appear in the data also fails, because a key that only one person's record contains reveals that person. So use fixed bins or a public list of keys. When the keys are not public, release only the keys whose noisy count is above a threshold, a step called **partition selection** (Release statistics with a library).

14.6. Keeping a budget

Fix a total budget for a dataset before the first release, and charge every release against it. In the Python library diffprivlib, a `BudgetAccountant` holds the total, and each function that you give it charges its own ε and δ. A call that would go above the total raises a `BudgetError` and gives no answer. The script practitioner_adult_statistics.py uses it on the Adult census data, 48,842 people with one row each. For these people, the default slack is 10^{-6}. It spends the budget on two queries and then asks for one more count.

```
age = adult["age"].to_numpy()
acc = BudgetAccountant(epsilon=1.0, delta=1e-6)  # the total, fixed in advance
mean_age = tools.mean(age, epsilon=0.5, bounds=(17, 90), accountant=acc, random_state=seed)
over_50 = tools.count_nonzero(age > 50, epsilon=0.5, accountant=acc, random_state=seed)
print(f"private mean age: {mean_age:.2f}  private count over 50: {over_50:,}")
print(f"spent: {acc.total()}")
```

```
try:
    tools.count_nonzero(age > 60, epsilon=0.1, accountant=acc, random_state=seed)
except BudgetError as err:
    print(f"refused: {err}")
```

Run it with `uv run python code/part03-dp-foundations/practitioner_adult_statistics.py`. With `random_state=0` it prints the following.

```
private mean age: 38.64  private count over 50: 9,813
spent: (epsilon=1.0, delta=0.0)
refused: Privacy spend of (0.1,0) not permissible; will exceed remaining privacy budget. Use
```

The true values are 38.64 and 9,808. The two calls add Laplace noise, so they spend no δ, and the 10^{-6} stays available for a Gaussian query. The ledger has two limits. First, it applies basic composition to every call, so it charges too much for calls on disjoint parts of the data. Second, it trusts the guarantee of each call, and diffprivlib's mean divides by the exact number of rows as if that number were public. The number is public only when neighbours have the same size, so this ledger holds only under replace neighbours.

Most real failures break a condition of the three properties, and then the guarantee is usually lost completely (Table 14.1).

Table 14.1.: What composes and what doesn't.

Situation	Composes?	What to do
A function of the output, with its own coins	Yes, for free	Process as much as you like
Another query on the same data, fresh noise	Yes, budgets add	Charge it to the ledger
A query chosen from earlier answers	Yes, budgets add	Fix its budget in advance
Two releases that share one noise draw	No	Draw fresh noise for every query
"Post-processing" that reads the data again	No	Charge it as a new mechanism
A DP release beside an exact statistic of the same data	No, the exact one has no guarantee	Release the statistic privately too
A split whose boundaries depend on the data	No, not in parallel	Fix the bins in advance
Guarantees under add/remove and replace in one ledger	Only after conversion	Convert to replace: 2ε and $(1 + e^{\varepsilon})\delta$

Shared noise is the clearest case of a broken condition. Suppose that you release the number of smokers and the number of smokers aged 40 or more, with the same Laplace draw of scale 1 on each. Each release alone is 1-DP, but their difference cancels the noise and gives the exact number

of smokers under 40. So the pair is not DP at all. In code, the bug hides in a shared random seed, a cached noise value or noise that several shards use. A fixed seed such as `random_state=0` above makes a book's numbers repeatable, but in production it makes the noise known and so removable. The same noisy answer to a repeated identical query is safe, because it is post-processing of one release.

14.7. Cheat sheet

Table 14.2.: The results of this chapter.

Property	Rule	Condition
Post-processing	$f(M(D))$ is (ε, δ)-DP	f never reads the data
Group privacy	$(k\varepsilon,\ \delta\frac{e^{k\varepsilon}-1}{e^{\varepsilon}-1})$ for k records	Prefer the person as the unit, with bounded contributions
Basic composition	$(\sum \varepsilon_i, \sum \delta_i)$	Fresh noise, one neighbouring relation, budgets fixed in advance
Parallel composition	$(\max \varepsilon_i, \max \delta_i)$	Add/remove, parts fixed in advance; 2ε under replace

Rules of thumb

- Add noise once, as early as possible. All that you calculate from the noisy output is then free.
- Fix the total budget before the first release, and let one accountant refuse what goes above it.
- Do not share a random seed between mechanisms, and do not fix one in production.

14.8. References

- Dwork & Roth, *The Algorithmic Foundations of Differential Privacy* (2014): post-processing, group privacy and basic composition, the standard reference.
- McSherry, "Privacy Integrated Queries" (SIGMOD 2009): parallel composition, and a query system built on post-processing and composition as its only rules.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

15. The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms

15.1. Why this matters

Suppose that a hospital wants to publish, with a differential privacy (DP) guarantee, how many of its patients have diabetes. Almost every such release, and every noisy gradient of private training, uses one of the two mechanisms of this chapter. Both calculate the exact answer of a query f on the dataset D, add fresh random noise, written Z, and publish

$$M(D) = f(D) + Z. \tag{15.1}$$

Three decisions fix such a mechanism. The noise must hide the **sensitivity**, which is how far one record can move the answer. The noise distribution sets the kind of guarantee, because Laplace noise gives pure DP and Gaussian noise needs a small slack δ. And a calibration formula sets the amount of noise for a target ε, through the privacy loss of the definition of differential privacy.

15.2. Sensitivity

The noise must cover the largest change that one record can make to the answer. A query often gives a vector of d numbers, such as the bins of a histogram, so the change needs a size. Laplace noise uses the ℓ_1 norm, the sum of the absolute changes. Gaussian noise uses the ℓ_2 norm, the square root of the sum of the squared changes. For a pair of neighbours $D \sim D'$, the ℓ_p **sensitivity** of the query is the largest change between their answers,

$$\Delta_p f = \max_{D \sim D'} \left\| f(D) - f(D') \right\|_p, \qquad p \in \{1, 2\}. \tag{15.2}$$

The two are equal when one record moves a single coordinate. When it moves all d of them, $\Delta_1 f$ can be $\sqrt{d}$ times $\Delta_2 f$.

The sensitivity also depends on the neighbouring relation. Under add/remove, one dataset has one record more than the other. Under replace, one record changes into another, so the size n is public. With B for the largest value of a record after clipping, Table 15.1 gives the standard queries.

Table 15.1.: Sensitivities of the standard queries under the two neighbouring relations.

Query	Add/remove Δ_1	Add/remove Δ_2	Replace Δ_1	Replace Δ_2
Count $\lvert D \rvert$	1	1	0	0
Sum, values in $[0, B]$	B	B	B	B

Query	Add/remove Δ_1	Add/remove Δ_2	Replace Δ_1	Replace Δ_2
Mean, values in $[0, B]$, n public	none (Section 15.6)	none	B/n	B/n
Histogram with k bins	1	1	2	$\sqrt{2}$
d threshold counts $\#\{x \geq j\}$, $j = 1..d$	d	$\sqrt{d}$	d	$\sqrt{d}$

A replaced record leaves one histogram bin and goes into another, so it changes two bins. The threshold counts, the numbers of records at or above each of d values, are a **dense** query, in which one record can move every coordinate.

Calculate the sensitivity from the domain, before you look at the data. If you take it from the data, for example as the largest value, the noise leaks that value (Beyond global sensitivity). Unbounded data have infinite sensitivity, so first clip every value to a fixed range. With ages clipped to at most 100, the mean age of 1,000 patients has sensitivity $B/n = 0.1$ under replace.

15.3. The Laplace mechanism

The Laplace mechanism adds independent noise from the **Laplace distribution**, a two-sided exponential with its peak at 0, to each coordinate. We write $\mathrm{Lap}(b)$ for this noise with scale b, which sets its typical size. For an ε-DP guarantee, the scale is the sensitivity divided by ε,

$$b = \frac{\Delta_1 f}{\varepsilon}. \tag{15.3}$$

The error of the mechanism is the noise itself. Each coordinate of the noise is b from zero on average, and goes past a distance t with probability $e^{-t/b}$. Give all d coordinates together a small failure probability β, so that each coordinate gets a share β/d. Then the width that holds for all of them is

$$\Pr\Big[\max_i |Z_i| > b \ln \frac{d}{\beta}\Big] \leq \beta. \tag{15.4}$$

Publish this width with the release. In reverse, the width gives an error budget, because for a single number you can fix a target width t and solve for the privacy level,

$$\varepsilon = \frac{\Delta_1 f \, \ln(1/\beta)}{t}. \tag{15.5}$$

So a count that must be within 10 of the truth with probability 0.95 needs $\varepsilon = \ln(20)/10 = 0.2996$. For d numbers, solve each with the failure probability β/d, and add their values of ε by composition.

At the hospital, 1,234 of the 10,000 patients have diabetes. A count has sensitivity 1 under add/remove, so at $\varepsilon = 0.1$ the noise is $\mathrm{Lap}(10)$. Its 95% error bar is $10 \ln 20 = 29.96$, or 2.43% of the count.

The scale does not depend on the size of the data, so the relative error of a count of size n is about $1/(n\varepsilon)$. But the sensitivity must include every number that one record can move. If one record can change all of 10 released counts, noise for one count makes the release 10ε-DP, not ε-DP.

15.4. The Gaussian mechanism

The Gaussian mechanism adds independent normal noise with mean 0 and standard deviation σ to each coordinate. Its privacy loss has no upper limit in the far tail, so it always needs a δ. But its noise follows the ℓ_2 sensitivity, which can be much smaller than the ℓ_1 one. Only the ratio of the sensitivity to the noise is important, so write $\mu = \Delta_2 f/\sigma$ for the number of noise standard deviations between the answers on two neighbours. Write Φ for the cumulative distribution function (CDF) of the standard normal distribution. Then the mechanism is (ε, δ)-DP exactly when δ is at least

$$\delta_\mu(\varepsilon) = \Phi\Big(\frac{\mu}{2} - \frac{\varepsilon}{\mu}\Big) - e^\varepsilon\, \Phi\Big(-\frac{\mu}{2} - \frac{\varepsilon}{\mu}\Big). \tag{15.6}$$

You calibrate with this formula. As μ increases, the exact δ increases from 0 to 1, so exactly one value μ^* gives your target. The smallest noise that works is then

$$\sigma^* = \frac{\Delta_2 f}{\mu^*}, \qquad \text{where } \delta_{\mu^*}(\varepsilon) = \delta, \tag{15.7}$$

and libraries solve for μ^* (Section 15.7). For 10,000 patients, the book's default slack is $\delta = 10^{-5}$. At $\varepsilon = 1$, this **analytic calibration** then gives $\sigma^* = 3.7306\,\Delta_2 f$.

Many papers and libraries still use the classic calibration of Dwork and Roth (2014), which has a proof only for ε and δ between 0 and 1,

$$\sigma = \frac{\Delta_2 f \sqrt{2\ln(1.25/\delta)}}{\varepsilon}. \tag{15.8}$$

At $\varepsilon = 1$ and $\delta = 10^{-5}$, it gives $4.8448\,\Delta_2 f$, 30% more noise than the analytic $3.7306\,\Delta_2 f$. Above $\varepsilon = 8.42$, it gives too little noise for the guarantee it claims. So use the analytic calibration.

A Gaussian mechanism has a whole curve of guarantees, one δ for each ε, and the accountants of Part 4 compose whole curves. So report $\sigma/\Delta_2 f$ with every Gaussian release, together with the pair that you chose.

At the hospital, Gaussian noise for the diabetes count at $\varepsilon = 0.1$ and $\delta = 10^{-5}$ gives a 95% error bar of 60.27, which is 1.96 standard deviations. Laplace noise gave 29.96 with no δ, so for a single count Laplace noise is better in error and in guarantee.

15.5. Laplace or Gaussian?

The choice depends on how one record spreads its change across the coordinates. To see why, compare the root-mean-square error (RMSE) of each released number at the same ε. Laplace noise of scale $b = \Delta_1 f/\varepsilon$ has standard deviation $\sqrt{2}\,b$. With σ_1 for the analytic Gaussian noise level at unit ℓ_2 sensitivity, the errors per coordinate are

$$\text{Laplace: } \frac{\sqrt{2}\,\Delta_1 f}{\varepsilon}, \qquad \text{Gaussian: } \Delta_2 f\, \sigma_1. \tag{15.9}$$

In a sparse query, such as a histogram under add/remove, one record moves one coordinate, so the two sensitivities are equal. At $\varepsilon = 1$ and the default δ, $\sigma_1 = 3.7306$. So Laplace noise is better

at every d, because $\sqrt{2} = 1.4142$ is smaller. In a dense query, such as the threshold counts, one record moves every coordinate. Then the Laplace error grows like d and the Gaussian error only like $\sqrt{d}$. So Laplace noise is more accurate only while

$$d < \frac{(\varepsilon\sigma_1)^2}{2}, \tag{15.10}$$

so with $\sigma_1 = 3.7306$, Gaussian noise is better for 7 or more threshold counts.

Gaussian noise is also better for many releases, because several Gaussian releases compose exactly into one Gaussian mechanism. Private training has dense queries and many releases, because one record's gradient moves every coordinate of a model at every step. So it clips the ℓ_2 norm of each gradient and calibrates Gaussian noise to that clip.

15.6. Calibrating a release

Every noisy release has five steps.

1. Fix the neighbouring relation and the unit of privacy, usually one person under add/remove.
2. Clip every value to a range fixed in advance. Then take the sensitivity from Table 15.1, or calculate it from the worst record.
3. Use Laplace noise for one number or a sparse vector, and Gaussian noise for a dense vector.
4. Set the scale with Equation 15.3 or Equation 15.6. Charge it to your budget (Post-processing, group privacy and composition).
5. Draw the noise with a library that experts have checked. Publish the error bar and the noise parameters with the result.

A mean under add/remove has no simple sensitivity, because its denominator also moves. So release a noisy sum and a noisy count, each with half of the budget. Then divide the sum by the count, which is post-processing and costs nothing. For the error bar of the mean, take the bar of each at 97.5%, so that both hold together 95% of the time. Then the mean is above the sum's lower end divided by the count's upper end. It is below the sum's upper end divided by the count's lower end, if both lower ends are positive.

OpenDP's `.dp.mean` makes the same split, and `summarize(alpha=0.025)` gives the two bars at 97.5%. When you do not know the range for the clip, Private mean estimation finds it privately. Use plain `numpy.random.laplace` only for prototypes, because textbook floating-point samplers can leak through the low-order bits of their output (Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms). For a whole release with clipping, grouping and one budget, follow Release statistics with a library.

15.7. Code

The snippet checks the hospital's numbers and the analytic σ^* at $\varepsilon = 1$. In OpenDP, a mechanism's `map` takes the sensitivity and gives the ε that it costs, and the accuracy helpers change a scale into a 95% error bar or back. For a count, with sensitivity 1, one over that scale is the ε of the error budget. IBM's diffprivlib calibrates the analytic Gaussian.

```python
import math

import opendp.prelude as dp
from diffprivlib.mechanisms import GaussianAnalytic

dp.enable_features("contrib")
laplace = dp.m.make_laplace(dp.atom_domain(T=float, nan=False), dp.absolute_distance(T=float
print(laplace.map(1.0))  # 0.1
print(f"{dp.laplacian_scale_to_accuracy(10.0, alpha=0.05):.2f}")  # 29.96
print(f"{1 / dp.accuracy_to_laplacian_scale(10.0, alpha=0.05):.4f}")  # 0.2996
gauss = GaussianAnalytic(epsilon=1.0, delta=1e-5, sensitivity=1.0)
print(f"{math.sqrt(gauss.variance(0.0)):.4f}")  # 3.7306
```

To add the noise, call the mechanism on the value, as in `laplace(1234.0)`.

15.8. Cheat sheet

Table 15.2.: The results of this chapter.

Result	Formula	Notes
Laplace mechanism	$\mathrm{Lap}(\Delta_1 f/\varepsilon)$ per coordinate	Pure DP; error does not depend on n
Laplace error bar	$b\ln(d/\beta)$ for all d coordinates, scale b	Solve it for ε to budget error
Exact Gaussian δ	$\Phi(\frac{\mu}{2}-\frac{\varepsilon}{\mu})-e^{\varepsilon}\Phi(-\frac{\mu}{2}-\frac{\varepsilon}{\mu})$, $\mu=\Delta_2 f/\sigma$	Solve for σ with `GaussianAnalytic`
Classic Gaussian	$\sigma=\Delta_2 f\sqrt{2\ln(1.25/\delta)}/\varepsilon$	Too much noise below 1, unsafe above 8.42
Dense query	Laplace wins only for $d<(\varepsilon\sigma_1)^2/2$	Otherwise use Gaussian noise

Rules of thumb

- Calibrate Laplace noise to $\Delta_1 f$ and Gaussian noise to $\Delta_2 f$, never the other way round.
- When n is not public, never use B/n as the sensitivity of a mean.

15.9. References

- Dwork & Roth, *The Algorithmic Foundations of Differential Privacy* (2014), §3.3 and Appendix A: the Laplace mechanism and the classic Gaussian calibration.
- Balle & Wang, "Improving the Gaussian Mechanism for Differential Privacy" (ICML 2018): the exact privacy curve and the bisection calibration.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

16. Advanced and optimal composition

16.1. What it is

A dashboard refreshes a hundred counts, and a training run takes thousands of noisy steps, but you report one differential privacy (DP) guarantee for the whole run. Each step has its own privacy level ε and slack δ (The definition of differential privacy). **Basic composition** adds them, so a run of k steps costs $k\varepsilon$ and $k\delta$ (Post-processing, group privacy and composition). That total is correct but too large, because each step's privacy loss depends on the noise and is often negative. So the sum almost never reaches $k\varepsilon$.

Advanced composition (Dwork, Rothblum & Vadhan 2010) uses these cancellations. With an extra slack δ' that you pick for the whole run, the steps are together $(\varepsilon_{\text{total}}, k\delta + \delta')$-DP, with

$$\varepsilon_{\text{total}} = \varepsilon\sqrt{2k\ln(1/\delta')} + k\varepsilon\tanh(\varepsilon/2). \tag{16.1}$$

The first term is the spread of the total loss, which grows only like $\sqrt{k}$. The second term, the drift, is its average.

Optimal composition (Kairouz, Oh & Viswanath 2015) gives the smallest total that is correct when you know each step only by its pair (ε, δ). For a hundred counts on 10,000 people, each at $\varepsilon = 0.1$ with no slack, basic composition gives a total of 10. Advanced and optimal composition spend a slack $\delta' = 10^{-5}$, the book's default for 10,000 people, and give 5.30 and 4.31.

16.2. When you meet it

You meet these rules in papers, privacy reviews and libraries that give one total ε for many steps (Table 16.1).

Table 16.1.: Which composition rule to use, at a slack of 10^{-5} (none for basic composition).

What you know about the steps	Rule	Total ε for 100 steps at 0.1
Each step's ε, and δ must stay 0	Basic composition	10
Each step's (ε, δ), to plan by hand	Advanced composition	5.30
Each step's (ε, δ), for the number you report	Optimal composition	4.31

What you know about the steps	Rule	Total ε for 100 steps at 0.1
The mechanism itself, such as Gaussian noise	An accountant (Part 4), which composes whole privacy curves	Often far smaller
Budgets chosen during the run	A privacy filter, which enforces a budget fixed in advance	—

Optimal composition is optimal only for steps that you know by one pair each. A real mechanism has a whole privacy curve, with one δ for each ε, and one pair loses the rest of it. For example, a thousand Gaussian steps with noise standard deviation 20 on a query of sensitivity 1 are exactly $(7.51, 10^{-5})$-DP as curves. With the best single pair of each step, optimal composition gives 62.7, about eight times worse. So when you know the mechanism, compose its curve with an accountant (Privacy accounting).

16.3. How to use it

To divide a total budget $\varepsilon_{\text{total}}$ among k steps, use advanced composition in reverse. When $\varepsilon\sqrt{k}$ is small, the drift term of Equation 16.1 is very small, so each step can have about

$$\varepsilon \approx \frac{\varepsilon_{\text{total}}}{\sqrt{2k \ln(1/\delta')}}. \tag{16.2}$$

When $\varepsilon\sqrt{k}$ comes near 1, the drift is no longer small, and this shortcut gives each step too much.

To report a run, give the accountant's number at the run's total δ when you know the mechanism. Otherwise, give the optimal composition. The snippet below plans the hundred counts within a total of $(1, 10^{-5})$, with all of the slack in δ'. Then it reports the thousand Gaussian steps with two accountants of Google's `dp_accounting`, one on the privacy loss distribution (PLD) and one on Rényi differential privacy (RDP).

```
import math

import dp_accounting

print(f"{1.0 / math.sqrt(2 * 100 * math.log(1e5)):.4f}")  # 0.0208
step = dp_accounting.GaussianDpEvent(noise_multiplier=20.0)
run = dp_accounting.SelfComposedDpEvent(step, 1000)
pld = dp_accounting.pld.PLDAccountant()
pld.compose(run)
print(f"{pld.get_epsilon(target_delta=1e-5):.2f}")  # 7.51
rdp = dp_accounting.rdp.RdpAccountant()
rdp.compose(run)
print(f"{rdp.get_epsilon(target_delta=1e-5):.2f}")  # 8.08
```

Each count gets 0.0208, twice the 1/100 of basic composition. The PLD accountant gives the exact 7.51, and the RDP accountant a correct but larger 8.08 (Choosing an accountant).

16.4. What goes wrong

For a few steps, advanced composition can give more than basic composition, so always take the smaller of the two. Every rule also adds the slacks of the steps, so count each δ.

All these rules hold when each query depends on earlier answers, but only if you fix the budget of each step before the run. If you choose the budgets from the answers, you need a privacy filter (Adaptive composition). Early stops also need care. A stop rule that reads only the noisy answers is post-processing, so the run costs no more than its planned length. But if a run stops when the true count of a group goes above a threshold, its length shows that count. Then each answer is ε-DP, but the whole run is not DP for any finite ε.

So in a review, a total below optimal composition is a red flag, unless an accountant calculated it from the curve of the mechanism.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

17. Selection: exponential mechanism, report-noisy-max, sparse vector

17.1. Why this matters

Many questions ask you to pick something, such as the best model on a validation set, a median, or the first alarm among many statistics. If you publish the score of every candidate with Laplace noise, you pay the budget once per candidate, because the budgets of separate releases add. The mechanisms of this chapter **release the position, not the values**. One record can change the winner only a little, for any number of candidates. So under differential privacy (DP), a selection costs as much as a single query, and the number of candidates changes only the accuracy, through its logarithm.

17.2. Which mechanism to use

Table 17.1 gives the mechanism for each common task. In each, the **sensitivity** Δu is the most that one person's record can change the score of a candidate.

Table 17.1.: Which selection mechanism to use.

Task	Mechanism	Privacy cost
Pick the best of a fixed list	Exponential mechanism or report-noisy-max	ε
Pick the top c, such as the most frequent items	Gumbel noise, keep the c largest, or noisy max c times	$c\varepsilon$
Pick a number from a range, such as a quantile or a clipping norm	Exponential mechanism over the range	ε
Find the first query in a stream above a threshold	AboveThreshold	ε, however long the stream

17.3. The exponential mechanism

The candidates form a fixed set, written $\mathcal{R}$. Each candidate r has a **score** on the dataset D, written $u(D, r)$, such as the number of validation records that a model gets right. The **exponential**

mechanism of McSherry and Talwar (2007) picks each candidate with a probability proportional to an exponential of its score. With a privacy budget ε, it outputs candidate r with probability

$$\Pr[M_E(D) = r] = \frac{\exp\left(\varepsilon\, u(D, r)/(2\Delta u)\right)}{\sum_s \exp\left(\varepsilon\, u(D, s)/(2\Delta u)\right)}. \tag{17.1}$$

It is ε-DP because one record changes each weight, and also their sum, by at most a factor $e^{\varepsilon/2}$, which makes e^{ε} for their ratio.

Two conditions decide whether a use is correct. First, fix the list of candidates before you look at the data. A list made from the data reveals records by itself, such as a word that only one person used. Second, remove the 2 in the exponent only when the scores are **monotone**, which means that one record pushes all of them the same way. Counts under add/remove neighbours are monotone. A histogram under replace neighbours is not, because a moved record lowers one count and raises another, so without the 2 the cost is double.

17.4. Accuracy, and the cost of many candidates

The number of candidates $|\mathcal{R}|$ costs no privacy but costs accuracy, because more candidates means more bad ones to pick. Call the best score minus the score of the chosen candidate the **gap**. On average it is at most

$$\frac{2\Delta u}{\varepsilon}(\ln|\mathcal{R}| + 1), \tag{17.2}$$

so twice the candidates add only $\ln 2$ to the bracket.

Suppose that you trained 50 models and want to release the best one on a private validation set of 1,000 records. Model r, numbered from 1, gets $900 - r$ records right, so model 1 is the best. The score is that count, which one record moves by at most 1, so $\Delta u = 1$. At $\varepsilon = 1$, the mechanism picks the best model only 39% of the time. But it loses only 1.54 correct predictions on average, or 0.15% accuracy, because its mistakes are mostly near-ties. Hyperparameter tuning picks models this way.

17.5. A private quantile or clipping norm

A median or a clipping norm read from the data leaks the data, so pick it with the exponential mechanism. Before you look at the data, fix a range. Then clip every record into it. The score of each point of the range is how close the share of records below it is to the quantile that you want. For the median, that quantile is one half. One added or removed record moves each score by at most 1. The score stays the same between consecutive sorted records, so the mechanism picks one of these intervals, called **pieces**, and returns a uniform point inside it. It prefers long pieces near the quantile.

diffprivlib's `tools.quantile` and `tools.median` take an `epsilon` and the range as `bounds`. OpenDP's `.dp.quantile` and `.dp.median` work on Polars data frames and pick one value from a finite list of candidates. The script practitioner_adult_statistics.py takes the median age of the Adult census data, 48,842 people with one row each, at $\varepsilon = 1$. The range of 17 to 90 comes from the survey's documentation.

```
age = adult["age"].to_numpy()
private = tools.median(age, epsilon=1.0, bounds=(17, 90), random_state=seed)
print(f"true median age: {np.median(age):.1f}  diffprivlib median: {private:.2f}")
```

With `random_state=0`, it prints a true median of 37.0 and a private one of 37.72. Ages are whole numbers, so every point between 37 and 38 has the same score, and the mechanism picked a random point in that piece. OpenDP does not run the median without a public upper bound on the number of rows, declared as a `Margin`. Choose a large bound from public facts, because it must be at least the true number of rows, and a larger bound costs almost nothing.

```
context = dp.Context.compositor(
    data=adult.lazy(),
    privacy_unit=dp.unit_of(contributions=1),  # one row per person
    privacy_loss=dp.loss_of(epsilon=1.0),
    split_evenly_over=1,
    margins=[dp.polars.Margin(max_length=100_000)],  # a public bound on the number of rows
)
age_col: Any = pl.col("age")  # OpenDP adds .dp to Polars expressions when it is imported
query = context.query().select(age_col.dp.median(candidates=list(range(17, 91))))
print(query.summarize(alpha=0.05))
released = query.release().collect()  # changes on every run: OpenDP's noise has no seed
```

Its summary shows `ExponentialMin` with a scale of 2.0, because OpenDP 0.16 adds exponential noise to the score of every candidate and reports the best. That is **permute-and-flip** (McKenna & Sheldon 2020), which has the guarantee of the exponential mechanism and never a worse error on average. The accuracy is `null`, because OpenDP gives no error bar for a quantile. The noise has no seed, so the released value changes on each run of `uv run python code/part03-dp-foundations/practitioner_adult_statistics.py`.

The error bar that you can state is about rank, not value. With probability $1 - \beta$, the gap of the exponential mechanism is at most $(2\Delta u/\varepsilon)(\ln|\mathcal{R}| + \ln(1/\beta))$, the tail form of Equation 17.2. For a median, with $\Delta u = 1$, the gap is the number of records by which the output misses the middle rank. So $\beta = 0.05$ gives its 95% bar in ranks. A bar in value would need the number of records near the median, which the release does not show. If a dashboard needs values, spend budget on a few noisy counts below candidate values. A large range costs little, because its width changes the gap only through the logarithm of the number of candidates.

Two things go wrong in practice. Where the data near the quantile are sparse, the best piece is long and the output can be anywhere in it. Then a small error in rank is a large error in value. And the range or the candidates must not come from the data. For example, an upper end set to the observed maximum brings back the leak. diffprivlib warns with a `PrivacyLeakWarning` when you leave out `bounds` (Sensitivity).

17.6. Report-noisy-max and Gumbel noise

Report-noisy-max adds independent Laplace noise to the score of each candidate and outputs the candidate with the largest noisy score. It is ε-DP for any number of candidates when the

noise has scale $2\Delta u/\varepsilon$, or $\Delta u/\varepsilon$ when one record pushes all scores the same way. Release only the index of the winner, and pay for a fresh noisy answer if you need its score.

Gumbel noise of scale $2\Delta u/\varepsilon$ in place of the Laplace noise gives exactly the exponential mechanism. Libraries sample it with this **Gumbel-max trick**, because the exponential of a score in the thousands overflows, but noisy scores do not. The c largest scores with Gumbel noise give the top c at once (Durfee & Rogers 2019).

17.7. The sparse vector technique

Sometimes queries come one at a time, and you want the first one that is high enough. The **sparse vector technique** (Dwork et al. 2009) compares each query with one noisy threshold and pays only for the query that fires. Its basic form, **AboveThreshold**, takes a threshold τ and a stream of queries f, all with the same sensitivity Δf. It divides the budget into ε_1 for the threshold and ε_2 for the queries.

1. Draw one threshold noise, written ν, from $\mathrm{Lap}(\Delta f/\varepsilon_1)$ for the whole run.
2. For each query, draw a fresh noise from $\mathrm{Lap}(2\Delta f/\varepsilon_2)$ and add it to the answer of the query. If the result is at least $\tau + \nu$, output "above" and stop. If not, output "below" and continue.

AboveThreshold is $(\varepsilon_1 + \varepsilon_2)$-DP for any number of "below" answers, even when each query is chosen after the earlier answers. All the "below" answers together pay ε_1, through the one threshold noise, and the single "above" pays ε_2.

But the accuracy depends on the stream length k, which you must fix before the run. Write β for the chance that the accuracy guarantee fails. With an equal split, $\varepsilon_1 = \varepsilon_2 = \varepsilon/2$, every query gets the correct answer unless its true value is within a margin

$$\alpha = \frac{8\Delta f(\ln k + \ln(2/\beta))}{\varepsilon} \tag{17.3}$$

of the threshold. Monitor 1,000 counts, each with $\Delta f = 1$, against a threshold of 500 at $\varepsilon = 1$. At $\beta = 0.05$, the margin is 84.77. So with probability 0.95, only a count that near the threshold can get the wrong answer.

To find the first c queries above the threshold, start AboveThreshold again after each "above", with fresh threshold noise and ε/c per run. Stop after the c-th. The margin then grows with c, so ask for as few alarms as you can. Lyu, Su and Li keep one threshold for all c alarms and multiply the query noise by c.

17.8. When the sparse vector technique goes wrong

Several published variants do not have the privacy they claim (Table 17.2).

Table 17.2.: Variants of the sparse vector technique and their actual privacy, from Lyu, Su & Li (2017).

Variant (as numbered by Lyu, Su & Li)	What it changes	Actual privacy
Algorithm 3	Outputs the noisy value of each "above"	∞
Algorithm 4	Query noise does not grow with c	$\frac{1+6c}{4}\varepsilon$
Algorithm 5	No noise on the queries	∞
Algorithm 6	Never halts	∞

The variant that never stops is the one to remember. It adds exactly as much noise per query as AboveThreshold, so a reviewer who checks noise scales does not find it. But at $\varepsilon = 1$, its privacy loss gets to 18.1246 on 80 queries.

So review the accounting, not only the noise. Draw one threshold noise per run. If you draw the threshold again for each query, every "below" answer costs budget that nobody counted. Draw fresh noise for every query, because one noise draw for all of them is the same as Algorithm 5. Stop after the permitted number of "above" answers. Never publish the noisy values that you compared.

17.9. Cheat sheet

Table 17.3.: The selection mechanisms of this chapter, with $|\mathcal{R}|$ candidates or k queries.

Mechanism	Privacy	Accuracy
Exponential mechanism, Equation 17.1	ε; drop the 2 only for monotone scores	Mean gap $\leq \frac{2\Delta u}{\varepsilon}(\ln \lvert\mathcal{R}\rvert + 1)$
Report-noisy-max, noise $\mathrm{Lap}(2\Delta u/\varepsilon)$	ε, index only	Similar to the exponential mechanism
AboveThreshold	$\varepsilon_1 + \varepsilon_2$	Margin $8\Delta f(\ln k + \ln \frac{2}{\beta})/\varepsilon$, failure probability β

Rules of thumb

- Release positions, not values.
- Fix the candidate list, and the range of any number you pick, before you look at the data.

17.10. References

- Dwork & Roth, *The Algorithmic Foundations of Differential Privacy* (2014), §3.3, §3.4 and §3.6: the three mechanisms in their standard form.
- Lyu, Su & Li, "Understanding the Sparse Vector Technique for Differential Privacy" (VLDB 2017): the budget split and the survey of broken variants.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

18. Query release and private multiplicative weights

18.1. Why this matters

Analysts ask for every two-way table over a few columns, or for a synthetic file to query as often as they like. Both must satisfy differential privacy (DP). Such tables are **marginal tables**. Each one counts the records for each combination of values of a few attributes, and each count is a **cell**.

These releases add noise to whole tables, not to single cells, and scale it to how much one person can change the table. One person is in one cell of a table, so a whole table costs about as much as one count. All later computation on the noisy tables is free. When the queries are too many for noise on every cell, use synthetic data fitted to a few noisy tables.

18.2. Which method to use

The choice depends on how many queries you have, compared with the number of records, and on the number of attributes of a record (Table 18.1).

Table 18.1.: Which query-release method to use.

Situation	Use
A few marginal tables, with a public list of cells	Noisy counts on every cell, one budget share per table
Hundreds of tables or thousands of cells	Gaussian noise on every cell, scaled to the whole set of tables
A table whose list of values is not public	Noisy counts, keeping only cells that clear a noisy threshold (Release statistics with a library)
Far more queries than records, or queries not known in advance	Synthetic data from AIM or MST
Queries that arrive one at a time, perhaps adaptively	Online private multiplicative weights

One person is in every table, so the tables form a dense query, and the dense-query rule of the Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms tells where "a few" tables end. At a privacy level ε of 1 and a slack δ of 10^{-5}, Gaussian noise is better from 7 tables on.

18.3. Noise on every cell

Under add/remove neighbours, a person with one record changes one cell of a marginal table by 1, so the whole table has sensitivity 1. Laplace noise of scale $1/\varepsilon$ on every cell then makes the table ε-DP, by parallel composition. Under replace neighbours, a person can move from one cell to another, so two cells change and the sensitivity doubles.

Several tables of the same people compose. With Laplace noise, you split the budget among the tables, so the error per cell grows in proportion to their number. Gaussian noise scales with the square root of the sum of squared changes. For one person in a number m of tables, that is $\sqrt{m}$, so the Gaussian error grows only like $\sqrt{m}$.

For example, a table of 10,000 records has eight yes/no attributes, so $2^8 = 256$ possible records. The release is every cell of the marginal table of every set of attributes, 6,560 cells in all. Each cell is a fraction of the records, under replace neighbours. A uniform guess, which ignores the data, has a largest error of 0.232 on these cells. At $\varepsilon = 1$, Laplace noise on every cell is worse, with 0.497. Gaussian noise at $\delta = 10^{-6}$ is much better, with 0.037.

Two mistakes are common. If you scale the noise of each cell to its own sensitivity, as if it were the only query, you silently spend ε once per table. And basic composition over thousands of separate cells wastes most of the budget. Calibrate to the whole set of tables instead.

18.4. Releasing a marginal with OpenDP

The script practitioner_adult_statistics.py releases the education-by-income table of the Adult census data, 48,842 people with one row each, at $\varepsilon = 1$. The survey's documentation lists 16 levels of education and two income classes, so the keys are public and the table has 32 cells. The release includes empty cells too, because a missing cell would show that nobody has those values. Map a missing value to a listed key such as "Unknown", because OpenDP drops a row whose key is not in the list. In OpenDP, a `Margin` (a setting, not a marginal table) with `invariant="keys"` makes the list of cells public, and `with_keys` limits the release to exactly those cells.

```
keys = pl.LazyFrame({"education": EDUCATION}).join(pl.LazyFrame({"income": INCOME}), how="cr
context = dp.Context.compositor(
    data=adult.lazy(),
    privacy_unit=dp.unit_of(contributions=1),
    privacy_loss=dp.loss_of(epsilon=1.0),
    split_evenly_over=1,
    margins=[dp.polars.Margin(by=["education", "income"], invariant="keys")],  # the cells a
)
query = context.query().group_by("education", "income").agg(dp.len(signed=True)).with_keys(k
print(query.summarize(alpha=0.05))
released = query.release().collect()  # all 32 cells, zeros included; changes on every run
```

Run it with `uv run python code/part03-dp-foundations/practitioner_adult_statistics.py`. The summary is deterministic.

```
shape: (1, 5)
┌────────┬──────────────┬──────────────────┬───────┬──────────┐
│ column ┆ aggregate    ┆ distribution     ┆ scale ┆ accuracy │
│ ---    ┆ ---          ┆ ---              ┆ ---   ┆ ---      │
│ str    ┆ str          ┆ str              ┆ f64   ┆ f64      │
╞════════╪══════════════╪══════════════════╪═══════╪══════════╡
│ len    ┆ Frame Length ┆ Integer Laplace  ┆ 1.0   ┆ 3.375618 │
└────────┴──────────────┴──────────────────┴───────┴──────────┘
```

Each cell gets integer Laplace noise of scale 1 (Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms). The 95% accuracy of 3.38 means that each noisy count is that close to the truth 95% of the time. Print that error bar next to every cell, and note that it covers only the noise, not sampling error or mistakes in the data. OpenDP's noise has no seed, so these four cells come from one run, next to the true counts.

```
Doctorate >50K: 432  true 431  accuracy 3.38
HS-grad <=50K: 13281  true 13281  accuracy 3.38
Preschool <=50K: 82  true 82  accuracy 3.38
Preschool >50K: 0  true 1  accuracy 3.38
```

The large cells barely move, but the smallest true cell, one person with a preschool education and a high income, is smaller than the noise. So if small cells matter, merge rare categories in advance. With `signed=True`, a count can come out negative, which keeps it unbiased. A clamp at zero, rounding, and scaling the cells to a total already released are post-processing, so they cost nothing.

Three things go wrong. First, a list of cells from the data, such as `unique()` on a private column, shows rare values by itself. Without a codebook, use partition selection (Release statistics with a library). Second, each extra table of the same people needs its own share of the budget, so set `split_evenly_over` to the number of tables. Third, for many tables, give the budget as `dp.loss_of(rho=...)`, with the ρ that converts to your (ε, δ) (Release statistics with a library shows how). OpenDP then uses Gaussian noise, which composes far better, and accounts in zero-concentrated differential privacy (zCDP) (Concentrated differential privacy).

18.5. Synthetic data

When the queries are too many for noise on every cell, or nobody knows them in advance, release synthetic data, in four steps.

1. **Select** a set of marginal tables to measure, from domain knowledge or privately with the exponential mechanism, scoring each table by how badly the current model fits it.
2. **Measure** each whole table with Gaussian noise, scaled to the whole set.
3. **Generate** a compact graphical model that fits the noisy tables.
4. **Sample** synthetic rows from the model.

All steps after the measurements are post-processing. So you can query and share the synthetic rows at no more privacy cost. The standard methods are MST and AIM, by McKenna and coauthors, and AIM selects the tables to measure as it goes. SmartNoise Synth, the `snsynth` package, gives the two methods one interface. This book's environment does not include it, so the call below did not run. Install it in an environment of its own.

```
# smartnoise-synth 1.0.8: not installed in this book's environment, not run
from snsynth import Synthesizer

synth = Synthesizer.create("aim", epsilon=1.0, delta=1e-6)
synth.fit(adult_pandas, categorical_columns=["education", "sex", "race", "occupation", "inco
rows = synth.sample(48_842)
```

A synthetic table is accurate on the tables that it measured, by construction. So evaluate it on other queries, but not freely on the private data. If you keep the best of several runs, judged against the private data, you select on that data. Also, each extra run spends the generator's budget again. So score candidate settings on a public dataset of the same shape, or charge the comparisons to the budget. A generator trained without DP is not anonymised, however synthetic its rows look.

18.6. Private multiplicative weights

The synthetic-data tools keep the select, measure and update loop of the **multiplicative weights exponential mechanism (MWEM)** of Hardt, Ligett and McSherry (2012). MWEM is the practical form of private multiplicative weights, and it keeps a guessed histogram with one weight for each possible record, 256 in the eight-attribute example. In each of a fixed number of rounds, it uses the exponential mechanism to select a query that the guess answers badly. Then it measures that query with fresh Laplace noise and moves the guess toward the measurement. The number of corrections has a limit for all numbers of queries, so the error grows only with the logarithm of the number of queries.

That pays off only for very large sets of queries. On the eight-attribute example at privacy level 1, with 38 rounds, the largest error of MWEM is 0.078. That is better than Laplace noise, but about two times worse than Gaussian noise. Its running time also grows with the number of possible records, which limits it to a few attributes.

If you implement it, fix the number of rounds before you see the data, from the error bound, which uses only public quantities. Measure each query with fresh noise, because the scores of the selection step are exact and must not leak. Release the average of the guesses, not the last one, because the accuracy guarantee covers only the average. For queries that arrive one at a time, an online form pays only for its corrections (Adaptive data analysis).

18.7. Cheat sheet

Table 18.2.: The query-release methods of this chapter.

Method	Privacy	Error grows with
Laplace noise on every cell	ε; one table costs ε under add/remove	The number of tables
Gaussian noise on every cell	(ε, δ) or zCDP	The square root of the number of tables
Private multiplicative weights	ε or (ε, δ)	The logarithms of the numbers of queries and possible records
Select, measure, generate (MST, AIM)	(ε, δ)	No closed form; the practical choice for many attributes

Rules of thumb

- Take the list of cells from a codebook, never from the private data.
- Add noise to whole tables, scaled to the set of tables, and post-process freely afterwards.
- Fit synthetic data once, and never pick the best of several runs on the private data.

18.8. References

- McKenna, Mullins, Sheldon & Miklau, "AIM: An Adaptive and Iterative Mechanism for Differentially Private Synthetic Data" (VLDB 2022): the select, measure and generate loop as used in practice.
- Hardt, Ligett & McSherry, "A Simple and Practical Algorithm for Differentially Private Data Release" (NeurIPS 2012): MWEM, with experiments on real tables.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

19. Beyond global sensitivity

19.1. What it is

The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms set their noise by the **global sensitivity**, the most one record can move the answer over all pairs of neighbouring datasets. The median of ages between 0 and 100 has global sensitivity 100. So under differential privacy (DP) at a privacy level of $\varepsilon = 1$, the Laplace mechanism's median error is $100 \ln 2 = 69.31$ years. But on a simulated sample of 1,001 ages, one person moves the median by only 0.1386 years. That smaller number is the **local sensitivity**, the most one record can move the answer f from the dataset D you hold:

$$\mathrm{LS}_f(D) = \max_{D' \text{ a neighbour of } D} |f(D) - f(D')|. \tag{19.1}$$

The techniques of this page add noise on the scale of the data you hold, under one rule. **A noise scale, bound or threshold that you compute from the data is itself a statistic of the data, so it must be private too.** On this page, datasets have a fixed size n, and neighbours replace one record.

19.2. When you meet it

You meet these techniques when a statistic has no useful worst case (Table 19.1).

Table 19.1.: Which technique releases what, and where you meet it.

You release	Technique	Where you meet it
A sum, mean or gradient of unbounded values	Clipping to a bound fixed in advance	Every library's `bounds`, and the clipping norm of private training
A median or quantile	Inverse sensitivity	`diffprivlib.tools.quantile`, OpenDP's `dp.quantile`
A discrete answer with a clear winner	Stability-based release	The threshold of private partition selection
A black-box model or estimator	Subsample-and-aggregate	Teacher ensembles for private prediction

A **stability-based release** publishes a discrete answer exactly, such as the most common value. It does so if a noisy test shows that the answer leads the runner-up by about $2 \ln(1/\delta)/\varepsilon$ records,

for a slack δ. Otherwise it refuses, so plan for refusals downstream. The same test selects the keys a group-by can release (Release statistics with a library).

Subsample-and-aggregate runs an estimator on disjoint blocks and averages their clipped answers with noise. Private aggregation of teacher ensembles (PATE) is its voting form (Private prediction).

Propose-test-release proposes a bound on the local sensitivity, and refuses unless a noisy test shows that the data are far from it. **Smooth sensitivity** scales heavy-tailed noise to a bound that cannot jump between neighbours. PATE uses it for the ε of its votes, but on the 1,001 ages it is about twelve times less accurate than inverse sensitivity (below).

19.3. How to use it

Most of the time you bound the inputs. **Clipping** replaces each value x by $\min(x, C)$, for a clip bound C that you fix before you see the data. If the values cannot be negative, one record then moves the mean of n records by at most C/n. So Laplace noise of scale $C/(n\varepsilon)$ on the clipped mean gives ε-DP, and a larger C gives less bias but more noise.

Choose C from domain knowledge, such as a legal maximum or a sensor range. Otherwise, spend a small part of the budget, charged by composition, on a private high quantile and clip there. If you give no bound, diffprivlib computes it from the data and issues a `PrivacyLeakWarning`. Make that warning an error with `warnings.simplefilter("error", PrivacyLeakWarning)`, as practitioner_adult_statistics.py does.

For a median or quantile, use **inverse sensitivity**. This exponential mechanism favours each candidate output by how few records must change before the median equals it. Give it bounds or a candidate grid fixed in advance. On the 1,001 ages at $\varepsilon = 1$, its median error is 0.0783 years, less than even the local sensitivity of 0.1386.

19.4. What goes wrong

Noise scaled to the local sensitivity is not private. The five ages $(0, 0, 0, 0, 100)$ have median 0. No single change moves it, so they get no noise. Their neighbour $(0, 0, 0, 100, 100)$ gets continuous noise, so its output is never exactly 0, and an output of exactly 0 names the first dataset. The same leak hides in a clip bound set to the observed maximum, a candidate grid made from the values of the data, or keys read from the data. In review, search for a `max()`, `quantile()` or `unique()` on the private data that sets a parameter.

A clip from above always moves a mean down. A two-sided clip removes that bias only when the range has the data at its centre (Private mean estimation). If neighbours add or remove a record, n is not public. Then release a noisy clipped sum and a noisy count, and divide the two.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

20. Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms

20.1. What it is

The proof of the Laplace mechanism is about densities on the real line. But a computer samples floating-point numbers, a finite set with uneven gaps. The textbook sampler adds $\pm b \ln(1/U)$ to the true answer, for a noise scale b and a uniform draw U. Mironov (2012) showed that in double precision this sampler leaks the true answer through the last bits of its output. Floats are dense near 0 and sparse far from it. So many outputs can come from a true answer of 0 or of 1, but not from the two. Such an output names its input with certainty.

Differential privacy (DP) cannot cover that leak. DP limits how much one record can change the chance of an output, by a privacy level ε and a slack δ (The definition of differential privacy). Take a set S of outputs that a dataset D can reach but its neighbour never can. No factor e^{ε} lifts the neighbour's probability of S above 0, so for a mechanism M the slack must cover all of

$$\delta \geq \Pr[M(D) \in S]. \tag{20.1}$$

In a toy sampler with 12-bit floats, such outputs carry probability 0.4791, and more bits do not shrink it.

So **DP is a property of the distribution that the code actually produces.** There are two repairs. The **snapping mechanism** keeps floats. It clamps the answer, adds noise, rounds to a coarse power-of-two grid and clamps again. The other repair makes the query integer-valued and adds exact discrete Laplace or discrete Gaussian noise.

20.2. When you meet it

You meet this problem when you review code that adds noise itself, such as the unsafe `x + np.random.laplace(0, b)`, and when you choose a library. OpenDP's samplers are exact, and on integer data they give discrete Laplace and discrete Gaussian noise. diffprivlib has `mechanisms.Geometric` (its name for the discrete Laplace), `mechanisms.GaussianDiscrete` and `mechanisms.Snapping`. Its continuous `Laplace`, which its `tools` functions use, is a mitigation, not an exact sampler: it draws four uniform variates against this attack (Holohan & Braghin 2021). Secure aggregation needs integer noise too (Local, shuffle and distributed trust models).

In private training, Opacus adds continuous Gaussian noise in floating point, so the proof of Private stochastic gradient descent covers only idealized code. Its `secure_mode=True` takes the noise from a cryptographic generator, which makes these attacks harder. For a released model, make sure that it used this mode and that its guarantee names the idealized mechanism.

20.3. How to use it

Use a library on integer data. Its **discrete Laplace** noise gives each integer z a probability proportional to $e^{-|z|/b}$, and you calibrate it like continuous noise. For an integer query with sensitivity Δf, it gives $\varepsilon = \Delta f/b$. At $b = 1$, a count comes out exact with probability 0.4621.

The **discrete Gaussian** gives each integer x a probability proportional to $e^{-x^2/(2\sigma^2)}$, for a width σ. Its exact privacy curve is a little worse than the continuous one. At sensitivity 1 and $\sigma = 1$, its δ at $\varepsilon = 1$ is 0.1414, against 0.1269. So report the discrete curve, or account as OpenDP does in zero-concentrated DP. In that accounting, the discrete Gaussian has the same privacy parameter as the continuous one, $\rho = (\Delta f)^2/(2\sigma^2)$. In the snippet, `map(1)` gives each guarantee at sensitivity 1.

```
import opendp.prelude as dp

dp.enable_features("contrib")
integers, distance = dp.atom_domain(T=int), dp.absolute_distance(T=int)
laplace = dp.m.make_laplace(integers, distance, scale=1.0)
print(laplace.map(1))  # 1.0
gauss = dp.m.make_gaussian(integers, distance, scale=2.0)
print(gauss.map(1))  # 0.125
print(gauss.output_measure)  # ZeroConcentratedDivergence
```

To make a real-valued query integer, such as a sum of clipped values, divide it by a step much smaller than the noise. Round up with probability equal to the fractional part, and down otherwise, so that the result has no bias. Compute the sensitivity again in those units, because rounding can move neighbours a little further apart. Then add discrete noise and multiply back.

20.4. What goes wrong

Ask these questions of each implementation.

- Is every sensitivity computed from bounds fixed in advance, with no `max()`, `quantile()` or `unique()` on the private data (Beyond global sensitivity)?
- Does a vetted library draw the noise, or an exact sampler with no floating-point `exp`, `log` or `random()` inside? Search for `np.random`, `random.`, `scipy.stats`, `default_rng`, `.laplace(` and `.normal(`.
- Does integer data get integer noise, and is every floating-point output snapped and clamped to a fixed range?
- Does each release draw fresh noise from a cryptographic source, such as `secrets.SystemRandom()`, rather than a fixed seed that makes it removable?
- Is the running time fixed or padded? The rounds of a rejection sampler depend on the value it draws, and Jin et al. (2022) use that time as a leak.
- Does the stated guarantee match the mechanism, including the discrete Gaussian's own curve and the sensitivity after rounding?

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

21. Local, shuffle and distributed trust models

21.1. Why this matters

Every mechanism so far in this part assumed a **trusted curator**, which holds the raw data and releases only the output of the mechanism. In this **central model**, the differential privacy (DP) guarantee protects what the curator publishes. It does not protect against a breach of its database, a curious engineer or a court order. A browser vendor that collects usage statistics often does not have that much trust.

Three other models trust less. In the **local model**, you trust nobody, and each person randomizes their own record before it leaves their device. The **shuffle model** trusts a shuffler only to cut the link between each report and its sender. The **distributed model** trusts cryptography that shows only a sum, run by enough honest participants. The closer to each person you add the noise, the fewer parties you trust, and the more noise reaches the answer.

21.2. Choosing a trust model

Less trust costs more noise. As the population grows, the noise on a private count stays fixed in the central model, but grows with its square root in the local model. The shuffle and distributed models close most of that gap.

So use the central model when you can trust a curator with the raw data, as Release statistics with a library does end to end. Choose local only when nobody can see a raw record and the population is large enough, which you check with the standard deviation of Section 21.3. In all cases, state the trust model next to the privacy parameters, because the same ε protects against a different adversary in each model.

21.3. Central and local differential privacy

In the local model, each person sends only a **report**, the output of a **local randomizer** R on their own record. Write ε_0 for the privacy level of one report. The randomizer is ε_0-DP when no set of possible reports becomes more than e^{ε_0} times as likely when the record changes. That is, all sets of reports S and all pairs of records x and x' satisfy

$$\Pr[R(x) \in S] \leq e^{\varepsilon_0} \Pr[R(x') \in S]. \tag{21.1}$$

A change to one person's record changes only their own report, so the whole collection is ε_0-DP in the central sense, with neighbours that differ in one replaced record. The guarantee covers

only the randomized value, so a network address stored with a report links the report back to the person.

The basic local randomizer is randomized response on one bit. Each person reports their true bit with a probability $p = e^{\varepsilon_0}/(1 + e^{\varepsilon_0})$, and the flipped bit otherwise. To remove the expected flips, the analyst subtracts $1 - p$ from the share of reported ones and divides by $2p - 1$. The standard deviation of the estimate then depends only on the level and the number of people n:

$$\mathrm{sd}(\hat{\pi}) = \frac{e^{\varepsilon_0/2}}{(e^{\varepsilon_0} - 1)\sqrt{n}}. \tag{21.2}$$

The script practitioner_adult_statistics.py runs the two models at $\varepsilon_0 = \ln 3$ on the 48,842 people of the Adult census data. Each bit says whether a person's income is more than \$50K. In the local model, diffprivlib's `Binary` mechanism randomizes each bit, and the analyst sees only the reports.

```
answers = (adult["income"] == ">50K").cast(pl.Int8).cast(pl.String).to_list()  # "1" or "0"
n, eps = len(answers), log(3)
coin = Binary(epsilon=eps, value0="0", value1="1", random_state=seed)
reports = [coin.randomise(a) for a in answers]  # each person randomizes their own answer
p = exp(eps) / (1 + exp(eps))  # chance a report is truthful: 0.75
reported = reports.count("1") / n
local = (reported - (1 - p)) / (2 * p - 1)  # undo the expected flips
local_sd = math.sqrt(p * (1 - p) / n) / (2 * p - 1)  # the randomization noise alone
print(f"true share over 50K: {answers.count('1') / n:.4f}")
print(f"local estimate: {local:.4f}  sd {local_sd:.4f}")
```

In the central model, a trusted curator counts the true bits with diffprivlib's `tools.count_nonzero` at the same level. This call adds Laplace noise with standard deviation $\sqrt{2}/\varepsilon$ to the count.

```
rich = (adult["income"] == ">50K").to_numpy()
central = tools.count_nonzero(rich, epsilon=log(3), random_state=seed) / len(rich)
central_sd = math.sqrt(Laplace(epsilon=log(3), sensitivity=1).variance(0)) / len(rich)  # th
print(f"central estimate: {central:.4f}  sd {central_sd:.6f}")
```

Its seed-0 run, `uv run python code/part03-dp-foundations/practitioner_adult_statistics.py`, prints this.

```
true share over 50K: 0.2393
local estimate: 0.2359  sd 0.0039
central estimate: 0.2393  sd 0.000026
local sd / central sd: 149
```

So at the same guarantee, the local estimate is 149 times noisier, and the factor grows like the square root of the population. This cost comes from the model, not from randomized response, because no local protocol can estimate a fraction with an error below order $1/((e^{\varepsilon_0} - 1)\sqrt{n})$, and randomized response reaches that order. That is why Apple, Google and Microsoft use local DP only for the most frequent items in very large populations.

21.4. Frequency estimation: k-ary randomized response and unary encoding

Most deployed local DP does **frequency estimation**. Each person has one value from a known list, such as an emoji, and the analyst wants the share of people with each value. A report votes for a value with some probability p_1 if the person has it, and with a smaller probability p_0 otherwise. Suppose that c_v of the n reports vote for a value v. When you remove the false votes on average, you get the unbiased estimate

$$\hat{f}_v = \frac{c_v/n - p_0}{p_1 - p_0}. \tag{21.3}$$

Two designs set p_1 and p_0 for a list of k values. In **k-ary randomized response**, each person reports their true value with probability $e^{\varepsilon_0}/(e^{\varepsilon_0}+k-1)$, and another value otherwise. **Optimized unary encoding** sends one bit per value, and keeps the 1 of the person's value only half the time, but almost never changes a 0 into a 1. The variance for a rare value sets the smallest share that you can see, so compare the designs by it. Use k-ary randomized response when $k < 3e^{\varepsilon_0} + 2$, and unary encoding otherwise, at the cost of a k-bit report. The pure-ldp Python package has the two designs.

Take a keyboard app that wants the share of each of 128 emoji from a million users at $\varepsilon_0 = 1$. The estimate for a rare emoji has a standard deviation of 0.0019 under unary encoding, against 0.0066 under k-ary randomized response. By convention, an estimate must be three standard deviations above zero before you can tell it from noise. So even the better design loses all emoji that fewer than about 3×0.0019, or 0.6%, of users choose. Size the population from that floor before you collect. For lists too large to send, local hashing and heavy-hitter protocols send a few bits per report (Wang et al. 2017; Bassily et al. 2017).

21.5. Numbers in one bit: local mean estimation

For numbers between 0 and a known bound, such as minutes in an app, one bit per person is enough (Ding, Kulkarni & Yekhanin 2017). The chance of a 1 increases in a straight line with the value, so the analyst inverts that line to get an unbiased mean. For a million users, a bound of 1,440 minutes and $\varepsilon_0 = 1$, the mean has a standard deviation of 1.420 minutes. Fix the bound before collection and clip to it on the device. A bound from the reports would let one person's value change the randomizer of all users.

21.6. Collecting every day: memoization

Telemetry asks the same question every day. If a value does not change, an analyst can average its daily reports to remove their fresh noise. Composition counts that leak as the sum of the ε_0 of each report. The fix is **memoization**. The device draws one permanent randomized response per value and sends it each day, so an unchanged value costs only the level of that response, written ε_∞. RAPPOR, Google's collection of the homepages of Chrome users, has $\varepsilon_\infty = 2.043$.

Memoization fails when the value changes, because each new value costs another ε_∞. A user who changes their homepage every month gets to $12 \times 2.043 = 24.5$ in a year.

21.7. The shuffle model and amplification by shuffling

In the **shuffle model** (Cheu et al. 2019), each person sends a local report to a **shuffler**. The shuffler removes identifiers and timing, and sends the reports on in random order. Each report then hides among the others, so the collection meets central (ε, δ)-DP at an ε far below ε_0 (Amplification by shuffling and by iteration). The closed-form bound of Feldman, McMillan & Talwar (2021) gives that ε only when there are enough people to hide among:

$$\varepsilon_0 \leq \ln \frac{n}{16 \ln(2/\delta)}. \tag{21.4}$$

In practice, you fix the central target and solve for the largest ε_0 that it allows. For a central $(1, 10^{-6})$, ten thousand people can each randomize at $\varepsilon_0 = 3.504$. But at a thousand people, the condition above limits it to 1.460. These targets use a δ below the book's default (How small δ must be). At ten thousand people, the closed form gives an ε 2.6 to 4.6 times too large, so plan with it, but deploy with the paper's numerical bound.

Three things remove the amplification. A shuffler that colludes with the analyst leaves each report at ε_0. So choose an ε_0 that you can defend on its own, within the tiers of the definition. Fake senders give no cover, so count only honest ones in n. And timing and sizes can leak, so real shufflers batch and pad their traffic.

21.8. Distributed DP: splitting the noise

In the **distributed model**, each client adds a small share of the central noise, and **secure aggregation** shows only the sum to the server (Cryptography basics in the full edition). Gaussian noise splits cleanly, because the variances of independent shares add. If each of n clients adds normal noise of variance σ^2/n, the sum has noise with standard deviation σ. That is as private as the central Gaussian mechanism.

But the small shares are also the weakness. A client that colludes with the server can show its share, and a client that drops out adds none. With t such clients, only the noise of the honest clients is left, with standard deviation

$$\sigma \sqrt{\frac{n-t}{n}}. \tag{21.5}$$

So fix in advance the largest fraction ρ of clients that may collude or drop out, and have each client add variance $\sigma^2/(n(1-\rho))$. The honest clients alone then supply the full noise.

For example, a server sums a histogram of about a hundred thousand users through 100 clients, at $(1, 10^{-6})$. A user who changes value moves one count down and another up, so the ℓ_2 sensitivity is $\sqrt{2}$. The analytic Gaussian calibration of the Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms gives a total σ of 5.975. That is $5.975/\sqrt{100} = 0.597$ per client. Without over-provisioning, if a fifth of the clients collude, the guarantee weakens to $\varepsilon = 1.128$ at the same δ.

Secure aggregation works on integers, so clients add integer noise. This noise is Skellam or the distributed discrete Gaussian of Discrete mechanisms, as in TensorFlow Federated's `tff.aggregators.DistributedDpSumFactory`. Secure aggregation also does not check inputs, so a malicious client can still send any vector.

21.9. Cheat sheet

Table 21.1.: Which trust model and protocol to use, by situation.

Situation	Use	Rule
A curator can be trusted	Central Laplace or Gaussian	The default
Nobody may see raw records	Local randomized response	Frequent items, very large populations
Frequencies over k values	k-ary randomized response or unary encoding	k-ary if $k < 3e^{\varepsilon_0} + 2$
The same question daily	Memoization	Each new value costs ε_∞
An anonymizing relay	Shuffle model	Deploy with a numerical bound
Federated sums	Distributed Gaussian or Skellam	Over-provision for colluders

Rules of thumb

- Local noise exceeds central noise by a factor that grows like $\sqrt{n}$, 149 on Adult at $\ln 3$.

21.10. References

- Wang, Blocki, Li & Jha, "Locally Differentially Private Protocols for Frequency Estimation" (USENIX Security 2017): frequency oracles and local hashing, compared.
- Feldman, McMillan & Talwar, "Hiding Among the Clones" (FOCS 2021): the shuffling bounds, closed form and numerical.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

22. Lower bounds: what privacy costs

22.1. What it is

A **lower bound** says that no mechanism with differential privacy (DP) can be more accurate than some floor. It holds for all mechanisms at once, so you can use it as a feasibility check. Accuracy has two numbers here. The **error** α is how far the output may land from the true answer, and the **failure probability** β is the chance that it lands further away.

The floor you meet most is for a histogram over N bins under pure DP, with a privacy level ε and no slack. Suppose that such a histogram is within α records of every count with probability at least $1 - \beta$. Then

$$\alpha \geq \frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{\ln\left(N(1-\beta)\right)}{\varepsilon} - 1\right). \tag{22.1}$$

The floor grows only with the logarithm of the number of bins, but under pure DP it never stops. Under approximate DP, which allows a small slack δ, it stops at about $\ln(1/\delta)/\varepsilon$ records for all numbers of bins.

22.2. When you meet it

You meet a lower bound when a design looks too good. Take a request for a histogram over a million locations at $\varepsilon = 1$ with no slack, accurate to five records in every bin with 95% probability.

First ask if one person moves one statistic, as in the disjoint cells of a histogram, or all of them, as in the means of many attributes. The histogram floor applies to the first case, and the fingerprinting and reconstruction floors below to the second. Then the floor tells you whether to tune more. A target below it needs more data, a coarser answer or a weaker guarantee. A mechanism within a small factor of the floor is done, because no algorithm can gain more than that factor.

22.3. How to use it

For the million locations, all pure-DP histograms have an error of 6.38 records or more in some bin. So the five-record promise is impossible. The Laplace histogram of the Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms, with an error of 16.79, is about 2.6 times the floor and so already near the best. With $\delta = 10^{-6}$, the floor stays below about $\ln(10^6) = 13.82$ records. A stability-based histogram, which releases only non-empty bins, has an error that does not grow with N (Beyond global sensitivity). So when a large, mostly empty universe puts the floor too high, change to approximate DP.

The same floor gives the size of a dataset, because an error in records divided by the number of records n is an error in frequencies. A pure-DP histogram whose frequencies must all be within α needs

$$n \geq \frac{\ln\left(N(1-\beta)\right) - \varepsilon}{2\alpha\varepsilon}. \tag{22.2}$$

If the data are a sample from a population, sampling costs records too, about $\ln(2N/\beta)/(2\alpha^2)$ by Hoeffding's inequality in the full edition. You need the larger of the two. At $\varepsilon = 1$ and 95% probability, a million cells at an error of 0.01 need at least 638 records for privacy, but 87,522 for sampling. So at $\varepsilon = 1$, fine answers run short of records because of sampling, which no mechanism can fix.

When one person moves many statistics, the cost grows faster. Under pure DP, the means of d yes/no attributes cost records in proportion to d. Under approximate DP, the **fingerprinting** bound puts the cost at about $\sqrt{d\ln(1/\delta)}/(\alpha\varepsilon)$ records. The Gaussian mechanism is within a factor $\sqrt{\ln d}$ of it. So use approximate DP for outputs with many coordinates, such as a gradient. After you calibrate the Gaussian noise, search for more records, not a better mechanism. For about n counting queries on n records, the reconstruction attack of Dinur and Nissim puts the floor at an error of order $\sqrt{n}$ per answer (Reconstruction attacks).

22.4. What goes wrong

Aggregates are not a defence. The attack behind the fingerprinting bound (Homer et al. 2008) found whether a given person took part in a genome study, from its published frequencies of genetic variants. It scores how far the released means lean towards the target's record and away from the population means, attribute by attribute. Members score higher, because each member pulls the means toward their own record. On the means of 50 people over 2,000 attributes, it reaches a true positive rate (TPR) of 0.242 at a false positive rate (FPR) of 1%. A $(1, 10^{-5})$-DP Gaussian mechanism cuts that TPR to 0.014.

So use the score to audit a release of many averages, with population means from a separate sample. Compare its TPR at a low FPR with the cap $\text{TPR} \leq e^{\varepsilon}\,\text{FPR} + \delta$ from the definition. If an audit beats the cap, it has found a bug in the mechanism or its accounting. Passing proves nothing, because an attack only bounds ε from below (Auditing private training).

Each approximate-DP floor here assumes a small δ, such as the book's default (How small δ must be), or it means little. A mechanism that publishes each record with probability δ is $(0, \delta)$-DP, so a claim with δ near $1/n$ lets about one record out in full.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

23. Private mean estimation

23.1. Why this matters

Private machine learning computes the mean more often than any other statistic. Each step of private gradient descent averages clipped per-example gradients, and a survey share is a mean of 0/1 answers. Before you release a mean, you must know how many records it needs, and how to choose a clipping range without a look at the data.

Differential privacy (DP) must hold for every dataset, also for datasets that your assumptions exclude (The definition of differential privacy). So an assumption such as "the records are normal" can make a mechanism more accurate, but never enters the privacy argument. For this reason, every mechanism below clips each record to a range. The noise grows with the width of that range, and you must not read a narrow range off the data. So spend a small part of the budget to find where the data are, then clip there.

23.2. Bounded data: privacy adds a lower-order term

In this chapter, datasets have a fixed size n, and neighbours differ in one replaced record. The measure of an estimate is its **root-mean-square error** (RMSE), the typical distance from the estimate to the mean of the population.

Start with records in a known interval of width w, such as yes/no answers coded 0 and 1, and write σ^2 for the variance of a record. Release the average plus Laplace noise with scale $w/(n\varepsilon)$, which is ε-DP because one record moves the average by at most w/n (The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms). Laplace noise has variance twice its scale squared, and it is independent of the sampling error, so the two variances add:

$$\mathrm{RMSE} = \sqrt{\frac{\sigma^2}{n} + \frac{2w^2}{n^2\varepsilon^2}}. \tag{23.1}$$

To plan a study, set the RMSE equal to a target error α and solve for n, as the snippet in the Code section does. The number of records that you need is at most

$$\frac{\sigma^2}{\alpha^2} + \frac{\sqrt{2}\,w}{\alpha\varepsilon}. \tag{23.2}$$

So sampling alone needs about σ^2/α^2 records, and privacy adds at most about $w/(\alpha\varepsilon)$ more. Take a yes/no survey of a population that is half yes, the worst case for sampling. An RMSE of 0.05 then needs 100 people, and privacy at $\varepsilon = 1$ raises that to 108. The privacy term grows only like $1/\alpha$, against $1/\alpha^2$ for sampling, so it matters most at a coarse target and a small ε. It also grows with the width w, and the rest of the chapter makes the range narrower.

Libraries ask you for the range. In diffprivlib, `tools.mean(x, epsilon=..., bounds=(lower, upper))` clips to the bounds and adds noise. Without `bounds`, it takes the observed minimum and maximum, which leaks them, and raises a `PrivacyLeakWarning`.

Bounds that are too tight cause a different problem, because they clip real records. The script practitioner_adult_statistics.py releases the mean weekly hours of work of the 48,842 people in the Adult census data at $\varepsilon = 1$, with loose and with tight bounds.

```
hours = adult["hours-per-week"].to_numpy()
loose = tools.mean(hours, epsilon=1.0, bounds=(1, 99), random_state=seed)
tight = tools.mean(hours, epsilon=1.0, bounds=(20, 60), random_state=seed)
clipped = np.clip(hours, 20, 60).mean()  # what the tight bounds can at best recover
print(f"true mean hours: {hours.mean():.3f}")
print(f"bounds (1, 99): {loose:.3f}  bounds (20, 60): {tight:.3f}")
print(f"bias of (20, 60): {clipped - hours.mean():+.3f}")
```

Its seed-0 run, `uv run python code/part03-dp-foundations/practitioner_adult_statistics.py`, prints these lines. The last two come from code next to the excerpt.

```
true mean hours: 40.422
bounds (1, 99): 40.421  bounds (20, 60): 40.361
bias of (20, 60): -0.061
people outside (20, 60): 8.7%
noise scale (1, 99): 0.0020  (20, 60): 0.0008
```

The tight bounds decrease the noise scale from 0.0020 to 0.0008 hours. But they clip the 8.7% of people outside them, and this moves the mean by 0.061 hours, much more than the noise they save. No budget removes that bias, so report the error in three parts, which are sampling, clipping bias and noise. Choose the bounds from the schema or public data, and measure the share that they clip on data that you may look at.

The formulas also treat n as public, which is true only because neighbours replace a record. If the size is private, divide a noisy sum by a noisy count, and split the budget between the two.

23.3. The cost of an unknown range

Now let the records be normal with variance 1, with a mean that you know only to be within a distance R of zero. Write τ for a distance from the mean that holds all the records, except with a small failure probability β. For 1,000 records at $\beta = 0.05$, τ is 4.604.

The **naive estimator** clips every record to the widest range where the data can be, $R + \tau$ on each side of zero. It then adds Laplace noise for that width, so its error grows in proportion to R. With 1,000 records at $\varepsilon = 1$, its RMSE is 2828.44 when R is a million. But Lower bounds shows that an unknown range needs only about $\ln R/\varepsilon$ more records.

Coarse then fine (Karwa & Vadhan 2018) comes close to that floor in two steps. The coarse step cuts the range into bins of width 2τ. It then uses a part ε_1 of the budget to pick the fullest

bin with the exponential mechanism. The records it needs grow only with the logarithm of the number of bins. The data can be across two bins, so the fine step clips every record to the chosen bin and its two neighbours. It releases the average with Laplace noise for that window and the rest of the budget, so by composition the two steps are ε-DP.

With a quarter of the budget on the coarse step, the same 1,000 records give an RMSE of 0.0609 for every R from 10 to a million. But the fine step has only three quarters of the budget and a window three bins wide. So for small ranges the naive estimator is better, here up to $R = 13.81$. For larger ranges, use coarse then fine, or find the data with a private quantile such as diffprivlib's `tools.quantile`. Under approximate DP, with its slack δ, a stability-based histogram does the coarse step with about $\ln(1/\delta)/\varepsilon$ records, so R goes away (Beyond global sensitivity).

Two things go wrong. A budget split, bin width or β that you choose after a look at the data leaks it. And a coarse step with too few records can pick an empty bin and clip all records to the wrong place.

23.4. Many dimensions: clip the norm

Vectors in d dimensions, such as embeddings or gradients, use the same recipe with a different measure of size. Here the size is the ℓ_2 norm, or length. Clip each record to a radius C, so that one replaced record moves the average by at most $2C/n$. Then add Gaussian noise for that sensitivity (The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms). This is the step of private gradient descent, and private training tells how to choose its clipping norm.

The radius sets the cost. With unit variance per coordinate, records are about $\sqrt{d}$ from their mean, so the radius must grow like $\sqrt{d}$. The noise in all coordinates then grows like d in total, against $\sqrt{d}$ for the sampling error. So in high dimension privacy is the larger cost, and the fingerprinting lower bound shows that no mechanism avoids it.

If you do not know where the mean is, a grid of bins pays for the range once per dimension. The **shrinking balls** of CoinPress (Biswas, Dong, Kamath & Ullman 2020) need no grid. Each round clips to a ball around a noisy guess of the mean, then makes the ball smaller. Fix the number of rounds and their budget split before the run.

23.5. Heavy tails: clip into the data

Incomes, session lengths and per-example gradient norms have heavy tails. If you know only that the variance is at most σ^2, a range that clips no record is very wide. So clip into the data on purpose, and accept a bias.

Now let τ be a clipping half-width. A coarse step finds a centre near the mean, and you clip every record to within τ of it. Only the rare records beyond τ move, so with the centre at the mean the bias is at most σ^2/τ. But the noise grows in proportion to τ. The bound on the total error is smallest at

$$\tau_b = \sigma \sqrt{\frac{n\varepsilon}{2\sqrt{2}}}, \tag{23.3}$$

which uses only n, ε and the variance bound. At this width, an error α needs about $\sigma^2/\alpha^2 + 8\sqrt{2}\,\sigma^2/(\alpha^2\varepsilon)$ records. Both terms grow like $1/\alpha^2$, so privacy now costs as much as sampling.

Table 23.1 shows the trade-off on Pareto records, a heavy-tailed distribution scaled to variance 1. The first width clips a record only with probability 0.05, and noise is most of its error. The worst-case width τ_b decreases the error to 0.0607, and the best width for this distribution is better again.

Table 23.1.: Clipped private means of Pareto records with variance 1, 1,000 records, $\varepsilon = 1$, for three clipping half-widths.

Clipping half-width τ	Bias	Sampling sd	Noise sd	RMSE
141.42 (no record clipped)	0.0000	0.0313	0.4000	0.4012
18.80 (worst-case best, τ_b)	−0.0018	0.0293	0.0532	0.0607
5.36 (best for this distribution)	−0.0153	0.0249	0.0152	0.0329

So use τ_b as a safe default, not as the best width. A narrower range is usually better, but choose it from domain knowledge or with a private quantile, never from a look at the records (Beyond global sensitivity).

23.6. Code

The snippet computes the records that a bounded mean needs, checks its noise with OpenDP, and computes the default clipping width for heavy tails. The RMSE equal to α, times n^2, is a quadratic in n, and the first function rounds its positive root up.

```
from math import ceil, sqrt

import opendp.prelude as dp


def records_for_bounded_mean(alpha: float, sd: float, width: float, eps: float) -> int:
    """Smallest n with sd^2/n + 2 (width/(n eps))^2 <= alpha^2."""
    a, c = sd**2, 2 * (width / eps) ** 2
    return ceil((a + sqrt(a * a + 4 * c * alpha**2)) / (2 * alpha**2))


def heavy_tail_width(n: int, eps: float, sd: float) -> float:
    """The clipping half-width that balances the bias bound sd^2/tau against the noise."""
    return sd * sqrt(n * eps / (2 * sqrt(2)))
```

```
n = records_for_bounded_mean(0.05, 0.5, 1.0, 1.0)
print(n)  # 108
print(f"{dp.laplacian_scale_to_accuracy(1.0 / (n * 1.0), alpha=0.05):.4f}")  # 0.0277
print(f"{heavy_tail_width(1000, 1.0, 1.0):.2f}")  # 18.80
```

OpenDP gives accuracy as a half-width that holds the noise with a chosen probability. So `laplacian_scale_to_accuracy` changes the noise scale $w/(n\varepsilon)$ of a range of width w at the planned 108 records into the half-width at 95%.

23.7. Cheat sheet

Table 23.2.: Private mean estimation at a glance, with $\tau_b = \sigma\sqrt{n\varepsilon/(2\sqrt{2})}$.

What you know	Mechanism	Records for error α (up to log factors)
Bounded, width w, variance σ^2	Mean plus Lap$(w/(n\varepsilon))$	$\sigma^2/\alpha^2 + \sqrt{2}\,w/(\alpha\varepsilon)$
Normal, mean within R of zero	Coarse histogram, then clip to three bins	$1/\alpha^2 + 1/(\alpha\varepsilon) + \ln R/\varepsilon$
Same, approximate DP	Stability-based coarse step	$1/\alpha^2 + 1/(\alpha\varepsilon) + \ln(1/\delta)/\varepsilon$, no R
d dimensions, mean length at most R	Clip the norm, Gaussian noise; shrinking balls to find the mean	$d/\alpha^2 + d\sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)}/(\alpha\varepsilon) + \sqrt{d}\ln R/\varepsilon$
Variance at most σ^2 only	Clip to within τ_b of the centre	$\sigma^2/\alpha^2 + 8\sqrt{2}\,\sigma^2/(\alpha^2\varepsilon)$

Rules of thumb

- Never clip to the observed minimum and maximum. Take bounds from the schema or public data, or spend a quarter of the budget or less, a simple default, finding the data.
- Bounds that clip real records bias the mean whatever ε is, so put the clipping bias into every reported interval.

23.8. References

- Karwa & Vadhan, "Finite Sample Differentially Private Confidence Intervals" (ITCS 2018): coarse then fine for normal means and variances, under pure and approximate DP.
- Biswas, Dong, Kamath & Ullman, "CoinPress: Practical Private Mean and Covariance Estimation" (NeurIPS 2020): shrinking balls in practice, with code.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

24. Release statistics with a library

24.1. Why this matters

Suppose that you are the analytics engineer of an online shop. The business wants a dashboard of purchase lines, revenue and the typical sale, overall and per country, and of how many customers bought each product. The figures describe customers, so they need a differential privacy (DP) guarantee. But one customer has many rows, and a guarantee for one row protects a single purchase, not the person behind a hundred. This chapter does the job with OpenDP, from the unit to the written guarantee.

The data are the Online Retail set from the University of California, Irvine (UCI) Machine Learning Repository, with 541,909 invoice lines of a British online shop. Each line records one product on one invoice, with its quantity, unit price, customer and country. The script practitioner_release_statistics.py does every step in less than a minute, with OpenDP 0.16.0 and Polars 1.36.1.

```
uv run python code/part03-dp-foundations/practitioner_release_statistics.py
```

OpenDP takes its noise from a cryptographic generator that has no seed, so the released values change on every run. So this page quotes scales, error bars and thresholds, which contain no noise, and shows released values only in a block marked as one run.

24.2. Choose the library

The main question is whether a library can bound the contribution of a person with many rows (Table 24.1).

Table 24.1.: Libraries for releasing statistics, and what each can express.

Library	Runs on	Person with many rows	Groups not known in advance	Use it for
OpenDP	Polars, one machine	Yes, with an identifier column	Yes, by a noisy threshold	Statistics on one machine; the default here
diffprivlib	NumPy, scikit-learn	No, one row per person	No	Quick experiments and simple models

Library	Runs on	Person with many rows	Groups not known in advance	Use it for
PipelineDP	Apache Beam, Spark	Yes, built in	Yes, built in	Pipelines that already run on Beam or Spark
Tumult Analytics	Spark	Yes, with an identifier column	Yes, in a separate query	Large releases on Spark

We did not run PipelineDP and Tumult, so their rows come from their documentation. Whichever library you use, do not write a mechanism yourself. Keep one accountant, which adds up the budget, for the whole release.

24.3. Decide the unit and the budget

The **unit of privacy**, which the guarantee protects, is a customer. So two neighbouring datasets differ by one customer with all their lines, added or removed (The definition of differential privacy). The script removes returns, lines with a zero price and lines with no customer identifier, which belong to nobody. Each filter looks only at the line itself, so a customer who is added or removed still changes only their own lines.

```
raw = practitioner_datasets.online_retail()
lines, stats = clean(raw)
n_customers = stats.customers
delta = delta_for(n_customers)  # 1/n^1.1, rounded down to a power of ten
per_line = per_customer(lines)
print(f"customers: {n_customers:,}  purchase lines: {lines.height:,}")
print(f"delta: {delta:.0e}")
p50, p90, p99, top = quantiles(per_line, [0.5, 0.9, 0.99, 1.0])
print(f"lines per customer: p50={p50} p90={p90} p99={p99} max={top}")
```

```
customers: 4,372  purchase lines: 397,884
delta: 1e-05
lines per customer: p50=41 p90=208 p99=662 max=7847
```

The slack δ follows the book's default for n people (How small δ must be), which gives 10^{-5}. OpenDP warns that δ must be at most 10^{-6}, but this book ties δ to the number of people. The privacy level is $\varepsilon = 1$ for the whole release, because all its tables describe the same customers and their costs add up (Post-processing, group privacy and composition).

With a guarantee per line, the largest customer is a group of 7,847 records, and group privacy multiplies ε by the size of the group. You can print that maximum only because this set is public.

24.4. Bound each customer's contribution

Write k for the largest number of lines that a customer may give, so that every query keeps at most k lines of each customer. A small k means little noise but removes data, and a large k keeps the data but needs more noise. The script measures this trade-off on the public set.

```
k=10: lines kept 10.2%  customers truncated 84.8%
k=25: lines kept 22.4%  customers truncated 64.6%
k=50: lines kept 36.9%  customers truncated 44.0%
k=100: lines kept 55.1%  customers truncated 24.9%
k=200: lines kept 72.7%  customers truncated 10.4%
k=500: lines kept 88.2%  customers truncated 1.8%
```

The default k is a high percentile of lines per customer in public or historical data, never in the data that you release. If you have neither, spend a small share of the budget on a private high quantile, over candidates fixed in advance (Selection). This chapter takes $k = 100$, which is less than the 90th percentile of 208 because the noise grows with k. It keeps 55.1% of the lines and truncates a quarter of the customers.

The first k lines by date bias every statistic towards early purchases, so the script keeps a random sample of k lines per customer. The filter below does what OpenDP's `truncate_per_group(k, keep="sample")` does, but with a seed, so that the true values of the check stay fixed.

```
def sample_per_customer(k: int, seed: int, *by: str) -> pl.Expr:
    """True for at most k randomly chosen lines of each customer (within each value of `by`)."""
    return pl.int_range(pl.len()).shuffle(seed=seed).over("CustomerID", *by) < k
```

Values need bounds too. The value of a line is its quantity times its unit price, and the script clips it to between £0 and £200. The lower end is true because the script removed the returns. The upper end is a bound that the business sets, and it clips 1.02% of the lines. So one customer can move the revenue by at most 100 lines of £200 each. Take value bounds from the domain, never from the minimum or maximum of the data (Beyond global sensitivity).

A group-by can use two more bounds. The bound L_0 is the number of groups that one customer may touch. The bound L_∞ is the number of lines that a customer may put in one group. Countries need neither, because the k lines of a customer change the country counts by at most k in total, and the noise already covers that. Products need both bounds for partition selection (Section 24.8).

24.5. Set up the context

OpenDP keeps the whole release in a **context**, which holds the data, the unit, the total budget and its split between queries. Contexts need `dp.enable_features("contrib")`, which turns on components that are not formally vetted. So a reviewer who needs vetted code must examine each call in the documentation of OpenDP.

```
context = dp.Context.compositor(
    data=lines.lazy(),
    privacy_unit=dp.unit_of(contributions=1, identifier="CustomerID"),
    privacy_loss=dp.loss_of(rho=rho, delta=delta / 2),  # Gaussian noise; delta/2 for thresh
    split_by_weights=WEIGHTS,  # scalars, countries, products
    margins=[dp.polars.Margin(by=[], max_length=MAX_LINES)],
)
```

The identifier column makes the unit a customer. So `contributions=1` means one customer with all their lines, added or removed, and the truncation filters bound those lines. For replace, OpenDP takes `changes=` instead. The budget is in **zero-concentrated differential privacy (zCDP)** (Concentrated differential privacy), which gives privacy as one number, written ρ. Values of ρ add up across queries and change to (ε, δ) at the end.

With a zCDP budget, the context adds Gaussian noise to every count and sum. That suits the product counts, where one customer touches many groups (The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms). The script's `rho_for` finds $\rho = 0.0284$, the largest value that the conversion of OpenDP turns into $\varepsilon \leq 1$ with half of δ. The other half pays for the threshold of Section 24.8. The margin gives a public upper bound on the number of lines, which OpenDP needs before it adds floating-point values.

The weights give a quarter of the budget to the overall statistics, a quarter to the countries and half to the products, which need it most. The script prints the split and converts the whole release back to the (ε, δ) of the statement.

```
budget scalars: rho=0.0071 delta=1.25e-06
budget countries: rho=0.0071 delta=1.25e-06
budget products: rho=0.0142 delta=2.50e-06
whole release as (epsilon, delta): (1.0000, 1e-05)
```

A query takes its share of the budget when you build it, but spends the share only when you release it. Each new query gets the next unspent share. So if you build all the queries first, each one gets the first share. The product query then gets the noise of a quarter but costs half. Build, check and release each query in turn, as the script does.

24.6. Release overall statistics with error bars

The first query releases the count of lines, the revenue and the median line value. The context holds the raw lines, so each query truncates them itself.

```
value = clipped_value()  # the line value, clipped to [low, high]
scalars = (
    context.query()
    .filter(sample_per_customer(K, seed))  # at most K lines per customer
    .select(
        dp.len(signed=True),
```

```
        value.dp.sum((low, high)).alias("revenue"),
        value.dp.median(candidates=MEDIAN_CANDIDATES).alias("median"),
    )
)
scalar_summary = scalars.summarize(alpha=0.05)
scalars_hat = scalars.release().collect()
```

`signed=True` keeps negative noisy counts, and `summarize` reports, before anything is released, each statistic's noise and 95% error bar.

```
scalars len: Frame Length, Integer Gaussian, scale=1,453.38 95% accuracy=2,850.0
scalars revenue: Sum, Float Gaussian, scale=290,804.33 95% accuracy=569,966.0
scalars median: 0.5-Quantile, GumbelMin, scale=1,453.38 95% accuracy=none
```

With probability 0.95, the released count of lines is within 2,850 of the truth, and the revenue within £569,966. These bars depend only on the bounds and the budget, so you can read them before the release and decide if the budget is sufficient.

The output also shows how OpenDP splits the share of a query among its statistics. Each statistic gets the same noise scale relative to its sensitivity. So the count and the median both get 1,453.38, and the revenue, with 200 times the sensitivity of the count, gets about 200 times that. To give one statistic more budget, put it in a query of its own with its own weight. The exponential mechanism, sampled by `GumbelMin`, chooses the median among candidates in steps of £0.50. So its error bar is in ranks, and `summarize` gives none (Selection).

The error bars cover only the noise, not the bias of truncation and clipping, which together keep only 48.5% of the revenue. So the private revenue estimates a truncated total, not the takings of the shop. Say so in the release. If the full total is more important than the noise, choose a larger k.

24.7. Group by a public key list

The next query gives lines and revenue per country, and its key list must not come from the data. The distinct values of the Country column tell which countries are in the private data, and no noise covers that. So the script fixes its keys in advance. The 38 keys are the United Kingdom, the 27 EU member states and the 4 states of the European Free Trade Association. Then come the United States, Canada, Australia, Japan, China and "Other". A rule renames three spellings, such as `EIRE` to Ireland, and maps every other value to Other.

```
by_country = (
    context.query()
    .filter(sample_per_customer(K, seed))
    .group_by("Market")
    .agg(dp.len(signed=True), value.dp.sum((low, high)).alias("revenue"))
    .with_keys(pl.LazyFrame({"Market": MARKETS}))  # every key is released, zeros included
)
```

```
country_summary = by_country.summarize(alpha=0.05)
countries_hat = by_country.release().collect()
```

```
per country len: Frame Length, Integer Gaussian, scale=1,185.25 95% accuracy=2,324.0
per country revenue: Sum, Float Gaussian, scale=237,698.48 95% accuracy=465,880.5
```

The query releases every key, also the 11 with no purchase lines, whose counts are only noise. So the release tells nothing about which markets have customers. The count of each market has a 95% error bar of 2,324, and its revenue one of about £466,000. The true count of 5,379 for Germany is still useful, but its revenue of £131,902 is less than its error bar. So publish the error bar with every cell, or merge small markets into Other before the release.

24.8. Group by unknown keys with partition selection

The list of products is not public. If one customer buys a product, its row in the table shows that purchase. So the release uses **partition selection** to choose privately which products to show. It releases only the products whose noisy count is above a threshold, so a product with few customers almost never appears. The threshold is what costs δ (Beyond global sensitivity).

To count customers, not lines, the query first keeps one line per customer and product. So L_∞, the lines per customer in one group, is 1. It then keeps at most a number m of products per customer, so L_0, the groups per customer, is m. The script measures the trade-off that m sets on this public set.

```
m=1: pairs kept 1.6%  customers truncated 97.9%  scale=5.93  threshold=29  products above it
m=5: pairs kept 7.9%  customers truncated 92.4%  scale=13.27  threshold=66  products above i
m=10: pairs kept 15.1%  customers truncated 83.6%  scale=18.77  threshold=96  products above
m=20: pairs kept 27.5%  customers truncated 68.3%  scale=26.54  threshold=138  products abov
m=50: pairs kept 52.7%  customers truncated 38.6%  scale=41.96  threshold=225  products abov
```

The threshold grows with m, from 29 to 225, because each customer can push more groups over it. But the counts grow faster, so the number of products whose true count is above the threshold goes from 1 to 50. The script takes $m = 50$ (`M` in the code), again chosen on public data.

```
by_product = (
    context.query()
    .filter(sample_per_customer(1, seed, "StockCode"))  # one line per customer and product
    .filter(sample_per_customer(M, seed))  # at most M products per customer
    .group_by("StockCode")
    .agg(dp.len(signed=True).alias("customers"))
)
product_summary = by_product.summarize(alpha=0.05)
products_hat = by_product.release().collect()
```

```
per product customers: Frame Length, Integer Gaussian, scale=41.96 95% accuracy=83.0 thresho
```

The release shows a product only if its noisy count is 225 or more, and a released count has a 95% error bar of 83. Never publish how many products were left out, or which, because both come from the private data. A product just below the threshold gets in when its noise is positive. So treat a count near 225 as a sign of popularity, not as a measurement.

In OpenDP 0.16.0, `truncate_num_groups` should bound the groups per customer, but it does not work. With the default `keep="sample"`, `summarize` accepts the query, but `release` fails after it spends the share of the query. So run each query end to end on public data first. With `keep="first"`, it keeps one group fewer than asked, and this biases the counts. The filters above avoid both problems only because $L_\infty = 1$ makes groups into lines. For $L_\infty > 1$, this book knows of no unbiased group bound in this version.

24.9. Check the release before publishing

To make sure that the code does what the plan says, the script compares the private values with the true values after the same truncation and clipping.

```
true lines after truncation: 219,291 (all purchase lines: 397,884)
true revenue after truncation and clipping: 4,318,947 (all lines, unclipped: 8,911,408)
true median line value after truncation: 15.00 (all lines: 11.80)
```

The release is random, and one run printed the following.

```
released (one run):
  lines 218,972  revenue 4,397,410  median 14.50
  United Kingdom: lines 196,311  revenue 3,927,959
  Germany: lines 7,151  revenue 643,094
  Spain: lines -546  revenue -37,048
  country line counts within their 95% accuracy: 34 of 38
  products released: 63
```

Compare it with the error bars, which must hold about 95% of the market counts. Negative values are noise on small markets, and you can round them up to zero, because post-processing costs no budget. Expect more than the 50 products whose true count is above the threshold, for the reason above. Compare the private median with the truncated £15.00, not with the £11.80 of all lines.

The check fails if a value is far outside its error bar, which shows a wrong sensitivity. It also fails if far more or far fewer than 95% of the cells are inside. And it fails if the true count of a released product is far below the threshold. In production you cannot compare with the truth, because a decision to publish that uses the true values is a release of them. So run this check on historical or public data during development. Then release the real data once, with the code that you checked.

24.10. Write the guarantee down

The script prints the claim from the variables that set the bounds and the budget, so the claim always agrees with the code.

```
This release satisfies (epsilon = 1, delta = 1e-05)-differential privacy for adding or
removing one customer and all their invoice lines, with at most 100 lines per customer
(sampled at random), at most 50 random products per customer in the product counts, and
line values clipped to [0, 200] pounds, under the central model, using OpenDP 0.16.0 with
Gaussian noise (accounted as 0.0284-zCDP plus 5e-06 for thresholds, converted to epsilon
and delta). The market list was fixed in advance; the product list is not public.
```

The statement names all that a reviewer needs to compute the claim again (Writing the guarantee down). Next to it, say what it does not cover. Another release about the same customers adds its own budget to the claim. If that release is pure ε-DP, you can add the two (ε, δ) pairs. Or you can add its $\rho = \varepsilon^2/2$ to this release's ρ and then convert. Use the smaller total (Concentrated differential privacy). Also, the dashboard must say that the figures describe truncated data. Release and governance maps such a claim to data-protection law.

24.11. Checklist

Table 24.2.: The release checklist: each step, its default and its check.

Step	Default	Check
Unit and budget	One person, add/remove; one ε; $\delta \leq 1/n^{1.1}$	n counts people, not rows
Contribution bound	k from a high percentile of public or historical data; random sample	No bound read from the release data
Value bounds	From the domain or the business	Share clipped and bias stated
Context	zCDP with Gaussian noise; weights by need	ρ converted to (ε, δ) equals the claim
Queries	Build, summarize and release one at a time	Scales match the plan; each query run end to end on public data
Public keys	Fixed in advance, values mapped by a rule; every key released	No key list built from the data
Unknown keys	Partition selection with L_0 and L_∞	Number dropped never published
Check	On historical or public data	About 95% inside their error bars

Step	Default	Check
Statement	Printed by the releasing code	Unit, bounds, version and public information named

24.12. References

- The OpenDP documentation, “Polars” and “Grouping” in its user guide: contexts, margins and partition selection.
- Wilson et al., “Differentially Private SQL with Bounded User Contribution” (PETS 2020): contribution bounding in a production SQL engine.
- Desfontaines, Voss, Gipson & Mandayam, “Differentially private partition selection” (PETS 2022): the threshold and why it needs δ.

Derivations. This workflow has no counterpart in the full edition. The results it uses are derived in the full edition’s chapters on the definition in the full edition, its properties in the full edition, the Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms in the full edition, selection in the full edition and sensitivity in the full edition.

Part IV.

Privacy accounting

A model trained with stochastic gradient descent (SGD) under differential privacy (DP), the method called DP-SGD, takes thousands of noisy steps. Yet you report one guarantee for the run, a privacy level ε with a small slack δ. The composition theorems of Part 3 are far too loose for that. An **accountant** does better, because it keeps a summary of the cost of each step that composes tightly. It converts the total to (ε, δ) once, at the end.

The running example is a DP-SGD run of 10,000 steps. Each step samples every record with probability 0.01 and adds noise with multiplier 1. At $\delta = 10^{-5}$, advanced composition certifies $\varepsilon = 24{,}379.55$, while the privacy loss distribution accountant of Google's `dp_accounting` certifies 6.19. So an ε means nothing until you name its accountant, with the sampler and the neighbouring relation that the accountant assumed.

The part starts with two jobs. Choosing an accountant says which accountant fits a mechanism and how to check that it matches the code. Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run turns a target ε into a noise multiplier for the Adult run of Part 5.

Two full chapters explain what those jobs rely on. Amplification by subsampling shows how much a random batch helps, if the data loader samples as the accountant assumes. Rényi differential privacy defines the curve most libraries track.

Short reference pages follow. Three finish the DP-SGD story: the conversion from Rényi DP, numerical accounting, and Gaussian DP, which reads a guarantee as a limit on attacks. Then come adaptive composition for budgets decided during training, concentrated DP for analytics ledgers, and shuffling and iteration.

Every number comes from code you can run with Opacus or `dp_accounting`. By the end, you will be able to calibrate a DP-SGD run, account for it with two libraries, and report ε so that others can reproduce it.

25. Choosing an accountant

25.1. Why this matters

You report a model trained with differential privacy (DP) with a privacy level ε and a small slack δ. The code that computes ε is an **accountant**, and the same run can get 6.24 from one accountant and 24,379.55 from another. Table 25.1 runs three accountants on one run of private stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD. They are advanced composition, Rényi differential privacy (RDP) and the privacy loss distribution (PLD). Each record joins each batch with probability $q = 0.01$, the sampling rate. The noise multiplier σ, the noise as a multiple of the clipping norm, is 1.

Table 25.1.: One DP-SGD run, $q = 0.01$ and $\sigma = 1$, under three accountants: ε at $\delta = 10^{-5}$. The PLD columns round the privacy loss up and down to a grid of width 10^{-5}, so they bracket the true value.

Steps	Advanced composition	RDP, improved	PLD upper	PLD lower
1,000	1258.64	2.1014	1.8332	1.8232
10,000	24379.55	6.7127	6.2377	6.1377

The true ε lies between the two PLD columns, because the lower PLD column is a lower bound. Advanced composition, which adds up the guarantees of the steps, is useless here. RDP is much closer, but it still overstates ε, by 14.6% on the shorter run and by 7.6% on the longer one. This gives the rule of the chapter. **Report the tightest upper bound whose assumptions hold for the code you ran, and give enough detail that someone else can recompute it.**

25.2. Which accountant

An accountant is tight only when its summary of each step fits the mechanism. So let the mechanism choose the accountant (Table 25.2).

Table 25.2.: Which accountant to report for which mechanism.

Mechanism	Report with	Avoid
Gaussian noise, no subsampling	Gaussian differential privacy (GDP), converted exactly (f-DP and Gaussian DP)	Per-step composition

Mechanism	Report with	Avoid
DP-SGD with Poisson sampling	PLD, or the privacy loss random variable (PRV) accountant (Numerical accounting), with the PLD's lower value as the error bar (its code)	Zero-concentrated DP (zCDP); the GDP central limit theorem (CLT)
Pure-DP steps (Laplace, randomized response)	PLD, exact when the privacy loss takes few values; Laplace with scale b is `LaplaceDpEvent(b/Δ)`, Δ its ℓ_1 sensitivity	Advanced composition
Many statistical releases	A zCDP ledger (Concentrated DP) or PLD	Adding up each release's ε
Noise or budget chosen during the run	A Rényi filter (Adaptive composition)	Plugging realized values into a fixed theorem
Correlated noise across steps: matrix factorization, or the follow the regularized leader (FTRL) optimizer on tree sums, DP-FTRL	The mechanism's own accountant (Matrix mechanisms)	The Poisson DP-SGD accountant
A shuffler of locally randomized reports, or only the last model released	Shuffling and iteration, with its conditions; a loader that shuffles is a sampler (Table 25.3)	The Poisson accountant for a shuffler; a last-model claim for non-convex training

The GDP CLT is an approximation, not a bound. After 1,000 steps it gives 1.6177, which is below the certified lower value of the PLD, 1.8232. So it claims a guarantee that the run does not have. Opacus's `"gdp"` accountant is this CLT, so do not report it. The default PRV accountant of Opacus is safe.

25.3. The inverse problem: noise for a target ε

Usually you fix the target ε, the batch size and the number of epochs, and you ask for the smallest σ that meets them. A looser accountant overstates ε, so it asks for more noise. For a target of 3 on the 10,000-step run, RDP needs a noise multiplier of 1.662 and the PLD only 1.584. So calibrate with the accountant that you will report. Opacus's `get_noise_multiplier` uses `"rdp"` by default, so give it `accountant="prv"` (Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run).

25.4. Choosing δ

Choose δ by the rule of this book, which for n people is at most $1/n^{1.1}$, rounded down to a power of ten (How small δ must be). Count n in the unit that the claim protects, which at the user level means users, not records. For example, run the 10,000 steps of Table 25.1 on 50,000 records. At $q = 0.01$, that is 100 epochs. For 50,000 records the rule gives 10^{-6}, so the 10^{-5} of the table fails it. The US National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) recommends the stricter $1/n^2$, so report ε there too.

Publish the upper value of the accountant that you name, rounded up, because the accountant does not certify a lower value. Write the statement shows the full privacy statement that carries these numbers.

25.5. Matching the accountant to the code

The number of an accountant holds only if the code does what its theorem assumes. Many papers reported the number for Poisson sampling but trained with shuffled batches of fixed size, a different algorithm (Ponomareva et al. 2023). So check the code against Table 25.3 before you report.

Table 25.3.: A checklist for matching the accountant to the training code.

Item	The accountant assumes	Check in the code	If it does not match
Sampler	Poisson sampling at rate q	Do batch sizes vary from step to step?	The sampler's row of Subsampling: fixed-size batches at $\sigma/2$; shuffle and partition unamplified, for zero-out neighbours
Neighbours	Add or remove one record	Which relation does the claim state?	Replace-one costs more per step; for Poisson sampling, compose the same steps in `PLDAccountant(NeighboringRelati`
Unit	One record	Can one person give several records?	Clip and sample per user, or pay for the group (User-level DP)

Item	The accountant assumes	Check in the code	If it does not match
Tuning, adaptivity and steps	Settings and steps fixed in advance	Tuning on private data, early stopping, restarts?	Account for the tuning runs (Hyperparameter tuning); report the planned maximum; keep the accountant's state across restarts
Other data	Only the training rows are private	Pretraining, fitted preprocessing, validation rows?	Name them; preprocessing fitted on private rows needs its own budget

The sampler has the largest effect. Under Poisson sampling, the PLD of `dp_accounting` gives 6.19 at $\delta = 10^{-5}$, but batches of fixed size raise this to 43.37. Shuffle and partition raise it to 91.82, and that number holds only for zero-out neighbours (Subsampling).

A review of someone else's claim also uses this checklist, in the order that Review someone else's claim gives.

25.6. Checking an accountant

An accountant is code, so test it on known answers. With sampling rate $q = 1$, each step is a plain Gaussian mechanism, and the composition of such steps is exact (f-DP and Gaussian DP). Ten such steps at noise multiplier 1 are exactly $(17.8566, 10^{-5})$-DP. So an upper bound must be above 17.8566, and a PLD bracket must contain it. Also, ε must not decrease when you add steps, and it must not increase when you add noise.

Then compare two maintained libraries at pinned versions. This snippet recomputes Table 25.1 with Google's `dp_accounting`.

```
import dp_accounting
from dp_accounting.pld import PLDAccountant
from dp_accounting.rdp import RdpAccountant

step = dp_accounting.PoissonSampledDpEvent(0.01, dp_accounting.GaussianDpEvent(1.0))
run = dp_accounting.SelfComposedDpEvent(step, 10_000)  # q = 0.01, sigma = 1, 10,000 steps
pld = PLDAccountant(value_discretization_interval=1e-4).compose(run)
rdp = RdpAccountant(orders=list(range(2, 65))).compose(run)  # integer orders only
print(f"{pld.get_epsilon(1e-5):.4f} {rdp.get_epsilon(1e-5):.4f}")  # 6.1877 6.7194
print(f"{pld.get_epsilon(1e-6):.4f} {rdp.get_epsilon(1e-6):.4f}")  # 6.9074 7.4869
```

Each PLD value is inside the bracket of the table. Each RDP value is just above the value in the table, because the table also tries fractional orders. When libraries disagree, look for three causes. If two RDP values differ by an amount that depends only on the order, such as 0.3612 at order

10, the libraries use different conversions (RDP conversions). If two PLD brackets do not overlap, one library has a bug. A factor of two often comes from different neighbouring relations.

25.7. Cheat sheet

Table 25.4.: Choosing and checking an accountant.

Question	Default	Check
Accountant for DP-SGD	PLD or PRV, upper value	RDP lies above it; never report the CLT
δ	The rule of How small δ must be, n counted in the claim's unit	Also report ε at $1/n^2$
Fixed-size batches	Poisson accountant at $\sigma/2$ (add/remove); replace-one: see Subsampling	Poisson batch sizes vary from step to step
Shuffle and partition	One Gaussian step per epoch, zero-out neighbours	Better, switch to Opacus's Poisson loader

25.8. References

- Ponomareva et al., "How to DP-fy ML: A Practical Guide to Machine Learning with Differential Privacy" (JAIR 2023): matching the accounting to the pipeline, and what to report.
- Near, Darais, Lefkovitz & Howarth, "Guidelines for Evaluating Differential Privacy Guarantees" (NIST SP 800-226, 2025): what an evaluator will ask of your claim.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

26. Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run

26.1. Why this matters

An **accountant** turns the settings of a training run into its privacy level ε under differential privacy (DP). Before the run, it finds the noise for your target, and after it, the ε the run spent. Both jobs can fail without a sign. The noise may come from one accountant and the report from another. The loader may not sample as the accountant assumes, or a restart may reset the step count. Each makes the claim false, and none changes the loss curve.

This chapter does the accounting for a run of stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with DP, called DP-SGD, on the Adult census data from the UCI Machine Learning Repository. It trains nothing. The run uses 30,000 people in batches of 1,000 for ten epochs, with a target of $\varepsilon = 4$. Train a model with DP-SGD trains it.

The script practitioner_calibrate.py runs the seven steps below in one to two minutes, with Opacus 1.6.0 and `dp-accounting` 0.6.0. Its defaults give the run of Part 5. Options such as `--n`, `--batch`, `--epochs` and `--epsilon` set your own, as the second command does for MNIST.

```
uv run python code/part04-privacy-accounting/practitioner_calibrate.py
uv run python code/part04-privacy-accounting/practitioner_calibrate.py --n 60000 --batch 256
```

26.2. Fix the privacy unit, n and δ

The guarantee protects exactly one record, so first decide what a record is. In Adult, each row is one person. If one person could own many rows, n, the number of records, would have to count people, as in User-level differential privacy.

The slack δ is roughly the chance that the guarantee fails. Set it by the rule of this book, at most $1/n^{1.1}$ rounded down to a power of ten (How small δ must be).

```
def delta_for(n: int) -> float:
    """The book's default delta: at most 1/n^1.1, rounded down to a power of ten."""
    return 10.0 ** math.floor(math.log10(n**-1.1))
```

```
Adult rows: 48,842; Part 5's training split: n=30,000
delta_for(30,000) = 1e-05
delta_for(60,000) = 1e-06
delta_for(569) = 1e-04
```

Here n counts the people of the training split, not all the rows of Adult. So δ is 10^{-5}. Set the validation rows aside first, because the run neither trains on them nor protects them. The other two lines show that each dataset needs its own δ.

26.3. Choose the sampler

The accountants here assume **Poisson sampling**, in which each record joins each batch independently with probability q, the sampling rate. So the batches vary in size. Other samplers cost far more privacy (Section 26.6). With an expected batch size B, the rate is $q = B/n$. A run of E epochs then takes E/q steps, rounded down, which the output calls T.

```
Poisson: B=1000, E=10: q=0.033333, T=300
Opacus DPDataLoader.from_data_loader: q=1/30=0.033333, 30 steps an epoch, 300 in 10 epochs
chosen run uses the loader's q and steps; get_noise_multiplier at that q counts int(E/q)=300
```

The second line is what training will run, because Opacus replaces your loader with a Poisson `DPDataLoader`. The rate of that loader is one over the number of batches of your loader, $\lceil n/B \rceil$, and it takes that many steps per epoch. Here B divides n, so the two lines agree. When it does not, training runs the numbers of the loader, so the script takes q and T from it. The third line checks that the calibration of Opacus counts the same steps.

This step goes wrong if the training code builds its own loader with `shuffle=True` and a fixed `batch_size`. Then all batches in the logs have the same size (Amplification by subsampling).

26.4. Plan the noise

Next, choose the batch size, the number of epochs and the noise multiplier σ. Training clips the gradient of each record to length at most C, the clipping norm, and σ is the standard deviation of the noise as a multiple of C. For a given target and sampler, an accountant finds the smallest σ that meets them, so calibrate with the accountant that you will report (The inverse problem). The script searches with two tight accountants that check each other (Numerical accounting). They are the privacy loss random variable (PRV) accountant of Opacus, to within 0.01 in ε, and the privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant of `dp_accounting`, to within 0.01 in σ.

```
def sigma_opacus(epsilon: float, delta: float, q: float, epochs: int) -> float:
    """Opacus: the sigma whose PRV epsilon after `epochs` is at most the target (to 0.01 in
    return get_noise_multiplier(
        target_epsilon=epsilon, target_delta=delta, sample_rate=q, epochs=epochs, accountant
    )


def sigma_dp_accounting(epsilon: float, delta: float, q: float, steps: int) -> float:
    """dp_accounting: the same search with a PLD accountant (to 0.01 in sigma)."""

    def training_run(sigma: float) -> DpEvent:
```

```
        return SelfComposedDpEvent(PoissonSampledDpEvent(q, GaussianDpEvent(sigma)), steps)

    def accountant() -> PLDAccountant:
        return PLDAccountant(value_discretization_interval=PLD_GRID)

    return calibrate_dp_mechanism(accountant, training_run, epsilon, delta, LowerEndpointAnd
```

Give `accountant="prv"` explicitly, because `get_noise_multiplier` otherwise uses the looser Rényi differential privacy (RDP) accountant, which asks for more noise. If `dp_accounting` raises an error, lower the 0.3 of `LowerEndpointAndGuess(0.3, 1.0)`, the lower end where its search starts.

The table uses a PLD grid of 10^{-3}, the step to which the accountant rounds the privacy loss, so each search takes about a second. The average over a batch of B records divides the noise on the sum by B. So the last column, σ/B times 1,000, is the noise on the average gradient per unit of clipping norm.

```
dataset             n  delta     B   E  eps      T  sigma PRV  sigma PLD  sigma/B x1000
Adult           30000  1e-05   100  10    4   3000       0.62       0.62           6.16
Adult           30000  1e-05   300  10    4   1000       0.74       0.74           2.45
Adult           30000  1e-05  1000  10    4    300       0.97       0.98           0.97
Adult           30000  1e-05  1000  10    8    300       0.72       0.73           0.72
Adult           30000  1e-05  1000  20    4    600       1.16       1.16           1.16
```

The block shows 5 of the 18 Adult cells of the script. At $\varepsilon = 4$ and ten epochs, a batch of 1,000 needs more noise than a batch of 100, 0.97 instead of 0.62. But the average divides that noise among ten times as many records, so the noise on the average falls from 6.16 to 0.97. Twenty epochs instead of ten raise σ to 1.16.

The table alone cannot choose the batch, because a larger batch lowers the noise on the average but also the number of steps. So find the steps that your model needs from a non-private run or from public data. Then take the largest batch that gives those steps and fits in memory, 1,000 for Part 5 (Batch size at a fixed budget).

A row from the end of the table shows that small datasets are different.

```
breast cancer     569  1e-04    64  20    1    177       4.96       4.91          77.51
largest gap between PRV and PLD sigma: 1.6% (Adult, B=300, E=10, eps=8)
```

With 569 records, a batch of 64 is more than a tenth of the data, so sampling amplifies little. The noise on the average is 77.51 at $\varepsilon = 1$. So a small dataset needs a large ε, public pretraining or another method.

The last line of the block checks the two libraries against each other. Across all 24 cells, their values of σ differ by at most 1.6%. A gap above about 3% means that the two calls got different inputs, such as a rate for a batch size, epochs for steps, or another slack δ.

26.5. Check ε with a second accountant

Train with the calibrated σ unrounded, as Part 5 does with the 0.9729 of Opacus. If you round it, round up to the three decimals that the statement prints, because less noise gives a larger ε. Before you train, compute the ε of the planned run with every accountant at hand.

```
def crosscheck_epsilon(sigma: float, q: float, steps: int, delta: float) -> dict[str, float]
    """Epsilon of one planned run by five accountants (GDP is the trap: it is not an upper b
    epsilons: dict[str, float] = {}
    for name, opacus_accountant in [("Opacus RDP", RDPAccountant()), ("Opacus PRV", PRVAccou
        opacus_accountant.history = [(sigma, q, steps)]  # what `steps` calls of .step() wou
        epsilons[name] = opacus_accountant.get_epsilon(delta)
    run = SelfComposedDpEvent(PoissonSampledDpEvent(q, GaussianDpEvent(sigma)), steps)
    epsilons["dp_accounting RDP"] = RdpAccountant().compose(run).get_epsilon(delta)
    epsilons["dp_accounting PLD"] = PLDAccountant().compose(run).get_epsilon(delta)
    gdp = GaussianAccountant()
    gdp.history = [(sigma, q, steps)]
    epsilons["Opacus GDP"] = gdp.get_epsilon(delta)
    return epsilons
```

```
chosen cell: Adult, B=1000, E=10, eps=4: sigma=0.972900 (Opacus PRV, as Part 5)
Opacus RDP          eps=4.50
Opacus PRV          eps=3.99
dp_accounting RDP   eps=4.50
dp_accounting PLD   eps=3.98
Opacus GDP          eps=3.34
PLD <= target: True; RDP >= PLD: True; |PRV - PLD|/PLD < 3%: True
crosscheck: pass
PLD bracket (grid 1e-4): lower 3.9656 (optimistic), upper 3.9806 (pessimistic); width 0.0150
```

The two tight accountants, PRV and the PLD, agree at 3.99 and 3.98, and both meet the target. The two RDP accountants agree at 4.50, above the target, as a looser bound should be. The trap is the Gaussian differential privacy (GDP) value of 3.34. It comes from a central limit theorem (CLT), which approximates the run but does not bound it, and it is below the certified values. So do not report it.

The pass line makes three checks. The PLD value must be at most the target, which fails if σ was rounded down or the steps differ from the plan. RDP must be at or above the PLD, up to the grid error, and PRV must agree with the PLD within 3%. If one of these two fails, the accountants got different runs.

The last line is the error bar of the PLD. Rounding the privacy loss of each step up to the grid gives the reported 3.9806, and rounding it down gives an optimistic 3.9656. So the true ε is between the two. Claim the upper value, with the lower value as its error bar (Which accountant). The bracket gets wider with more steps, so a long run needs a finer grid.

26.6. If the loader is not Poisson

Not every training loop uses Poisson sampling, with its batches of random size, so find the cost of the others before you train. The script accounts the chosen run under the four samplers of Amplification by subsampling.

```
Poisson (PLD)                                eps=3.98
fixed size, add/remove, sigma/2 (PLD)        eps=23.03
fixed size, replace-one (RDP)                eps=52.60
shuffle, zero-out, no amplification (PLD)    eps=18.51
PLDAccountant supports sampling without replacement: add/remove False, replace-one False
```

Random batches of fixed size cost more, because a record that joins a full batch pushes another out. So the clipped sum can move by twice the clipping norm C. Under add/remove neighbours, the Poisson accountant at $\sigma/2$ covers them, which turns 3.98 into 23.03. Under replace-one neighbours, only RDP can account them, also at $\sigma/2$ (last line). Its 52.60 protects the value of a record, not its presence, so it is not comparable with the add/remove values.

A loader that shuffles once per epoch and cuts the data into batches gets no amplification. All that is certain is one Gaussian step per epoch, 18.51 here. It holds for zero-out neighbours, in which one gradient becomes zero, so the statement must name that relation. A sum then moves by at most C, as under add/remove, so the value is comparable with the add/remove values. It beats fixed-size batches here, but the order reverses on the 100-epoch run of Matching the accountant to the code. So the fix for a loader that is not Poisson is to keep the Poisson loader of Opacus's `make_private`.

26.7. Train, stop early and resume

During training, the optimizer of Opacus calls `accountant.step` once per noisy update. That is once per logical batch, even when `BatchMemoryManager` splits it into smaller physical batches. The script simulates the 300 calls and asks for ε after each epoch.

```
def train_epochs(
    accountant: PRVAccountant, sigma: float, q: float, steps_per_epoch: int, epochs: int, de
) -> list[float]:
    """Step the accountant once per logical batch for `epochs` epochs; epsilon at the end of
    epsilons: list[float] = []
    for _ in range(epochs):
        for _ in range(steps_per_epoch):
            accountant.step(noise_multiplier=sigma, sample_rate=q)  # what the optimizer's s
        epsilons.append(float(accountant.get_epsilon(delta)))
    return epsilons
```

Suppose that the validation loss stalls and the run stops after six of its ten epochs. An early stop is safe, because the planned guarantee covers each prefix of the planned run. But report the planned maximum, because the decision to stop depended on what the run released. So the ε at

the stop is not a valid claim, and only a privacy filter that runs from the first step could certify it (Adaptive composition). Still log ε every epoch. It must never decrease, so a drop shows that something reset the accountant.

Training past the maximum is not safe. If you add epochs after you see the model, the number of steps depends on what the run released. So the longer run needs a new plan, accounted from the first step. Plan the longest run that you might want, and treat a shorter run as an early stop.

A job that stops and restarts must keep its accountant. Save the `state_dict` of the accountant with the model, and load it before the first new step. Opacus's `PrivacyEngine.save_checkpoint` and `load_checkpoint` do this.

```
state = accountant.state_dict()  # saved with the model; PrivacyEngine.save_checkpoint store
# ... the job stops, and later restarts ...
restarted = PRVAccountant()
restarted.load_state_dict(state)  # without this, epsilon would restart from zero
resumed = train_epochs(restarted, sigma, q, steps_per_epoch, epochs - stop, delta)
steps_recorded = sum(steps for _, _, steps in restarted.history)
```

```
steps per epoch: 30; planned: 10 epochs = 300 steps
epoch  1: eps=1.70
epoch  2: eps=2.09
epoch  4: eps=2.69
epoch  6: eps=3.18
epsilon never decreases over 10 epochs: True
stopped early at epoch 6: eps=3.18; report the planned maximum: eps=3.99
after resuming at epoch 6: eps at epoch 10=3.99; uninterrupted run: eps=3.99; equal: True
steps recorded: 300; planned (the loader's 10 x 30): 300; equal: True
```

The resumed run ends at 3.99, like a run that never stopped, with all 300 steps in its history. A fresh accountant would have counted only the last four epochs and reported 2.69.

26.8. Write the statement

The last step writes the claim with every input that a reviewer needs to recompute it. The script fills the template from the run. It rounds up the PLD's ε at two values of the slack, the rule's δ and $1/n^2$, where n is still the number of training records.

```
def privacy_statement(
    unit: str, dataset: str, n: int, batch: int, epochs: int, sigma: float, clip: float, del
) -> str:
    """The filled template of the reporting page: every input a reviewer needs to recompute
    q, _, steps = opacus_loader_plan(n, batch, epochs)  # the steps the Poisson loader runs
    run = SelfComposedDpEvent(PoissonSampledDpEvent(q, GaussianDpEvent(sigma)), steps)
    epsilon = round_up(PLDAccountant().compose(run).get_epsilon(delta))
    epsilon_tiny_delta = round_up(PLDAccountant().compose(run).get_epsilon(1 / n**2))
```

```
    return f"""\
Unit: one {unit} (a row of {dataset}); neighbouring datasets differ by adding or removing on
Data: n = {n:,}; Poisson sampling with q = {q:.6f} (B = {batch}); T = {steps:,} steps ({epoc
Mechanism: DP-SGD, clipping norm C = {clip}, noise multiplier sigma = {sigma:.3f}
Accountant: PLD, dp-accounting {version("dp-accounting")}; {calibration}
Guarantee: (epsilon = {epsilon:.2f}, delta = {delta:.0e}); epsilon = {epsilon_tiny_delta:.2f
Not covered: hyperparameter tuning runs (see Part 5), and any model released before this one
```

```
Unit: one person (a row of Adult); neighbouring datasets differ by adding or removing one pe
Data: n = 30,000; Poisson sampling with q = 0.033333 (B = 1000); T = 300 steps (10 epochs)
Mechanism: DP-SGD, clipping norm C = 1.0, noise multiplier sigma = 0.973
Accountant: PLD, dp-accounting 0.6.0; calibrated with Opacus 1.6.0 (PRV)
Guarantee: (epsilon = 3.99, delta = 1e-05); epsilon = 6.30 at delta = 1/n^2 = 1.1e-09
Not covered: hyperparameter tuning runs (see Part 5), and any model released before this one
```

The guarantee reads 3.99 because the script rounds the PLD value up, while the cross-check above printed it to the nearest value, 3.98. The unit, the dataset and the clipping norm come from options, because the accountant never sees them. The last line matters most to a reviewer, because it names privacy spent outside this ε. Examples are tuning on the private data (Hyperparameter tuning) and earlier models trained on the same people.

A published statement also gives what the script cannot know (Write the statement). That is the setting, the grid and bracket of the PLD, and the data outside the run, such as pretrained weights and the unprotected validation rows.

26.9. Checklist

Table 26.1.: The steps of calibrating and accounting a DP-SGD run.

Step	Default	Check
Unit, n and δ	One person; n from the training split, validation rows excluded; δ by the book's rule	n counts people, not rows; δ recomputed for each dataset
Sampler	Poisson; q and T from Opacus's loader, $\lceil n/B \rceil$ steps an epoch	Calibration counts the same steps; batch sizes vary
Plan the noise	Calibrate with PRV or PLD, the accountant you report	Two libraries agree within about 3%
Cross-check	Train at the calibrated σ, or round it up	PLD at most the target; RDP above PLD; GDP never reported; PLD bracket reported

Step	Default	Check
Other samplers	Keep Opacus's Poisson loader	No `shuffle=True` loader with fixed batches in the training code
Train and resume	One accountant step per logical batch; save the accountant's state; any extension inside the plan	ε never decreases; steps recorded equal the loader's steps
Statement	ε at the planned maximum, rounded up, at δ and $1/n^2$	Every input to recompute it; tuning, earlier models, pretraining, preprocessing and validation named

26.10. References

- Ponomareva et al., "How to DP-fy ML: A Practical Guide to Machine Learning with Differential Privacy" (JAIR 2023): planning a run's privacy budget, and what to report.
- Lebeda, Regehr, Kamath & Steinke, "Avoiding Pitfalls for Privacy Accounting of Subsampled Mechanisms under Composition" (IEEE SaTML 2025): why fixed-size and shuffled batches need their own accounting.

Derivations. The results this workflow relies on are derived in the full edition's chapters Amplification by subsampling in the full edition, Numerical accounting in the full edition and Choosing an accountant in the full edition.

27. Amplification by subsampling

27.1. Why this matters

Most private training uses stochastic gradient descent (SGD) made to satisfy differential privacy (DP), a method called DP-SGD. Each step clips every record's gradient to a maximum length, the **clipping norm**, sums the clipped gradients and adds Gaussian noise. The noise's standard deviation is the clipping norm times the **noise multiplier** σ. Suppose every record paid the cost of a full Gaussian step each time. Then ten thousand steps at $\sigma = 1$ would cost a privacy level ε of 5425.5 at a slack δ of 10^{-5}, no guarantee at all (Rényi DP).

DP-SGD avoids this cost because each step uses only a small random batch. Write q for the **sampling rate**, the probability that a given record is in the batch. An attacker must then first guess whether the step used the record at all, and that doubt is worth a lot. This **amplification by subsampling** depends on how the batch was drawn. So the accountant, the code that adds up a run's privacy cost, must assume the sampler that the training code runs. A wrong sampler is the largest single error in DP-SGD accounting, far larger than the choice of accountant (Section 27.4).

27.2. One step under Poisson sampling

The simplest sampler is **Poisson sampling**: each record enters the batch by its own coin flip, with probability q, independently of every other record. It goes with **add/remove** neighbours, two datasets of which one has an extra record. For this pair, Balle, Barthe and Gaboardi (2018) give the best possible one-step result. Suppose a step is (ε, δ)-DP when it uses every record, where δ is the small slack of Part 3. Then the same step on a Poisson sample is (ε', δ')-DP with

$$\varepsilon' = \ln\left(1 + q(e^{\varepsilon} - 1)\right), \qquad \delta' = q\delta. \tag{27.1}$$

Small and large ε behave very differently. For small ε the amplified cost is about $q\varepsilon$. So a 1% sample makes a step about a hundred times cheaper, and a 1-DP step costs 0.0170. For large ε the amplified cost is about

$$\varepsilon' \approx \varepsilon - \ln(1/q), \tag{27.2}$$

so sampling only subtracts a fixed amount, and a 10-DP step on the same sample still costs 5.3993. The change happens where ε is near $\ln(1/q)$. So amplification helps most when each step is already fairly private, which is why DP-SGD takes many cheap steps.

The result has two conditions. First, each record's coin must be independent of the others, so that every record is drawn with probability exactly q, whatever else is in the batch. Second, the batch must stay secret, because an attacker who reads the list of drawn records, for example in a log, knows whether the step used the target.

27.3. Match the sampler to the accountant

Most training code does not draw Poisson batches. Some draws a new random batch of a fixed size B from the n records at each step. More often, it shuffles the data once per epoch and cuts it into consecutive batches, which is **shuffle and partition**.

Each sampler needs its own accounting under each neighbouring relation. Besides add/remove, two relations are in use. Under **replace-one**, the two datasets have the same size and differ in one record's value, and under **zero-out**, the target's gradient becomes zero. Table 27.1 gives DP-SGD's accounting for each case as events of Google's `dp_accounting` library, which a Rényi differential privacy (RDP) or privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant then composes.

Table 27.1.: What to account for under each sampler and neighbouring relation in DP-SGD.

Sampler	Neighbours	What to account for	`dp_accounting` step
Poisson, rate q	add/remove	A Poisson accountant with q and σ	`PoissonSampledDpEvent(q, GaussianDpEvent(σ))`
Poisson, rate q	replace-one	The same event, at σ, in a PLD accountant built with `NeighboringRelation.REPLACE_ONE`, which models the swap itself	`PoissonSampledDpEvent(q, GaussianDpEvent(σ))`
Fixed size B of n	add/remove	A Poisson accountant with rate B/n and noise multiplier $\sigma/2$	`PoissonSampledDpEvent(B/n, GaussianDpEvent(σ/2))`
Fixed size B of n	replace-one	Sampling without replacement at noise multiplier $\sigma/2$, in the RDP accountant only	`SampledWithoutReplacementDpEver B, GaussianDpEvent(σ/2))`
Shuffle and partition	zero-out	No amplification: each epoch is one full Gaussian release	`GaussianDpEvent(σ)` once per epoch

The factor of two for fixed-size batches comes from the gradient sum. Under Poisson sampling, to add or remove a record moves the clipped sum by at most the clipping norm. A fixed-size batch has no space for an extra record. So a drawn record takes the place of another, and the sum can move twice as far (Lebeda et al. 2025). Twice the shift with the same noise is the same as the original shift with half the noise multiplier. Replace-one swaps a record by definition, so its shift doubles too, and for it only the RDP accountant of `dp_accounting` covers fixed-size batches.

Shuffle and partition is worse, because it has no source of amplification. In an epoch the record is in exactly one batch and is never absent, so the attacker only has to find which batch held it. Chua et al. (2024) build a dataset in which the target's gradient points against all the others, so

that its batch stands out. There, at $q = 0.01$ and $\sigma = 1$, one shuffled epoch provably has an ε of at least 4.06, but a Poisson accountant reports at most 1.21. The honest bound is the table's last row, one full Gaussian release per epoch, because each epoch uses the record exactly once.

So read the data loader before you trust a reported ε. A PyTorch `DataLoader` with `shuffle=True` and a `batch_size` is shuffle and partition. Opacus replaces the loader with a Poisson one by default, because `PrivacyEngine.make_private` sets `poisson_sampling=True` unless you turn it off. Its `batch_sampler` is then a `UniformWithReplacementSampler`, which flips one coin per record despite its name. So batch sizes change from step to step, which you can check in the training log. If you cannot use Poisson sampling, report under the matching row of Table 27.1. Name the sampler next to ε.

27.4. Accounting each sampler

Never account DP-SGD step by step with Equation 27.1. That route gives each step a tiny share of δ, and a tiny δ forces a large per-step ε, which sampling barely reduces, as for the 10-DP step above. On 10,000 steps, advanced composition then gives 24379.55, worse even than 5425.5 without sampling. An RDP accountant instead adds the steps' Rényi curves order by order and converts the total to (ε, δ) once, which gives 6.71 (Rényi DP). A PLD accountant is tighter still (Numerical accounting).

The snippet below accounts that run under four rows of Table 27.1, with 50,000 records in batches of 500, so $q = 0.01$. It uses $\delta = 10^{-5}$ to compare with the rest of the part, not the smaller δ of a report (How small δ must be).

```
from dp_accounting import GaussianDpEvent, NeighboringRelation, PoissonSampledDpEvent
from dp_accounting import SampledWithoutReplacementDpEvent, SelfComposedDpEvent
from dp_accounting.pld import PLDAccountant
from dp_accounting.rdp import RdpAccountant

n, batch, sigma, steps, delta = 50_000, 500, 1.0, 10_000, 1e-5  # q = 0.01, 100 epochs
poisson = SelfComposedDpEvent(PoissonSampledDpEvent(batch / n, GaussianDpEvent(sigma)), step
fixed_size = SelfComposedDpEvent(PoissonSampledDpEvent(batch / n, GaussianDpEvent(sigma / 2)
shuffled = SelfComposedDpEvent(GaussianDpEvent(sigma), 100)  # one Gaussian release per epoc
pld = [PLDAccountant(value_discretization_interval=1e-3).compose(e) for e in (poisson, fixed
print(" ".join(f"{accountant.get_epsilon(delta):.2f}" for accountant in pld))  # 6.19 43.37
replace_one = RdpAccountant(neighboring_relation=NeighboringRelation.REPLACE_ONE)
swap = SampledWithoutReplacementDpEvent(n, batch, GaussianDpEvent(sigma / 2))  # replace-one
replace_one.compose(SelfComposedDpEvent(swap, steps))
print(f"{replace_one.get_epsilon(delta):.2f}")  # 118.73
```

Poisson sampling costs 6.19. With the same noise, fixed-size batches cost 43.37 under add/remove neighbours, about seven times more, and shuffling costs 91.82 under zero-out. The replace-one value, 118.73, protects a record's value, not its presence, so compare it only with other replace-one numbers. Thus the sampler changes ε sevenfold or more, while the accountant changes it by less than 10%, from 6.71 by RDP to 6.19 by PLD.

Before you compose an unusual event, check it with `PLDAccountant().supports(event)`, which returns `False` for a `SampledWithoutReplacementDpEvent`, for example.

27.5. Batch size, epochs and noise

Amplification also changes how you plan a run. Write E for the number of epochs, so that a run takes E/q steps at sampling rate q. For small q and a large noise multiplier, the run's Rényi curve, its cost at each order α, is then roughly

$$\varepsilon(\alpha) \approx \frac{E\,q\,\alpha}{2\sigma^2}. \tag{27.3}$$

So at a fixed number of epochs a smaller sampling rate costs less privacy, because each step costs about q^2 while the number of steps grows only as $1/q$. Use this only to plan, never as the reported number, because at high orders the true curve rises far above it (from about order 9 at $\sigma = 1$ and $q = 0.01$).

Privacy is not the only cost, because the noise also changes the averaged gradient. With C for the clipping norm, the noise on the average of B records has standard deviation $\sigma C/B$. So compare plans by σ/B, not by σ. At the same ε, a ten times larger batch needs a larger σ, but its σ/B is six times smaller (Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run).

So plan in this order. First fix the batch size B and the epochs E that your accuracy needs. They set $q = B/n$ and the number of steps, where n is the size of the dataset you actually train on, after any filters. Then let the accountant find σ. Name the numerical accountant in the Opacus call `get_noise_multiplier`, because its default is RDP (Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run).

27.6. Cheat sheet

Table 27.2.: Which accounting to use for each sampler.

Situation	What to use	Notes
One step, Poisson, add/remove	$\varepsilon' = \ln(1 + q(e^{\varepsilon} - 1))$, $\delta' = q\delta$	About $q\varepsilon$ for small ε
DP-SGD, Poisson loader	PLD or RDP accountant with q and σ	6.19 by PLD for the running example
DP-SGD, fixed-size batches, add/remove	Poisson accountant with B/n and $\sigma/2$	43.37, about seven times the Poisson value
DP-SGD, fixed-size batches, replace-one	`SampledWithoutReplacementDpEvent` at $\sigma/2$ in the RDP accountant	Not comparable with add/remove numbers
DP-SGD, shuffle and partition	One Gaussian release per epoch, under zero-out	A Poisson number does not apply; better, switch the loader to Poisson sampling

Rules of thumb

- Account for the sampler you run, check that its batches vary in size, and state the neighbouring relation next to ε.

27.7. References

- Balle, Barthe & Gaboardi, "Privacy Amplification by Subsampling: Tight Analyses via Couplings and Divergences" (NeurIPS 2018): amplification for each sampler and neighbouring relation.
- Lebeda, Regehr, Kamath & Steinke, "Avoiding Pitfalls for Privacy Accounting of Subsampled Mechanisms under Composition" (IEEE SaTML 2025): fixed-size batches and other accounting pitfalls.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

28. Rényi differential privacy

28.1. Why this matters

Training a model runs thousands of private steps, but you report one differential privacy (DP) guarantee for all of them, a privacy level ε with a small slack δ. The advanced composition of Part 3 adds up the pairs of the steps, and the result is far too pessimistic (Composition). Take 1000 steps of full-batch noisy gradient descent, each with Gaussian noise whose standard deviation is 20 times the most one record can move the gradient. At $\delta = 10^{-5}$, advanced composition gives $\varepsilon = 68.01$, nine times the exact 7.51. So a run calibrated to it adds more noise than it needs.

Rényi differential privacy (RDP) fixes this, because it keeps a whole curve of privacy costs for each step instead of one point. The curves of the steps add, with no δ spent along the way, and you convert the total into (ε, δ) once, at the end. Even with Mironov's original conversion (Section 28.6), the same run then costs 8.84, only 18% above the exact value. Opacus and Google's `dp_accounting` both have an RDP accountant.

28.2. The RDP curve

A DP guarantee compares the outputs of a mechanism on two neighbouring datasets, which differ in one person's record. RDP measures the distance between those two output distributions with the **Rényi divergence** of Divergences. That divergence has a dial, the **order** α, which is any number above 1. A small order looks at the typical output. A large order gives more weight to the rare outputs that are much more likely on one dataset than on the other.

A mechanism is (α, ε)**-RDP** if, at order α, the divergence is at most ε for every pair of neighbours. The smallest such ε at each order gives the **RDP curve** $\varepsilon(\alpha)$ of the mechanism, and a higher curve means less privacy. The curve never decreases with the order. At order infinity, it is the largest privacy loss of any output, which is what pure DP, the case $\delta = 0$, bounds. You never compute the divergence yourself, because accountants know the curves of the standard mechanisms on a grid of orders.

28.3. RDP curves of the basic mechanisms

To account for a mechanism, you need its curve, and the basic mechanisms have one in closed form (Mironov 2017). For the **Gaussian mechanism**, write σ for its noise multiplier. That is the standard deviation of the noise in units of the ℓ_2 sensitivity, the most one record can move the answer. Its curve is the straight line

$$\varepsilon(\alpha) = \frac{\alpha}{2\sigma^2}. \tag{28.1}$$

Table 28.1 gives the curves of the Gaussian, Laplace and randomized-response mechanisms at a few orders, each at sensitivity 1.

Table 28.1.: RDP curves of the three basic mechanisms with sensitivity 1.

Mechanism	$\varepsilon(1.5)$	$\varepsilon(2)$	$\varepsilon(10)$	$\varepsilon(64)$	$\varepsilon(\infty)$
Gaussian, $\sigma = 1$	0.7500	1.0000	5.0000	32.0000	∞
Laplace, scale $b = 1$	0.5129	0.6191	0.9287	0.9891	1
Randomized response, which reports a bit truthfully with probability 0.75	0.7340	0.8473	1.0666	1.0940	1.0986

The Laplace and randomized-response curves level off at their pure DP level. The Gaussian curve has no limit, so the Gaussian mechanism is not ε-DP for any ε. But an accountant converts only at finite orders, where the curve is finite. These curves are for steps on the whole dataset. The private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD, runs each step on a random batch, and libraries compute its much smaller curves for you (Amplification by subsampling).

28.4. Composition adds curves

Training runs thousands of mechanisms in sequence, and each may depend on what the earlier ones released, as a gradient step depends on the current model. RDP composes these mechanisms by adding their curves, order by order. Write ε_i for the curve of the i-th step. Then a whole run of k steps has a curve ε_M with

$$\varepsilon_M(\alpha) \le \sum_{i=1}^{k} \varepsilon_i(\alpha) \qquad \text{for every order } \alpha. \tag{28.2}$$

Different mechanisms mix freely, because you only add numbers at the same order.

Two conditions come with the sum. First, every curve must describe the same neighbouring relation, such as add/remove or replace-one, and the same unit of privacy, such as one record or one user. Second, the curve of each step must be fixed before the run. Steps may adapt to earlier outputs, but if the data choose the noise level or the number of steps, the curves depend on the data too. An early stop when a validation metric looks good is such a choice, and it needs Adaptive composition instead.

The sum is simplest for Gaussian steps, because their curve is the straight line $\alpha/(2\sigma^2)$. Adding k such lines multiplies the slope by k, which gives the line of one step with noise multiplier $\sigma/\sqrt{k}$.

So k Gaussian steps cost as much privacy as one step with $\sqrt{k}$ times less noise, which is bad news for training. If 10,000 steps with noise multiplier 1 each used the whole dataset, they would cost as much as one step with noise multiplier $1/\sqrt{10{,}000} = 0.01$, whose ε at $\delta = 10^{-5}$ is 5425.5, no guarantee at all. DP-SGD escapes this by running each step on a small random sample. This part's running example is such a run: 10,000 steps with noise multiplier 1, each on a random 1% of the data.

28.5. Post-processing and group privacy

Post-processing is free in RDP, because a computation on the output that does not look at the data again cannot make the curve larger. So the release of the trained model or its predictions costs nothing beyond the training run.

Groups of records are harder, and the generic group rule of RDP is loose. So when one user gives m records and the noise is Gaussian, use the sensitivity of the group instead, which is at most m times that of one record. The curve becomes

$$\varepsilon_{\text{group}}(\alpha) = \frac{m^2 \alpha}{2\sigma^2}, \tag{28.3}$$

which is m^2 times the curve of one record, so ten records per user cost a hundred times as much. The fix is to clip the whole contribution of each user to one clipping norm and to account per user (User-level privacy).

28.6. Compose, then convert once

After composition, you have a curve, but you report an (ε, δ) pair. Both libraries turn the curve into a pair with the **improved conversion** (Balle et al. 2020, and independently Canonne, Kamath and Steinke 2020). From the value $\varepsilon(\alpha)$ of the curve at one order and a target δ, it gives the privacy level

$$\varepsilon' = \varepsilon(\alpha) + \ln \frac{\alpha - 1}{\alpha} - \frac{\ln \delta + \ln \alpha}{\alpha - 1}. \tag{28.4}$$

Report the smallest ε' over the grid of orders, or 0 if that is negative. Libraries call the order that gave it the best order.

Older papers and code use Mironov's original conversion, which gives 7.43 instead of 6.71 on the DP-SGD running example. The **moments accountant** of the original DP-SGD paper (Abadi et al. 2016) is the RDP curve with that conversion, so its ε is loose but not wrong (From Rényi DP to (ε, δ) and to tests).

28.7. Check the order grid

A conversion can use only the orders on the grid of the accountant, so the grid must contain the best order. That order moves with the run, towards 1 for long runs with little noise and up for short runs with much noise. For the noisy gradient descent at the start of the chapter, it falls from 128 after one step to 4 after 1000.

The default grid of Opacus, `RDPAccountant.DEFAULT_ALPHAS`, stops at order 63, and that of `dp_accounting`, `DEFAULT_RDP_ORDERS`, at 1024. A best order at either end of the grid means that the true optimum is outside it, so give a longer list, with `alphas=[...]` in Opacus or `orders=[...]` in `dp_accounting`. Opacus warns you, but `dp_accounting` does not, so compare the returned order with the ends of the list yourself.

28.8. Accounting with a library

In practice, you describe each step to a library, and it composes and converts. In `dp_accounting`, a DP-SGD step is a `GaussianDpEvent` inside a `PoissonSampledDpEvent`, which samples each record independently, with probability 0.01 in the running example. This snippet composes the 10,000 steps and prints ε with the best order.

```
import dp_accounting

step = dp_accounting.PoissonSampledDpEvent(0.01, dp_accounting.GaussianDpEvent(1.0))
accountant = dp_accounting.rdp.RdpAccountant()
accountant.compose(step, count=10_000)
eps, order = accountant.get_epsilon_and_optimal_order(1e-5)
print(f"{eps:.4f} {order:g}")  # 6.7128 4.1
```

In Opacus, the accountant is attached to the optimizer, which calls `step` after every noisy update. The same calls by hand give the same ε to the fourth decimal, at the same order, 4.1, which is well inside both grids.

```
from opacus.accountants import RDPAccountant

accountant = RDPAccountant()
for _ in range(10_000):  # what the optimizer does at each step of training
    accountant.step(noise_multiplier=1.0, sample_rate=0.01)
eps, order = accountant.get_privacy_spent(delta=1e-5)
print(f"{eps:.4f} {order:g}")  # 6.7127 4.1
```

Opacus's defaults mix two accountants, so name the one that you want. In Opacus 1.6.0, `PrivacyEngine` uses `"prv"`, a numerical accountant, by default, and `accountant="rdp"` selects this class. But `get_noise_multiplier`, which solves for the noise multiplier σ, uses RDP by default. Both give valid upper bounds, but different ones, and the numerical accountant gives 6.19 for the running example.

Two more checks catch most mistakes. The event must match the sampler of your data loader, because shuffled batches of fixed size get none of the amplification of a Poisson event (Amplification by subsampling). And a manual call to `step` on top of the optimizer's own call charges each update twice.

28.9. Cheat sheet

Table 28.2.: The results of this chapter.

Result	Formula	Notes
RDP curve	$\varepsilon(\alpha)$ over orders $\alpha > 1$	Never decreases; $\varepsilon(\infty)$ is pure DP
Gaussian, noise multiplier σ	$\varepsilon(\alpha) = \alpha/(2\sigma^2)$	σ in units of the ℓ_2 sensitivity
Composition	$\varepsilon_M(\alpha) \le \sum_i \varepsilon_i(\alpha)$	Same relation and unit; curves fixed in advance
Group of m, Gaussian	$m^2\alpha/(2\sigma^2)$	The generic group rule is loose
Improved conversion	$\varepsilon(\alpha) + \ln\frac{\alpha-1}{\alpha} - \frac{\ln\delta+\ln\alpha}{\alpha-1}$, best α	What Opacus and `dp_accounting` use

28.10. References

- Mironov, "Rényi Differential Privacy" (IEEE CSF 2017): the definition, composition, the curves of the basic mechanisms and group privacy.
- Abadi et al., "Deep Learning with Differential Privacy" (CCS 2016): DP-SGD and the moments accountant.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

29. From Rényi DP to (ε, δ) and to tests

29.1. What it is

An accountant that tracks Rényi differential privacy (RDP) ends a run with a curve (Rényi differential privacy). The curve gives a privacy level, written $\varepsilon(\alpha)$, at each order α above 1. A report needs a differential privacy (DP) guarantee, a privacy level ε' with a small slack δ. A conversion turns each point of the curve into such a pair, and you keep the smallest ε'.

Two conversions are in use. The original one, **Mironov's conversion** (Mironov 2017), gives at each order

$$\varepsilon' = \varepsilon(\alpha) + \frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{\alpha - 1}. \tag{29.1}$$

The **improved conversion** (Balle et al. 2020) gives

$$\varepsilon' = \varepsilon(\alpha) + \ln\frac{\alpha - 1}{\alpha} - \frac{\ln\delta + \ln\alpha}{\alpha - 1}. \tag{29.2}$$

Both are valid, but at the same order the improved one is always lower, by 0.3612 at order 10 and more at smaller orders. If the improved value is negative, report 0.

For example, one Gaussian release with noise multiplier 1 has the curve $\alpha/2$. At $\delta = 10^{-5}$ its exact ε is 4.377, Mironov's conversion gives 5.299 and the improved one 4.729.

29.2. When you meet it

You meet the conversion when you compare RDP numbers from two sources. Opacus 1.6.0 and `dp_accounting` 0.6.0 use the improved one, and older papers and code use Mironov's. This part's running example is 10,000 steps of the private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD, each on a random 1% of the data with noise multiplier 1. There, Mironov's conversion gives 7.43 and the improved one 6.71.

The saving depends only on the order. So two RDP accountants that report values about 0.36 apart for one run, with a best order near 10, use different conversions. Recompute both with one library before you compare them.

29.3. How to use it

In `dp_accounting`, `get_epsilon_and_optimal_order` converts at the best order of the grid and returns both. One curve gives every δ, so `get_epsilon` can report several pairs at no extra privacy cost. This snippet converts the single Gaussian release above.

```
from dp_accounting import GaussianDpEvent
from dp_accounting.rdp import RdpAccountant

accountant = RdpAccountant()
accountant.compose(GaussianDpEvent(1.0))  # one release, noise multiplier 1
eps, order = accountant.get_epsilon_and_optimal_order(1e-5)
print(f"{eps:.4f} {order:g}")  # 4.7285 5.4
print(f"{accountant.get_epsilon(1e-8):.4f}")  # 6.0864
```

A δ a thousand times smaller raises ε only from 4.7285 to 6.0864, because δ enters the conversion through a logarithm. The best order comes from a fixed grid. Short runs with much noise can need orders above 63, where the Opacus default grid stops. So if the returned order is at an end of the grid, extend the grid and convert again (Rényi differential privacy).

29.4. What goes wrong

No conversion closes the whole gap to the exact value, because the curve is only a summary. Other mechanisms with the same curve have a larger exact ε, and the conversion must hold for them too. For the plain Gaussian, the improved conversion is 5 to 10% above the exact value, and more for the subsampled steps of DP-SGD. A privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant keeps the whole distribution instead, and gets the exact 4.377 for the single release (Numerical accounting).

The conversion works in one direction only, because a guarantee with δ above 0 gives no RDP curve. For example, a mechanism that publishes your record with probability δ is $(0, \delta)$-DP, but its Rényi divergence is infinite. So never put an (ε, δ) pair into an RDP accountant. Take the curve from the mechanism instead.

A conversion also loses what the curve says about attacks. Take a membership attack on the single release above, at a false-positive rate of 10^{-3}. The curve limits the attack's true-positive rate to 2.4910×10^{-2}. But the pair at $\varepsilon = 4.729$ limits it only to 0.1131 (f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy).

29.5. References

- Balle, Barthe, Gaboardi, Hsu & Sato, "Hypothesis Testing Interpretations and Rényi Differential Privacy" (AISTATS 2020): the improved conversion, and what an RDP curve says about tests.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

30. Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions

30.1. What it is

A privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant computes the privacy level ε of a whole differential privacy (DP) run numerically. Take a dataset and a neighbour that differs in one record, and run the mechanism on the first. The **privacy loss** L of that run is the logarithm of how much likelier the output is on the first dataset than on the second. The output is random, and the distribution of its loss is the PLD. Only outputs whose loss is more than ε add to the slack δ, so the smallest slack is the following, where $(\cdot)_+$ sets a negative value to 0:

$$\delta(\varepsilon) = \mathbb{E}[(1 - e^{\varepsilon - L})_+]. \tag{30.1}$$

When steps draw their noise independently, their losses add, so the PLD of a run is the convolution of the steps' PLDs. All the error comes from the grid of losses that holds each PLD, with a spacing h between points. To round every loss up can only make δ larger, so the ε it gives is an upper bound, the **pessimistic** side. To round down gives a lower bound, the optimistic side. Each rounding moves a step's loss by at most h, so after T steps the two values are at most Th apart.

30.2. When you meet it

You meet a PLD accountant each time you train with Opacus, whose default `"prv"` is the privacy loss random variable (PRV) accountant of Gopi, Lee and Wutschitz (2021). It rounds each loss to the nearest grid point, adds a proven error bound and reports the upper value. Google's `dp_accounting` has `PLDAccountant`, which by default rounds up with **connect the dots**, the tightest pessimistic rounding on a grid.

Table 30.1 compares a PLD with Rényi differential privacy (RDP) and with the central limit theorem (CLT) estimate of Gaussian differential privacy (GDP). The run is the part's example of the private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD, with sampling rate 0.01 and noise multiplier 1.

Table 30.1.: ε at $\delta = 10^{-5}$, for the running example. The PLD columns round up and down on the grid $h = 10^{-5}$, without connect the dots.

Steps	PLD upper	PLD lower	RDP	GDP CLT
1	0.1995	0.1994	0.9555	0.0368

Steps	PLD upper	PLD lower	RDP	GDP CLT
1000	1.8332	1.8232	2.1014	1.6177
10000	6.2377	6.1377	6.7127	6.0071

RDP gives a valid but loose bound (Rényi DP). The CLT estimate is below the PLD's lower bound at every length, so it claims a guarantee the run lacks (f-DP and Gaussian DP).

30.3. How to use it

In `dp_accounting`, compose the run as an event and read ε at your δ. The method `get_delta` goes the other way, from a claimed ε to a bound on its δ.

```
from dp_accounting import GaussianDpEvent, PoissonSampledDpEvent, SelfComposedDpEvent
from dp_accounting.pld import PLDAccountant
from opacus.accountants import PRVAccountant

run = SelfComposedDpEvent(PoissonSampledDpEvent(0.01, GaussianDpEvent(1.0)), 10_000)
pld = PLDAccountant(value_discretization_interval=1e-4).compose(run)  # h, 10x the table's
print(f"{pld.get_epsilon(1e-5):.4f}")  # 6.1877
print(f"{pld.get_delta(6.24):.1e}")  # 8.5e-06

prv = PRVAccountant()
prv.history = [(1.0, 0.01, 10_000)]  # (noise multiplier, sample rate, steps)
print(f"{prv.get_epsilon(delta=1e-5):.4f}")  # 6.1980
```

Both answers are upper bounds inside the bracket of Table 30.1, so you can report either. A reviewer can use `get_delta` to confirm the claim $(6.24, 10^{-5})$, because it bounds the run's slack at that ε by 8.5×10^{-6}.

Each library has one accuracy setting. In `dp_accounting` it is the grid spacing `value_discretization_interval` and a grid ten times finer makes the bracket ten times narrower, for about ten times the memory. In Opacus it is `eps_error`, the error allowed in ε. The error grows with the steps, so set either for your longest run.

30.4. What goes wrong

The most frequent mistake is to report the wrong side of the bracket. Only the pessimistic value, or the PRV accountant's upper value, is a guarantee. The optimistic value and the midpoint are estimates.

Under add/remove neighbours, a subsampled step has one PLD for an added record and another for a removed one, and neither is larger in general. So an accountant must compose both and report the larger, as `dp_accounting` does by default. The PRV accountant of Opacus models

only removal, which is the larger direction in the running example. Both libraries assume Poisson sampling, and shuffled or fixed-size batches break it (Amplification by subsampling).

A run that adapts its steps or noise to the outputs needs a filter instead (Adaptive composition).

30.5. References

- Gopi, Lee & Wutschitz, "Numerical Composition of Differential Privacy" (NeurIPS 2021): the PRV accountant, with explicit error bounds.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

31. f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy

31.1. What it is

Every differential privacy (DP) guarantee limits how well an attacker can tell whether the data held a target's record. That attacker runs a hypothesis test, so the fullest guarantee is a **trade-off curve**, the lowest false negative rate any test can get at each false positive rate. A mechanism is **f-DP** when its curve is never below a given curve f (Dong, Roth and Su 2022). A privacy level ε with its slack δ is only a summary of that curve.

For Gaussian noise the curve has one parameter. Write σ for the noise multiplier, the noise's standard deviation in units of the query's ℓ_2 sensitivity. In those units the attacker must tell a standard normal draw from one shifted by $\mu = 1/\sigma$. So the mechanism satisfies Gaussian differential privacy (GDP) with parameter μ, written **μ-GDP**. Write Φ for the standard normal distribution function. Then no membership attack at a false positive rate α gets a true positive rate above

$$1 - \Phi(\Phi^{-1}(1-\alpha) - \mu). \tag{31.1}$$

31.2. When you meet it

You meet GDP when you decide whether a guarantee is enough, and as a trap in Opacus (Section 31.4). Table 31.1 reads μ as the best true positive rate (TPR) of an attack at a given false positive rate (FPR), whatever else the attacker knows.

Table 31.1.: Reading μ-GDP as an attack and as (ε, δ).

μ	Best TPR at 0.1% FPR	At 1%	At 5%	ε at $\delta = 10^{-5}$
0.5	0.0048	0.0339	0.1261	1.9931
1	0.0183	0.0924	0.2595	4.3772
2	0.1378	0.3721	0.6388	9.9973

For example, at a false positive rate of 1%, no attacker on a 1-GDP release finds the record in more than 9.24% of the trials where it is present. That is the ceiling for any membership inference attack, and the value a privacy audit tests. Dong et al. suggest that $\mu \leq 0.5$ is a reasonable guarantee and that $\mu \geq 6$ promises almost nothing. So report μ next to a Gaussian pipeline's (ε, δ).

31.3. How to use it

Gaussian releases compose exactly in GDP, also when each one depends on the earlier ones. Write μ_i for the parameter of the i-th release. The run is then μ-GDP with

$$\mu = \sqrt{\mu_1^2 + \mu_2^2 + \cdots + \mu_k^2}, \tag{31.2}$$

so the quantity that adds up is μ^2. For releases on the whole dataset, such as analytics queries and full-batch noisy gradient descent, no accountant does better. So keep a ledger of μ^2 and convert once, at the end. For example, four 1-GDP releases compose to 2-GDP, which is $(9.9973, 10^{-5})$-DP. If you convert each release first, with a quarter of the slack, the four values of ε add to 18.7607, almost twice as much.

The snippet computes the attack ceiling and converts both ways. The `dp_accounting` functions take a noise multiplier, so for μ-GDP you give $1/\mu$.

```
from statistics import NormalDist

import dp_accounting

N = NormalDist()


def attack_power(mu: float, fpr: float) -> float:
    """Best true positive rate of any membership attack on mu-GDP at a false positive rate."
    return 1 - N.cdf(N.inv_cdf(1 - fpr) - mu)


print(" ".join(f"{attack_power(mu, 0.001):.4f}" for mu in (0.5, 1.0, 2.0)))  # 0.0048 0.0183
print(f"{dp_accounting.get_epsilon_gaussian(1.0, 1e-5):.4f}")  # 4.3772
print(f"{dp_accounting.get_sigma_gaussian(1.0, 1e-5):.4f}")  # 3.7306
```

The last print finds the noise multiplier of a single $(1, 10^{-5})$-DP release. It uses the exact curve, which needs less noise than the classical formula of the Gaussian mechanism.

31.4. What goes wrong

Opacus has `accountant="gdp"` for the private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD. It estimates μ with the central limit theorem (CLT) of Bu et al. (2020), which says that many steps that each leak little compose to nearly a Gaussian curve. This estimate is an approximation, not a bound, and its error is on the unsafe side. A small δ depends on rare, large losses, and a CLT fits those tails badly. On the part's running example of 10,000 steps, the CLT gives 6.0071, but a numerical accountant proves that the true ε is at least 6.1377. So report with the default numerical accountant of Opacus, `"prv"`.

A mix of Laplace and Gaussian releases needs a numerical accountant, because a curve that is not Gaussian takes the composition out of GDP. But for Gaussian pipelines without subsampling,

GDP is the best accountant. Even the best conversion from a Rényi DP curve loses: for 1-GDP at $\varepsilon = 1$, it gives a δ of 0.2149 against the exact 0.1269.

31.5. References

- Dong, Roth & Su, "Gaussian Differential Privacy" (Journal of the Royal Statistical Society Series B, 2022).

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

32. Adaptive composition: filters, odometers and individual accounting

32.1. What it is

The composition theorems of differential privacy (DP) assume that you fix each step's privacy parameter and the number of steps before the run (Composition). Actual runs often choose them from the outputs, for example when training stops on the validation loss. Then the theorems do not hold for the actual values (Rogers et al. 2016). This **plug-in mistake** can make the bound fail about three times as often as its δ claims.

A **privacy filter** fixes a total budget in advance and refuses any step that would go past it, so the run keeps the budget's guarantee for any stopping rule. A **privacy odometer**, for open-ended analyses, reports the spend so far instead. Its value holds at every step, at a higher ε.

32.2. When you meet it

Early stopping with a planned maximum needs neither. Fix the noise, sampling rate and maximum number of steps in advance, then stop when the validation loss stops falling. **Report the ε of the planned maximum, not of the steps you ran.** The steps you ran are the start of the planned run, so the planned guarantee covers them. If 100 planned full-batch Gaussian steps with noise multiplier 10 are $(5.299, 10^{-5})$-DP, a run that stops at step 60 reports that.

The rule has three conditions. The stop signal must come from the released models or from held-out data, so that the stop is post-processing. To train past the maximum, make a new plan and account it from the first step. A resumed run must restore its accountant (the calibration workflow).

You meet filters when training changes the noise in response to the outputs, and in analytics services, such as OpenDP's `make_privacy_filter` or Tumult Analytics' `Session`.

32.3. How to use it

The Rényi filter of Feldman and Zrnic (2021) works in Rényi differential privacy (RDP) at one order, written α and fixed in advance. It charges each step its spend at that order (Rényi DP). The spend can depend on earlier outputs, but the filter must know it before the step runs. The

filter refuses a step that would take the total past a budget B. For a target privacy level ε_g with slack δ, use the conversion from RDP in reverse, which sets

$$B = \varepsilon_g - \frac{\ln(1/\delta)}{\alpha - 1}. \tag{32.1}$$

A Gaussian step with a noise multiplier, written σ, spends $\alpha/(2\sigma^2)$ at order α. At order 5.8, the best order for this target, the budget is $B = 2.900$, enough for 100 full-batch steps at $\sigma = 10$. Suppose that the validation loss stops falling at step 60 and you halve the noise. Each later step then costs four times as much, so the budget left for 40 steps pays for 10, and the run still meets the target.

OpenDP's filter works in zero-concentrated DP (zCDP). Its single budget number, written ρ, bounds the RDP spend at every order at once (Concentrated DP).

```
import opendp.prelude as dp

dp.enable_features("contrib")
domain, metric = dp.atom_domain(T=float, nan=False), dp.absolute_distance(T=float)
odometer = dp.c.make_fully_adaptive_composition(domain, metric, dp.zero_concentrated_diverge
queryable = dp.c.make_privacy_filter(odometer, d_in=1.0, d_out=0.5)(0.0)  # rho = 0.5, i.e.

answered = 0
try:
    for _ in range(1000):  # sigma = 10: rho = 1 / (2 sigma^2) = 0.005 each
        queryable(dp.m.make_gaussian(domain, metric, scale=10.0))
        answered += 1
except dp.OpenDPException:  # the release that would exceed the budget
    pass
print(answered)  # 99
```

OpenDP lets 99 releases through, not 100, because it rounds each charge up for floating-point safety. For pure-DP queries, the **Whitehouse filter** (Whitehouse et al. 2023) holds many more small queries than a plain sum of their ε.

32.4. What goes wrong

An odometer costs more than a filter. The **Ville odometer** converts the RDP spend at the best order of a grid fixed in advance. It pays for that late choice with δ divided by the grid's size, which raises ε from 5.299 to 6.253 on the 100-step run above.

Individual accounting charges each training record by its own clipped gradient norm, because a small gradient moves the model less. It drops a record when its spend would pass the budget. In the full edition's simulation, the median record ends at an individual ε of 3.17, against 5.299 for the worst case. But it comes from the actual norms, so it is an estimate, not a guarantee. It is also sensitive, because a small value says that the model fits that record well. And the records with large gradients, which go first, are often those the model serves worst (Disparate impact).

32.5. References

- Whitehouse, Ramdas, Rogers & Wu, "Fully-Adaptive Composition in Differential Privacy" (ICML 2023).
- Feldman & Zrnic, "Individual Privacy Accounting via a Rényi Filter" (NeurIPS 2021).

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

33. Concentrated differential privacy

33.1. What it is

Zero-concentrated differential privacy (zCDP) keeps a differential privacy (DP) budget as one number that adds up. It starts from the curve of Rényi differential privacy (RDP), which bounds how far apart a mechanism's outputs on neighbouring datasets can be at each order α. A mechanism is ρ-**zCDP** when that curve lies under the straight line $\rho\alpha$, so ρ is a slope. Composition adds the slopes, also when each step depends on the earlier outputs.

The Gaussian mechanism's curve is such a line. Write σ for the standard deviation of its noise. Write $\Delta_2 f$ for the ℓ_2 sensitivity of the query f, the most one record can move it in Euclidean distance. One release then costs

$$\rho = \frac{(\Delta_2 f)^2}{2\sigma^2}. \tag{33.1}$$

So a release with noise multiplier 1, where $\sigma = \Delta_2 f$, costs $\rho = 0.5$, and twice the noise cuts ρ to a quarter.

33.2. When you meet it

You meet zCDP in releases that add Gaussian noise to the whole dataset, such as noisy counts or the marginals behind a synthetic dataset. The 2020 United States Census used it with the discrete Gaussian mechanism (Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms). Tumult Analytics and OpenDP also keep budgets in ρ.

33.3. How to use it

Keep a ledger of releases, and charge each its ρ from Table 33.1.

Table 33.1.: What each kind of step costs in a zCDP ledger.

Step	Charge in ρ	Notes
Gaussian, sensitivity $\Delta_2 f$, noise σ	$(\Delta_2 f)^2/(2\sigma^2)$	Exact
Any pure ε-DP step	$\varepsilon^2/2$, or $\varepsilon^2/8$ for an exponential mechanism	Above the plain ε once $\varepsilon \geq 2$: keep such a step in RDP

Step	Charge in ρ	Notes
An (ε, δ)-DP step	$\varepsilon^2/2$, plus δ in a second column that also adds	**Approximate zCDP**
Poisson-subsampled Gaussian	$(\Delta_2 f)^2/(2\sigma^2)$, as without sampling	No amplification

Add the charges. Then convert the total to a privacy level ε and a small slack δ once, at the end, so that you pay the conversion's slack only once. An all-Gaussian total ρ costs the same as one Gaussian release with noise multiplier $1/\sqrt{2\rho}$, so `get_epsilon_gaussian` converts it exactly. The snippet does this, then calibrates a $(1, 10^{-5})$-DP release.

```
from math import sqrt

import dp_accounting

rho = 1 / (2 * 1.0**2)  # one Gaussian release, noise multiplier 1
print(f"{rho:.1f} {dp_accounting.get_epsilon_gaussian(1 / sqrt(2 * rho), 1e-5):.4f}")  # 0.5
sigma = dp_accounting.get_sigma_gaussian(1.0, 1e-5)  # one release that must be (1, 1e-5)-DP
budget = 1 / (2 * sigma**2)
quarter = budget / 4  # four releases share it
print(f"{budget:.5f} {sigma:.3f} {1 / sqrt(2 * quarter):.3f}")  # 0.03593 3.731 7.461
```

So the budget for $(1, 10^{-5})$ is $\rho = 0.03593$, which one query meets with noise multiplier 3.731. Four queries that share it get a quarter each, and each needs twice the noise. Split the budget in ρ, which adds exactly, never in ε. A histogram in which each person is in one cell costs one charge, not one per cell (Parallel composition).

A ledger with steps that are not Gaussian has no exact conversion. At $\rho = 0.5$, the simple conversion of Bun and Steinke (2016) is 21% above the exact Gaussian value. The improved conversion of Canonne, Kamath and Steinke (2020) is only 8% above, and the RDP accountant in `dp_accounting` uses it. Use it, or the exact one for an all-Gaussian ledger. Name the conversion in the report.

33.4. What goes wrong

The most frequent error is to read ρ as ε. A Gaussian release at $\rho = 0.5$ is $(4.3772, 10^{-5})$-DP. So if you read it as $\varepsilon = 0.5$, you overrate the protection by far. Also, ρ covers only what passed through the noise. The Census Bureau released some counts exactly, and such **invariants** are outside the guarantee, so list them next to the budget.

Keep subsampled steps out of zCDP, because it gives them no amplification. On this part's running example, a run of the private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD, zCDP gives $\varepsilon = 5475.8$ at $\delta = 10^{-5}$ where RDP gives 6.719. So keep a pipeline with DP-SGD in RDP or a numerical accountant. A ρ-zCDP release joins it without loss as a `GaussianDpEvent` with noise multiplier $1/\sqrt{2\rho}$.

Several records of one user cost more, because a group of m records costs $m^2\rho$. For example, four records in a 0.1-zCDP release cost $\rho = 1.6$.

A budget never renews, because next year's releases about the same people compose with this year's. So fix the period and its total in advance (Release and governance). Keep a long ledger in ρ, not in diffprivlib's `BudgetAccountant`, which adds ε by plain composition (Keeping a budget).

33.5. References

- Bun & Steinke, "Concentrated Differential Privacy: Simplifications, Extensions, and Lower Bounds" (TCC 2016): the definition.
- Canonne, Kamath & Steinke, "The Discrete Gaussian for Differential Privacy" (NeurIPS 2020): the improved conversion.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

34. Amplification by shuffling and by iteration

34.1. What it is

In the shuffle model, each of n users randomizes their own data, so each report satisfies local differential privacy (DP) at a level ε_0. A **shuffler** removes identities and mixes the order, so each report hides among the others. The set of reports then satisfies central DP at a much smaller ε, which falls like $\sqrt{\ln(1/\delta)/n}$ for a slack δ above 0. All results here are for replace-one neighbours.

For binary randomized response, the analyst learns only the count of 1-reports, so you can compute the shuffled guarantee exactly. For any other local randomizer, use the clone bound of Feldman, McMillan and Talwar (2021). With probability $e^{-\varepsilon_0}$, the report of another user looks exactly like one you could have sent, and such **clones** hide yours. The **numeric clone bound** computes this exactly, while the paper's closed form is looser and needs enough users.

34.2. When you meet it

You meet shuffling in telemetry systems such as Prochlo (Bittau et al. 2017), where the decision is how large ε_0 can be. No maintained library accounts for it, so use the full edition's shuffling_iteration.py.

Two other things have the same name but get none of this amplification. A data loader that shuffles once per epoch is a sampler (Match the sampler to the accountant). Federated clients that join rounds when available pass through no shuffler either, so account for them without amplification or with matrix mechanisms.

34.3. How to use it

Start from the central target. Compute the numeric clone bound for a few values of ε_0, and keep the largest value that meets the target.

Table 34.1.: Central ε at $\delta = 10^{-6}$ after shuffling the reports of n users. "n/a" marks too few users for the closed form.

n	ε_0	Exact, randomized response	Clones, numeric	Clones, closed form
1,000	4	1.6910	3.9900	n/a
10,000	2	0.0870	0.1550	0.5009

n	ε_0	Exact, randomized response	Clones, numeric	Clones, closed form
100,000	2	0.0247	0.0450	0.1862
100,000	4	0.0847	0.1698	0.5346

The choice of bound can decide whether a design is possible. For example, for 100,000 users and a target of 0.2, the closed form allows ε_0 up to 2 but the numeric bound allows 4, so use the numeric bound.

Before you report a shuffled ε, check the assumptions below. If one fails, for example if the order leaks, only ε_0 remains.

- The order is uniformly random and hidden, with no metadata such as arrival time or network address.
- The shuffler does not collude with the analyst.
- Only honest users count in the number of users n, because colluders reveal their reports to the analyst.
- The count of users is the number of reports shuffled, so with several batches it is the size of the smallest batch.
- Each user sends one report per batch, or the reports compose like any other releases.

34.4. What goes wrong

Shortcuts fail when users are few or ε_0 is large. For 1,000 users at $\varepsilon_0 = 4$, a normal approximation of the count of 1-reports gives 0.9667 against the exact 1.6910.

In amplification by iteration, later training noise protects earlier records. It covers one pass of noisy stochastic gradient descent (SGD) that keeps the weights in a fixed convex set (Feldman et al. 2018). It has two conditions. You can release only the final model, and every step must be a contraction, which never moves two sets of weights further apart. That needs a convex, smooth loss and a small enough step.

Even then the gain depends on the record. Over 10,000 records with noise multiplier 1, the middle record gets $\varepsilon = 0.0707$ at $\delta = 10^{-5}$. But the last record gets 5.2985, the cost of one Gaussian step, so report the worst record's value.

Deep learning breaks both conditions. Checkpoints, logged models and a best checkpoint chosen from several all release more than the final model. Steps on a non-convex loss are not contractions, and Annamalai (2024) builds a loss whose final model leaks as much as all the intermediate models. So claim amplification by iteration only for convex models, such as logistic regression, that release only their final weights.

34.5. References

- Feldman, McMillan & Talwar, “Hiding Among the Clones” (FOCS 2021): the clone bound and how to compute it.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition’s chapter.

Part V.

Differential privacy in machine learning

This part is for anyone who trains, ships or reviews a model under differential privacy (DP). It builds on the Gaussian mechanism and composition from Part 3 and an accountant from Part 4. Its audits reuse the membership-inference attacks of Part 2.

Every private training method has two halves. The privacy half, the guarantee ε, is computed by an accountant, while the utility half, accuracy, can only be measured. The main private algorithm is stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with clipped per-example gradients and Gaussian noise, called DP-SGD. Its accountant needs just three settings: the noise multiplier, the sampling rate and the number of steps. So every page asks whether the ε is correct and whether the accuracy at that ε is good enough.

Three pages are workflows, each a whole job done with real libraries on public data. Train a model with DP-SGD trains a classifier on the Adult census data with Opacus. Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA adapts a small public language model to a private text and checks it for memorized secrets. Release and governance recomputes the guarantee, writes it down, maps it to the law and lists what to check before a model ships.

The other pages explain the decisions those jobs make, in the order a project meets them. A short page on private empirical risk minimization for convex models leads to DP-SGD. Then come hyperparameter tuning, the privacy unit in User-level differential privacy and the budget in Choosing ε. Public data and private fine-tuning explains why a public starting model helps so much. Disparate impact and Auditing private training are the checks before release. Three reference pages cover rarer methods: private prediction, correlated noise across steps and adaptive data analysis.

Every number on these pages comes from a script you can run.

35. Private empirical risk minimization

35.1. What it is

Most of machine learning is **empirical risk minimization (ERM)**, which picks the weights θ with the least average loss over a training set. Write D for that set and n for its number of records. A ridge penalty usually keeps the weights small. Its strength is a number λ, and training minimizes

$$\mathcal{L}(\theta; D) = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^{n} \ell(\theta; z_i) + \frac{\lambda}{2} \|\theta\|^2, \tag{35.1}$$

where $\ell(\theta; z)$ is the loss of the weights on one record z. Differential privacy (DP) asks that replacing one record barely change the released weights, so noise must enter the trained weights, the objective or each gradient step.

Output perturbation trains as usual and adds Gaussian noise to the final weights, with a small slack δ. The noise is scaled to the most that the trained weights θ^* can move between datasets D and D' that differ in one record. For a convex loss, the ridge limits that move to

$$\|\theta^*(D) - \theta^*(D')\| \le \frac{2L}{\lambda n}. \tag{35.2}$$

Here the constant L bounds the length of each record's loss gradient. It is 1 for logistic regression with labels ± 1 and features of length at most 1.

Objective perturbation adds a random linear term to the objective and minimizes the result exactly. Part of the privacy budget ε pays for the loss's curvature, which is at most a constant c, one quarter for the logistic loss. The noise is scaled to what is left,

$$\varepsilon' = \varepsilon - 2 \ln \Big(1 + \frac{c}{n\lambda} \Big). \tag{35.3}$$

The subtracted term grows as $n\lambda$ shrinks, so with little data the ridge must grow to keep ε' positive.

Gradient perturbation adds noise to every gradient step instead. With random batches and clipped per-record gradients, it becomes noisy stochastic gradient descent (SGD), DP-SGD, the only option for a model that is not convex.

35.2. When you meet it

You meet these methods for linear models, such as a linear probe on features from a public pretrained network (Public data and private fine-tuning). Objective perturbation is usually the

most accurate, because the objective's full curvature damps its noise, while only the ridge damps output perturbation's. So use output perturbation only when training is a black box.

Whether you have enough data depends on n and ε. On the training objective they matter only through their product, so halving ε costs as much as halving the data. On new data, with d features, privacy adds less error than sampling does once n is well above $d\ln(1/\delta)/\varepsilon^2$.

35.3. How to use it

IBM's diffprivlib offers objective perturbation as `LogisticRegression(epsilon=..., data_norm=...)`, with `data_norm` bounding each row's length. Its version 0.6.6 fails with scikit-learn 1.8, so the snippet calls the mechanism it wraps, `mechanisms.Vector`, with the curvature bound c as `function_sensitivity`. The breast-cancer data has no public data dictionary for feature bounds. So the snippet treats 500 rows as private and 69 as a public stand-in. It clips the private rows to the stand-in's log-transformed ranges and maps them to $[-1, 1]$. A constant 1 replaces the intercept, and dividing by $\sqrt{31}$ keeps each row's length at most 1.

```
import numpy as np
from diffprivlib.mechanisms import Vector
from scipy.optimize import minimize
from sklearn.datasets import load_breast_cancer
data = load_breast_cancer()
public, private = np.log1p(data.data[:69]), np.log1p(data.data[69:])  # 69 stand-in rows fix
lo, hi = public.min(axis=0), public.max(axis=0)
X = np.hstack([2 * (np.clip(private, lo, hi) - lo) / (hi - lo) - 1, np.ones((500, 1))]) / np
y = 2 * data.target[69:] - 1
Xt, yt, n = X[::2], y[::2], 250  # even rows train, odd rows test
lam = 1 / n  # diffprivlib's default ridge, fixed in advance

def objective(w):  # J(w) and its gradient
    m = yt * (Xt @ w)
    return np.logaddexp(0, -m).mean() + lam / 2 * w @ w, lam * w - Xt.T @ (yt / (1 + np.exp(

def accuracy(eps, seed):  # eps = inf adds no noise
    vector = Vector(epsilon=eps, function_sensitivity=0.25, dimension=31, alpha=n * lam, n=n
    w = minimize(vector.randomise(objective), np.zeros(31), jac=True, options={"gtol": 1e-9}
    return np.mean(np.sign(X[1::2] @ w) == y[1::2])

print(" ".join(f"{np.mean([accuracy(e, s) for s in range(20)]):.3f}" for e in [1, 4, np.inf]
```

Averaged over 20 noise draws, test accuracy is 0.783 at $\varepsilon = 1$ and 0.946 at $\varepsilon = 4$, against 0.964 without noise. So with only 250 training records, accuracy comes close only at $\varepsilon = 4$. Nothing was tuned on the private rows, so the guarantee is pure DP for the 250 training rows, against replacing one record. The 69 stand-in rows get none.

35.4. What goes wrong

The most common failure is a bound taken from the data. Left unset, `data_norm` is computed from the training rows with a `PrivacyLeakWarning`, and the guarantee is gone. A range table computed from the same rows is no better, because each minimum and maximum is one record's value. So take every bound from public knowledge or public rows, and clip the private rows to it.

The second failure is the solver, because output and objective perturbation assume the exact minimizer. A solver that stops where the gradient still has length g adds $2g/\lambda$ to the sensitivity. That is small beside the exact sensitivity $2L/(\lambda n)$ only when g is well below L/n. So set the tolerance there, and check the final gradient rather than the number of steps.

The third failure is an unpenalized weight, because the sensitivity bound needs the ridge's curvature in every direction. Scikit-learn's loss, which diffprivlib reuses, leaves the intercept out of the ridge, so the snippet adds a constant feature. Fix λ by a rule or on public data, since tuning it on private data is a search that must be paid for (Hyperparameter tuning). Finally, these guarantees assume replaced records, unlike the add/remove accountants of later chapters, and the two do not convert freely. So state the relation next to every ε.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

36. DP-SGD

36.1. Why this matters

Nearly every deep-learning system that satisfies differential privacy (DP) runs one algorithm. It is stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with clipped per-record gradients and Gaussian noise at every step, called DP-SGD (Abadi et al. 2016). Clipping limits how far one record moves the model at each step, and the noise hides that move. An **accountant** adds up the cost of the steps into the guarantee's ε, with a small additive slack δ.

The accountant sees only the noise, the sampling rate (the chance that a record joins a batch) and the number of steps, never the model. So those three decide ε, and you can tune the clipping norm and learning rate for accuracy alone. Most failures come from code that breaks an assumption of the privacy proof, so the checks matter as much as the settings. Train a model with DP-SGD does the whole job in Opacus.

36.2. The algorithm and its guarantee

A training set holds n records. The gradient of one record's loss is its **per-example gradient**, written g_i for record i. Each step of DP-SGD does five things.

1. Sample a batch. Each record enters independently with probability q, the **sampling rate**, which is called Poisson sampling.
2. Compute the per-example gradient of each record in the batch.
3. Clip each gradient longer than the **clipping norm** C to length C.
4. Sum the clipped gradients, and add Gaussian noise with standard deviation σC to each coordinate, where the **noise multiplier** σ measures the noise in units of C.
5. Divide the noisy sum by the expected batch size $B = qn$, a fixed public number, and step against it, scaled by the **learning rate** η.

Write θ_t for the weights at step t and S_t for its batch. With Gaussian noise ξ_t drawn afresh on each coordinate, the update is

$$\theta_{t+1} = \theta_t - \frac{\eta}{B}\Big(\sum_{i \in S_t} g_i \min\Big(1, \frac{C}{\|g_i\|}\Big) + \xi_t \Big), \qquad \xi_t \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2 C^2 I). \tag{36.1}$$

Releasing every intermediate set of weights then satisfies (ε, δ)-DP for **add/remove neighbours**, datasets that differ by one record (Amplification by subsampling).

This part's running example (Section 36.7) is the run of Train a model with DP-SGD. A network with one hidden layer of 64 units learns from 30,000 people of the Adult census survey whether a person's income exceeds \$50K. It runs 300 steps with $\sigma = 0.973$, and each person joins a batch

with probability $q = 1/30$, so a batch holds about 1,000 people. At the $\delta = 10^{-5}$ of the book's rule (How small δ must be), the accountant Opacus uses gives $\varepsilon = 3.99$ for this run. The Rényi differential privacy (RDP) accountant, a standard and slightly loose upper bound, gives 4.50. To pick σ for a target ε, let the accountant you will report solve for it (Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run).

36.3. The implementation checklist

The guarantee rests on four properties of your code. Code that breaks one still trains and reports as before.

First, one record must move the clipped sum by at most C. Batch normalization breaks this, because its statistics let one record change every other record's gradient. So private models use group or layer normalization, which works on each record alone. With `strict=False`, Opacus's validator lists the layers to replace instead of raising an error.

```
from opacus.validators import ModuleValidator
from torchvision.models import resnet18

model = resnet18(weights=None)
print(len(ModuleValidator.validate(model, strict=False)))  # 20
model = ModuleValidator.fix(model)
print(len(ModuleValidator.validate(model, strict=False)))  # 0
```

Also fix C in advance, from public data or a private estimate. A C read off the current batch makes the noise depend on the data.

Second, the accountant must assume the sampler the code actually runs (Amplification by subsampling). The Poisson accountant's saving comes from each record's chance of being left out of a batch. A loader that shuffles once per epoch and cuts fixed batches puts every record in exactly one batch per epoch. That chance is then gone, and the true ε can be far above the Poisson number.

Fixed-size batches drawn afresh at every step can still use a Poisson accountant, at the batch's share of the data and half your noise multiplier. The noise counts as halved because a record that enters a fixed-size batch pushes another out, so the sum can move by $2C$. This raises the running example's ε from 3.98 to 23.03, both from `dp_accounting`'s numerical accountant, and it holds only for add/remove neighbours.

Third, divide the noisy sum by the public number B, never by the actual batch size. The actual size is one larger when the protected record is drawn, so dividing by it reveals whether it was.

Fourth, the accountant must count every step that touched the data, including those of runs discarded in tuning.

Beyond the proof, state the neighbouring relation next to every ε, and make data-dependent preprocessing private too. A person with many records needs user-level privacy. For a model you release, turn on Opacus's `secure_mode=True`, because floating-point sampling is not the exact Gaussian noise of the proof (Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms).

36.4. Clipping and the learning rate

Clipping must happen per record. PyTorch's `torch.nn.utils.clip_grad_norm_` clips a whole batch's gradient, which bounds no single record and so gives no privacy at any threshold.

The clipping norm C does not change ε, but it costs accuracy either way. A small C clips more gradients, so records with large gradients count for less, and they are often rare records (Disparate impact). A large C means more noise, since the noise is σC.

When every gradient is clipped, each has length exactly C and the noise is proportional to C too. So the step depends only on the product ηC of the learning rate and the clipping norm. Clip hard, and tune that one number. On the running example at $\varepsilon = 4$, holding ηC at 2 keeps test accuracy between 0.8446 and 0.8464 for every C from 0.1 to 10. Holding η at 2 instead, $C = 10$ drops it to 0.7869.

Noise and clipping also move the best learning rate. Noise lowers it (Optimization in the full edition), while clipping raises it, because clipped gradients are shorter. The two do not cancel predictably, so search the step again whenever σ or C changes, and count the search's runs in ε.

Gradient norms also drift. The running example's median per-example norm, measured on public rows, falls from 1.444 to 0.044 in its 300 steps. So $C = 1$ clips every row at the start and only a quarter of them at the end. Adaptive clipping moves C toward a quantile of the norms, measured by a small private count, and Opacus offers it with `clipping="adaptive"`. The count spends part of the budget, so the gradient gets more noise at the same σ.

36.5. Batch size at a fixed budget

Averaging the noisy sum over B records divides the added noise by B, so larger batches dilute it. At a fixed budget and number of epochs, a larger batch also means fewer steps. So the noise multiplier must rise to keep ε, but more slowly than B does. For a small sampling rate q and a σ well above 1, the accountant's cost over a fixed number of epochs depends on q/σ^2. So σ only has to grow like $\sqrt{q}$. Since $q = B/n$, with n the number of records, the noise on the averaged gradient falls with the batch size,

$$\sigma \propto \sqrt{\frac{B}{n}}, \qquad \frac{\sigma C}{B} \propto \frac{C}{\sqrt{Bn}}. \tag{36.2}$$

So choose the largest batch your hardware allows, with a larger learning rate for the fewer steps. When it does not fit in memory, Opacus's `BatchMemoryManager` splits the sampled batch into physical batches that fit, and still steps once per sampled batch.

36.6. Making it fast

Computed one record at a time, DP-SGD can run tens or hundreds of times slower than ordinary training. Two fixes cost no accuracy. Vectorized per-example gradients, from `torch.func.vmap` or Opacus's hooks, compute the same clipped sum in parallel. **Ghost clipping** also saves memory,

because it gets each record's gradient norm from each layer's inputs and errors without the gradient itself. Opacus turns it on with `grad_sample_mode="ghost"`.

The third fix, microbatching, costs accuracy. It clips the average gradient of each group of m records. One record can change its group's clipped average by up to $2C$, so the noise doubles. The update then averages over B/m groups rather than B records, so the noise on each coordinate of the averaged update becomes

$$2m \cdot \frac{\sigma C}{B}. \tag{36.3}$$

On the running example at $\sigma = 0.973$, groups of 4 cut test accuracy from 0.8444 to 0.8206, more than a quarter of the way down to always predicting the larger class. So use microbatching only as a last resort.

36.7. What privacy costs in accuracy

Table 36.1 trains the running example at five budgets with $C = 1$ and $\eta = 2$, ten times the best non-private learning rate on public data, and scores it on the 16,842 test rows. Always predicting the larger class, an income of at most \$50K, scores 0.759.

Table 36.1.: Test accuracy of the running example under DP-SGD at five budgets, with $\delta = 10^{-5}$ and Opacus's accountant.

	Noise multiplier	Test accuracy (mean ± standard deviation over 3 runs)
$\varepsilon = 0.25$	8.125	0.7933 ± 0.0200
$\varepsilon = 1$	2.383	0.8406 ± 0.0023
$\varepsilon = 2$	1.431	0.8440 ± 0.0014
$\varepsilon = 4$	0.973	0.8447 ± 0.0010
$\varepsilon = 8$	0.722	0.8452 ± 0.0012
Clipped, no noise	0	0.8454 ± 0.0005
Non-private SGD	—	0.8449 ± 0.0029

Clipping without noise scores as well as non-private SGD here, so the whole loss comes from the noise, and it grows steeply as ε shrinks. Going from $\varepsilon = 8$ to 1 costs half a point, while going from 1 to 0.25 costs almost 5, and the spread between runs grows eightfold. The noise grows in total length with the square root of the number of trained weights, while the clipped signal stays at most C, so a smaller model or public pretraining often helps.

36.8. Cheat sheet

Table 36.2.: DP-SGD starting settings and checks.

Setting	Start with	Check
δ	The book's rule	n counts people
Batch size	256 to 4,096, as large as fits	Noise on the average is $\sigma C/B$
Epochs	Fixed before calibrating; Adult uses 10	σ recomputed if they change
Noise multiplier	From the accountant you report	A second accountant gives the same ε
Clipping norm	1, or the median norm on public data	Per record, never `clip_grad_norm_`
Optimizer, learning rate	SGD with momentum 0.9; several times the non-private learning rate (ten on Adult), chosen on public data	Retuned when σ or C changes
Sampler	Poisson	Fixed-size batches: account at $\sigma/2$ (add/remove only)
Report	ε, δ, neighbours, accountant	Every run counted

Rules of thumb

- Fix ε, δ and the number of epochs first, since they are the contract. Then choose the batch, let the accountant set σ, and tune the learning rate last.
- Find the ε below which accuracy collapses on your task before you promise a budget.

36.9. References

- Abadi et al., "Deep Learning with Differential Privacy" (CCS 2016): DP-SGD and the moments accountant.
- Ponomareva et al., "How to DP-fy ML: A Practical Guide to Machine Learning with Differential Privacy" (JAIR 2023): what to clip, how to tune and what to report.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

37. Train a model with DP-SGD

37.1. Why this matters

You have a PyTorch training loop on sensitive data, and it must become private. The algorithm is stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with differential privacy (DP), called DP-SGD, which clips each record's gradient and adds noise at every step (DP-SGD). Opacus does it with one call that wraps the model. The hard part is the decisions around that call. A mistake in one of them leaves code that trains as before but reports a false privacy level ε.

This chapter trains on Adult, a census survey of 48,842 people from the UCI Machine Learning Repository, to predict whether a person earns more than $50,000 a year. Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run plans the privacy side of this run, and this chapter keeps training, tuning and utility. The script practitioner_dp_sgd.py runs every step except tuning, which practitioner_tuning.py does. Each runs in one to two minutes without a GPU.

```
uv run python code/part05-dp-ml/practitioner_dp_sgd.py
uv run python code/part05-dp-ml/practitioner_tuning.py
```

37.2. Fix the privacy unit, n and δ

The guarantee protects exactly one record, so first decide what a record is (User-level differential privacy). Adult has no person identifier, so one row counts as one person because of how the survey was collected. When your data has an identifier, count distinct identifiers, not rows.

The script splits the rows with seed 0 into 30,000 private training rows and 16,842 test rows. The other 2,000, the stand-in rows from here on, play the part of public data. The script chooses settings on them but never trains on them. They come from the same survey, so this is an assumption for the demonstration. In production the role belongs to public data, and without any, tuning costs privacy (Section 37.10).

The slack δ depends on the number of people n in the training set, not in the whole dataset. The book's rule (How small δ must be) gives $\delta = 10^{-5}$ for $n = 30{,}000$.

37.3. Preprocess from public facts

Every statistic computed from the private rows is a release that the accountant does not count. A scaler fitted on the training set leaks each column's mean and spread. An encoder fitted on it leaks which categories occur, even a country that only one person comes from. So the script takes its category lists from the dataset's documentation, and scales each number by bounds the

survey publishes, such as ages from 17 to 90. Capital gains and losses go on a log scale first, and a missing value becomes its own category.

```
def features(rows: pl.DataFrame) -> Array:
    """One-hot categories from the documented lists, numbers scaled by public bounds."""
    rows = rows.with_columns(pl.col("capital-gain", "capital-loss").log1p())
    numeric = [
        np.clip((rows[name].to_numpy() - low) / (high - low), 0.0, 1.0) for name, (low, high
    ]
    encoder = OneHotEncoder(categories=list(CATEGORIES.values()), sparse_output=False)
    text = rows.select(pl.col(list(CATEGORIES)).fill_null("?")).to_numpy()
    encoder.fit(text[:1])  # the categories are given, so fitting learns nothing from the ro
    return np.hstack([np.column_stack(numeric), encoder.transform(text)])
```

This gives 91 features for a network with one hidden layer of 64 units and 6,018 weights. To check this step in other code, find every `fit` call and ask what data it sees.

37.4. Train the baselines

A private accuracy means little on its own, so train three baselines with the same model, batch size, epochs and optimizer. The non-private model shows the best you can expect. A model with clipping and no noise separates the cost of clipping from the cost of noise. The majority class shows the floor, where a collapsed private model lands.

```
non-private: test accuracy 0.847
clip only (C=1, no noise): test accuracy 0.845
always '<=50K': test accuracy 0.759
```

Clipping alone costs little here. If clip-only accuracy were far below non-private, no budget would fix it, because the problem would be the clipping norm or the learning rate.

37.5. Check the model

Opacus computes one gradient per record, and some layers break that. Batch normalization is the common case, because its statistics let one record change every other record's gradient. The validator lists such layers before you train.

```
errors = ModuleValidator.validate(model, strict=False)
print(f"validator errors: {len(errors)}")
```

Here it finds none. For a model with such layers, `ModuleValidator.fix` replaces batch normalization with group normalization (DP-SGD shows it on a ResNet).

37.6. Choose the clipping norm, batch and epochs

Fix these settings before you touch the private data, because choosing them on it costs privacy. The usual guide for the clipping norm C, the length each record's gradient is cut to, is the typical gradient norm on public data. So the script measures it on the stand-in rows.

```
wrapped = GradSampleModule(model)  # adds hooks that keep one gradient per row
wrapped.train()
logits: torch.Tensor = wrapped(split.x)
nn.CrossEntropyLoss()(logits, split.y).backward()  # fills p.grad_sample for every weight p
norms = stacked_norms(wrapped)
```

```
at initialisation: median norm 1.444  90th percentile 1.538
fraction clipped at C=1: 1.000
```

The median rule would give a C of about 1.4. The script keeps the usual default $C = 1$, just below the median, so every gradient is clipped at the start. That costs nothing, because when every gradient is clipped, only the learning rate times C matters (DP-SGD).

Make the batch as large as you can afford. The reason is that the noise on the averaged gradient is $\sigma C/B$, where B is the expected batch size and the noise multiplier σ is the noise's standard deviation in units of C. With $B = 1{,}000$, Opacus sets the sampling rate q, the chance that a row joins a batch, to $1/30 = 0.0333$. Ten epochs then make 300 steps. Fix the epochs now, because the noise is calibrated to them.

The optimizer is SGD with momentum 0.9. The script picks its learning rate on the stand-in rows too. It trains a non-private model on 1,500 of them at six rates and scores each on the other 500.

```
  lr=0.05: 0.814  lr=0.1: 0.816  lr=0.2: 0.826  lr=0.5: 0.792  lr=1: 0.812  lr=2: 0.768
non-private learning rate 0.2; DP-SGD learning rate 2 (x10)
```

DP-SGD then uses ten times the winning rate, a rule of thumb rather than a measurement. Private runs usually need a larger step, because clipped gradients are shorter (DP-SGD). No private row was used, so this choice costs no privacy.

37.7. Calibrate the noise

The target is a privacy level of $\varepsilon = 4$ at the slack $\delta = 10^{-5}$ of Section 37.2. For this q and these epochs, Opacus's `get_noise_multiplier` finds the smallest σ that meets it. With its privacy loss random variable (PRV) accountant it gives $\sigma = 0.973$, and Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run shows the call. That σ holds only for those epochs and that q, so recompute it if you change either.

37.8. Train

The privacy engine wraps the model, the optimizer and the data loader. Its optimizer clips each record's gradient and adds the noise. Its loader draws Poisson batches, in which each row joins each batch independently with probability q, as the accountant assumes. The script's own loader cuts fixed batches, so `make_private` must replace it.

```
engine = PrivacyEngine(accountant="prv")
optimizer = torch.optim.SGD(model.parameters(), lr=lr, momentum=0.9)
model, optimizer, data_loader = engine.make_private(
    module=model,
    optimizer=optimizer,
    data_loader=data_loader,
    noise_multiplier=sigma,
    max_grad_norm=clip,
)  # Poisson sampling is the default: each row joins each batch with probability q
```

The training loop runs inside `BatchMemoryManager`, which splits each logical batch of about 1,000 rows into physical batches of at most 500. The optimizer still steps once per logical batch, so the accounting does not change.

```
with BatchMemoryManager(
    data_loader=data_loader, max_physical_batch_size=PHYSICAL_BATCH, optimizer=optimizer
) as batches:
    for x, y in batches:  # Opacus splits each logical batch; it steps once per logical batc
        optimizer.zero_grad()
        loss = criterion(model(x), y)
        loss.backward()
        optimizer.step()
```

```
steps=300  q=0.0333
epsilon (Opacus PRV) = 3.99
test accuracy at epsilon=4: 0.846
```

The script leaves `secure_mode` off, so that its noise is seeded and its numbers repeat, and its record says so. For a model you release, pass `secure_mode=True` to `PrivacyEngine`. It draws the noise from a secure generator and guards against the floating-point flaws of ordinary Gaussian samples (Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms).

37.9. Cross-check ε

An ε from one library is a claim about that library's arithmetic. So the script recomputes it with Google's `dp_accounting`, whose privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant gives 3.98 against Opacus's 3.99. The looser Rényi differential privacy (RDP) accountant gives 4.50, so a statement must name its accountant. Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run runs this check and says what a disagreement means.

37.10. Tune honestly

This run chose every hyperparameter on a public stand-in, so tuning cost nothing. Without public data, tuning runs on the private rows, and every private run that influences the release costs privacy, the discarded ones too (Hyperparameter tuning).

The tuning script measures that cost for six learning rates at a total ε of 4. A grid runs all six rates and pays for each by composition. A random search runs a Poisson number of models with mean 4, each at a rate drawn from the six, and releases only the best. Only RDP handles a random number of runs, so the script uses it throughout, and its single-run σ is larger than the PRV value above.

```
def random_search(sigma: float) -> dp_accounting.DpEvent:
    """A Poisson number of runs with mean 4 (shape=inf selects the Poisson case); only the b
    return dp_accounting.dp_event.RepeatAndSelectDpEvent(one_run(sigma), mean=MEAN_RUNS, sha


def sigma_for(strategy: Callable[[float], dp_accounting.DpEvent], epsilon: float, delta: flo
    """The smallest noise multiplier per run that keeps the whole strategy within (epsilon,

    The search starts at 0.1 and tries 1 first.
    """
    return dp_accounting.calibrate_dp_mechanism(
        dp_accounting.rdp.RdpAccountant, strategy, epsilon, delta, dp_accounting.LowerEndpoi
    )
```

```
one run, no tuning: sigma=1.029
grid of 6, all runs counted: sigma=1.816
random search, Poisson mean 4 runs: sigma=1.256
naive grid of 6 at sigma=1.029: reports epsilon=4.00
naive grid, true epsilon of all 6 runs = 9.84
```

The naive grid is the common mistake. It trains six models at the single-run noise, reports the ε of one, and actually spends 9.84. The random search costs a modest rise in σ, from 1.029 to 1.256.

With seed 0, the search drew only two runs, both at the learning rate 0.05. So its model reaches only 0.828 on the test set, against 0.846 for the run tuned on public data. Do not redraw until you like the answer, because the guarantee depends on the randomness of the draw. So spend private runs on tuning only when no public data can stand in.

37.11. Measure utility and groups

Train at several budgets with everything else fixed, and compare against the baselines. Fix the released budget beforehand, as the script does with $\varepsilon = 4$, because the script scores these runs on private rows that no ε counts (Choosing ε).

Table 37.1.: Test accuracy on Adult against the privacy budget, with $\delta = 10^{-5}$ and one seed.

Run	Noise multiplier	Test accuracy
Non-private	—	0.847
Clipped, no noise	0	0.845
$\varepsilon = 8$	0.722	0.846
$\varepsilon = 4$	0.973	0.846
$\varepsilon = 2$	1.431	0.845
$\varepsilon = 1$	2.383	0.843
$\varepsilon = 0.25$	8.125	0.793
Always "≤50K"	—	0.759

Privacy costs almost nothing on Adult down to $\varepsilon = 1$. Only at $\varepsilon = 0.25$ does accuracy drop, by about five points, and the other differences are too small to read on one seed.

Adult is easy. Its training set is large, so a batch of 1,000 still has a small sampling rate and divides the noise by 1,000. Its model is small, and the noise's total length grows with the square root of the number of trained weights. So expect a steeper curve with millions of weights trained from scratch, a few thousand records, a rare class or many more epochs. Even here, five points are lost at $\varepsilon = 0.25$ (Table 37.1), and public pretraining is the usual remedy: on the 1,500 public stand-in rows it wins most of them back (Public data and private fine-tuning).

An average can hide a group that pays. So check accuracy by group with exact (Clopper–Pearson) intervals, which stay valid for small groups (Disparate impact).

```
in_group = sex == group
correct, total = int(right[in_group].sum()), int(in_group.sum())
interval = binomtest(correct, total).proportion_ci(confidence_level=0.95, method="exact")
```

```
non-private Female: 0.924 [0.917, 0.931]  (5,186/5,613)
non-private Male: 0.808 [0.800, 0.815]  (9,071/11,229)
DP Female: 0.922 [0.915, 0.929]  (5,177/5,613)
DP Male: 0.807 [0.800, 0.815]  (9,065/11,229)
```

At $\varepsilon = 4$ neither group pays a measurable price, since each private interval almost covers its non-private one. The gap between the groups exists without privacy too, so it is the baseline for the private model.

37.12. When it goes wrong

Table 37.2.: Common DP-SGD failures and their fixes.

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
The validator reports errors	Batch normalization or an unsupported custom layer	`ModuleValidator.fix`, then build the optimizer on the fixed model's weights and retrain the baseline
"Model needs to be in training mode"	A model last used for evaluation	`model.train()` before `make_private`
Out of memory	Per-example gradients for a large physical batch	Lower `max_physical_batch_size`, or use ghost clipping: pass `grad_sample_mode="ghost"` and `criterion=` to `make_private`, which then returns the model, optimizer, loss function and loader, and train with that loss
Ten times slower than usual	Per-example gradients for every weight	Train fewer weights: freeze a public backbone, use adapters
Accuracy near the majority class	Noise too large for the signal	Check $\sigma C/B$; raise the batch, or train fewer epochs so that the accountant needs a smaller σ; start from a public model
ε looks too good	A shuffling loader with `poisson_sampling=False`, uncounted tuning runs, or epochs changed after calibration	Check that the loader is Opacus's `DPDataLoader`, as the record's sampler does; `engine.get_epsilon` and the cross-check report the same ε either way. Recount runs and epochs

Accuracy and privacy fail independently. A run whose ε is wrong usually trains normally, so only the cross-check and the audit of Auditing private training catch it.

37.13. Record the run

A reviewer can only check a claim whose inputs are on record. So the script ends by writing a record of the run. Release and governance lists its fields and turns it into a statement. The script reads the sampler from the loader Opacus returned and `secure_mode` from the engine, so the record cannot claim Poisson sampling that the code did not do.

37.14. Checklist

Table 37.3.: The steps of training with DP-SGD, their defaults and their checks.

Step	Default	Check
Unit, n, δ	Person; δ by the book's rule	n counts people in the training set
Preprocessing	Public categories and bounds	No `fit` on private rows
Baselines	Non-private, clip-only, majority class	Clip-only close to non-private
Model	No batch normalization	`ModuleValidator.validate` returns nothing
Clipping, batch, epochs	C near or below the median norm on public data; large B; epochs fixed	Chosen without private data
Noise and cross-check	As in Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run	Epochs and q match the run
Training	Poisson sampling, `BatchMemoryManager`, `secure_mode=True` for release	The loader is Opacus's
Tuning	On public data; else random search with a Poisson number of runs	Every private run counted
Utility and groups	Several budgets; per-group exact intervals	Compared with the baselines
Record	Every parameter and version written	ε recomputable from it

37.15. References

- Ponomareva et al., "How to DP-fy ML: A Practical Guide to Machine Learning with Differential Privacy" (JAIR 2023): the decisions of this chapter, with what to report.
- The Opacus documentation and tutorials (opacus.ai): the privacy engine, `BatchMemoryManager`, ghost clipping and the validator.

Derivations. This workflow draws on the full edition's chapters on DP-SGD in the full edition, hyperparameter tuning in the full edition, disparate impact in the full edition and choosing ε in the full edition.

38. Hyperparameter tuning and private selection

38.1. Why this matters

Stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with clipped gradients and Gaussian noise satisfies differential privacy (DP) at the level its accountant reports for one run. It is called DP-SGD. But nobody trains once. You try several learning rates, score each model and ship the best, and every run and every score touched private data. So the privacy level ε you report must pay for the search too.

Releasing only the best of a fixed number of runs can cost as much as releasing all of them. On the Adult census data, a grid of six runs that each meet $\varepsilon = 4$ really costs 9.84. If instead you draw the *number* of runs at random, from a distribution fixed in advance, the whole search costs little more than one run.

38.2. The procedure and the report

The cheapest tuning is the tuning you don't do on private data. Runs on public or proxy data cost nothing, and neither do published settings for similar tasks. Fix a large batch, the number of epochs and a small clipping norm in advance. With the clipping norm below the typical gradient norm, only its product with the learning rate matters, so often only that product needs a search (DP-SGD).

If you must tune on private data, fix the search before you touch the data. Write down the candidate set, the distribution of the number of runs (Section 38.4), the score, which must be private too (Section 38.5), and the validation set. Trying "a few more" later, or restarting a disappointing search, makes the search depend on the data, which no accountant covers.

Then account for the whole search. For two or three candidates, charge for every run (Section 38.3), and for more, use random search with a random number of runs (Section 38.4). Either way, count every run that touched the private data, including crashed and debugging runs and evaluations for early stopping.

Finally, log the candidate set, the drawn number of runs and each run's settings and score, and report two numbers. The ε of the released run says what the model alone would leak if its hyperparameters had been public. The ε of the whole procedure is what the release guarantees, and an audit cannot check it, because an audit tests only the released model. With the slack $\delta = 10^{-5}$ that the book's rule gives for 30,000 records (How small δ must be), the Adult search of Section 38.6 reports as follows.

> DP-SGD ran for 300 steps with Poisson sampling at rate 1/30. It clipped gradients to norm 1 and added noise with multiplier 1.256, so one run satisfies $(2.73, 10^{-5})$-DP. The learning rate was chosen by random search over $\{0.05, 0.1, 0.2, 0.5, 1, 2\}$. The

number of runs was drawn from a Poisson distribution with mean 4, and each run was scored on 2,000 validation records treated as public. The whole procedure satisfies $(4.00, 10^{-5})$-DP for add/remove neighbours, datasets that differ by one record. It was computed with `dp_accounting` from the Rényi bound of Papernot & Steinke (2022).

38.3. Paying for every run

A common argument says that choosing among eight learning rates reveals at most three bits. It is wrong, because the release is a whole private run, picked because of how it came out. If each run says only "good" or "bad", the best is bad only when every run was bad. So a bad best reveals all of them. Even tuning without privacy and then training once privately leaks. The winning regularization weight can change when you add a few outliers, and so reveal whether they were in the data (Membership inference).

The safe answer is to charge for every run, because the best run is computed from all the runs' outputs (Composition). For DP-SGD, a grid of k runs, each of T steps, costs exactly as much as one run of kT steps. One run of Part 4's running example, 10,000 DP-SGD steps that each sample a record with probability 0.01 at noise multiplier 1, costs $\varepsilon = 6.71$ at $\delta = 10^{-5}$. Ten such runs cost 27.23, about four times one run rather than ten, because the conversion to ε pays its δ cost only once.

38.4. A random number of runs

The way out is to draw the number of runs K at random, independently of the data. A search whose runs all came out bad then most likely drew few runs, which says little about the data. So the whole search costs about one run, plus a term that grows with the logarithm of the expected number of runs. For DP-SGD, use the version of Papernot & Steinke (2022), which works with the Rényi differential privacy (RDP) that DP-SGD's accountants already compute (Rényi DP).

To use it, fix the candidate set and the distribution of K, either Poisson or a truncated negative binomial with a shape parameter ν. That family includes the geometric distribution, $\nu = 1$, which is the **random stopping** of Liu & Talwar, and the logarithmic one, $\nu = 0$. Then draw K, run that many candidates drawn at random from the set, and release the best one by a private score. To get the cost from Google's `dp_accounting`, wrap the event of one run in a `RepeatAndSelectDpEvent`. Give it ν as its `shape` (infinite for Poisson), and compose it in an `RdpAccountant`.

NumPy draws K with `rng.poisson(mean)`, `rng.geometric(1 / mean)` or `rng.logseries(p)`. The last takes p rather than a mean, so solve its mean, $-p/((1-p)\ln(1-p))$, for p.

Table 38.1.: The ε at $\delta = 10^{-5}$ of a search over runs of the running example (one run: 6.71), from the full edition's chapter.

Expected runs	10	100	1,000
Composition	27.23	145.17	1035.93
Poisson	13.67	67.77	302.57

Expected runs	10	100	1,000
Geometric ($\nu = 1$)	11.31	14.32	16.76
Logarithmic ($\nu = 0$)	10.08	11.95	13.46

In Table 38.1, the geometric and logarithmic searches barely grow from 10 to 1,000 runs, while composition grows almost linearly. A smaller ν gives a cheaper bound, but the search also stops after one run more often. The Poisson bound needs runs that are already very private, which a run at $\varepsilon = 6.71$ is not, so here it grows almost like composition. A random number of runs may also miss the best candidate. With eight candidates and a geometric number of runs with mean eight, it never tries the best one with probability 0.4667.

The theorems have three conditions, and each is easy to break. First, each run must draw its candidate independently from a fixed distribution, as random search does. Bayesian optimization picks each candidate from earlier scores, so it is not covered and needs adaptive composition. Second, the number of runs must be drawn independently of the data. Third, the score that ranks the runs must be private and counted in each run's cost.

38.5. Selecting by a noisy validation score

Sometimes the candidates are fixed in advance, such as public pretrained checkpoints, and only the choice among them uses private data. That is a **selection** problem, which Selection solves with the exponential mechanism, a random choice weighted toward high scores. Score each candidate by its number of correct predictions, which one record changes by at most 1, not by an accuracy, which divides by a private set size. The mechanism's shortfall from the best count then grows only with the logarithm of the number of candidates.

For the random-number bounds, add Gaussian noise to each run's count of correct predictions, since an exact validation accuracy leaves the validation records unprotected. With noise of standard deviation 20, one noisy count costs $\varepsilon = 0.182$. If the validation set is disjoint from the training set, each record pays only one of the two costs. So the event for one run is the costlier of its training and its count, not their sum. Otherwise compose both into one event. On the running example the counts are the cheaper, so they add nothing to the total.

38.6. Tuning on Adult

The script practitioner_tuning.py tunes the learning rate of a small network on 30,000 Adult census records, with 300 steps per run. It asks the accountant for the noise multiplier per run that each strategy can afford.

Table 38.2.: Tuning the learning rate on Adult at a total of $\varepsilon = 4$, $\delta = 10^{-5}$, with `dp_accounting`'s RDP accountant.

Strategy	Noise multiplier per run	Total ε
One run, no tuning	1.029	4.00

Strategy	Noise multiplier per run	Total ε
Grid of 6 at the noise of one run, one run's ε reported	1.029	9.84 (reported as 4.00)
Grid of 6, every run counted	1.816	4.00
Random search, Poisson number of runs with mean 4	1.256	4.00

The second row is the reporting bug of Section 38.3. This snippet recomputes it, together with the numbers of the report in Section 38.2.

```
import dp_accounting


def one_run(sigma: float) -> dp_accounting.DpEvent:
    step = dp_accounting.PoissonSampledDpEvent(1 / 30, dp_accounting.GaussianDpEvent(sigma))
    return dp_accounting.SelfComposedDpEvent(step, 300)


def epsilon(event: dp_accounting.DpEvent) -> float:
    return dp_accounting.rdp.RdpAccountant().compose(event).get_epsilon(1e-5)


search = dp_accounting.dp_event.RepeatAndSelectDpEvent(one_run(1.256), mean=4, shape=float("
naive_grid = dp_accounting.SelfComposedDpEvent(one_run(1.029), 6)
print(f"{epsilon(one_run(1.256)):.2f}")  # 2.73
print(f"{epsilon(search):.2f}")  # 4.00
print(f"{epsilon(naive_grid):.2f}")  # 9.84
```

With seed 0, the search drew only two runs, both at the smallest learning rate. So its model reaches only 0.828 on the test set, against 0.846 for the run of Train a model with DP-SGD, tuned for free on public stand-in rows.

38.7. Cheat sheet

Table 38.3.: Which tuning strategy for which search.

Situation	Strategy	Cost
Two or three candidates	Fixed grid, composition	k runs of T steps = one run of kT steps

Situation	Strategy	Cost
Many candidates	Random search; compute Poisson, geometric and logarithmic for your per-run noise and mean, and take the cheapest	Poisson wins only for very private runs; at one run of 6.71, logarithmic is cheapest at every size in Table 38.1, but it stops after one run more often
Fixed candidates	Exponential mechanism on correct counts	Shortfall grows with the log of the candidate count
Trained candidates, disjoint validation set	Exponential mechanism or noisy counts	The larger of training and selection costs

Rules of thumb

- Tune on public or proxy data when you can. Otherwise fix the search before touching the private data, and never extend it.
- Report the whole search's ε, never the selected run's alone.

38.8. References

- Papernot & Steinke, "Hyperparameter Tuning with Renyi Differential Privacy" (ICLR 2022): the Poisson and truncated negative binomial bounds for DP-SGD.
- Liu & Talwar, "Private Selection from Private Candidates" (STOC 2019): random stopping and its bound of three times one run.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

39. User-level differential privacy

39.1. Why this matters

Every differential privacy (DP) guarantee in this part so far protects one record. Stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with clipping and noise, this part's DP-SGD, gives each person of its Adult run a privacy loss ε of 3.98. But a messaging user contributes hundreds of messages, and together a person's records can reveal far more than any one of them.

A DP guarantee protects whatever differs between two neighbouring datasets, so **the neighbouring relation sets the privacy unit**. Adult has no household identifier, so to show what a larger unit costs, this chapter makes one up. It gives the 30,000 training rows to 3,000 households, very unevenly, each household a cluster of similar rows. The median household holds 4 rows and the largest 359. A household is the user of this chapter, and a row its record.

39.2. The privacy unit and δ

Take a mechanism M, and call two datasets neighbours, D and D', when they differ by adding or removing all the records of one user. The mechanism is **user-level** (ε, δ)-DP, with a small slack δ, if every such pair and every set S of outputs satisfy

$$\Pr[M(D) \in S] \leq e^{\varepsilon} \Pr[M(D') \in S] + \delta. \tag{39.1}$$

Example-level DP is the same inequality for datasets that differ in one record. So every property and accountant of Part 4 holds for user-level DP unchanged. What changes is the sensitivity, because one user can move the computation with all of their records at once.

The right unit, such as a record, a user, a household or a device, answers the question "whose participation do I want to hide?". Report it with every ε (Release and governance). The unit also sets the slack, because the book's rule for δ (How small δ must be) now counts users. For 3,000 households it gives 10^{-4} (Section 39.8), so this chapter's 10^{-5} is stricter than it needs to be.

The textbook answer for a person with k records is **group privacy** (Post-processing, group privacy and composition). An example-level (ε, δ)-DP mechanism is also user-level DP for users with at most k records, at level $k\varepsilon$ and with slack

$$\delta_k = \delta \, \frac{e^{k\varepsilon} - 1}{e^{\varepsilon} - 1}. \tag{39.2}$$

The fraction grows like $e^{(k-1)\varepsilon}$, so never read a record-level δ as a user's. To hold a user's slack at 10^{-5}, the per-record δ must be much smaller, and so the per-record ε larger. This chapter accounts with the full edition's Rényi accountant, which puts the Adult run at 4.50 per row. A household with two rows therefore gets $\varepsilon = 12.43$, not twice 4.50, and for ten rows no per-row δ is small enough.

39.3. What an example-level model gives a user

Group privacy treats DP-SGD as a black box, but you know how a user's records enter each step. Each step includes every record independently with the sampling rate q. So it sees some record of a user with k records with probability about kq. While kq is small, two of their records rarely share a batch. So **a user with k records looks like one record sampled at rate kq**. To screen a user's exposure, rerun the record-level accountant at rate kq (Section 39.8). An exact accountant for a user with k records also exists (Charles et al. 2024).

Table 39.1.: The household-level ε at $\delta = 10^{-5}$ of the Adult run's example-level DP-SGD ($q = 1/30$, $\sigma = 0.973$, 300 steps) for a household with k rows, from the full edition's Rényi accountant (4.59 at one record comes from its coarser grid of orders).

Rows of the household k	1	2	5	10	20
Exact user accountant	4.59	10.02	29.96	74.82	202.89
One record at rate kq	4.50	9.25	25.37	57.57	138.67

Ten rows already cost 74.82, which protects nothing. Yet the exact accountant beats group privacy for every user with more than one record, so never use group privacy for DP-SGD.

The rate-kq screen is always low, by 8% at two rows and by 23% at ten. The reason is that it ignores steps that draw several of the household's rows together, and with $q = 1/30$ such steps are common. So report the exact value when you have an implementation. The libraries this book uses offer only the screen, so report its value, say how low it can be, and keep kq small. It is not a pessimistic bound, because a person's similar records do push the gradient partly the same way.

39.4. User-level DP-SGD

The better route makes the user the unit that DP-SGD samples, clips and accounts for (McMahan et al. 2018). Starting from weights chosen without looking at the data, each step does five things.

1. **Sample users.** Put each user in the batch independently with probability q, now the user sampling rate.
2. **Compute one vector per user.** From that user's records alone, compute their average gradient, or the change in weights after a few training steps on their records.
3. **Clip per user.** Rescale that vector to length at most the clipping norm C.
4. **Add noise.** Sum the clipped vectors and add Gaussian noise of standard deviation σC, for a noise multiplier σ.
5. **Step.** Divide by the expected number of sampled users and take a gradient step.

One user moves the sum by at most C, however many records they have. So the guarantee is user-level DP with exactly the accountant of example-level DP-SGD, run at the user sampling rate.

That has two consequences. First, **you pay for having fewer units**. With 300 steps and about 100 units per batch, sampling rows needs $\sigma = 0.581$ for $\varepsilon = 4$. The same batch drawn from ten

times fewer households needs a ten times higher rate, and so $\sigma = 1.03$. Second, **records inside a user are free**, since you can average them, train on them for several steps or subsample them without changing ε.

Carry a user identifier through the pipeline, and split training and test data by user. Opacus clips each row of a batch, so write a data loader that yields users and clip each user's vector yourself. Three things break the guarantee:

1. A user's vector depends on other users' data, for example through normalization statistics computed over all users.
2. One person is spread over several accounts, so the unit is the account and the person is again a group.
3. Users are iterated in a fixed shuffled order instead of Poisson-sampled, which is a different mechanism that this accountant does not cover (Matrix factorization).

39.5. Contribution bounding

A pipeline built around records can still protect users. **Contribution bounding** keeps at most k records of each user, the cap, and runs example-level DP-SGD on what remains. The result is user-level DP with the ε the user accountant gives for k records. The condition is that each user's kept records are chosen without looking at other users' data, for example at random. Otherwise adding one user could change which records other users keep, and neighbours would differ by more than one user's records. To calibrate the noise for a cap, solve for σ with `dp_accounting.calibrate_dp_mechanism` at rate kq (Train a model with DP-SGD).

```
import polars as pl

rows = pl.DataFrame({"user": ["a", "a", "a", "a", "b", "c", "c"], "x": [1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7]
k = 2  # the cap, fixed from public knowledge of the population
capped = rows.sample(fraction=1.0, shuffle=True, seed=0).group_by("user").head(k)
print(capped.height)  # 5
print(capped.group_by("user").len()["len"].max())  # 2
```

Choosing the cap trades noise against bias (Amin et al. 2019). A larger cap keeps more data but needs more noise, while a smaller cap discards records and reweights the data toward light users. On Adult's households at a household-level $\varepsilon = 4$, a cap of fifty rows instead of one multiplies the noise by 4.2, and accuracy falls from 0.8362 to 0.7943.

So take the cap from public knowledge of the population, or choose it privately and count the cost, for example with a private quantile of records per user (Beyond global sensitivity). Trying caps on test accuracy spends privacy that the accountant does not see.

39.6. Heterogeneous users

User-level training also changes the objective. Averaging per user weights users equally, while example-level training weights them by their number of records (Disparate impact). If heavy

users should count for more, sum a user's gradients before clipping. Their influence then rises with their records until clipping caps the sum at C, and ε does not change.

39.7. Which strategy

Table 39.2 compares three routes on Adult's households, each with 300 steps, about 100 units per batch and the learning rate 0.2. That rate is the best of 0.1, 0.2, 0.5 and 1 for route (b) at $\varepsilon = 4$, and also the workflow's non-private rate. Strategy (a) runs example-level DP-SGD on all rows and accounts for the largest household.

Table 39.2.: Test accuracy at the same household-level budget, $\delta = 10^{-5}$, one run each. The non-private model reaches 0.847, and always predicting the larger class 0.759.

Household-level ε	(a) All rows, $k = 359$	(b) Household-level DP-SGD	(c) At most 2 rows per household
1	0.5730	0.8212	0.7929
2	0.6179	0.8374	0.8207
4	0.6431	0.8432	0.8309
8	0.6838	0.8445	0.8348

Keeping the row as the unit fails. Strategy (a) stays below always predicting the larger class, because the largest household forces a noise multiplier between 13.4 and 84.6 on everyone. Household-level DP-SGD is the best at every budget, and its cost is compute, since each step processes all the rows of about 100 households. The cap is the fallback for a pipeline that must stay row-based. How far it trails depends on how rows are spread over households, and here it keeps only 5,394 of the 30,000.

39.8. Code

The rate-kq screen needs only a record-level accountant, such as Google's `dp_accounting`. This snippet screens households with one and two rows, and computes the book's δ for 3,000 households.

```
import math

import dp_accounting


def screen(k: int, q: float = 1 / 30, sigma: float = 0.973, steps: int = 300) -> float:
    """The epsilon of a user with k records, screened as one record sampled at rate k * q."""
    step = dp_accounting.PoissonSampledDpEvent(k * q, dp_accounting.GaussianDpEvent(sigma))
    accountant = dp_accounting.rdp.RdpAccountant()
    accountant.compose(dp_accounting.SelfComposedDpEvent(step, steps))
    return accountant.get_epsilon(1e-5)
```

```
print(f"{screen(1):.2f}")  # 4.50
print(f"{screen(2):.2f}")  # 9.25
print(10 ** math.floor(math.log10(3_000**-1.1)))  # 0.0001
```

Its 9.25 matches the table's screen, but two Rényi accountants with different orders can differ in the last digits, so quote the value you ran and name its accountant. With $k = 1$ and q the user sampling rate, the same code accounts for user-level DP-SGD.

39.9. Cheat sheet

Table 39.3.: Which route to a user-level guarantee.

Situation	Use	What you get
Example-level model already trained	User accountant, or the rate-kq screen	A user's ε grows about linearly in k, then faster for large kq
Records can be grouped by user	User-level DP-SGD	DP-SGD's accountant over users
Pipeline must stay record-based	Contribution bounding with a public cap	User accountant for k records; loses data
Heavy users should count more	Sum before clipping instead of averaging	Same ε, different objective

Rules of thumb

- Name the privacy unit with every ε, and set δ from the number of users.
- Never use group privacy for DP-SGD; screen a user at rate kq instead.

39.10. References

- Charles et al., "Fine-Tuning Large Language Models with User-Level Differential Privacy" (arXiv 2407.07737, 2024): the tight user accountant, and sampling records against sampling users.
- Chua et al., "Mind the Privacy Unit! User-Level Differential Privacy for Language Model Fine-Tuning" (Conference on Language Modeling 2024): contribution bounding against user-level DP-SGD.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

40. Choosing ε

40.1. Why this matters

Every model trained with differential privacy (DP) ships with a privacy budget ε. The chapter on private stochastic gradient descent (SGD), DP-SGD, showed what each budget costs in accuracy. This chapter adds what it means for the people in the data, so that ε is not chosen by habit ("everyone uses 8").

An attacker who wants to know whether a record was used for training runs a membership test. The test catches real members, its true positives, and wrongly flags non-members, its false positives. The budget ε and its small slack δ cap the first rate in terms of the second (The definition of differential privacy). But each training run also has its own curve of the best rates an attacker can reach, usually far below the cap. So compute that curve, read it at the false positive rate of your threat, and set it beside the accuracy each budget buys.

40.2. Justifying a choice

A defensible choice says what the budget protects before it picks the number.

1. **Unit and period.** Say whether one unit is a record, a user or a device, and whether neighbouring datasets differ by adding or removing one unit or by replacing one. Say which runs the budget covers, since every tuning run spends budget too (Hyperparameter tuning).
2. **Threat.** Say whether the concern is membership, reconstruction or attribute inference, and what the attacker knows and sees. This sets the false positive rate at which you read the curve, a low one for an attacker who must rarely accuse a non-member.
3. **Whole guarantee.** Choose δ by the book's rule (Section 40.5), then compute the trade-off curve (Section 40.3) and read it there.
4. **Evidence.** The curve is a theorem about an algorithm, not about your code, so run an audit that could refute it (Auditing private training).
5. **Utility.** Put accuracy against ε next to the risk, and pick the smallest budget past the bend, where accuracy stops improving. Draw it on public or proxy data, because private runs that choose ε are a search whose cost the reported ε leaves out.
6. **Comparison.** Only now compare with deployments (Section 40.6) and with the tiers in the rules of thumb.

Adult, a public census survey, shows step 5 on a real run. Train a model with DP-SGD trains a small network on 30,000 of its people at five budgets, each with $\delta = 10^{-5}$. Table 40.1 sets their test accuracies beside a risk measure from Section 40.3. It is the largest true positive rate (TPR) that any membership test can reach at a false positive rate (FPR) of 10^{-3}.

Table 40.1.: Accuracy and worst-case membership risk on Adult, one seed.

ε	Noise multiplier	Test accuracy	Largest TPR at FPR 10^{-3}
0.25	8.125	0.793	0.0013
1	2.383	0.843	0.0023
2	1.431	0.845	0.0046
4	0.973	0.846	0.0123
8	0.722	0.846	0.0445
Non-private	—	0.847	—

Accuracy rises by five points from $\varepsilon = 0.25$ to 1, then stays within a few thousandths of the non-private model, which is noise on one seed. The risk grows faster with each doubling of the budget, from 0.0023 at $\varepsilon = 1$ to 0.0445 at $\varepsilon = 8$. So on Adult the bend sits at $\varepsilon = 1$, and a budget of 1 or 2 is the defensible choice. The script scored these runs on private rows, so the table only illustrates step 5. A real choice reads it from a public stand-in, and on a harder task, a larger model or a smaller dataset, expect the bend further right.

40.3. The pair and the whole curve

A membership test says "member" or "non-member" about one target record. Its TPR is the chance that it says "member" when the target was in the training set, and its FPR the chance when it was not. Every test against an (ε, δ)-DP mechanism satisfies

$$\mathrm{TPR} \le \min\left\{1,\ e^{\varepsilon}\,\mathrm{FPR} + \delta,\ 1 - e^{-\varepsilon}(1 - \delta - \mathrm{FPR})\right\}. \tag{40.1}$$

The middle term is the one that binds at low FPR, and the last applies the same cap to the members a test misses. Attacks are judged at a low FPR, because an attack that rarely flags a non-member identifies people with confidence (Membership inference). Yet at $\varepsilon = 8$ and an FPR of 10^{-3}, the pair caps the TPR at 0.9997, which constrains almost nothing.

A real training run satisfies DP for a whole range of pairs, one $\delta(\varepsilon)$ for each ε, because its accountant can trade ε for δ. Each pair gives a line, the middle term of Equation 40.1, and every test must stay under all of these lines at once. The best test reaches the lowest line exactly, which is called the **trade-off curve**:

$$\mathrm{TPR}^{*}(\mathrm{FPR}) = \min_{\varepsilon}\left(e^{\varepsilon}\,\mathrm{FPR} + \delta(\varepsilon)\right). \tag{40.2}$$

For DP-SGD, a privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant computes this curve. It can round the privacy loss up or down, and the two curves it gets bracket the true one (Numerical accounting).

Table 40.2 compares the pair with the curve for two of the Adult runs of Table 40.1, each sampled at rate 1/30 for 300 steps.

Table 40.2.: Largest TPR of a membership test against two Adult runs at $\delta = 10^{-5}$, from the pair and from the curve.

ε	Noise multiplier	Pair, FPR 10^{-3}	Curve, FPR 10^{-3}	Curve, FPR 10^{-2}
4	0.973	0.05461	[0.01221, 0.01234]	[0.06447, 0.06515]
8	0.722	0.9997	[0.04414, 0.04452]	[0.155, 0.1563]

So a budget of 8 means little as a bare pair, while its curve caps the TPR at 0.0445 at an FPR of 10^{-3}.

To compute the curve with Google's `dp_accounting`, build the run's PLD, ask it for δ on a grid of ε, and take the lowest line. The snippet's first print is the upper end of a bracket in Table 40.2, and its second gives the last column of Table 40.1.

```
import numpy as np
from dp_accounting.pld import privacy_loss_distribution as pld

EPS_GRID = np.linspace(0.0, 20.0, 2001)


def tpr_at(sigma: float, q: float, steps: int, fpr: float) -> float:
    run = pld.from_gaussian_mechanism(sigma, sampling_prob=q).self_compose(steps)
    deltas = np.array(run.get_delta_for_epsilon(EPS_GRID))
    return float(np.min(np.exp(EPS_GRID) * fpr + deltas))


print(f"{tpr_at(0.722, 1 / 30, 300, 1e-2):.4f}")  # 0.1563
adult = [tpr_at(sigma, 1 / 30, 300, 1e-3) for sigma in (8.125, 2.383, 1.431, 0.973, 0.722)]
print(" ".join(f"{tpr:.4f}" for tpr in adult))  # 0.0013 0.0023 0.0046 0.0123 0.0445
```

The library's default PLD rounds the loss up, so its curve is a valid upper bound. A Rényi differential privacy (RDP) accountant gives a valid but looser curve. The Gaussian differential privacy (GDP) approximation is quick but not a bound, so use it to explain and the PLD to certify.

The curve is a worst case, for an attacker who sees every intermediate model, so a typical record attacked through the final model alone is much safer. The curve bounds reconstruction too, since a guess among m equally likely records is a membership test at an FPR of $1/m$ (Reconstruction attacks).

40.4. What an attacker can believe

Most people ask how sure an attacker can become that a person was in the data. Write p for the attacker's **prior**, its probability of "member" before it sees the model. A privacy loss of at most ε

means that no output is more than e^{ε} times as likely with the person's record as without it. So the attacker's belief afterwards is at most

$$\Pr[\text{member} \mid \text{output}] \le \frac{p\, e^{\varepsilon}}{p\, e^{\varepsilon} + 1 - p}. \tag{40.3}$$

So DP bounds the change of belief, not the belief itself.

For example, an attacker who starts at 1% can end at 35.55% when $\varepsilon = 4$. That is for the worst output, and in DP-SGD the privacy loss of the released model is usually far below ε.

Base rates matter as much as the loss. An attacker who accuses every person its test flags as a member is right with probability

$$\Pr[\text{member} \mid \text{flag}] = \frac{p\,\mathrm{TPR}}{p\,\mathrm{TPR} + (1-p)\,\mathrm{FPR}}. \tag{40.4}$$

Take the Adult run at $\varepsilon = 8$ and an attacker with a 1% prior who flags at an FPR of 10^{-2}. The curve caps its TPR there at 0.1563 (Table 40.2), so at most 0.1363 of its flags are right, and more than six out of seven are false. An insider with a prior of 0.5 would be right far more often, so a statement about beliefs must name the attacker.

40.5. How small δ must be

For n privacy units, the book's rule sets $\delta \le 1/n^{1.1}$, rounded down to a power of ten (How small δ must be). The units are people when one person has many records (User-level differential privacy). For Adult's 30,000 people it gives 10^{-5}. That is not far below $1/n$, as always when n is just above a power of ten. NIST SP 800-226, the US guidelines for evaluating DP claims, calls a δ above 10^{-5} suspicious unless justified.

For DP-SGD a smaller δ is cheap. Take the Adult run at $\varepsilon = 4$. When δ falls to 10^{-8}, the PLD accountant puts it at only 5.763. So report ε at a second, smaller δ too, and never quote a δ as large as one over the number of units.

40.6. Comparing with deployed values

"Industry uses ε between 1 and 10" hides what every ε needs, its **privacy unit** and the **period** over which it is spent. The Census Bureau's 2020 redistricting data used zero-concentrated differential privacy (zCDP), which states the guarantee as one number, written ρ, that converts to (ε, δ) pairs. Its unit was one person's record under the replace-one relation, and persons got $\rho = 2.56$, reported as $\varepsilon = 17.14$ at $\delta = 10^{-10}$.

So before you compare, convert both budgets to the same unit, neighbouring relation and δ. A zCDP parameter ρ converts to a pair by

$$\varepsilon = \rho + 2\sqrt{\rho \ln(1/\delta)}. \tag{40.5}$$

For the Census figures this formula gives 17.92, and the Bureau's 17.14 comes from a tighter conversion. Since a replacement is a removal followed by an addition, an add/remove guarantee

(ε, δ) implies only the replace-one guarantee $(2\varepsilon, (1 + e^{\varepsilon})\delta)$ (The definition of differential privacy). And a budget stated per day adds up over time by composition, to 365 a year at $\varepsilon = 1$ per day.

So it would be wrong to call the Adult run at $\varepsilon = 8$ "less than half the Census budget". At the Census's $\delta = 10^{-10}$ it is at 13.812, and under the Census's replace-one relation that can double.

40.7. Cheat sheet

Table 40.3.: Which tool answers which question when choosing ε.

Question	Tool	Notes
What does DP-SGD allow?	The trade-off curve, Equation 40.2	Certify with the PLD, not with GDP
How sure can an attacker become?	Equation 40.3 and Equation 40.4	Name the prior; base rates dominate
How small a δ?	The book's rule, Section 40.5	n counts privacy units
Comparing with a deployment?	Equation 40.5; replace-one doubles ε	Same unit and δ

Rules of thumb

- A budget of at most 1 is strong for any mechanism. A budget between 1 and 10 needs DP-SGD's curve as justification, and a budget above 10 needs the curve and an audit (Ponomareva et al. 2023).
- Never quote ε without its unit, δ and period.

40.8. References

- Near, Darais, Lefkovitz & Howarth, *Guidelines for Evaluating Differential Privacy Guarantees* (NIST SP 800-226, 2025): privacy units, δ, and the hazards of large budgets.
- Ponomareva et al., "How to DP-fy ML: A Practical Guide to Machine Learning with Differential Privacy" (JAIR 2023): tiers and reporting.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

41. Public data and private fine-tuning

41.1. Why this matters

The differential privacy (DP) version of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), DP-SGD, loses much accuracy when it trains a model from random weights, most at a privacy loss ε of 1 or below. The most accurate private models avoid this. They start from a model **pretrained** without privacy on a large public dataset, and only **fine-tune** it privately on the sensitive data (Tramèr & Boneh 2021).

Fine-tuning only a small part of the model often helps further. DP-SGD adds noise to every weight it trains, while the useful signal does not grow with their number, so fewer weights mean less noise for the same signal. The workflow Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA does the job end to end.

41.2. How many weights to train

Which weights you train leaves ε unchanged, because DP-SGD's guarantee needs only that one record moves the clipped sum by at most the clipping norm C. The choice changes only how much noise lands on the model. Anything else computed only from public data is also free, if no choice in it looked at the private data. Examples are the starting weights, a tokenizer and normalization statistics.

The noise grows with the number d of trainable weights. Write σ for the noise multiplier and B for the expected batch size, expected because DP-SGD's Poisson sampling draws batches of random size. Then the noise on the averaged gradient has length about

$$\text{noise length} \approx \frac{\sigma C \sqrt{d}}{B}. \tag{41.1}$$

The signal, the average clipped gradient, is at most C long whatever d is. When fewer weights train it loses the frozen weights' part of the gradient, though clipping then cuts the rest less.

Take the running example of DP-SGD, the Adult network with 6,018 weights. Pretrain it without privacy on the 1,500 public stand-in rows of Train a model with DP-SGD, then fine-tune it on the 30,000 private rows. At $\varepsilon = 1$ and the pretrained weights, the noise is 1.6 times longer than the signal when all weights train. It is only 0.4 times as long when the 130 weights of the last layer train. That gap is narrower than the formula's factor of 6.8, because the signal is shorter when only the last layer trains (0.0726 against 0.1137).

But counting weights overstates the cost of training them all. Noise does harm only along the directions in which the loss is curved, because a step along a flat direction barely changes the loss. Near a pretrained model, few directions are curved (Li, Liu et al. 2022). So on the running

example, full fine-tuning trains 46 times as many weights as the last layer, but its noise should raise the loss only 16 times as much. A larger learning rate lets the noise into more of the nearly flat directions, so private fine-tuning wants smaller steps than training from scratch.

Training fewer weights has its own cost, a **bias**, because no private data can move the model along a frozen direction that the task needs.

41.3. Linear probing first

The simplest option freezes everything but the last layer and trains a linear classifier on the frozen features, which is **linear probing**. Because the features are fixed, the probe's loss is convex. So linear probing turns private deep learning back into Private empirical risk minimization, which makes it the safe first baseline.

A private probe's error has two parts. One is the error that privacy adds to convex empirical risk minimization (ERM), which grows with the number d of features. The other is the **feature gap**, how far the best linear model on the features falls short of the best model of any kind, which no number of records or size of ε closes. For example, the running example's probe without privacy, its ceiling, has a test accuracy of 0.8431, while a non-private network trained from scratch reaches 0.8498. At every budget of Section 41.5 the private probe stays within 0.002 of that ceiling, on either side, which is the spread between runs.

So measure the probe's ceiling first, by fitting it without privacy on labelled public data that resemble the task. If it already meets your target, stop there. To train the probe privately, feed the frozen features to diffprivlib's `LogisticRegression` (Private empirical risk minimization), or run DP-SGD on the one layer.

41.4. Low-rank adapters and full fine-tuning

When the probe's ceiling is below your target, only changing the earlier layers can lift it. **Low-rank adaptation** (LoRA, Hu et al. 2022) freezes each pretrained matrix and learns a small correction to it. The correction is the product of two thin matrices that each have r columns, where r is the rank. A matrix with d_{in} inputs and d_{out} outputs has $d_{\text{in}}d_{\text{out}}$ weights, while its adapter has only

$$d = r(d_{\text{in}} + d_{\text{out}}). \tag{41.2}$$

The adapter comes from Hugging Face's `peft` library. This snippet puts a rank-4 adapter on the first layer of the running example's network, and trains its last layer in full.

```
import torch
from peft import LoraConfig, get_peft_model

model = torch.nn.Sequential(torch.nn.Linear(91, 64), torch.nn.ReLU(), torch.nn.Linear(64, 2)
print(sum(p.numel() for p in model.parameters()))  # 6018
config = LoraConfig(r=4, lora_alpha=8, target_modules=["0"], modules_to_save=["2"], lora_dro
adapted = get_peft_model(model, config)  # freezes every pretrained weight
print(sum(p.numel() for p in adapted.parameters() if p.requires_grad))  # 750
```

In the snippet, `target_modules` and `modules_to_save` name layers by their index in the `Sequential`, and `lora_alpha` scales the correction. It trains 750 weights, the adapter's $4 \times (91 + 64) = 620$ and the last layer's 130. Opacus's `PrivacyEngine` computes per-example gradients only for the parameters that require them, so the frozen weights cost nothing. Call `model.train()` before `make_private`, because Opacus rejects a model in evaluation mode, as a pretrained model often is after you measure it.

The adapter's second factor starts at zero, so training begins exactly at the pretrained model. The first factor starts random, and that draw must not depend on the private data.

Yu et al. (2022) showed that private fine-tuning of language models with LoRA matches or beats private full fine-tuning, at a fraction of the compute and memory. Each adapter factor is an ordinary linear layer, so the ghost clipping of DP-SGD applies to it. Still, Li, Tramèr et al. (2022) matched the adapters with full fine-tuning, using large batches and a learning rate tuned for private training.

41.5. Which method at which budget

The script practitioner_adult_studies.py pretrains the running example on the public stand-in rows, then fine-tunes it with Opacus on the private rows, for the workflow's 300 steps. DP-SGD fine-tunes the last layer, a rank-4 adapter plus the last layer, or all weights, against a model trained privately from scratch. Each method's learning rate was chosen at $\varepsilon = 1$ from 0.1, 0.3, 1 and 3, on half of the test rows, and accuracy comes from the other half. That choice looked at private data without paying, so the table shows each method at its best, not what a real run could claim (Hyperparameter tuning).

Table 41.1.: Accuracy on half of the Adult test rows (mean of two runs), $\delta = 10^{-5}$. The pretrained model without fine-tuning scores 0.8383.

	Scratch	Full	Last layer	Adapter, rank 4
Trainable weights d	6,018	6,018	130	750
Learning rate	1	1	1	0.3
$\varepsilon = 0.25$	0.8260	0.8233	0.8416	0.8396
$\varepsilon = 0.5$	0.8402	0.8404	0.8432	0.8456
$\varepsilon = 1$	0.8434	0.8459	0.8440	0.8469
$\varepsilon = 4$	0.8450	0.8491	0.8435	0.8468

Adult is an easy task, so every gap here is under two points, but the pattern is the one larger tasks show. Pretraining is worth about a factor of eight in ε, since the adapter at $\varepsilon = 0.5$ matches training from scratch at $\varepsilon = 4$.

At $\varepsilon = 0.25$ the last layer is best, because its noise is 6.8 times shorter than full fine-tuning's, and its ceiling does not yet bind. From $\varepsilon = 0.5$ on it stays near its ceiling, while first the adapter and then full fine-tuning pass it. The adapter is never more than 0.0023 below the best method, so it is the robust middle choice here. But a public task further from the private one can reverse the ranking even when the probe's ceiling looks fine, so rerun the comparison on a public stand-in for your task.

The learning rate matters as much as the method, since a step three times too large costs full fine-tuning 1.1 percentage points of accuracy at $\varepsilon = 1$. The adapter's rank matters little, since at $\varepsilon = 1$ ranks 1, 4 and 16 differ by about the run-to-run spread.

41.6. What public data does not buy

Whatever the public data are, training on the private data is (ε, δ)-DP, where δ is the small additive slack the guarantee allows. The public data get no guarantee of any kind. Non-private pretraining can memorize individual records (Memorization and training-data extraction), and the fine-tuned model inherits whatever the pretrained weights encode (Tramèr, Kamath & Carlini 2024).

So a person in both datasets has protection only in the private copy. A membership attack against the pretrained model (Membership inference) has no bound at all. Web-scale "public" datasets contain posts, profiles and leaked documents, so private notes or emails may well overlap with them. For text, also mind the privacy unit, because one person's documents span many training sequences (User-level differential privacy).

Check three things before you train and when you report.

1. Check that the public data resemble the private task, and deduplicate the private set against them. Deduplication protects copies, not people, since exact matching misses paraphrases.
2. Choose the public model and the hyperparameters on public data. Otherwise every private run costs privacy (Hyperparameter tuning).
3. Name the public data and the overlap check, and state that the guarantee covers the private data given the pretrained model.

41.7. Cheat sheet

Table 41.2.: Where to start when fine-tuning privately; the ranking depends on the task.

Situation	Train	Why
Tiny budget, or the probe meets the target	Last layer (linear probe)	Fewest weights; convex
Moderate budget, features not quite right	Low-rank adapter plus last layer	Never far from the best
Larger budget, large batches, tuned learning rate	All weights	Noise costs only along curved directions

Rule of thumb. Measure the linear probe's ceiling before anything else. Then use large batches and a smaller learning rate than for training from scratch. Tune the learning rate with DP-SGD runs at the target noise on public data, because a non-private sweep does not show how the noise moves the best step.

41.8. References

- Tramèr & Boneh, "Differentially Private Learning Needs Better Features (or Much More Data)" (ICLR 2021): linear probing on good features.
- Li, Tramèr, Liang & Hashimoto, "Large Language Models Can Be Strong Differentially Private Learners" (ICLR 2022), and Yu et al., "Differentially Private Fine-tuning of Language Models" (ICLR 2022): full and adapter-based private fine-tuning.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

42. Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA

42.1. Why this matters

You have a pretrained language model and private text, such as support tickets or clinical notes. You want the model to learn from that text without being able to repeat it. A model fine-tuned without privacy can write out a phone number or a password that was often in its training text (Memorization and training-data extraction). The fix is to fine-tune with the differential privacy (DP) version of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD. It costs least when it trains only a small adapter on the frozen model, which is often as accurate as training every weight (Public data and private fine-tuning). Here the adapter is low-rank adaptation (LoRA), from Hugging Face's `peft` library, and Opacus does the private training.

The model is Pythia-14m, a public language model of 14 million parameters from EleutherAI. The private text is Tiny Shakespeare, a million characters of Shakespeare's plays. The script fine-tunes the model twice, once without privacy and once at a privacy loss ε of 8 for each sequence of training text. First it plants made-up secrets, called canaries, in the text, so that you can see what each model memorized. The script practitioner_lora.py runs in a few minutes without a GPU.

```
uv run python code/part05-dp-ml/practitioner_lora.py
```

42.2. Fix the privacy unit, n and δ

The guarantee protects one unit, so decide first what the unit is. A language model trains on fixed-length sequences of tokens, the word pieces its tokenizer cuts text into. The script cuts the text into sequences of 32 tokens, about one or two lines of verse, and makes each sequence the unit. To keep the run short, it trains on the first 1,024 sequences and holds out the last 128.

```
sequences of 32 tokens: 10,632  training n=1,024  held out 128
delta=1e-04 (privacy unit: one training sequence)
```

For $n = 1{,}024$ sequences, the book's rule for the slack δ gives 10^{-4} (How small δ must be).

A sequence is the right unit for this demonstration, but rarely in production. One person's document spans many sequences, and one user writes many documents, so a guarantee per sequence protects a person much less than it seems. In production, make the unit a document or a user, and bound how many sequences each contributes. Then set δ from the number of users (User-level differential privacy).

42.3. Plant canaries

To check memorization later, you need secrets whose presence you control. So the script writes **canaries** into the training text. Each is a sentence such as "the pin of Alice is 8 6 5 2 3", whose last five digits are the secret. There are four groups of three canaries, inserted 1, 4, 16 and 64 times each. Three more, the controls, are drawn the same way but never inserted, so they show what an unseen secret scores in the audit of Section 42.9.

```
def insert_canaries(
    train: torch.Tensor, canaries: list[Canary], tokenizer: PreTrainedTokenizerBase, rng: np
) -> torch.Tensor:
    """Write each copy of each canary over the start of a different training sequence."""
    train = train.clone()
    total = sum(c.copies for c in canaries)
    rows = iter(rng.choice(len(train), size=total, replace=False).tolist())
    for canary in canaries:
        tokens = torch.tensor(tokenizer(canary.text)["input_ids"])
        for _ in range(canary.copies):
            train[next(rows), : len(tokens)] = tokens
    return train
```

The 255 copies take up a quarter of the training set. That is far denser than secrets in real data, on purpose, because it lets a model this small memorize within a short run, so the audit has a positive control.

```
canary sequences: 255 (3 canaries each at (1, 4, 16, 64) copies)
tokens per secret: [5]
candidates: 2,000  exposure cap 10.97 bits  (full space 16.61)
```

The digits are separated by spaces so that every possible secret is exactly five tokens long, which the second line confirms over 1,000 random secrets.

42.4. Load a public model and tokenizer

Everything not trained privately must come from outside the private data. That includes the tokenizer, whose vocabulary would leak rare words if it were built from the private text. So the weights and the tokenizer both come from the same public checkpoint, Pythia-14m, pinned to one revision. The script loads the model in float32, because `transformers` loads some checkpoints in float16, which is far slower on a CPU.

The guarantee then covers the private text given the pretrained model, and says nothing about the model's own training data. Pythia was pretrained on the Pile, which includes Project Gutenberg's books and so very likely Shakespeare's plays. That is harmless here, but with real data, check for overlap with the public model's training data (Public data and private fine-tuning).

42.5. Choose what to train

DP-SGD adds noise to every weight it trains. So the noise on the averaged gradient grows with the square root of the number of trained weights, but the clipped signal does not (Public data and private fine-tuning). That makes the choice of trainable weights a main lever on accuracy, with the learning rate. LoRA freezes each pretrained matrix and learns a correction to it, the product of two thin factors whose width is the rank.

```
attention_and_mlp = ["query_key_value", "dense", "dense_h_to_4h", "dense_4h_to_h"]  # every
config = LoraConfig(r=rank, lora_alpha=2 * rank, target_modules=attention_and_mlp, lora_drop
lora_model = get_peft_model(model, config)  # freezes the pretrained weights
trainable_count = sum(p.numel() for p in lora_model.parameters() if p.requires_grad)
total_count = sum(p.numel() for p in lora_model.parameters())
print(f"trainable parameters: LoRA {trainable_count:,}  full fine-tuning {total_count - trai
```

```
full model parameters: 14,067,712
trainable parameters: LoRA 98,304  full fine-tuning 14,067,712
```

By default the adapters have rank 8 and sit on every linear layer, in attention and in the feed-forward blocks. They train 98,304 weights, against about 14 million for full fine-tuning. `lora_alpha` scales the adapters' correction, set to the usual twice the rank. For a real task, choose the rank and the layers on public data, because a choice made from private runs costs privacy (Hyperparameter tuning).

42.6. Make the model Opacus-compatible

Opacus needs one gradient per sequence, and layers that mix the records of a batch, such as batch normalization, make that impossible. Opacus's `ModuleValidator.validate` lists such layers before you train.

```
validator errors: 0
```

Pythia has none, and only the adapters train in any case. They are ordinary linear layers, which Opacus's default hooks handle, so the script passes `grad_sample_mode="hooks"`. Opacus computes per-sequence gradients only for the weights that require gradients, so the 14 million frozen weights add no cost. Call `model.train()` before you wrap a model you have just evaluated, because Opacus rejects one in evaluation mode. After training, the hooks stay attached and slow down everything the model does next, so the script calls `remove_hooks()` before it evaluates the private model.

42.7. Calibrate and train

The accountant finds the noise for a fixed target, here $\varepsilon = 8$ over 3 epochs with an expected batch of 32 sequences. The sampling rate q, the share of the data in an average batch, is then

32/1,024, so the 3 epochs take 96 steps. The accountant is the privacy loss random variable (PRV) accountant, which computes ε almost exactly (Choosing an accountant).

```
privacy_engine = PrivacyEngine(accountant="prv")
private_model, optimizer, loader = privacy_engine.make_private_with_epsilon(
    module=model,
    optimizer=optimizer,
    data_loader=loader,  # replaced by Poisson sampling with rate BATCH / n
    target_epsilon=epsilon,
    target_delta=delta,
    epochs=EPOCHS,
    max_grad_norm=MAX_GRAD_NORM,
    grad_sample_mode="hooks",
)
print(f"noise multiplier: {optimizer.noise_multiplier:.3f}")
```

The training loop is an ordinary one, with Poisson batches, in which each sequence joins each batch independently with probability q.

```
for (batch,) in loader:  # each batch holds a random number of sequences
    optimizer.zero_grad()
    loss = private_model(input_ids=batch, labels=batch).loss
    loss.backward()  # Opacus's hooks keep one gradient per sequence
    optimizer.step()  # clips each one to MAX_GRAD_NORM, sums, adds noise
    steps += 1
```

```
noise multiplier: 0.553
sample rate q=0.03125  steps=96  noise multiplier=0.553
epsilon (Opacus PRV)=7.99  epsilon (dp_accounting PLD)=7.98  at delta=1e-04
```

The noise multiplier is the noise's standard deviation in units of the clipping norm, `MAX_GRAD_NORM`, which the script sets to 1. The last line cross-checks the ε with the privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant of Google's `dp_accounting`, as in Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, and the two agree.

Both runs use AdamW at a learning rate of 10^{-3}, and the private run differs only by clipping, noise and Poisson sampling. That learning rate, the rank and the epochs were chosen in a few non-private trial runs on the same text. A real run must choose them on similar public text, such as other public-domain plays, or pay for the trials in ε (Hyperparameter tuning).

Two more settings change for a real run. With more data, use batches in the thousands, and let Opacus's `BatchMemoryManager` split them into physical batches that fit in memory (Train a model with DP-SGD). And a model you release needs `secure_mode=True` in `PrivacyEngine`. Its secure noise cannot be seeded, so the script leaves it off.

42.8. Evaluate

A language model is judged by how well it predicts held-out text. The script measures the mean cross-entropy per token on the 128 held-out sequences, and its exponential, the **perplexity**. A perplexity of 159.3 means the model is as unsure as if it chose among about 159 equally likely tokens. So lower is better.

```
held-out loss pretrained: 5.306 nats/token  perplexity 201.6
held-out loss LoRA non-private: 5.071 nats/token  perplexity 159.3
held-out loss LoRA DP eps=8: 5.044 nats/token  perplexity 155.1
```

Both fine-tuned models improve on the pretrained one. On one seed, the private model's slightly lower perplexity means only that DP costs nothing measurable here. Both gains are modest, because a quarter of the training sequences begin with canaries rather than Shakespeare.

Do not expect privacy to be this cheap on every task. This run is short, trains few weights, and uses text that is very likely in the pretraining data already. With a harder task or a smaller ε, compare the private model with both baselines at several budgets, as Train a model with DP-SGD does.

42.9. Check memorization

The canaries show what perplexity cannot, whether the model will repeat a secret. The script measures each canary in two ways. The first is extraction. It gives the model the prefix "the pin of Alice is", lets it write the likeliest next token five times, and checks whether the result is the secret.

```
@torch.no_grad()
def greedy_completion(model: PeftModel, tokenizer: PreTrainedTokenizerBase, prefix: str) ->
    """The five tokens the model writes after the prefix when it always picks the likeliest
    ids = tokenizer(prefix, return_tensors="pt")["input_ids"]
    for _ in range(5):
        next_token = model(input_ids=ids).logits[:, -1].argmax(dim=-1, keepdim=True)
        ids = torch.cat([ids, next_token], dim=1)
    return tokenizer.batch_decode(ids[:, -5:])[0].strip()
```

The second is the **exposure** of Memorization and training-data extraction. It ranks the canary's secret among random secrets of the same format by how likely the model finds each, and turns the rank into bits. The script's likelihood is the summed log-probability of the five digits. Each bit halves the number of guesses an attacker needs.

```
@torch.no_grad()
def secret_scores(model: PeftModel, tokenizer: PreTrainedTokenizerBase, prefix: str, secrets
    """Summed log-probability of each secret's five digit tokens after the prefix."""
    prefix_ids = tokenizer(prefix)["input_ids"]
```

```
    rows = [prefix_ids + tokenizer(" " + s)["input_ids"] for s in secrets]
    ids = torch.tensor(rows)  # every secret is five tokens, so the rows have equal length
    logits = model(input_ids=ids[:, :-1], logits_to_keep=5).logits  # the predictions of the
    logprobs = logits.log_softmax(dim=-1).gather(-1, ids[:, -5:, None])
    return logprobs.sum(dim=(1, 2)).double().numpy()


def canary_exposure(
    model: PeftModel, tokenizer: PreTrainedTokenizerBase, canary: Canary, candidates: list[s
) -> tuple[float, float]:
    """The exposure of the canary's secret among the candidates, measured and extrapolated p
    candidate_scores = scores_batched(model, tokenizer, canary.prefix, candidates)
    score = float(scores_batched(model, tokenizer, canary.prefix, [canary.secret])[0])
    return exposure(score, candidate_scores), extrapolated_exposure(score, candidate_scores,
```

No library installed with this book computes exposure, so `exposure` and `extrapolated_exposure` come from the book's helper module practitioner_privacy_tests.py, after TensorFlow Privacy's versions. With 2,000 random candidates, a canary that beats them all reaches a cap of 10.97 bits. A secret the model has never seen has a random rank and averages about 1.44 bits ($\log_2 e$). Each line below gives a group's mean exposure, the same past the cap, and how many of its three secrets greedy decoding wrote out.

```
non-private 1 copies: mean exposure 2.0 bits  extrapolated 2.0  extracted 0/3
non-private 4 copies: mean exposure 5.9 bits  extrapolated 5.7  extracted 0/3
non-private 16 copies: mean exposure 10.0 bits  extrapolated 13.0  extracted 0/3
non-private 64 copies: mean exposure 11.0 bits  extrapolated 16.3  extracted 3/3
non-private controls: mean exposure 1.4 bits  extrapolated 1.5  extracted 0/3
DP 1 copies: mean exposure 0.9 bits  extrapolated 0.9  extracted 0/3
DP 4 copies: mean exposure 0.6 bits  extrapolated 0.6  extracted 0/3
DP 16 copies: mean exposure 4.2 bits  extrapolated 4.3  extracted 0/3
DP 64 copies: mean exposure 4.0 bits  extrapolated 3.9  extracted 0/3
DP controls: mean exposure 2.2 bits  extrapolated 2.2  extracted 0/3
```

The non-private model, the positive control, leaks. Exposure rises with the number of copies, from 2.0 bits for one copy to the cap for 64, and the model writes out all three 64-copy secrets. The extrapolated column sees past the cap by fitting a skew-normal distribution, a normal with one heavier tail, to the candidates' scores. It puts the 64-copy secrets near the 16.61 bits of the whole space.

The 4-copy canaries are the instructive case. Two of the three reach 6.9 and 8.2 bits, yet none is extracted, so exposure detects memorization that extraction alone would miss.

Greedy decoding extracts nothing from the private model, and its canaries with 1 or 4 copies score no higher than its controls. The controls' 2.2 bits are within the scatter of a mean over three secrets. Still, DP limits the effect without erasing it, since the canaries with 16 and 64 copies still average about 4 bits.

The guarantee allows that, because $\varepsilon = 8$ protects one sequence, while a canary with many copies is many sequences. Group privacy bounds a group of units at about their number times ε. So 16 copies get 16×8, far too much to promise anything (User-level differential privacy). A secret that a user repeats across many documents is the same case, one more reason to make the unit the user.

Two cautions apply. Because the canaries are so dense, a real non-private model may leak less than this one, and a real audit should plant fewer copies. And three canaries per group is a small sample. For a fuller assessment before release, run the attacks of Pre-release privacy risk assessment. For a statistical lower bound on ε, run the one-run audit of Auditing private training.

42.10. Variants

Three variants matter for real models. The block below shows ghost clipping, LoRA on GPT-2, and packages that wrap the whole loop, with pinned versions. It was not run.

```
# opacus==1.6.0: ghost clipping, when per-sequence gradients do not fit in memory
model, optimizer, criterion, loader = privacy_engine.make_private_with_epsilon(
    module=model, optimizer=optimizer, data_loader=loader, criterion=torch.nn.CrossEntropyLo
    target_epsilon=8.0, target_delta=1e-4, epochs=3, max_grad_norm=1.0, grad_sample_mode="gh
)
logits = model(input_ids=batch).logits[:, :-1]                # predict each next token
loss = criterion(logits.flatten(0, 1), batch[:, 1:].flatten(), shape=logits.shape)
loss.backward()                                               # norms first, then the clipp

# peft==0.21.2: GPT-2 stores its attention as Conv1D, with the weight transposed
LoraConfig(r=8, lora_alpha=16, target_modules=["c_attn"], fan_in_fan_out=True)

# dp-transformers==1.0.0 (Microsoft): Opacus inside the Hugging Face Trainer
# private-transformers (Li et al.): install from its GitHub repository, pinned to a commit
```

Ghost clipping gets each sequence's gradient norm without storing the gradient, so memory no longer holds one gradient per sequence (DP-SGD).

42.11. Report

Release and governance builds the statement from the run's record. For this run, it adds three things. The guarantee covers the private text given the pretrained model, named with its revision. The hyperparameters came from non-private trials on the private text, which a real release could not claim for free. And the canary audit is attached as evidence, with its caveats.

What ships is the adapter. With `--save-adapter FOLDER`, the script saves it after `remove_hooks()` and loads it back onto the same pinned checkpoint.

```
private.save_pretrained(path)  # only the adapter weights and config, after Opacus's hooks a
base_model = AutoModelForCausalLM.from_pretrained(folder, dtype=torch.float32)  # the same p
reloaded = PeftModel.from_pretrained(base_model, path)
```

The folder holds only the adapter, so the statement names the base checkpoint and revision it fits. The guarantee covers the adapter and anything computed from it.

42.12. Checklist

Table 42.1.: The steps of fine-tuning a language model privately, their defaults and their checks.

Step	Default	Check
Unit, n, δ	Document or user in production; δ by the book's rule	n counts units, not tokens or lines
Canaries	A few per group, inserted 1 to many times, plus controls	Controls near 1.44 bits, allowing for the scatter of a few
Public model and tokenizer	One public checkpoint, pinned revision, float32	Nothing fitted on private text; overlap checked
What to train	LoRA, rank 8, on every linear layer	Trainable count printed; chosen on public data
Opacus	Validator; hooks; `remove_hooks()` after training	No validator errors
Calibrate and train	PRV accountant; Poisson sampling; large batches	PLD agrees with PRV
Evaluate	Held-out perplexity against the pretrained and non-private models	Private model beats the pretrained one
Memorization	Exposure and greedy extraction, non-private and private	Nothing extracted; one-copy canaries no higher than the controls
Report and save	Unit, ε, δ, accountant, public model, tuning; adapter saved after `remove_hooks()`	Statement names what is not covered and the base revision

42.13. References

- Yu et al., "Differentially Private Fine-tuning of Language Models" (ICLR 2022): LoRA and other adapters with DP-SGD, and their accuracy.

- Li, Tramèr, Liang & Hashimoto, "Large Language Models Can Be Strong Differentially Private Learners" (ICLR 2022): full fine-tuning with ghost clipping, and the hyperparameters that make it work.
- Carlini et al., "The Secret Sharer: Evaluating and Testing Unintended Memorization in Neural Networks" (USENIX Security 2019): canaries and exposure.

Derivations. This workflow draws on the full edition's chapters on public data and private fine-tuning in the full edition, DP-SGD in the full edition and memorization and training-data extraction in the full edition.

43. Private prediction: PATE and in-context learning

43.1. What it is

Private prediction applies differential privacy (DP) to each *answer* instead of to the model. You split the private records into disjoint shards and train an ordinary model, a **teacher**, on each one. The teachers stay secret. Each query gets the winner of their vote after noise is added to the counts, private at a level ε with a small slack δ. A record lives in one shard, so it can move one teacher's vote to another label. That changes the counts by at most $\sqrt{2}$ in Euclidean length.

GNMax adds Gaussian noise with a standard deviation σ to each count and releases only the label with the largest noisy count. In Rényi differential privacy (RDP), each answer costs a straight line of slope $1/\sigma^2$ in the order α, and the slopes add (Rényi DP). So write $\rho(\varepsilon, \delta)$ for the largest slope that still converts to your target. A fixed number Q of answers, even adaptively chosen, then needs the noise

$$\sigma = \sqrt{\frac{Q}{\rho(\varepsilon, \delta)}}. \tag{43.1}$$

For example, at $\delta = 10^{-5}$ a budget of $\varepsilon = 1$ allows a slope of 0.0306, so 1,000 answers need $\sigma = 181$.

43.2. When you meet it

You meet private prediction when you cannot train a private model. The common case is a large language model (LLM) behind an interface, whose prompt holds private records that its answers leak. The fix splits the records into disjoint groups, prompts the model once per group, and releases the GNMax label (Duan et al. 2023). At $\varepsilon = 1$, Wu et al. (2024) answered 10,000 sentiment queries this way as accurately as one non-private prompt.

Otherwise the choice is between private answers and a private model, whose accuracy is fixed. The vote's noise grows with $\sqrt{Q}$, so answers win up to a **break-even** number of queries, and the model wins beyond it. On the full edition's 10,000-record synthetic task, the vote beats noisy stochastic gradient descent (SGD), DP-SGD, only on the first 18 queries at $\varepsilon = 1$. So compare the two at your budget and expected number of queries, with the DP-SGD baseline of Train a model with DP-SGD.

PATE (private aggregation of teacher ensembles) spends the budget once. It labels public, unlabelled inputs by GNMax and trains a new model, the **student**, on them. Only the student is released, at exactly the cost of its labels, so PATE needs public inputs from the private data's distribution. Papernot et al.'s MNIST student comes within a percentage point of non-private accuracy, but at a data-dependent ε (Section 43.4). On the synthetic task, DP-SGD beats the best student at every budget.

43.3. How to use it

`dp_accounting` accounts for the vote. One GNMax answer is a `GaussianDpEvent` whose noise multiplier, the noise over the sensitivity, is $\sigma/\sqrt{2}$.

```
import numpy as np
from dp_accounting import GaussianDpEvent, SelfComposedDpEvent
from dp_accounting.pld import PLDAccountant
from dp_accounting.rdp import RdpAccountant

sigma, queries = 181.0, 1000  # noise per count, answers to release
event = SelfComposedDpEvent(GaussianDpEvent(sigma / np.sqrt(2)), queries)  # sensitivity sqr
rdp = RdpAccountant().compose(event).get_epsilon(1e-5)
pld = PLDAccountant().compose(event).get_epsilon(1e-5)
print(f"{rdp:.3f} {pld:.3f}")  # 0.999 0.914
```

The RDP accountant confirms $\varepsilon = 0.999$. The privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant, exact for Gaussian noise, gives 0.914, so solving for σ with it gives less noise. To solve, pass a function from σ to this event to `dp_accounting.calibrate_dp_mechanism`. For many answers the PLD is much slower, so RDP is the fallback. When each query draws a fresh Poisson sample of records, as in Wu et al., wrap each event in a `PoissonSampledDpEvent`.

43.4. What goes wrong

The guarantee needs each record in exactly one shard. So assign shards by a hash of the record's or the user's identifier, never by position in a file, where one inserted record shifts every later shard. Release the label only, and fix Q in advance.

Noise this large wipes out close votes. With two labels and a gap g between the counts, the vote returns the plurality with probability $\Phi(g/(\sqrt{2}\sigma))$, where Φ is the standard normal distribution function.

For example, the noise for 1,000 answers at $\varepsilon = 4$ is $\sigma = 51.8$. Then a lopsided vote of 98 to 2 is right with probability 0.9051, but a close vote of 52 to 48 only about half the time. So measure the noiseless vote first, since no budget beats it. Adding teachers widens the gaps, because σ does not depend on their number, until the shards get too small to train on.

Finally, beware of a data-dependent ε. When teachers agree, a sharper analysis charges less, but that smaller ε is computed from the votes and leaks them. Until it is released with noise, it is a measurement, not a guarantee.

Confident-GNMax answers only queries on which a noisy check finds agreement, the cheap and accurate ones.

43.5. References

- Papernot et al., "Scalable Private Learning with PATE" (ICLR 2018): GNMax, its data-dependent analysis and Confident-GNMax.
- Wu et al., "Privacy-Preserving In-Context Learning for Large Language Models" (ICLR 2024): subsampled voting over prompts.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

44. DP-FTRL and matrix factorization

44.1. What it is

Gradient descent without momentum adds up its steps. So its weights after each step depend on the sum of all clipped gradients so far, a **prefix sum**. Stochastic gradient descent (SGD) with differential privacy (DP), DP-SGD, adds fresh noise at every step. So the noise in the prefix sums grows like a random walk. Matrix mechanisms correlate the noise across steps, so that each step's noise partly cancels earlier noise in the sums.

Stack the gradient sums of the steps as the rows of a matrix x. The prefix sums are then Ax, where A has ones on and below the diagonal. The **matrix factorization mechanism** writes A as a decoder L times an encoder R. It adds a matrix of Gaussian noise, written z, to the encoded gradients and decodes the result,

$$\hat{S} = L(Rx + z) = Ax + Lz. \tag{44.1}$$

A record enters only through the column of R for its step, so privacy depends on the longest column of the encoder, its sensitivity. Accuracy depends on the decoder, whose row t carries the noise into the t-th prefix sum.

The first such method ran the follow the regularized leader (FTRL) optimizer on sums from a binary tree, and is called DP-FTRL (Kairouz et al. 2021). Today's usual choice is the **square-root factorization**, which uses the lower-triangular square root of A for both factors. At equal privacy over one epoch of 100 steps, it leaves about a quarter of independent noise's standard deviation in the final sum.

44.2. When you meet it

You meet matrix mechanisms when your pipeline cannot honestly claim Poisson sampling, the random batches that DP-SGD's accountant assumes. Examples are fixed batches cut from a shuffled order, data read in arrival order, and phones in federated learning that check in when they can. Accounting them as Poisson understates ε (Amplification by subsampling), while a matrix mechanism needs no sampling.

Without sampling, independent noise loses much accuracy, and correlated noise wins most of it back. On the full edition's synthetic task, trained in a fixed order for ten epochs at $\varepsilon = 2$, independent noise reaches a test accuracy of 0.8641. The banded square root of Section 44.4 reaches 0.9491, and DP-SGD with Poisson sampling 0.9493. So if you can implement Poisson sampling, use DP-SGD with Opacus. If you cannot, use a banded matrix mechanism, as Google did for its Gboard keyboard models (Xu et al. 2023).

44.3. How to use it

Google's JAX Privacy implements banded matrix factorization. The block below was not run, because JAX is not in this book's environment. It cycles through 100 fixed groups of records, one per step, so each record takes part once every 100 steps.

```
# jax-privacy==2.0.0 (not run)
from jax_privacy.experimental.execution_plan import BandMFExecutionPlanConfig

config = BandMFExecutionPlanConfig.default(
    num_bands=100,       # at most the 100 steps between a record's turns
    iterations=1000,     # ten epochs of 100 steps
    epsilon=2.0,
    delta=1e-5,
    sampling_prob=1.0,   # all of the step's group joins: no amplification claimed
    l2_clip_norm=1.0,
)
plan = config.plan       # calibrates the noise multiplier with dp_accounting
```

The training loop draws each batch from `plan.batch_selection_strategy`, sums its clipped gradients with `plan.clipped_grad`, and adds the noise with `plan.noise_addition_transform`. A `dp_accounting` accountant turns `plan.dp_event` into the ε you report. The module is marked experimental, so pin the version.

44.4. What goes wrong

The pitfalls come from records that take part more than once. Over E epochs a record enters through E columns of the encoder. The square root's columns for nearby steps are nonzero in the same rows, so they add up and the sensitivity grows faster than $\sqrt{E}$. **Banding** keeps a number b of the encoder's diagonals, the main one and those just below it. It needs every two participations of a record to be at least b steps apart, a condition called b**-min-separation**. The record's columns then share no rows, so the sensitivity is at most $\sqrt{E}$ times the longest column, as for independent noise.

So the data order is part of the mechanism. Fix it before training, independently of the data, and keep the same permutation every epoch, because a new shuffle can put a record at the end of one epoch and the start of the next.

The neighbouring relation changes the numbers too. The analysis here leaves a neighbour's slot empty, so a step moves by at most the clipping norm. If a neighbour replaces the record with another instead, every sensitivity doubles, so state the relation next to every ε.

`dp_accounting` 0.6.0 enforces this. Its tree-aggregation event works only in a Rényi differential privacy (RDP) accountant built with `NeighboringRelation.REPLACE_SPECIAL`, where a neighbour replaces the record with an empty one. Under add/remove, DP-SGD's default, it raises `UnsupportedEventError`, and the privacy loss distribution accountant rejects it too. So DP-FTRL and DP-SGD runs cannot share one add/remove ledger.

44.5. References

- Choquette-Choo et al., "(Amplified) Banded Matrix Factorizations: A Unified Approach to Private Training" (NeurIPS 2023): banding, min-separation and amplification.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

45. Disparate impact

45.1. Why this matters

A private model's test accuracy is an average over everyone, so it cannot show which people lose the accuracy that privacy costs. Bagdasaryan, Poursaeed & Shmatikov (2019) trained networks with differential privacy (DP), using the private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD) called DP-SGD. They found that the lost accuracy fell mostly on under-represented groups, and called this the **disparate impact** of DP.

So a model that is a point worse on average can be ten points worse for one small group, often one that privacy should protect. Before you ship a private model, measure its cost for each group against a non-private baseline, with a confidence interval on every number.

45.2. Evaluating a private model per group

Decide which groups matter before you look at any results, so that the results cannot steer the choice. Then train a non-private baseline with the same data and recipe, because a gap between groups may exist without privacy. DP is responsible only for how far each group's own accuracy drops when training becomes private.

Write acc_g for a model's accuracy on the test records of group g. Private training is random, so its accuracy is averaged over several training runs, written $\mathbb{E}$. The **privacy cost** π_g is the accuracy the group loses when the same data and hyperparameters are trained privately,

$$\pi_g = \text{acc}_g(\text{non-private}) - \mathbb{E}[\text{acc}_g(\text{private})]. \tag{45.1}$$

DP has disparate impact when groups have different privacy costs.

Every accuracy needs an interval. Each test record is classified correctly or not, so a group's accuracy is a binomial proportion, and its exact Clopper–Pearson interval contains the true accuracy in at least 95% of test samples (Hypothesis testing).

The gap between two groups needs its own interval. Write $\hat{p}_g$ for group g's measured accuracy and m_g for its number of test records. For two groups a and b measured on disjoint test records, the variances of the two estimates add. So for large counts an approximate 95% interval for the gap is

$$(\hat{p}_a - \hat{p}_b) \pm 1.96\sqrt{\frac{\hat{p}_a(1-\hat{p}_a)}{m_a} + \frac{\hat{p}_b(1-\hat{p}_b)}{m_b}}. \tag{45.2}$$

These intervals are wider than most people expect. Suppose a test split holds only 100 records of a minority, and 88 of them are classified correctly. The majority gets 1,812 of its 1,900 records

right, an accuracy of 0.954, so the measured gap is 0.074. SciPy gives the minority's interval, and Equation 45.2 gives the gap's.

```
from math import sqrt

from scipy.stats import binomtest

minority = binomtest(88, 100).proportion_ci(confidence_level=0.95, method="exact")
print(f"{minority.low:.3f} {minority.high:.3f}")  # 0.800 0.936

gap, se = 0.954 - 0.880, sqrt(0.954 * 0.046 / 1_900 + 0.880 * 0.120 / 100)
print(f"{gap - 1.96 * se:.3f} {gap + 1.96 * se:.3f}")  # 0.010 0.138
```

So the gap is real, since its interval excludes zero, but it could be anywhere from one point to fourteen. An interval separates a 5-point gap from zero only with a few hundred test records from the group, and a 1-point gap only with thousands.

The privacy cost needs a different interval. Both models are scored on the same test records, so their accuracies are not independent and Equation 45.2 does not apply. Pair them instead. Among group g's m_g test records, write u for the number only the non-private model gets right, and v for those only the private one gets right. One run's cost is then $(u - v)/m_g$, and for large counts an approximate 95% interval is

$$\frac{u - v}{m_g} \pm \frac{1.96}{m_g} \sqrt{u + v - \frac{(u - v)^2}{m_g}}. \tag{45.3}$$

Training adds a second source of variation, which no test set removes. A small group's accuracy varies far more between training runs than a large group's, so a one-run comparison of two recipes can reverse. So train each recipe with several seeds, and report the mean cost and its spread.

The evaluation can also leak, because per-group accuracies on private test data are statistics of that data. To publish them, add noise to each group's count of correct predictions and charge it to a budget of its own (Release statistics with a library).

45.3. Disparate impact, measured

The script practitioner_dp_sgd.py of Train a model with DP-SGD trains a small network on the Adult census data to predict whether a person's income exceeds $50K. It trains once without privacy and once with DP-SGD at a privacy level ε of 4 and a slack δ of 10^{-5}. Then it scores both on the test rows of each `sex`, with exact intervals from SciPy, which gives Table 45.1 for seed 0.

Table 45.1.: Accuracy on Adult by sex, with exact 95% intervals, for one training run of each model.

Group	Test records	Non-private accuracy	Accuracy at $\varepsilon = 4$	Privacy cost
Female	5,613	0.924 [0.917, 0.931]	0.922 [0.915, 0.929]	+0.002
Male	11,229	0.808 [0.800, 0.815]	0.807 [0.800, 0.815]	+0.001

Here DP has no measurable disparate impact. Each group loses at most 0.002 in one private run, well inside its intervals. The large gap between the groups is there without privacy too, so DP is not responsible for it. Both groups are large, and the whole model loses almost nothing at this budget.

Small groups tell a different story at a smaller budget. Adult's `race` column has three groups with under 1,000 of the 30,000 training rows. The script practitioner_adult_studies.py trains the same model three times each without privacy, with clipping only, and at $\varepsilon = 4$ and 1, and scores every group (Table 45.2).

Table 45.2.: Test accuracy on Adult by race, averaged over 3 runs ($\delta = 10^{-5}$, noise multiplier 0.973 at $\varepsilon = 4$ and 2.383 at $\varepsilon = 1$). Costs are fractions of accuracy.

Group	Training rows	Test rows	Non-private	Clipping only	$\varepsilon = 4$	$\varepsilon = 1$	Privacy cost at $\varepsilon = 1$
White	25,670	14,352	0.8368	0.8376	0.8363	0.8331	0.0037
Black	2,876	1,650	0.9042	0.9046	0.9079	0.9038	0.0004
Asian-Pac-Islander	926	532	0.8346	0.8289	0.8315	0.8045	0.0301
Amer-Indian-Eskimo	283	167	0.9281	0.9361	0.9361	0.9281	0.0000
Other	245	141	0.9149	0.9031	0.9031	0.8936	0.0213

At $\varepsilon = 4$ no group loses more than 1.2 points. At $\varepsilon = 1$ the White group loses 0.37 points, while the Asian-Pac-Islander group loses 3.01 and the Other group 2.13. Black and Amer-Indian-Eskimo people lose nothing, although the second is one of the smallest groups. Nor does the share of high incomes explain it: about 12% of the Black, Amer-Indian-Eskimo and Other groups earn above \$50K, yet only the Other group pays. So no simple feature of a group predicts its cost, and every small group must be checked, whatever the overall accuracy says.

These numbers are only suggestive. At an accuracy of 0.85 the exact interval for 532 test rows is $[0.816, 0.879]$, three points on each side, and for 141 rows it is six. Three training runs do not remove that spread either, so a real check uses the paired interval of Equation 45.3 and more runs.

45.4. Why small groups pay: clipping and noise

DP-SGD loses accuracy through two steps, clipping and noise, and both treat every record alike. Yet the clipping column of Table 45.2, which adds no noise and so gives no privacy, already costs the Asian-Pac-Islander group 0.57 points and the Other group 1.18, while the White group gains 0.08. So clipping by itself can treat the groups unequally.

Clipping caps every record's pull on the update at the clipping norm C, so it cuts back the groups with long gradients hardest. A group's gradients are long where the model fits it badly, as it does a rare pattern the rest of the data does not teach. So training gives such a group less weight than its share of the records.

The noise is the same for every group, while a group's signal grows with its size. So a small group's signal is the weakest against the noise, and when the group needs a rule of its own, its privacy cost can grow like one over its share of the training records. On Adult, cutting the Asian-Pac-Islander group from 3.1% to 1% of the training rows leaves its cost at $\varepsilon = 1$ at 3.13 points, within the spread of three runs, so measure the cost instead of predicting it from the share. The two causes compound, because the noise acts on the weight that clipping has already shrunk. A group whose gradients clipping halves pays like a group half its size.

To see which cause hurts your model, measure per-example gradient norms by group. Opacus's `GradSampleModule`, the wrapper DP-SGD training already uses, keeps one gradient per row in each parameter's `grad_sample`, so one backward pass gives the norms.

```
wrapped = GradSampleModule(model)  # adds hooks that keep one gradient per row
wrapped.train()
logits: torch.Tensor = wrapped(split.x)
nn.CrossEntropyLoss()(logits, split.y).backward()  # fills p.grad_sample for every weight p
norms = stacked_norms(wrapped)
```

Group the norms by each row's group label, kept beside the batch but not fed to the model. Log each group's median norm and fraction clipped as training goes on, because the groups can separate late. At initialization on Adult, the median norm is 1.444, so $C = 1$ clips every row, whatever its group.

45.5. Mitigations and what they cost

At a fixed budget, a change to the training recipe only moves the cost between the groups or between clipping and noise (Table 45.3). Only the last row, which changes the data, the starting model or the budget, reduces it.

Table 45.3.: Mitigations for disparate impact, and when to use them.

Fix	What happens	Use it?
Upweight the group's loss, or use a smaller clipping norm	Clipping cuts an upweighted gradient back to C, and a smaller norm clips more of the group	No
Larger clipping norm, with learning rate times C held fixed	Less clipping, but more noise relative to short gradients	Rarely, since it trades one cause for the other
Clipping norm set to the largest gradient seen in the data	Breaks the privacy proof, which assumes C is fixed in advance	Only if chosen privately and charged
Oversample the group	Its records' ε is set by their higher sampling rate, so σ must rise	Only with that accounting
Global scaling with an adaptive bound (Esipova et al. 2023), one shared scale for every gradient	Keeps the update's direction and needs no group labels	Worth a try
More data from the group, a public pretrained model (Public data and private fine-tuning), or a larger ε	Raises the group's signal or lowers the noise	The fixes that work

Oversampling costs the group's privacy, because a record's guarantee depends on its own chance of being sampled (Amplification by subsampling). So run the accountant at the oversampled rate. On Adult, sampling the Asian-Pac-Islander rows four times as often at $\varepsilon = 1$ raises the noise multiplier from 2.383 to 8.828. Every group then loses, the oversampled group most: it falls from 0.8145 to 0.7657, and the White group from 0.8310 to 0.7860, against the same DP-SGD at the ordinary rate. That is **levelling down** with no gain for anyone.

No algorithm avoids some of the cost. Learning a small group's own rule means estimating it privately from that group's few records, and private estimation from few records has an error floor that no mechanism beats (Lower bounds).

45.6. Cheat sheet

Table 45.4.: The decisions of this chapter.

Question	Answer	Conditions
Does DP hurt this group?	Its privacy cost, Equation 45.1, against the non-private baseline	Same data and recipe, averaged over runs
How big will the cost be?	Negligible for large groups at moderate ε, roughly one over the group's share for small ones	Grows as ε falls

Rules of thumb

- Report accuracy and privacy cost per group, with intervals, next to the non-private model's.
- Never report the gap alone, because levelling down closes it too.

45.7. References

- Bagdasaryan, Poursaeed & Shmatikov, "Differential Privacy Has Disparate Impact on Model Accuracy" (NeurIPS 2019): the observation.
- Esipova, Ghomi, Luo & Cresswell, "Disparate Impact in Differential Privacy from Gradient Misalignment" (ICLR 2023): global scaling.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

46. Auditing private training

46.1. Why this matters

When you train with differential privacy (DP), the accountant turns your configuration into a privacy level ε at a slack δ. That number is a proof about an algorithm, but what ships is code. A bug in the noise, the clipping or the sampling makes the model less private but barely changes its accuracy, which is flat across a wide range of noise levels (the training workflow). So the usual tests never notice the bug.

An **audit** checks the code by attacking it. It plants records called **canaries**, trains with and without them, and counts how often a membership test guesses right. DP caps how often any test can be right, so a test that is right too often proves that the code is less private than claimed. A test that is rarely right proves nothing, since a weak attack also fails against a leaky model.

46.2. Known bugs, and which audit catches them

These bugs break the private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), DP-SGD.

- **The variance passed where the standard deviation is expected,** or **noise scaled for the mean but added to the sum,** which adds the batch size times too little noise. A unit test in continuous integration (CI) catches both (Section 46.3).
- **Clipping applied after averaging, or noise from a weak seed.** Nasr et al. (2023) found both in real code with per-step audits like the CI test.
- **The accountant told the wrong numbers,** such as a record count that includes augmented copies, which makes ε look smaller than it is. Only an end-to-end audit can catch it, and only if the error is large.
- **Batches shuffled but accounted as Poisson sampling,** which can make the true ε several times the reported one (Amplification by subsampling). No audit here exercises the sampling, so check the loader itself.

Audits catch errors only in the unsafe direction, so code that adds too much noise passes them all.

46.3. A CI test for the noise and the clipping

The cheapest strong audit tests one step of the optimizer, many times. A **Dirac canary** is a per-example gradient that is zero except on one coordinate, where every other record's gradient is zero. Put it into every step of one run and leave it out of another. The reading x_t is step t's noisy

gradient sum on that coordinate, divided by the clipping norm C. The canary is longer than C, so a correct optimizer clips it to length C and it adds exactly 1 to the reading. The optimizer also adds noise of standard deviation σC, where σ is the noise multiplier, so each reading follows

$$x_t \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2) \text{ without the canary}, \qquad x_t \sim \mathcal{N}(1, \sigma^2) \text{ with it.} \tag{46.1}$$

A threshold test says "canary in" whenever a reading exceeds a threshold. Its **true positive rate (TPR)** is how often it says so when the canary was there, and its **false positive rate (FPR)** how often when it was not.

For two normal distributions a distance μ apart, every threshold gives $\Phi^{-1}(\mathrm{TPR}) - \Phi^{-1}(\mathrm{FPR}) = \mu$, where Φ is the standard normal distribution function. So measured rates bound the true separation μ, which a correct optimizer keeps at $1/\sigma$:

$$\mu \geq \Phi^{-1}(\mathrm{TPR}) - \Phi^{-1}(\mathrm{FPR}). \tag{46.2}$$

The test plugs in the low end of the TPR's Clopper–Pearson interval and the high end of the FPR's. Each end is taken at level $\beta/2$, so the bound holds with probability $1 - \beta$ (Hypothesis testing). If this bound exceeds $1/\sigma$, the code adds less noise than it claims.

The script practitioner_audit.py runs the test on Opacus's own `DPOptimizer`. It writes per-example gradients into `grad_sample` by hand, as Opacus's hooks would, and reads the noisy sum that `optimizer.step()` leaves in `grad`.

```
def canary_coordinate(sigma: float, planted_bug: str, with_canary: bool, steps: int) -> Arra
    """Run the optimizer for `steps` steps; return the canary coordinate of each noisy sum,
    layer = torch.nn.Linear(DIM_CI, 1, bias=False)
    optimizer = make_optimizer(layer, sigma, planted_bug)
    observations = np.empty(steps)
    for t in range(steps):
        setattr(layer.weight, "grad_sample", batch_grad_samples(with_canary))  # as Opacus's
        optimizer.step()  # clip each row to C, sum, add N(0, σ²C²)
        assert layer.weight.grad is not None
        observations[t] = layer.weight.grad[0, CANARY_COORD].item() / CLIP_CI
        optimizer.zero_grad()
    return observations
```

The canary's gradient is ten times C, so the test also exercises clipping. The script chooses the threshold on the first half of the steps and counts the rates on the second half. It also checks that the canary-free readings have a standard deviation within 10% of σ, since with no noise every reading is 0. The command `uv run python code/part05-dp-ml/practitioner_audit.py` tests three optimizers at $\sigma = 0.7$ and a batch of $B = 64$ records, the correct one, one with the variance bug and one with no noise. The variance bug removes noise only because $\sigma^2 < \sigma$ when σ is below 1, and above 1 it would pass.

```
sigma=0.7  C=1.0  B=64  steps per run=2000  claim mu=1/sigma=1.429
correct: noise std 0.687 (claim 0.7)  FP 206/1000  TP 710/1000
correct: mu_lo=1.201  pass
variance for std: noise std 0.481 (claim 0.7)  FP 206/1000  TP 862/1000
```

```
variance for std: mu_lo=1.722  FAIL
no noise: noise std 0.000 (claim 0.7)  FP 0/1000  TP 1000/1000
no noise: mu_lo=5.360  FAIL
```

The correct optimizer's bound on μ is 1.201, below its claimed 1.429, so it passes. The variance bug's bound is 1.722 and the missing noise's is 5.360, so both fail. The test takes seconds, so run it on every commit.

Three things go wrong in practice.

First, a correct optimizer still fails with probability β, here 5%, so an unseeded test fails one build in twenty. Fix the seed, or use a β of 10^{-3} with more steps. Second, the script builds its own optimizer, so it tests Opacus, not your call to it. To test your code, have your setup function return the optimizer it makes, and drive that one. Third, the test never draws a batch or calls the accountant. So the same suite should assert that the loader is Opacus's `DPDataLoader` and that a second library's ε matches yours (Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run).

46.4. From an attack to a lower bound

For a whole training run, the attack is a membership test on a planted canary. A **trial** is one training run, with or without the canary. Under (ε, δ)-DP, every such test satisfies

$$\mathrm{TPR} \le e^{\varepsilon}\,\mathrm{FPR} + \delta, \qquad 1 - \mathrm{FPR} \le e^{\varepsilon}\,(1 - \mathrm{TPR}) + \delta. \tag{46.3}$$

Solving these for ε turns measured rates into a lower bound on it. Write $\overline{\mathrm{FPR}}$ for the one-sided Clopper–Pearson upper bound on the FPR at level $\beta/2$, and $\underline{\mathrm{TPR}}$ for the TPR's lower bound. With probability at least $1 - \beta$, the code is then not (ε, δ)-DP, at the claimed δ, for any ε below

$$\varepsilon_{\mathrm{lo}} = \max\left\{ \ln \frac{\underline{\mathrm{TPR}} - \delta}{\overline{\mathrm{FPR}}},\ \ln \frac{1 - \overline{\mathrm{FPR}} - \delta}{1 - \underline{\mathrm{TPR}}} \right\}. \tag{46.4}$$

The bound needs independent trials, and a threshold chosen on other trials than those it counts, because a threshold tuned on them inflates it.

No library installed with this book computes the bound, so the script imports `eps_lower_bound` from the book's helper module, practitioner_privacy_tests.py. Suppose an attack catches the canary in 500 of 1,000 runs that include it, and raises one false alarm in 1,000 runs without it.

```
for false_pos, true_pos in ((1, 500), (0, 1_000)):  # out of 1,000 runs without and with the
    eps_lo = eps_lower_bound(false_pos, true_pos, 1_000, DELTA)
    print(f"FP {false_pos}/1000  TP {true_pos}/1000: certified eps lower bound {eps_lo:.2f}"
```

```
FP 1/1000  TP 500/1000: certified eps lower bound 4.43
FP 0/1000  TP 1000/1000: certified eps lower bound 5.60
```

The raw rates alone would suggest 6.21, but the certified bound is only 4.43, and even a perfect attack certifies only 5.60 from 1,000 trials per hypothesis. So do not expect an end-to-end audit to certify all of a large claim.

46.5. A one-run audit of the trained model

Thousands of runs are out of reach for a real model, so Steinke, Nasr & Jagielski (2023) get many trials from one run. Plant a number m of canaries, include each one by its own fair coin, train once and score every canary. Then fix a list length r. Guess "in" for the $r/2$ highest scores and "out" for the $r/2$ lowest, and make no guess about the rest. Write W for the number of correct guesses.

Under ε-DP, no attack guesses one canary's coin right with a probability above the limit p_ε given below. So the count W is no more likely to reach any value v than a binomial count with that success rate is:

$$\Pr[W \geq v] \leq \Pr\left[\mathrm{Bin}(r, p_\varepsilon) \geq v\right], \qquad p_\varepsilon = \frac{e^\varepsilon}{1 + e^\varepsilon}. \tag{46.5}$$

An observed count that this binomial reaches with probability below β rules out that ε, and the certified bound is the largest ε ruled out. Under (ε, δ)-DP, the paper adds at most $2m\delta$ to that probability. The coins must be independent and fair, and several list lengths need a Bonferroni correction, which runs each test at β divided by their number.

The script runs it on the released pipeline of Train a model with DP-SGD on the Adult census data. It adds only the canaries, 1,000 held-out rows with flipped labels. The coins put 537 of them in the training set, and the release's noise multiplier gives $\varepsilon = 3.91$ for this larger set at $\delta = 10^{-5}$. A non-private model uses the release's baseline recipe, and a memorizing control runs non-private Adam for 60 epochs with small batches. Each canary is scored by minus its loss, and Table 46.1 gives each model's best of six list lengths from 20 to 1,000.

Table 46.1.: One-run audit of the released pipeline on Adult with 1,000 mislabeled canaries, at 95% overall confidence and $\delta = 10^{-5}$.

Training	Mean canary loss, in / out	Correct guesses	Certified ε
DP-SGD, release recipe	4.105 / 4.006	10 of 20	0.00
Non-private, release recipe	2.240 / 2.222	8 of 20	0.00
Memorizing control	1.994 / 2.992	75 of 100	0.53

Both release-recipe models certify nothing, and the reason is the recipe, not privacy. Ten epochs with large batches barely fit the flipped labels, so included canaries have the same loss as excluded ones, with or without noise. Only the memorizing control separates its canaries. Even it certifies just 0.53 for a model with no finite ε, because each canary is a single trial. A perfect list of all 1,000 guesses would certify at most 5.27.

So use the one-run audit to expose a bug, when a DP model certifies more than its claim, never as evidence of privacy. Report it with its threat model, a black-box attacker who sees only the final model, and with a control that shows the attack can detect leakage on your data.

Stronger black-box attacks, such as the likelihood ratio attack (LiRA) of Pre-release privacy risk assessment, train **shadow models**. These are copies of the model, trained with its exact recipe

on similar data. Run them before release and keep their results with the evidence (Release and governance). LiRA's TPR at a low FPR shows what a realistic attacker learns. But its (model, record) pairs share models, so they are not independent trials and give no certified bound.

46.6. Cheat sheet

Table 46.2.: Which audit answers which question, and its rule.

Question	Audit and cost	Rule	Blind to
Does the code clip and add the noise it claims?	CI test, seconds	Fail if the bound on μ, Equation 46.2, exceeds $1/\sigma$	Sampling and accounting bugs
Is the claimed ε right, accounting included?	End-to-end audit, thousands of runs	Equation 46.4, Clopper–Pearson at $\beta/2$	Bugs smaller than the bound's shortfall
Does a trained model leak planted records?	One-run audit, one extra run	Equation 46.5 plus $2m\delta$, Bonferroni	Most bugs, since its bounds are low
What can a realistic attacker learn?	Shadow-model attack (LiRA)	TPR at a low FPR; no certified bound	The most the code could leak

46.7. References

- Nasr et al., "Tight Auditing of Differentially Private Machine Learning" (USENIX Security 2023): Dirac canaries, per-step audits and real bugs.
- Steinke, Nasr & Jagielski, "Privacy Auditing with One (1) Training Run" (NeurIPS 2023): the one-run audit.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

47. Adaptive data analysis

47.1. What it is

When you tune on a held-out validation set, you read the scores and try new settings, so each question depends on earlier answers. Such **adaptive** reuse overfits the holdout set, whose scores then overstate how the model does on new data.

Each such question is a **statistical query**, which averages a per-record answer between 0 and 1 over the n records you hold. A classifier's accuracy is an example. Its population value is the same average over new data. Suppose the records are drawn independently and a number k of queries are fixed before any answer is seen. Then the largest gap between the two values is on average at most

$$\sqrt{\frac{\ln(2k)}{2n}}. \tag{47.1}$$

The number of queries enters through a logarithm, so it hardly matters.

Adaptive queries break this, because a later query can be built to fit the sample's own noise. For example, Blum & Hardt's boosting attack runs on a leaderboard whose labels are coin flips, where nothing can beat 0.5 on new data. Yet after 1,000 submissions on as many holdout records, it reports 0.7182.

Differential privacy (DP) is the remedy, because answers that reveal little about any record cannot be used to overfit it. Let a mechanism's answers be on average within a distance α of the empirical values. Let the whole exchange be DP at a privacy level ε, with a small slack δ, for samples that differ in one replaced record. The **transfer theorem** then bounds the expected largest error against the population by

$$\alpha + e^{\varepsilon} - 1 + \delta, \tag{47.2}$$

whatever the analyst does with the answers. For small ε the middle term is about ε, so the bound is useful only well below $\varepsilon = 1$. It protects the validity of the answers, not the people in the holdout set.

47.2. When you meet it

You meet adaptivity when a validation set, a test set or a leaderboard answers more than one round of questions, as in hyperparameter search. A round is a batch of questions fixed before any of its answers is seen, and the bounds below grow with the number of rounds. Table 47.1 gives the choice for each situation.

Table 47.1.: How to reuse a holdout set, by situation.

Situation	What to do
A final evaluation	Keep a test set and use it once
Few adaptive rounds, plenty of data	Give each round its own slice of data
Many adaptive rounds, scarce data	Answer through noise, or use Thresholdout
A search that is private in the holdout set	Nothing more, since the transfer theorem covers the winner
A public leaderboard	Show a new score only when it beats the best by a margin (Blum & Hardt's Ladder)

47.3. How to use it

The simplest fix is **sample splitting**, which answers each of r rounds on its own n/r records. The expected largest error is then at most $\sqrt{r \ln(2k)/(2n)}$ for k queries in all, so the data you need grow in proportion to r. Take 10,000 validation records and a search over 1,000 configurations, each chosen from the earlier scores, so $r = k = 1{,}000$. Splitting then gives a bound of 0.6165, useless for scores between 0 and 1. A bound of 0.05 would need 1,520,181 records, where fixed queries would need 1,521.

Answering every query with Gaussian noise, under the transfer theorem, needs records that grow only like $\sqrt{k}$. But its constants are large, so splitting stays cheaper up to a few hundred adaptive queries.

Thresholdout (Dwork et al. 2015) answers from a training set while the training value agrees with the holdout value. Such answers reveal nothing about the holdout set. When they differ by more than a noisy threshold, it records a **detection** and returns a noisy holdout value. So its privacy cost grows with the number of detections, not of queries. But its formal ε in the full edition's experiment is about 29, and no mainstream library ships it. So treat it as a brake, not a guarantee.

47.4. What goes wrong

The common failure is not an attack but a long search that picks each setting from earlier validation scores. A fixed grid scored once, as in scikit-learn's `GridSearchCV`, is a single round, so Equation 47.1 bounds its winner's overstatement. So count rounds, and report how many a validation number has been through. Practice is often milder than the worst case, but the risk is real with few records and many rounds.

47.5. References

- Dwork et al., "The Reusable Holdout" (*Science* 2015): Thresholdout.
- Blum & Hardt, "The Ladder" (ICML 2015): the boosting attack and a leaderboard that resists it.

Derivations. Every result here is derived step by step in the full edition's chapter.

48. Release and governance

48.1. Why this matters

A model trained with differential privacy (DP) is not finished when training stops. A privacy reviewer or a data protection officer decides whether it may ship. They ask what the guarantee covers, whether its number is right and what it means under the law, and none of them can rerun your training. So the claim must travel with everything needed to check it. This chapter is the book's home for the privacy statement and for the review of someone else's claim.

The model is a small network, trained on 30,000 people from Adult with the private form of stochastic gradient descent (SGD), called DP-SGD. It comes from Train a model with DP-SGD, with a target privacy level ε of 4. The script practitioner_release.py runs in a few seconds. It reads the run record that the training script writes, passed with `--record PATH`, or else a built-in copy of the book's record.

```
uv run python code/part05-dp-ml/practitioner_release.py
```

48.2. Assemble the run record

The record must hold what the accountant needs. The accountant is the code that turns a run's settings into ε (Choosing an accountant). It reads four settings, the noise multiplier σ, the sampling rate q, the number of steps and the slack δ. It also takes four things for granted, so the record states those too. They are the privacy unit, here one person, the neighbouring relation and the sampler that drew each batch. The fourth is that no other use of the private data went uncounted.

The record also gives n, the number of units, the seed, Opacus's `secure_mode` and the library versions. It says how the hyperparameters were chosen and whether any preprocessing saw private data. In the excerpt, `data` is the training script's record and `RELEASE_CONTEXT` holds the release owner's additions.

```
merged = RELEASE_CONTEXT | data  # the training record, plus what the release owner adds
rec = load_record(merged)
for key, value in asdict(rec).items():
    print(f"{key}: {value}")
problems = record_problems(merged)  # missing fields, sampler not Poisson, delta above 1/n^1
limitations = record_limitations(merged)  # stated, so not a problem, but the statement must
print(f"record problems: {len(problems)}")
for problem in problems:
```

```
    print(f"  - {problem}")
print(f"record limitations: {len(limitations)}")
for limitation in limitations:
    print(f"  - {limitation}")
```

```
unit: person (one row of Adult)
neighbours: add/remove
n: 30000
delta: 1e-05
sigma: 0.972900390625
sample_rate: 0.03333333333333333
sampler: poisson
secure_mode: False
seed: 0
steps: 300
...
record problems: 0
record limitations: 1
  - secure_mode=False: Opacus drew the noise from a seeded, non-cryptographic generator so t
```

The record's δ of 10^{-5} follows the book's rule (How small δ must be). Its values of ε come from the cross-check of Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run.

The tuning entry matters most to a reviewer, because the final run's ε leaves out every run that helped choose a hyperparameter. Here non-private runs chose the learning rate on 2,000 held-out Adult rows that play the part of public data, and $\varepsilon = 4$ was fixed before any private run. So the run's ε is also the ε of the whole procedure. Those 2,000 people come from the same survey and get no guarantee, so the statement names them. If you tune on private data, report both values (Hyperparameter tuning).

A record problem stops the release, such as a missing field, a sampler that is not Poisson, a δ above the rule or unreported tuning. The one limitation here is `secure_mode`, left off so that the book's numbers repeat. The statement discloses it, and a model you ship is retrained with it on.

48.3. Recompute the guarantee

The release owner recomputes ε from σ, q and the steps alone, with a library other than the one that trained. A recomputation inside the training code would reuse any wrong number. Compare the result only with a budget from the same kind of accountant, because a looser accountant gives a larger ε for the same run. The script uses the privacy loss distribution (PLD) accountant of `dp_accounting`, as in the cross-check, and compares it with the looser Rényi differential privacy (RDP) accountant. It also reads ε at a δ a hundred times smaller, and the trade-off curve. That curve gives the largest true positive rate (TPR) that any membership test can reach at each false positive rate (FPR) (Choosing ε).

```
pld = privacy_loss_distribution.from_gaussian_mechanism(sigma, sampling_prob=sample_rate).se
eps_pld = pld.get_epsilon_for_delta(delta)
eps_pld_small = pld.get_epsilon_for_delta(delta / 100)
eps_rdp = rdp_epsilon(sigma, sample_rate, steps, delta)
eps_rdp_small = rdp_epsilon(sigma, sample_rate, steps, delta / 100)
tpr = {fpr: tpr_bound(pld, fpr) for fpr in FPRS}  # largest TPR of any membership test
```

```
eps PLD at delta=1e-05: 3.981
eps RDP at delta=1e-05: 4.503
eps PLD at delta=1e-07: 5.191
eps RDP at delta=1e-07: 5.736
TPR bound at FPR 1e-03: 0.0123 (PLD curve)  0.0536 (pair eps, delta only)
TPR bound at FPR 1e-02: 0.0652 (PLD curve)  0.5355 (pair eps, delta only)
record's PRV eps: reported 3.99, recomputed 3.98: consistent
```

The PLD value, 3.981, agrees with the reported 3.99. The curve gives a number a non-specialist can use. At an FPR of 10^{-3}, no membership test can reach a TPR above 0.0123, while the pair $(3.98, 10^{-5})$ on its own would allow 0.0536.

The script flags a reported ε more than 0.05 below the recomputation. The subtler failure is a recomputation that agrees on wrong inputs, such as code that shuffles the data into fixed batches while the accountant assumes Poisson sampling (Amplification by subsampling). No number shows that, so the record's sampler, read from the loader, is what catches it.

48.4. Attach the evidence

An accountant proves a theorem about an algorithm, not about the code that runs it, so the release also needs evidence about the code and the model. Attach each piece in Table 48.1, and say which attacker it models. The curve covers the strongest attacker, who sees every intermediate model, while the audit and the attack cover only the attacks they run.

Table 48.1.: The evidence attached to a DP model release, and its limits.

Evidence	Source	On the Adult run	What it cannot show
Independent ε	This chapter's recomputation	3.981 against the reported 3.99	That the sampler matches the code
Clipping and noise test	Continuous integration (CI) test of Auditing private training	Passes on Opacus's optimizer; fails with the variance passed as the standard deviation, or with no noise	Sampling or accounting bugs

Evidence	Source	On the Adult run	What it cannot show
One-run audit	Auditing private training: the released pipeline retrained with 1,000 planted canaries	A lower bound on ε of 0.00 for DP-SGD and for the non-private baseline, against 0.53 for a memorizing control	That the model is private; a low bound proves nothing
Black-box attack	Likelihood ratio attack of Pre-release privacy risk assessment	Not run on this model; say so in the evidence	Whether a stronger attacker does better
Groups	Per-group accuracy with exact 95% intervals (Disparate impact)	Women 0.922 [0.915, 0.929], men 0.807 [0.800, 0.815]	Groups too small to measure

The audits can only refute a claim. A one-run bound above the claimed 4 would prove a bug, but 0.00 shows only that this attack found nothing, as in the non-private baseline. The audit also tests the released training code, not the released weights.

The group accuracies come from the 16,842 Adult test rows, which are private too. To publish them, add noise to each group's count of correct predictions and charge it to its own budget (Release statistics with a library). Or measure them on a test set that is not private.

48.5. Write the statement

The statement goes in the model card's privacy section. The script's `format_statement` builds it from the record, so no number is typed by hand. The block omits lines that repeat the record.

```
Guarantee: (3.98, 1e-05)-DP per person (one row of Adult), add/remove neighbours,
  for the whole training run on Adult (UCI 2), 30,000 training rows (n = 30,000).
  Also (5.19, 1e-07)-DP. Any membership test has TPR at most 0.0123 at FPR 1e-3.
Mechanism: DP-SGD, poisson sampling q = 0.0333, noise multiplier 0.9729,
  clipping norm 1, 300 steps (10 epochs).
Accounting: prv, Opacus 1.6.0; recomputed with dp_accounting PLD (RDP gives 4.50).
...
Noise generator: Opacus secure_mode=False, seed 0.
...
Not covered: data outside the training set, API outputs that use other private data, other r
```

Below the statement, add the evidence of Table 48.1. The last line needs the most care. The guarantee covers the weights and anything computed from them alone, such as the logits that the deployed application programming interface (API) returns, because post-processing cannot

weaken DP. An output that also uses other private data, such as a retrieval index, is a new release, and so is a second model trained on the same people.

48.6. Map the claim to regulation

This section is not legal advice, since every answer depends on facts beyond the model. In the European Union, Recital 26 of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) exempts anonymous information. It asks about the means of identification "reasonably likely to be used". Pseudonymised data, which only information kept separately links to a person, remain personal data under Article 4(5).

For AI models, Opinion 28/2024 of the European Data Protection Board (EDPB) sets a test, assessed case by case. A model is anonymous only if the likelihood of extracting personal data about its training set is insignificant. The opinion names DP and attack tests, such as membership inference, as measures to weigh, and warns that a test shows resistance only to the attacks tested. The trade-off curve speaks to extraction as well as membership, because it caps reconstruction too (Choosing ε).

Table 48.2.: What DP evidence answers, and leaves open, for the legal questions a release meets.

Legal question	What DP evidence supports	What DP does not answer
Is the model anonymous (GDPR Recital 26; EDPB Opinion 28/2024)?	A bound on what any attacker can learn about one person's presence or record: the TPR cap and the audits	Whether the bound is "insignificant"; the training data stay personal data
Is this only pseudonymisation (GDPR Art. 4(5))?	DP relies on no separately kept key that could re-link the data to people	Removing identifiers before training is pseudonymisation at most
What goes in the risk assessment (GDPR Art. 35)?	The statement, the curve, the audits and the group table	Necessity and proportionality (Art. 35(7)(b)), and the lawful basis (Art. 6)
Is the risk of identification very small (HIPAA §164.514(b)(1))?	A quantitative bound that an expert can cite, with documented methods	Whether it is "very small"; the expert's determination itself
Is the information deidentified (California Consumer Privacy Act, Cal. Civ. Code §1798.140(m))?	A bound on how much one person's record can change what is inferred	Whether that meets the standard, since DP does not stop inferences from population patterns; the business's own duties
Does the data governance meet the EU AI Act (Art. 10)?	Documented data handling and per-group evaluation	Data quality, representativeness and bias, which DP can worsen

Training still processes personal data, so the GDPR applies to it, lawful basis included. Article 35 requires a data protection impact assessment (DPIA) before processing likely to result in a high risk. The DPIA is the natural home for the statement. In the United States, the safe harbor route

of the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) removes listed identifiers (§164.514(b)(2)), which DP does not do. Its expert determination route can cite DP evidence but not be replaced by it. California's law, as amended by the California Privacy Rights Act, adds duties against re-identification for the business.

None of these texts says that DP makes a model anonymous by itself. A DPIA entry built from this chapter's evidence can read as follows, and the controller and counsel fill in the bracketed parts.

> The model was trained on personal data under [lawful basis, Art. 6]. Training used DP-SGD with a guarantee of $(3.98, 10^{-5})$-DP per person, add/remove neighbours, for the whole training run. No membership test against the released weights can exceed a TPR of 0.0123 at an FPR of 10^{-3}, and the same curve caps reconstruction. The code passed a CI test of its noise and clipping. A one-run audit of the released pipeline found nothing, while a memorizing control certified 0.53. [A shadow-model attack was / was not run.] These tests show resistance only to the attacks run. DP does not remove identifiers and is not pseudonymisation. Whether the bound makes the model anonymous is for [counsel], and we make no claim of automatic anonymity. Not covered: the 2,000 stand-in rows, the test rows, outputs that use other private data, and later model versions.

48.7. Review someone else's claim

When someone else hands you a model, run the same steps in reverse. Ask for the record of Section 48.2, and refuse a claim that cannot be recomputed. Recompute ε from the claim's own parameters, and check its δ against the number of units. Matching the accountant to the code gives the checks on the accountant and the sampler.

The script reviews a claim made up for this book, with every flaw a review should catch. It claims $\varepsilon = 1$ at $\delta = 10^{-3}$ for a model trained on 50,000 records, over 5,000 steps with noise multiplier 0.8. Its batches of 256 were shuffled and of fixed size but are accounted as Poisson sampling. The claim states no unit, no clipping norm and no tuning.

```
def review(claim: dict[str, Any]) -> list[str]:
    """Recompute a claim from its own parameters and list what does not hold up."""
    findings = record_problems(claim)  # includes a sampler that is missing or not Poisson
    sigma, q, steps, delta = claim["sigma"], claim["sample_rate"], claim["steps"], claim["de
    pld = privacy_loss_distribution.from_gaussian_mechanism(sigma, sampling_prob=q).self_com
    recomputed = {"PLD": pld.get_epsilon_for_delta(delta)}
    if "rdp" in str(claim.get("accountant")).lower():  # also the accountant the claim names
        recomputed["RDP, the accountant named,"] = rdp_epsilon(sigma, q, steps, delta)
    for name, eps in recomputed.items():
        if eps > claim["epsilon"] + 0.05:
            findings.append(f"eps={claim['epsilon']} does not follow: {name} gives {eps:.2f}
    delta_ok = delta_for(claim["n"])
    findings.append(f"at delta={delta_ok:.0e} (1/n^1.1) PLD gives eps={pld.get_epsilon_for_d
    return findings
```

```
claim: Our model is trained with differential privacy, epsilon = 1.
findings: 10
  - missing field: unit
  - missing field: neighbours
  - missing field: max_grad_norm
  - missing field: secure_mode
  - sampler 'shuffled fixed-size batches' is not Poisson subsampling: Poisson-subsampled acc
  - delta=1e-03 is above 1/n^1.1 (use 1e-06)
  - tuning not reported: the cost of choosing hyperparameters is unknown
  - eps=1.0 does not follow: PLD gives 2.17 at its delta
  - eps=1.0 does not follow: RDP, the accountant named, gives 2.55 at its delta
  - at delta=1e-06 (1/n^1.1) PLD gives eps=3.75
```

By the vendor's own parameters the claimed 1 is 2.17, and the RDP accountant it names gives 2.55. At a δ the book accepts it is 3.75. Even that is too low, because shuffled fixed-size batches get no amplification by Poisson subsampling, so the true ε can be far above all these numbers.

The script takes n as given, so it cannot see a wrong unit. If the records are messages and a customer sends many, screen the per-customer ε yourself with User-level differential privacy. Send the findings back with a request for a corrected record.

48.8. After release

Every retraining on the same people is a new release that composes with the old ones. For identical runs, compose the PLD of one run with itself once per version, `pld.self_compose(steps * versions)`. State the budget per model version and in total over a fixed **period**. If the total over a schedule is too large, calibrate each version to a share of it.

Deletion requests need their own answer, because DP deletes nothing. The model is about as likely as one trained without the person, but their row is still in the data. So honour a request by removing the row, from the stand-in and test rows too, and retraining on a fixed schedule. Whether that is fast enough for the GDPR's Article 17 is a question for counsel.

Give each model version its own record and statement, and name in advance the incidents that reopen a release. A failing CI test, an audit bound above the claim, or a bug in the sampler or the accountant needs a corrected statement or a retrained model.

48.9. Checklist

Table 48.3.: The release checklist: each step, its default and its check.

Step	Default	Check
Run record	The fields of Section 48.2, with the sampler read from the loader	`record problems: 0`; `secure_mode` on for the shipped model

Step	Default	Check
δ	The book's rule (How small δ must be)	n counts units, not rows
Tuning	Choices on public data, or every private run counted	Run and procedure ε both reported
Recomputed ε	PLD in `dp_accounting`, at δ and $\delta/100$, and TPR from the curve	Reported value not below the recomputation
Audits	The evidence of Table 48.1	CI passes on the released commit; no bound above the claim; the control detects leakage; any attack not run is named
Groups	Per-group accuracy with exact intervals	Test set not private, or its release accounted
Statement	Generated from the record	Every number recomputable; "not covered" filled in
Regulation	DPIA entry mapping the evidence to each legal question	Reviewed by counsel; no claim of automatic anonymity
Third-party claim	Recompute from its own parameters	Unit, sampler, δ and tuning all stated
After release	Budget per period; retraining and deletion schedule; incident triggers	Versions composed; each has its own record

48.10. References

- Near, Darais, Lefkovitz & Howarth, *Guidelines for Evaluating Differential Privacy Guarantees* (NIST SP 800-226, 2025): what to ask of any DP claim.
- European Data Protection Board, *Opinion 28/2024 on certain data protection aspects related to the processing of personal data in the context of AI models* (December 2024): when a model can count as anonymous.
- Ponomareva et al., "How to DP-fy ML: A Practical Guide to Machine Learning with Differential Privacy" (JAIR 2023): its reporting section lists what a privacy statement contains.

Derivations. This workflow has no counterpart in the full edition.

A. Glossary

Acronyms used in the book and the pages that use them.

AI Artificial intelligence. Used in Release and governance.

API Application programming interface. Used in Threat models and privacy games, Pre-release privacy risk assessment, Release and governance.

ART Adversarial Robustness Toolbox. Used in Threat models and privacy games, Membership inference, Attribute inference and model inversion.

AUC Area under the curve. Used in Hypothesis testing, Membership inference.

CDF Cumulative distribution function. Used in The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms.

CI Continuous integration. Used in Auditing private training, Release and governance.

CLT Central limit theorem. Used in Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions, f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy.

CPU Central processing unit. Used in Pre-release privacy risk assessment, Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA.

DLG Deep Leakage from Gradients. Used in Gradient inversion.

DP Differential privacy. Used in Property inference, Gradient inversion, Pre-release privacy risk assessment, Differential privacy foundations, The definition of differential privacy, Post-processing, group privacy and composition, The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms, Advanced and optimal composition, Selection: exponential mechanism, report-noisy-max, sparse vector, Query release and private multiplicative weights, Beyond global sensitivity, Discrete and floating-point-safe mechanisms, Local, shuffle and distributed trust models, Lower bounds: what privacy costs, Private mean estimation, Release statistics with a library, Privacy accounting, Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, Amplification by subsampling, Rényi differential privacy, From Rényi DP to (ε, δ) and to tests, Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions, f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy, Adaptive composition: filters, odometers and individual accounting, Concentrated differential privacy, Amplification by shuffling and by iteration, Differential privacy in machine learning, Private empirical risk minimization, DP-SGD, Train a model with DP-SGD, Hyperparameter tuning and private selection, User-level differential privacy, Choosing ε, Public data and private fine-tuning, Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA, Private prediction: PATE and in-context learning, DP-FTRL and matrix factorization, Disparate impact, Auditing private training, Adaptive data analysis, Release and governance.

DPIA Data protection impact assessment. Used in Release and governance.

ERM Empirical risk minimization. Used in Private empirical risk minimization, Public data and private fine-tuning.

FL Federated learning. Used in Gradient inversion.

FNR False negative rate. Used in Hypothesis testing.

FPR False positive rate. Used in Hypothesis testing, Threat models and privacy games, Membership inference, Pre-release privacy risk assessment, The definition of differential privacy, Lower bounds: what privacy costs, f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy, Choosing ε, Auditing private training, Release and governance.

FTRL Follow the regularized leader. Used in Choosing an accountant, DP-FTRL and matrix factorization.

GDP Gaussian differential privacy. Used in Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions, f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy, Choosing ε.

GDPR General Data Protection Regulation. Used in Linkage and re-identification, Release and governance.

GPU Graphics processing unit. Used in Train a model with DP-SGD, Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA.

HIPAA Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act. Used in Release and governance.

HIV Human immunodeficiency virus. Used in Syntactic anonymity and how it breaks.

HMAC Hash-based message authentication code. Used in Linkage and re-identification.

KL Kullback–Leibler. Used in Divergences.

LLM Large language model. Used in Private prediction: PATE and in-context learning.

LR Likelihood ratio. Used in Hypothesis testing.

ML Machine learning. Used in Membership inference, Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, DP-SGD, Train a model with DP-SGD, Choosing ε, Release and governance.

MWEM Multiplicative weights exponential mechanism. Used in Query release and private multiplicative weights.

PATE Private aggregation of teacher ensembles. Used in Beyond global sensitivity, Private prediction: PATE and in-context learning.

PII Personally identifiable information. Used in Memorization and training-data extraction.

PLD Privacy loss distribution. Used in Advanced and optimal composition, Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, Amplification by subsampling, From Rényi DP to (ε, δ) and to tests, Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions, Train a model with DP-SGD, Choosing ε, Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA, Private prediction: PATE and in-context learning, Release and governance.

PRV Privacy loss random variable. Used in Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions, Train a model with DP-SGD, Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA.

RDP Rényi differential privacy. Used in Advanced and optimal composition, Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, Amplification by subsampling, Rényi differential privacy, From Rényi DP to (ε, δ) and to tests, Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions, Adaptive composition: filters, odometers and individual accounting, Concentrated differential privacy, DP-SGD, Train a model with DP-SGD, Hyperparameter tuning and private selection, Choosing ε, Private prediction: PATE and in-context learning, DP-FTRL and matrix factorization, Release and governance.

RMSE Root-mean-square error. Used in The Laplace and Gaussian mechanisms, Private mean estimation.

ROC Receiver operating characteristic. Used in Hypothesis testing, Threat models and privacy games, Membership inference.

SGD Stochastic gradient descent. Used in Pre-release privacy risk assessment, Privacy accounting, Choosing an accountant, Calibrate and account a DP-SGD run, Amplification by subsam-

pling, Rényi differential privacy, From Rényi DP to (ε, δ) and to tests, Numerical accounting with privacy loss distributions, f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy, Concentrated differential privacy, Amplification by shuffling and by iteration, Differential privacy in machine learning, Private empirical risk minimization, DP-SGD, Train a model with DP-SGD, Hyperparameter tuning and private selection, User-level differential privacy, Choosing ε, Public data and private fine-tuning, Fine-tune a language model privately with LoRA, Private prediction: PATE and in-context learning, DP-FTRL and matrix factorization, Disparate impact, Auditing private training, Release and governance.

SQL Structured Query Language. Used in Release statistics with a library.

TPR True positive rate. Used in Hypothesis testing, Threat models and privacy games, Membership inference, Pre-release privacy risk assessment, The definition of differential privacy, Lower bounds: what privacy costs, f-DP and Gaussian differential privacy, Choosing ε, Auditing private training, Release and governance.

TV Total variation. Used in Divergences, Hypothesis testing, Syntactic anonymity and how it breaks.

ZIP Zone Improvement Plan code, the US postal code. Used in Linkage and re-identification.

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